

Fate's Edge

Player's Guide

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*“The coin that never spends is the one you don’t remember taking.”
— Serafine of the Velvet Touch*

Fate's Edge: Player's Guide

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Chapter 1

Welcome to Fate's Edge

A world where every choice carries weight, every spell risks backlash, and every legend is written in the shadow of consequence.

Welcome to **Fate's Edge**, a tabletop roleplaying game where narrative drives mechanics, and every decision shapes not only your character's path—but the world around them. This is not a game of perfect successes or clean victories. It is a game of risk, drama, and legacy.

What Is This Game?

Fate's Edge is a narrative-first RPG where:

- Every roll introduces potential for triumph *and* complication.
- Magic is powerful—but dangerous.
- Choices ripple outward, shaping character arcs and the setting.
- Growth is meaningful, earned through experience spent on skills, talents, and assets.

This guide helps you build a character, understand the setting, and step into a world where your actions matter. For the complete core rules (dice resolution, Position, Difficulty Values, Story Beats, Boons, and more), refer to the *Fate's Edge System Reference Document (SRD)*.

Modular by Design

One of the most important things to understand about *Fate's Edge* is that it is **modular**. You are not expected to memorise every subsystem before you sit down to play. Instead, the game is designed to be discovered layer by layer, as your table's ambition grows.

- **Session 1:** Use only the core resolution cycle ([chapter 2](#)) and maybe one regional travel generator. That is a complete, playable game.
- **Session 5:** You will have integrated Assets, Followers, and a Patron or two. The system will feel natural.
- **Session 20:** You will be juggling Obligation, Corruption, faction timers, and legacy planning without looking at the book.

The GM decides which subsystems to introduce and when. Your job as a player is to learn what is on your character sheet and trust that the rest will come when it is needed. This modularity means:

- You never need to read the entire book before playing.
- The game grows with your table, not against it.
- Every rule exists to serve a narrative purpose; if a subsystem is not in play, your story is not poorer for it.

So do not panic when you see a long table of Patrons or a complex ritual procedure. Start with the core loop, then add one new thing each session. The road is long; you will get there.

Core Principles

The game is built on four key ideas:

Narrative First Mechanics serve the story. Rules reward descriptive play and creative problem-solving.

Risk Creates Drama Every roll carries tension. Even success may come at a cost.

Meaningful Growth Experience is a currency of choice. Invest in yourself or in your influence on the world.

Consequences Matter No action is free. Every choice changes the fiction.

Style of Play

Expect cinematic, collaborative storytelling:

- Stories driven by character choices.
- A world that reacts to your decisions.
- Themes of legacy, sacrifice, and moral complexity.

Whether you are a lone duelist, a scheming mastermind, or a spirit-touched outlander, your path is yours to forge.

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Fate's Edge explores mature themes—conflict, loss, horror, betrayal, and difficult choices. The table should always feel safe. Use these simple tools to keep the game enjoyable for everyone.

X-Card (by John Stavropoulos). Any player (including the GM) can draw an “X” on a card or simply say “X” when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is **removed from the fiction**—no questions, no explanations, no judgments. You do not need to justify using the X-Card. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

Lines. A **Line** is a hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: “No sexual violence,” “No harm to children,” “No body horror.” Before the campaign or a session, players name their Lines. The GM and group honor them completely.

Veils. A **Veil** is a soft boundary: content that can happen “off screen” or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described in detail. Example: “A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit.” Veils allow the story to acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

How to Use These Tools at Your Table.

- Establish Lines and Veils during **Session Zero** (or before your first game). Write them down where everyone can see them.
- Keep an X-Card visible on the table (a printed card, a drawn X, or a digital symbol). Remind players they can use it at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player who used it.
- The GM is also a player. The GM may use the X-Card for their own comfort.
- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust that they had a good reason and support them.

These tools are not about censorship—they are about **consent**. They allow the group to tell darker, more intense stories together *because* everyone knows they can tap out at any time. A game that feels safe is a game that can go to the edge.

For more detail, search online for “TTRPG X-Card” or “Lines and Veils RPG”. Many free resources are available.

Session Zero: The Foundation of Your Story

Before you roll your first die, gather with your GM and fellow players for a **Session Zero**. This is where you build the shared understanding that makes Fate’s Edge sing – and where you make sure everyone is excited for the same kind of story.

Core Philosophy to Embrace as Players

- **Optimal play = most fun.** Spending Boons, embracing failure, and courting Patron attention leads to better stories. There is no “winning” except an unforgettable session.
- **You and the GM are co-creators, not adversaries.** The GM frames pressure; you drive the fiction. No one is trying to “beat” anyone else.
- **Boons are not XP tokens.** Spend them. Hoarding Boons for conversion starves the table of drama and leads to less engagement.
- **Patrons are allies who demand payment – embrace it.** Obligation is plot, not punishment. When a Patron calls, a story hook arrives.

Session Zero Checklist (Player's Edition)

Session Zero Checklist

Answer these together and write down the answers where everyone can see them.

1. **Lines & Veils** – What content is off-limits (Lines) or only implied (Veils)?
2. **Tone** – Cinematic action? Grim survival? Political intrigue? Dark horror? Mix of several?
3. **Campaign length** – One-shot, short arc (3–6 sessions), or long campaign (12+ sessions)?
4. **Character hooks** – Each player shares one goal and one fear for their character.
5. **Patron interest** – Which Patrons (if any) are already watching the party?
6. **Starting situation** – Where does the story begin?
7. **House rules** – Any optional subsystems (Threat Pool, Deck of Consequences, etc.) the GM plans to use?
8. **Scheduling & attendance** – How often do you meet? What happens if a player misses a session?

Taking thirty minutes for Session Zero will save hours of mid-campaign friction and give you a richer, more invested table.

Guide Structure

This Player's Guide contains:

- **chapter 2** — Action resolution, Position, Difficulty Values, Story Beats, Boons, and basic combat.
- **chapter 7** — Attributes, Skills, dice pools, Experience Points, and the Tier system.
- **chapter 9** — Special abilities that define your character's style.
- **chapter 5** — The five magical paths (Free Caster, Runekeeper, Invoker, Cantor, Summoner).
- **chapter 6** — How to recover Fatigue and Harm.
- **chapter 12** — Off-screen holdings and on-screen allies.
- **chapter 17** — No coin; use XP, Strings, and Debt Timers.
- **chapter 14** — The peoples, lands, and factions of Fate's Edge.
- **chapter 15** — The Patrons and their Rites, Obligation, and Corruption.
- **chapter 11** — Ten example characters to inspire you.
- **chapter 20** — Tactical advice, momentum banking, and optional rules.
- **chapter 13** — What you do between adventures.
- **chapter 19** — Passing the torch to a successor.

Quick Reference: Where to Find It

Use this one-page guide to jump straight to the rules you need at the table.

What you need	Where to look
Core resolution (roll dice, DV, outcomes)	chapter 2
Position & Effect	section 2.8 (Core Mechanics)
Magic (paths, rites, backlash)	chapter 5
Travel (legs, timers, roles)	section 16.4 (World Interaction)
Story Beats (SB)	section 2.9 (Core Mechanics)
Boons (earning, spending, limits)	section 2.7 (Core Mechanics)
Assets & Followers	chapter 12

How to Use This Book

Read cover to cover or jump to relevant sections. Each chapter stands alone while connecting to broader themes. The SRD provides full mechanical detail; this guide focuses on character creation, setting, and player-facing options.

Getting Started

This is a game of bold choices and lasting consequences. Your story is written in decisions—not dice rolls.

Welcome to the Edge. The world is watching.

What will you risk to reshape the world?

1.1 The Philosophy of Narrative First

In Fate’s Edge, the story is not a byproduct of the rules—it is the reason the rules exist. When you sit down to play, you are not rolling dice to see what happens; you are telling a story together, with dice as your co-authors. This is the *narrative first* philosophy.

1.1.1 Why Narrative First?

Imagine this scene:

Your character, a wounded duelist, faces the baron’s champion in the royal arena. Your legs ache from the earlier fight, and the crowd’s roar has become a physical pressure. You know one strike will end it—but you also know you are one misstep from death.

Now consider two ways this might play out:

- **Mechanics-First Approach:** “I roll Body 3 + Melee 2 to attack. I get 3 successes. The baron’s champion has 2 Harm. I win.”
- **Narrative-First Approach:** “I lunge forward, my blade a silver arc against the red of the arena sand. But my injured leg buckles—I spend 1 Boon to re-roll the die that came up 1—and I twist to drive my shoulder into his chest instead. The crowd roars as we both fall to the sand, my blade at his throat.” GM: “You have the advantage, but your wound has reopened.”

What do you do?"

The first version tells you who won. The second tells you *how* you won and what it cost you. This is the heart of narrative first: your choices matter not because of numbers on a sheet, but because of the story they create.

1.1.2 Your Role in the Story

In Fate's Edge, you are:

- **A storyteller** — Your descriptions shape the world.
- **An active participant** — Your choices drive the narrative.
- **A co-creator** — You and the GM build the story together.

This means:

- **Flavor is free:** Describe how you fight, what your character looks like, or what the world feels like—no mechanical cost, only story enrichment. *Example:* "I parry with the grace of a dancer, my movements a memory of my mother's training, even as blood drips from my brow."
- **Describe your action before rolling:** Do not just say "I attack"—show us how. This informs the GM's response and often determines Position (Dominant, Controlled, Desperate). *Example:* "I use the crowd's noise as cover to slip behind him and strike his exposed back." (Likely *Dominant Position*.)
- **Embrace failure as opportunity:** A miss is not "you fail to hit." It is "the blade glances off his armor, and you see the baron's hand reach for the hilt of his dagger." Failures should always move the story forward.

1.1.3 The Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. If you find yourself asking "What's the optimal move?" try reframing it as "What would be most interesting for the story?"

Remember

In Fate's Edge, the dice do not determine your success or failure. *You* determine the story. The dice just help decide which path you take to get there.

1.1.4 Flavor is Free (Even for Mundane Actions)

Flavor is Free

Players: Add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or requiring rolls. **This applies to all descriptive actions, not just magic.** Want your Vhasian duelist to parry with a flourish from royal fencing schools? Go ahead. Want to describe the eerie silence of a Valewood ruin when searching for clues? Perfect. Want to narrate how you reload your crossbow with a practiced flick of the wrist? Even better. Flavor enriches the narrative without changing mechanical outcomes. Describe your character's background, customs, or scene details. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate. Mechanics determine success or failure, but flavor determines the story we tell about it.

Narrative-Heavy Gameplay Options (Optional)

For groups that prefer strong narrative focus, consider these approaches:

- **Collaborative Scene Framing:** Players may suggest scene elements (weather, NPC reactions, environmental details) that fit the fiction, with GM approval.
- **Intent-Driven Resolution:** When success is reasonably assured, the GM may ask players to describe *how* they accomplish their goal rather than rolling.
- **Flashback Declarations:** Spend 1 Boon to declare a flashback establishing past preparation, and describe the scene.
- **Descriptive Assistance:** Players can assist each other by providing vivid descriptions, granting a +1 die to the primary actor's roll.
- **Narrative Control Points:** Each player starts each session with 1 Narrative Control Point. Spend it to:
 - Introduce a minor NPC who provides useful information or assistance.
 - Establish that they have a useful item on hand (within reason).
 - Create a favorable environmental detail.

These points refresh each session and encourage proactive storytelling.

What's Next?

The next chapter ([chapter 2](#)) covers the core mechanics that drive play. If you are eager to build a character, jump ahead to [chapter 7](#) (Attributes & Skills). For an overview of the world, see [chapter 14](#) (World Regions and Cultures).

Now close the book—or keep reading. The road is waiting.

Chapter 2

Core Mechanics

A Word from the Raven Road

*“The road remembers. Every broken wheel leaves a mark, every lit lamp bears witness. The only question is: what are you willing to owe?” — Dusana of the Raven Road, *The Hearth Ledger**

2.1 The 90-Second Play Loop

At the heart of every scene is a simple, fast loop that keeps the story moving:

1. **GM sets the stage** – Describe the situation and ask “What do you do?”
2. **Player declares intent and approach** – State what you want to achieve and how (Attribute + Skill).
3. **GM sets Position and Difficulty Value (DV)** – Choose Dominant/Controlled/Desperate and a DV (2–5+).
4. **Player rolls dice** – Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).
5. **Apply outcome** – Compare Successes to DV (Clean Success / Success with SB / Partial / Miss).
6. **GM spends Story Beats (SB)** – Introduce complications, advance timers, or escalate the scene.
7. **Player marks resources** – Gain Boons (1 on Partial, 2 on Miss), track Fatigue/Harm, update Obligation, etc.
8. **Pass the spotlight** – Next player acts, or GM frames a new beat.

This loop should take about 90 seconds per player action. If it drags, simplify: focus on intent, one roll, and a clear consequence.

2.2 The Core Resolution Cycle

Every meaningful action in Fate’s Edge follows this cycle:

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** State what you want to achieve and how (Attribute + Skill).
2. **GM sets Difficulty Value (DV):** Based on narrative stakes (see 2.5).

3. **GM sets Position:** Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate (see 2.8).
4. **Roll dice pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s.
5. **Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).**
6. **Check against DV using the Outcome Matrix** (see 2.6).
7. **Apply outcome:** Clean Success, Success with SB, Partial, or Miss.
8. **GM spends Story Beats (SB)** for complications and twists.

Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. If you find yourself asking “What’s the optimal move?” try reframing it as “What would be most interesting for the story?”

2.3 Player-Managed Modules

In Fate’s Edge, you are the primary manager of your character’s mechanical state. This isn’t just about convenience—it is a core design principle that reduces GM overhead and keeps you engaged.

You Track Your Own Story

What You Manage:

- Obligation tracks (one per Patron or Symbol)
- Corruption timers (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers)
- Leash timers (summoned spirits)
- Asset states (Flourishing, Stable, Strained, Collapsed)
- Follower states (Loyalty: Faithful/Strained/Broken; Fitness: Ready/Hurt/Down)
- Progression timers (Repertoire, Spirit Bond)
- Boons, Favor, Leverage

Your Responsibilities:

1. **Mark immediately** when a rule says “mark +X”.
2. **Declare thresholds** (“My Obligation is full!”).
3. **Keep it visible** (use trackers everyone can see).
4. **Maintain ownership** – you know your state best.

GM Support: The GM spot-checks and provides consequences, but you drive your character’s mechanical narrative.

Example: Tracking Your Obligation

A character with Spirit 2 and Presence 2 has an Obligation Capacity of 4. She invokes a Rite from Patron A (+1), then later Pushes a Rite from Patron B (+1), then Cracks the Seal on a Symbol (+2). She now has:

- Patron A: 1 segment
- Patron B: 1 segment
- Symbol (Invoker): 2 segments

Total Obligation = 4 → exactly at Capacity. No Fatigue yet. If she invokes one more Rite

from any Patron, she exceeds Capacity and marks **1 Fatigue** immediately.

2.4 Basic Dice Mechanics

When you attempt a significant action, roll a pool of ten-sided dice (d10s). The size of your pool is:

$$\text{Dice Pool} = \text{Attribute} + \text{Skill}$$

Attribute (1–5) Broad traits like Strength, Wit, or Charm.

Skill (0–5) Training in a specific area (e.g., Melee, Stealth, Arcana).

Lore of the Fall: The Weight of Numbers

“The Aeler count their breaths; the Aelaerem pour eight cups and stop. The ninth is not a number – it is a wound that hasn’t closed.” In Fate’s Edge, dice are not mere randomisers. They are the echo of every oath sworn, every debt unpaid. When you roll a 1, you feed the Hollow – and the Hollow feeds the story.

Reading the Dice

Each die that rolls **6 or higher** counts as a **Success**. Each die that rolls a **1** generates a **Story Beat (SB)**.

Die Result	Effect
6–10	+1 Success
1	+1 Story Beat (SB)
2–5	Nothing

2.4.0.0.1 Example: Lyra (Agility 3 + Stealth 2 = 5 dice) rolls: 6, 4, 3, 1, 6 → 2 Successes, 1 SB. The DV is 2 – she succeeds, but the GM has 1 SB to spend (perhaps a guard stirs).

When to Roll

You roll only when:

- The outcome is uncertain, **and**
- Failure would matter to the story, **and**
- The action is significant enough to deserve a spotlight.

For routine actions with no real risk, the group can simply agree that you succeed. *Example:* Climbing a knotted rope in calm weather → no roll. Climbing the same rope while goblins shoot arrows → roll.

2.5 Difficulty Value (DV)

The Game Master sets a **Difficulty Value** – the target number of Successes needed.

Difficulty Value (DV) Ladder

DV	Situation
2	Routine, no pressure
3	Pressured, mild opposition (default)
4	Difficult, active resistance
5	Extreme, high stakes
6+	Nearly impossible, mythic challenge

DV 3 is the default. If the GM calls for a roll, something is at stake. Do not inflate DVs – they already do their job.

2.6 The Outcome Matrix

Compare your Successes to the DV to determine the outcome.

Outcome Matrix

Outcome	What It Means
Clean Success ($S \geq DV$)	You achieve your goal without complication.
Success with SB ($S \geq DV$, $SB > 0$)	You succeed, but the GM spends SB to add a twist.
Partial ($0 < S < DV$)	You make progress, but the situation remains unresolved. You gain 1 Boon.
Miss ($S = 0$)	You fail, and the situation escalates. You gain 2 Boons.

2.6.0.0.1 What a Partial Means. A Partial is not failure – it moves the story forward. Examples:

- Improve your Position for the next attempt (see 2.8).
- Reduce the effective DV of the next roll.
- Succeed at reduced scale or duration.
- Reveal information or open a new path.

Fail Forward

A **Miss** is never “nothing happens.” The GM must introduce a complication, advance a timer, or reveal a hidden danger. You gain 2 Boons – the story moves, and you get resources to try again.

Example: You fail to pick a lock (Miss). The GM says: “Your pick snaps, but you hear the guard’s footsteps – he’s about to turn the corner. You have one beat to hide.” The story advances.

2.6.1 Critical Successes

A roll of **10** counts as **two Successes**. If the roll succeeds, each 10 adds narrative weight.

10s Effect

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Strong success – improve your Position by one step on your next action this scene, or gain a minor ad |
| 2 | Exceptional success – choose two benefits from the list above. |
| 3 | Legendary success – decisive victory; clear 1 segment from a relevant timer. |
| 4+ | Mythic success – reshape the scene; clear 1–2 segments from a relevant timer. |

Important: A roll showing a **10** is never re-rolled, even by Position effects or other mechanics. Critical effects apply only if the overall roll succeeds.

Example: Rolling a 10

Lyra rolls 3 dice: **10**, 8, 1. She gets: 2 successes (from the 10) + 1 success (from the 8) = 3 successes. The roll also generates 1 SB (from the 1). Because she rolled a 10, the GM grants an extra benefit: “Your arrow pierces the bandit’s shoulder – he drops his sword.” (*Narrative benefit chosen by GM.*)

2.7 Boons

Boons represent momentum and narrative leverage. You may hold up to **5 Boons**.

Lore of the Velvet Touch

“The coin that never spends is the one you don’t remember taking.” Boons are the thief’s best friend – a second chance when the lock clicks wrong, a sudden shadow when the guard turns. In Silkstrand, they say a Boon is a debt to luck, and luck always collects.

Why You Should Spend Boons – The Math of Fun

Hoarding Boons for XP conversion leads to less engagement and lower fun scores.

Every Boon you hold is a dramatic moment waiting to happen:

- Re-rolling a critical failure turns despair into triumph.
- Improving Position before a risky roll turns a Desperate gamble into a Controlled chance.
- Activating an Asset brings your character’s network into the story.

XP from Boons is a trickle (max 2 per session). The real reward is *agency*. Spend Boons freely – they are not XP tokens.

Example: You have 3 Boons. Instead of converting them later, use 1 to re-roll a missed lockpick, another to improve your Position before a fight, and save the last for an emergency. That is how legends are made.

2.7.1 Earning Boons

- **Partial Success:** Gain 1 Boon (see 2.6).
- **Miss:** Gain 2 Boons.
- **Bond-Driven Action:** Once per bond per session, gain 1 Boon when an action meaningfully

engages that bond (see Chapter 18 for establishing Bonds).

- **GM Award:** For creativity, sacrifice, or strong narrative play.

When not awarded: Safe rehearsal, null-risk probes, or repeated identical attempts in the same scene do not generate Boons.

2.7.2 Spending Boons

- Re-roll a single die (after seeing the result)
- Activate an on-screen Asset (1 Boon)
- Improve Position by 1 step before a roll (see 2.8)
- Power certain Rites or abilities (see 5)
- Convert to XP (2 Boons = 1 XP, once per session during downtime, max 2 XP per session)

2.7.2.0.1 Substituting Fatigue for Boons If you have no Boons remaining (or wish to conserve them), you may pay **1 Fatigue** in place of 1 Boon to activate any effect that normally costs a Boon. This represents pushing through exhaustion, relying on raw effort, or accepting a minor physical toll. The GM may veto this substitution if the fiction makes it implausible (e.g., activating a delicate Asset while exhausted). Using this option does not change the effect's outcome or generate additional Story Beats; it simply changes the resource spent.

2.7.3 Carryover Limit

At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of **2**. Excess are lost – spend them or lose them.

2.8 Position

Every action takes place from a **Position** that reflects the character's advantage.

Position Effects

Position	Narrative Frame	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	You press your advantage	Re-roll one <i>failure</i> .
Controlled	Balanced norm	No re-rolls.
Desperate	You act under duress	Re-roll one <i>success</i> .
You can spend 1 Boon to improve Position by one step before rolling. The GM can spend 2 SB to worsen your Position by one step (after the roll).		

Important: A roll showing a **10** is never re-rolled, even by Desperate position.

A Vhasian Duelist's Lesson

“On the Pont-du-Tithe, Position is everything. Stand with the sun at your back – you are Dominant. Feet on a slippery plank – Desperate. The bridge does not care for your pride.”
Your Position is the story's judgement of your risk. Change the fiction, and Position follows.

2.8.0.0.1 Boon Interaction with Fatigue: When Fatigue forces a success re-roll (see 2.10.1), spending 1 Boon negates *one* such re-roll. You may spend Boons after seeing the result of a Fatigue re-roll.

Boon Economy at a Glance

Action	Boon Change	
Partial Success	Gain 1 Boon	
Miss	Gain 2 Boons	
Bond-Driven Action	Gain 1 Boon (once/bond/session)	
GM Award	+1 Boon (rare)	Maximum
Re-roll a die	Spend 1 Boon	
Activate Asset	Spend 1 Boon	
Improve Position (before roll)	Spend 1 Boon	
Convert to XP (downtime)	Spend 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP/session)	

held: 5 Boons. At end of scene, reduce to **2** (excess lost).

Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) = How risky is this action? – determines severity of failure and re-rolls.

Effect (Limited/Standard/Great) = How much do you achieve on a success? – determines scope, scale, or quality.

Example: Disarming a trap – Limited Effect lets one person cross, Standard lets two, Great lets all four.

2.9 Story Beats (SB)

Story Beats are narrative tools the GM spends to introduce twists. They keep the story alive with complications.

2.9.1 SB Spend Examples

- **1 SB:** Minor complication – noise, trace, +1 Supply segment.
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback – alarm raised, lose cover, lesser foe appears, or advance a faction or front timer by 1 segment.
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble – reinforcements, key gear breaks.
- **4+ SB:** Major turn – trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts.

2.9.1.0.1 Player Advice: Don't fear Story Beats – they are fuel for drama, not punishment. Every time you roll a 1, you give the GM a spark. That spark can light a fire that makes the story burn brighter.

2.10 Harm and Fatigue

2.10.1 Fatigue Track

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to **Body**. Mark Fatigue for exertion, magical strain, or stress.

- Each Fatigue step worsens your Position: Dominant → Controlled → Desperate (see 2.8).
- If already Desperate, apply –1 die per Fatigue instead.
- Penalties from Fatigue and Harm **stack**. For example, a character with Harm 1 (–1 die) who is also Desperate from Fatigue suffers both penalties.
- **Overflow**: When the track fills, increase Harm by 1 step (see 2.10.3) and clear all Fatigue.
- **Recovery**: Short rest clears 1–2 Fatigue; full night’s rest clears all.

Aeler Breath-Counting

“The Deep Accountants say: eight breaths is a corridor, sixteen is a chamber, thirty-two is a fool who forgot to turn back. Fatigue is your breath running out – mark it, or the mountain will mark you.” Fatigue is not just tiredness; it is the weight of every hard choice you’ve already made.

2.10.2 The Roller-Coaster Effect (Taking Harm Clears Fatigue)

When you take Harm, the shock of the wound temporarily clears your Fatigue. This creates natural dramatic swings – a character near collapse who takes a wound and suddenly finds a second wind.

2.10.2.0.1 Example: Mateo is at Fatigue 3 (Desperate, –2 dice). A goblin stabs him for Harm 1. Following the procedure in 2.10.4, the Harm clears his Fatigue (step 2), then he adds the converted Fatigue (step 3). He ends with Harm 1, Fatigue 0 – wounded but clear-headed.

2.10.3 Harm Levels

Harm Level	Effect
Harm 1	–1 die on related actions
Harm 2	–1 die on most actions until treated
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying

2.10.4 Taking Harm and Fatigue – The Procedure

When you are hit, follow these steps **in order**:

1. **Convert** incoming Harm to Fatigue using the Armor Conversion Table below. *Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.*
2. **Apply remaining Harm** – if any Harm remains after conversion, increase your Harm level by that amount, and **clear all existing Fatigue** (the shock of a wound resets your exhaustion).
3. **Add the Fatigue** from step 1 to your Fatigue track. If this fills or exceeds your track, resolve **Overflow** (see 2.10.1).

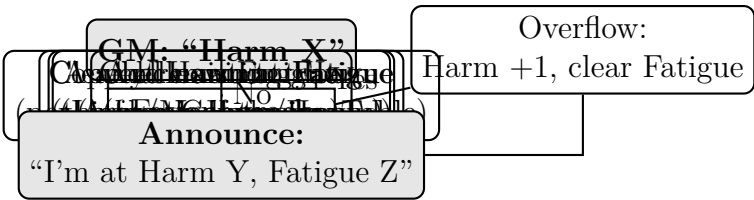


Figure 2.1: Taking Harm and Fatigue – The Procedure (see 2.10.4)

2.10.4.0.1 Armor Conversion Table

Armor Type	Incoming Harm		
	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.

2.10.4.0.2 Examples

- **Light Armor, Harm 2:** Result is Harm 1, Fatigue 1. Apply Harm (clears existing Fatigue, Harm 0→1), then add Fatigue 1. (If you had Fatigue before, it is cleared first.)
- **Heavy Armor, Harm 3:** Result is Fatigue 2. No Harm taken. Add Fatigue 2.
- **Heavy Armor, Harm 1:** Result is Fatigue 1. No Harm taken. Add Fatigue 1.
- **Overflow example:** Body 2, currently 1 Fatigue, Heavy Armor hit with Harm 3 → result Fatigue 2. Total Fatigue becomes 1+2=3, which fills the track (max 2). Overflow triggers: Harm 0→1, clear all Fatigue. Final: Harm 1, Fatigue 0.

2.10.5 Recovery

- **Fatigue:** Short rest (food/water) removes 2 Fatigue; full night removes all.
- **Harm:** Requires medical care and time – minor treatment downgrades Harm, proper care removes it.

2.11 Initiative and Turn Order

2.11.0.0.1 Default: Narrative Initiative. Fate's Edge does not use fixed initiative. Turn order follows the fiction:

- **Narrative Fiat:** The GM frames spotlight order based on circumstances.
- **Player Input:** Players may suggest acting when it makes sense.
- **Surprise:** Ambushers act first; targets respond after.
- **Flexibility:** Spotlight may shift mid-scene if fictionally appropriate.

(Optional structured initiative systems – popcorn, side-based, speed slots – are available in the GM Guide if your table prefers them.)

2.11.1 Turn Economy (Quick Rules)

Each character takes **1 Action and 1 Move** on their turn. Actions and Moves may be taken in any order; repeating the same Action is not allowed unless noted.

2.11.1.0.1 Move: Traverse up to **one range band** (Close $\rightarrow$ Near $\rightarrow$ Far, or the reverse).

- **Stand:** Use your Move to stand from prone.

Action	Effect	Notes
Attack	Make melee or ranged attack against a target.	Ranged in Close is Desperate .
Disengage	Enable safe movement.	Your Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; you cannot Attack this turn.
Shove	Push a target back one range band (Close → Near).	Opposed Body + Athletics vs. Body + Athletics. On success, target moves back and suffers −1 Position on their next action.
Grapple	Seize a target to restrain or control.	Opposed Body + Melee vs. Body + Athletics. On success, both are Engaged (cannot move apart). Grappled target suffers −1 die on all actions. Breaking free requires a new opposed roll as an action.
Charge (Full turn)	Move two bands toward an enemy + make one melee attack.	Costs 1 Fatigue, next defense Desperate, requires open ground. Leaving Close range during a Charge provokes opportunity attacks as normal.
Skirmish (Full turn)	Move two bands away from an enemy + make one ranged attack.	Costs 1 Fatigue, next defense Desperate, requires open ground. Leaving Close range during a Skirmish provokes opportunity attacks as normal.
Observe / Change Position	Gain +1 Position once.	Once per turn.
Setup (Team)	Grant an ally +1 Position or stop	Requires a roll (typ

2.11.1.0.2 Action Options:

2.11.1.0.3 Sidestep Strike (Closing or Stepping Back) As part of a melee attack action, you may move **one range band** (Close $\leftrightarrow$ Near, or Near $\leftrightarrow$ Far) without using your Move action for the turn. If you do so, your Position for that attack worsens by one step (e.g., Controlled becomes Desperate, Dominant becomes Controlled). You cannot also use your regular Move action in the same turn.

This represents a daring lunge to close distance or a quick step back to create space, sacrificing safety for tactical positioning.

- **Example (Rogue):** Lyra is at Near range with a knife (light weapon). She declares a Sidestep Strike, moving into Close range as she attacks. Her Position drops from Controlled to Desperate, but she now benefits from the knife's Close bonus (+2d). She rolls with the Desperate re-roll (successes are re-rolled once) but gets +2 dice from her weapon.
- **Example (Spear Fighter):** Mateo is at Close range with a spear (medium weapon, +1d at Close, +2d at Near). He steps back to Near as part of his attack, worsening his Position from Controlled to Desperate, but gains +2d instead of +1d.

2.11.1.0.4 Opportunity Attacks Leaving an enemy's **Close** range without using *Disengage* provokes one free melee attack (Controlled Position, no action cost). Additionally, the following actions provoke an opportunity attack if performed while **engaged in Close** with an enemy:

- Making a ranged attack (bow, crossbow, thrown weapon).
- Casting a spell that does not have the [TOUCH] or [WARD] attribute.

A **Charge** or **Skirmish** that takes you out of an enemy's Close range provokes an opportunity attack as usual (unless you used *Disengage* beforehand). Using **Sidestep Strike** to leave Close range also provokes an opportunity attack unless you also used *Disengage*.

2.11.1.0.5 Position and Dice Modifiers

- **Position ladder:** Desperate $\rightarrow$ Controlled $\rightarrow$ Dominant.
- **Improving Position:** Each step above Dominant grants **+1 die** instead.
- **Worsening Position:** Each step below Desperate imposes **-1 die** instead.
- **Example:** If bonuses would raise Position two steps above Dominant, you gain **+2 dice**. If penalties would drop you two steps below Desperate, you suffer **-2 dice**.

2.11.1.0.6 Caveats and Talents:

- **Charge** and **Skirmish** require open ground (no difficult terrain) unless a talent says otherwise (see 9).
- Talents such as *Effortless Charge* (4 XP) or *Effortless Skirmish* (4 XP) allow ignoring the Fatigue cost once per scene.
- The *Relentless* talent (6 XP) allows Charge or Skirmish over difficult terrain (Fatigue cost still applies).

Combat in Brief

- **Turn:** 1 Action + 1 Move.
- **Move:** Close ↔ Near ↔ Far.
- **Attack:** Roll Attribute + Skill vs. DV (enemy's defense). Ranged attack while in Close range → Desperate.
- **Shove:** Opposed Body + Athletics vs. Body + Athletics. Push target one band.
- **Grapple:** Opposed Body + Melee vs. Body + Athletics. Both Engaged; target suffers -1 die.
- **Sidestep Strike:** Move one band as part of a melee attack; worsen Position by one step.
- **Harm:** When you hit, the target marks Harm (see 2.10.4). Enemies use the same Harm levels as players.
- **Fatigue:** Each point worsens your Position (or -1 die if already Desperate). Taking Harm clears Fatigue – the “roller-coaster”.
- **Timers:** GMs often use timers for reinforcements, environmental collapse, or enemy morale.

Full combat rules are in Chapter ?? (GM Guide).

2.12 Weapons & Armor

Silkstrand Steel

“A Light blade is a courtier’s promise – fast, elegant, easy to hide. A Heavy blade is a condotta captain’s ultimatum – slow, brutal, and final.” Choose your weight as you choose your words. Both can cut.

2.12.1 Weapons by Weight Class

- **Light (4 XP)** – fast, concealable.
- **Medium (8 XP)** – balanced, battlefield standard.
- **Heavy (12 XP)** – punishing, slow.

2.12.2 Melee Modifiers

Weight	Close	Near	Notes
Light	+2d	+1d	Quick in tight quarters
Medium	+1d	+2d	Set once/scene or -1d first attack
Heavy	-1d	+3d	Set once/scene or -2d first attack

2.12.3 Ranged & Tempo

Ranged weapons have a **Tempo** that determines how they interact with movement, aiming, and reloading.

2.12.3.0.1 Tempo Types

Fast – You may **Move and Shoot in the same turn**. *Examples:* throwing knives, light crossbow (if pre-loaded), sling.

Standard – You may either **Move** or **Shoot** on your turn, not both. As a special action, you may **Aim** (gain +1d or +1 Effect on your next shot), but Aim replaces your attack that turn. *Examples:* longbow, heavy crossbow (if pre-loaded), musket.

Slow – The weapon requires a **full round to load** (or set/brace). *Round 1:* Use your action to load (no attack). You may still move, but moving while loading is at Desperate Position unless you have a talent. *Round 2:* Shoot (and may move afterwards). Then you must reload again for another shot. *Examples:* ballista, hand-cannon, heavy arquebus.

2.12.3.0.2 Ranged Modifiers by Weight

Weight	Tempo	Close	Near	Far
Light (4 XP)	Fast	Controlled	+1d	—
Medium (8 XP)	Standard	Desperate	+2d	+1d
Heavy (12 XP)	Slow	Desperate	+1d	+3d

2.12.3.0.3 Tempo Quick Reference

Tempo	Move + Shoot?	Aim Option?	Reload Required
Fast	Yes (same turn)	No	None (or free)
Standard	No (move or shoot)	Yes (+1d/+1 Effect)	None (Aim costs action)
Slow	No (load one turn, shoot next)	No	Full round

2.12.4 Weapon Tags (Optional, +4 XP each, max 2)

Reach, Close, Accurate, Brutal, Hook, Concealable, Quickdraw, Two-Handed, Off-Hand.

2.12.5 Shields (Optional)

Shield	XP	Benefit	Tradeoff
Buckler	4	+1d Defend vs melee or +1 DV once	Off-hand occupied
Heater	8	+1d Defend; convert 1 Harm→1 Fatigue	–1d Ranged
Pavise	12	Plant: heavy cover cone	Slow to move; bulky

2.12.6 Armor

Armor	XP	Conversion (Harm → Fatigue)	Penalty
Light	4	1→1 (minimum 1 Fatigue per hit)	—
Medium	8	2→1 (minimum 1 Fatigue per hit)	–1d physical skills
Heavy	12	3→2 (minimum 1 Fatigue per hit)	–2d physical, no sprint in rough

Notes: Conversion is applied per Harm instance before marking Fatigue. See 2.10.4 for the full step-by-step procedure.

2.12.7 Condition & Upkeep

Neglected Weapons: –1d; Armor: conversion worsened by one step (e.g., Light behaves as no armor, Heavy as Medium).

Compromised Weapons: –1d first attack each round; Armor: no conversion.

Fix: Short rest with tools removes Neglected (no roll required). A scene of work or a smith removes Compromised; a successful Craft roll (DV 3) can reduce the time to a short rest.

2.13 Ranged Options

- **Aim:** +1 die or +1 Effect next shot (lost if you Move or are disrupted).
- **Volley:** Spend extra ammo for +1 die (max +2).
- **Suppress:** Zone under fire; foes there act at –1 die or Limited Effect until they shift cover.
- **Overwatch:** Ready a Controlled shot on a clear trigger crossing your line.

2.14 Followers and Assets

2.14.1 Followers

Followers are named NPCs with a personal relationship to your character. They:

- Assist during scenes via Bonds and Assists (see Chapter 18).
- Act offscreen to gather information or manage tasks.
- Have motives and vulnerabilities – the GM may place them at risk.

Followers are not disposable tools. They can grow, change, or be lost.

2.14.1.1 Follower States

Instead of numeric timers, track a follower's **Loyalty** and **Fitness** as one of three states each.

State	Meaning	Mechanical Effect
<i>Loyalty</i>		
Faithful	Committed, trustworthy	Normal assist, independent actions available
Strained	Doubtful, pressured	Assist at –1 die; may refuse risky orders
Broken	Betrayed or deserted	Follower leaves or becomes hostile
<i>Fitness</i>		
Ready	Uninjured, rested	Full function
Hurt	Wounded, exhausted	Assist at –1 die; no independent actions
Down	Incapacitated	Requires rescue or medical care

Change states when the fiction demands it (e.g., after a failed mission, a moral compromise, or taking damage). No rolls required.

2.14.1.2 High-Capability Followers (Cap 4–5)

Followers with Capability 4 or 5 are trusted lieutenants, stewards, or commanders. They can be delegated the management of your Assets, freeing you from direct oversight.

- A **Cap 4** follower can be delegated **up to 2 Assets**.

- A **Cap 5** follower can be delegated **up to 4 Assets**.

When an Asset is delegated to a follower, the follower's own upkeep (paid in XP or downtime action) **automatically covers the upkeep of those Assets** – you do not pay separate Asset upkeep. The follower handles the logistics, staff, or political maintenance as part of their role.

If the follower's Loyalty becomes **Strained** or **Broken**, all delegated Assets immediately become **Neglected** as well until the follower is restored. If a follower is **Compromised**, those assets are lost.

2.14.2 Assets

Assets are durable resources or positions under your control – safehouses, networks, political offices, relics. They:

- Create advantages that persist beyond a single scene.
- Resolve problems that dice alone cannot.
- Cost Boons to activate (the GM determines the impact).

Assets can be threatened, degraded, or lost. Overuse attracts attention.

2.14.2.1 Asset Status

Assets have a single unified **Status** that describes their overall health and usability.

Status	Meaning	Effect
Flourishing	Well-maintained, respected	+1 die on rolls involving the asset, +1 Yield
Stable	Normal operation	No modifier
Strained	Problems accumulating	–1 die on asset-related rolls, no Yield
Collapsed	Non-functional	Requires quest or major downtime to restore

The Status worsens when the asset is neglected, attacked, or suffers a public failure. It improves through dedicated downtime actions or successful missions that benefit the asset.

2.14.3 Followers vs. Assets

	Followers	Assets
Nature	People	Resources/Structures
Primary Role	Personal support	Strategic leverage
Activation	Assists (spend Boon) or narrative interaction	Boon expenditure
Risk	Emotional, narrative	Structural, political
Growth	Can become PCs	Can expand or collapse

2.14.3.0.1 Design Principle: Followers create *depth*. Assets create *reach*. High-tier play depends on managing both.

2.15 Game Structure

2.15.1 Time Scales

Moment A heartbeat, a single action.

Some Time A few minutes, a short activity.

Significant Time Hours, extended effort.

Days Large-scale endeavors.

2.15.2 Game Units

Scene Basic narrative unit, covers a specific conflict.

Session One game session (3–6 hours).

Campaign Entire story arc.

2.16 Action Resolution Steps

1. Describe your intent and method.
2. Build dice pool: Attribute + Skill (+ gear, assists).
3. Roll d10s; count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).
4. Compare Successes to DV.
5. Apply outcome from the Outcome Matrix (see 2.6).
6. GM spends SB if applicable (see 2.9).
7. Earn Boons for Partial or Miss (see 2.7).

Quick Reference

Dice Pool: Attribute + Skill d10s

Success: 6+ on each die

Story Beat: 1 on any die gives SB to GM

DV: 2 (easy) to 5+ (extreme) – default 3

Harm: 3-level system; see 2.10.4 for the procedure

Boons: 2 on miss, 1 on partial

2.17 Narrative Suggestions

- **Collaborative Scene Framing:** Players may suggest scene elements (weather, NPC reactions) with GM approval.
- **Intent-Driven Resolution:** If success is reasonably assured, the GM may ask players to describe *how* rather than roll.
- **Flashback Declarations:** Spend 1 Boon to declare a flashback establishing past preparation, and describe the scene.
- **Descriptive Assistance:** Players can assist by providing vivid descriptions, granting a +1 die to the primary actor.
- **Proactive Storytelling:** Players may suggest minor favorable details (a helpful NPC, a useful item on hand) subject to GM approval.

Core Mechanics Quick Reference

What	How
Dice Pool	Attribute + Skill d10s
Success	Die ≥ 6
Story Beat (SB)	Die = 1
Difficulty (DV)	Default 3 (2=easy, 4=hard, 5+=extreme)
Outcomes	Clean Success ($S \geq DV$, $SB=0$) Success with SB ($S \geq DV$, $SB > 0$) Partial ($0 < S < DV \rightarrow$ gain 1 Boon) Miss ($S=0 \rightarrow$ gain 2 Boons)
Boons	Max 5; trim to 2 at scene end. Spend: re-roll, improve Position, activate Asset, convert 2 $\rightarrow$ 1
Position	Dominant (re-roll failure), Controlled (normal), Desperate (re-roll success)
Fatigue	Worsens Position (or -1 die if Desperate). Full track $\rightarrow$ Harm+1, clear Fatigue.
Harm	1 (-1 die), 2 (-2 dice), 3 (incapacitated). Taking Harm clears Fatigue first.
Armor	Converts Harm to Fatigue; minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.
Sidestep Strike	Move one band as part of melee attack; worsen Position by one step.
Shove	Opposed Body + Athletics. Push target one band.
Grapple	Opposed Body + Melee. Both Engaged; target suffers -1 die.

Chapter 3

Character Creation Summary

Quick Start

This chapter walks you through building a character in about 10–15 minutes. Follow the steps in order. Most choices are guided by your character concept; the numbers come later.

3.1 Overview

You begin at **Tier I (Novice)** with **30 Experience Points (XP)**. You may gain up to **+4 XP** by taking meaningful **Bonds** (with other player characters) and **Complications** (see 3.8). Maximum starting XP: **34**.

Step	Where to Find Rules	Time
1. Concept	Anywhere	2 min
2. Attributes	7.1	2 min
3. Skills	7.2	2 min
4. Talents	9	3 min
5. Patron (optional)	15	2 min
6. Assets / Followers (optional)	12	1 min
7. Bonds & Complications	3.8	2 min
8. Gear & Final Touches	3.9	1 min

3.2 Step 1 – Concept

Write one sentence that describes your character’s **origin, profession, and one defining trait**. Examples:

- “An Aeler tunnel-wright who lost her breath-count and now hears stone sing.”
- “A Vhasian duelist with a scarred face and a vow to never lose again.”
- “A Ykrul sky-speaker who owes a blood-price to a rival clan.”

Also choose your character’s **ancestry** (see [14.20](#)):

- Small Folk (Aelaerem / Aelinnel)

- Aeler (dwarf)
- Lethai (wood, high, or dark elf)
- Ykrul (orc)
- Mixed Heritage
- Human (any culture: Ecktorian, Vhasian, Viterran, Linn, etc.)

3.3 Step 2 – Attributes

You have four **Attributes** (1–5). Spend XP to raise them from a base of 1 each.

3.3.0.0.1 Cost: $\text{new rating} \times 3 \text{ XP}$ per step.

3.3.0.0.2 Recommended starting ranges:

- Primary attribute (the one you use most): **3** (cost 9 XP)
- Secondary attributes: **2** each (cost 6 XP)

3.3.0.0.3 Example: Body 3 ($1 \rightarrow 2 = 6$, $2 \rightarrow 3 = 9 \rightarrow$ total 15 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Spirit 1, Presence 1 $\rightarrow$ 21 XP spent.

For detailed descriptions see [7.1](#).

3.4 Step 3 – Skills

Choose **Skills** (0–5) that match your concept. **Key skills** (used often) should be 2–3; others 0–1.

3.4.0.0.1 Cost: $\text{new level} \times 2 \text{ XP}$ per step.

3.4.0.0.2 Recommended starting total: Spend **8–12 XP** on skills.

3.4.0.0.3 Example: Melee 2 ($0 \rightarrow 1 = 2$, $1 \rightarrow 2 = 4 = 6$ XP), Athletics 1 (2 XP), Endurance 1 (2 XP) $\rightarrow$ total 10 XP.

See [7.2](#) for the full skill list.

3.5 Step 4 – Talents

Talents are special abilities. Start with **1–3 talents**. Many concepts work well with two minor talents (2–3 XP each) or one major talent (4–6 XP).

3.5.0.0.1 Magic access talents (if you want magic):

- **Spellcraft (6 XP)** – free casting
- **Familiar (2 XP) + Codex (4 XP)** – Runekeeper (rites)
- **Patron’s Symbol (4 XP)** – Invoker (rituals)
- **Cantor’s Path (8 XP)** – Cantor (songs)
- **Pact-Whisperer (2 XP) + Lesser Pactwright (2 XP)** – Summoner

3.5.0.0.2 Non-magic talents (examples):

- **Keen Senses (2 XP)** – +1 die to perception
- **Defensive Survival (3 XP)** – +1 die to melee defense, convert Harm to Fatigue
- **Weapon Mastery (5 XP)** – +2 dice with a chosen weapon

See 9 for the full list.

3.6 Step 5 – Patron (Optional)

If your character uses magic through a **Patron**, choose one (see 15). The six recommended for first characters are:

Patron	Theme
Oath of Flame & Light	vows, radiance, smiting
The Traveler	roads, safe passage
Inaea (Angel of the Spider)	mercy, community
The Witness	truth, memory
Carrion King	decay, renewal
Ikasha (She Who Sleeps)	shadows, secrets

You do **not** need a Patron if you are a free caster (Spellcraft) or a psion (optional).

3.6.1 Step 6 – Cultural Affinity

Choose a cultural affinity from the region where your character was raised (see Chapter 14). This grants a once-per-session benefit.

3.6.1.0.1 Note on Stacking. If your ancestral gift (from your people) and your cultural affinity provide the same benefit (e.g., both improve Position), they do not stack. You may use one per scene. Choose which applies when you need it.

3.7 Step 7 – Assets & Followers (Optional)

You may spend XP on:

- **Minor Asset (4 XP)** – e.g., a safehouse, a workshop
- **Follower (Cap² XP)** – e.g., Cap 2 scout (4 XP), Cap 3 lieutenant (9 XP)

Most starting characters skip these or take one minor asset. See 12.

3.8 Step 8 – Bonds & Complications

Bonds: Establish **two bonds** with other player characters. Each bond grants a one-per-session Boon when you act on it with an intricate description. At Tier III (90+ XP) bonds also allow Boon transfers.

Complications: You may take up to **two complications** (e.g., a feud, a cursed item, a debt). Each gives +2 XP but adds +1 **banked Story Beat** to early scenes. Work with your GM.

See 18 for examples.

3.9 Step 9 – Gear & Final Touches

3.9.0.0.1 Starting gear (assumed):

- One set of clothing appropriate to your culture
- A melee weapon (Light or Medium) or a ranged weapon with ammunition
- Light armor (or Medium if your concept demands it)
- A backpack, a waterskin, 1d6 days of rations, a knife, flint and steel, a small lantern or candle
- Any tools required for your skills (e.g., lockpicks, healer's kit, writing materials)

For special gear (heavy armor, heavy weapons, magical items), spend XP or acquire them through play.

3.9.0.0.2 Final XP tally:

- Start with **32 XP**.
- Add **+2 XP per Bond** (max +4).
- Add **+2 XP per Complication** (max +4).
- Maximum starting XP: **36**.

Spend all XP; you cannot bank starting XP.

3.9.0.0.3 Example build (36XP):

- Body 3 (15 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP) → 21 XP
- Melee 2 (6 XP), Athletics 1 (2 XP), Endurance 1 (2 XP) → 10 XP total 31
- Talent: Keen Senses (2 XP) → 33 XP
- Bond with another PC → +2 XP (now 35 – adjust by lowering one skill)

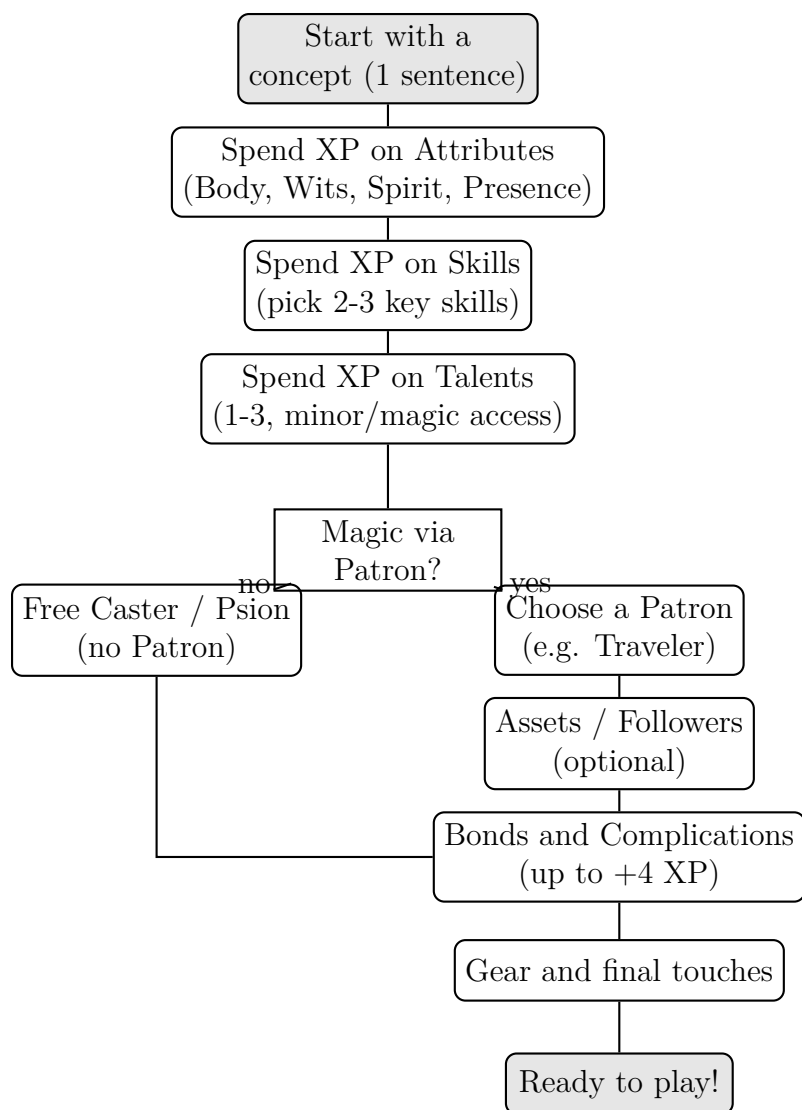
(Adjust to your table's needs.)

3.10 Next Steps

- Read [2](#) to learn how to roll dice, use Position, and spend Boons.
- Read [5](#) if your character uses magic.
- Read [16](#) for travel, time, and social rules.
- Work with your GM to decide on starting situation and campaign timers.

The Gray Wanderer's Advice

“Do not try to build a ‘perfect’ character. Build one who owes a debt, carries a scar, and has a name that someone will remember. The numbers will follow the story – not the other way around.”



Chapter 4

Gear, Magic Items, and Crafting

4.1 The Philosophy of Gear

In Fate’s Edge, your character’s possessions are described in the fiction, not tracked on a ledger. You have enough coin, barter, or credit to afford:

- Ordinary meals, lodging, and travel rations
- Basic tools (rope, lantern, writing kit, lockpicks)
- Small bribes (a drink, a gift)
- Routine transportation (ferry, caravan passage)

If the GM ever asks “Do you have enough?” the answer is usually **yes** – unless scarcity is the point of the scene.

4.2 Mundane Equipment

4.2.1 Weapons and Armor

Weapons and armor are covered in §2.12 (Core Mechanics). Briefly:

- **Light weapons (4 XP):** fast, concealable.
- **Medium weapons (8 XP):** balanced.
- **Heavy weapons (12 XP):** slow, powerful.
- **Light armor (4 XP):** converts 1 Harm → 1 Fatigue.
- **Medium armor (8 XP):** converts 2 Harm → 1 Fatigue, –1 die physical skills.
- **Heavy armor (12 XP):** converts 3 Harm → 2 Fatigue, –2 dice physical skills, no sprint in rough terrain.

You may acquire these with XP at character creation or later.

4.2.2 Adventuring Gear

You are assumed to have the following unless you are in a survival situation:

- Backpack, waterskin, 1d6 days of rations, a knife, flint and steel, a small lantern or candle

- Tools for any skill you have at level 1+ (e.g., lockpicks for Subterfuge, healer's kit for Medicine)
- A set of clothing appropriate to your culture

If you need something unusual (a climber's kit, a disguise, a rare herb), you may:

- Spend 1 Boon to declare you already have it (narrative permission).
- Spend 1 XP to acquire it (as a one-time resource).
- Acquire it as a minor asset (4 XP) if you want permanent access.

4.3 Magic Items

Magic items are not bought with gold. They are acquired by spending XP, completing quests, or crafting. A magic item is a **permanent asset** that grants a mechanical benefit. It requires **upkeep** (see below).

4.3.1 Cost Basis: Talent Equivalents

A magic item's effect is roughly equivalent to a **Talent** (see 9). Use the Talent XP cost as the base price, then apply a **discount** because items can be lost, stolen, or broken.

Effect Power	Talent Cost	Magic Item Cost (XP)
Minor (e.g., +1 die to a narrow skill once/scene)	2–3 XP	2 XP
Major (e.g., +1 die to a broad skill always)	4–6 XP	4 XP
Prestige (e.g., once/session reroll a failed save)	7–10 XP	6 XP
Epic (e.g., teleport once/day)	11+ XP	8 XP

Discount reason: A Talent is permanently attached to your character; an item can be taken away. The discount also covers the need for upkeep.

4.3.2 Sample Magic Items

Name	Cost (XP)	Effect
Emberfang Dagger	2	When drawn, glows faintly if undead are within Near. Once per scene, gain +1 die to detect hidden spirits.
Storm Lantern	4	Once per session, as an action, create a gust of wind that extinguishes all mundane flames in Near and gives +1 Position to disengage.
Cloak of the Unseen	4	+1 die to Stealth in dim light. Once per scene, reroll a failed Stealth check.
Vial of the Last Breath	2 (consumable)	Heal 1 Fatigue when drunk. One use.
Pendant of the Witness	6	Once per session, when you detect a lie, the liar suffers 1 Fatigue (no save).

Raven's Key	8	Once per day, as an action, unlock any mundane lock or open any door that is not magically sealed.
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4.3.3 Attunement and Upkeep

A character may be **attuned** to up to 3 magic items at a time (attunement takes a short rest). During each downtime, you must pay **upkeep** for each magic item you keep attuned:

- **Efficient:** Pay XP equal to the item's cost divided by 3 (rounded up, minimum 1). You spend minimal effort.
- **Intensive:** Pay 1 XP and describe a downtime scene where you maintain the item (cleaning, recharging, appeasing its spirit).

If you neglect upkeep, the item becomes **Neglected** (no benefit until you pay the upkeep retroactively). If neglected for two consecutive downtimes, it becomes **Compromised** (requires a quest to restore).

4.3.4 Losing Magic Items

If you lose a magic item (theft, destruction, sacrifice), you lose the XP you spent on it. The GM may allow you to recover it as a story hook. You may also choose to “retire” an item (sell it, trade it, give it away) and regain half its XP cost (rounded down) to spend on something else.

4.4 Crafting Magic Items

Crafting a permanent magic item is a **campaign-level project**. It requires:

- A character with relevant skills: **Arcana 3+** and **Craft 2+** (or appropriate specialty).
- A workspace (e.g., a workshop asset, a consecrated forge).
- Rare components (obtained through adventuring – the GM will decide).
- A **Downtime Project Timer** (6–12 segments). Each segment requires a scene or a downtime action.
- The XP cost of the item (see table above) – paid when the timer is completed.

4.4.1 Crafting Procedure

1. **Design:** Describe what the item does. The GM sets the Tier (Minor/Major/Prestige/Epic) and XP cost.
2. **Quest:** The GM frames a short arc to obtain a rare component (e.g., “a phoenix feather”, “the heart of a storm elemental”).
3. **Downtime Timer :** Roll **Wits + Craft** or **Wits + Arcana** each downtime. Each success advances the timer by 1. Partial successes create complications (lost components, attracting attention). On a failure, the timer may tick backwards.
4. **Completion:** When the timer fills, you pay the XP and the item is complete. The GM may add a final, optional cost (e.g., “it also consumes a memory”).

4.4.2 Crafting Consumables

One-use items (potions, scrolls, runestones) are much easier. Crafting a consumable:

- Takes a single downtime action (no timer).
- Costs **1 XP** per consumable (or 2 XP for a powerful one).
- Requires an appropriate skill roll (DV 3) – on a failure, the components are wasted.
- No upkeep required.

Examples: *Healing potion* (restores 1 Fatigue), *Sight scroll* (grants +1 die to Investigation for one scene), *Thunderstone* (ranged attack, Harm 1 to a small area).

4.5 Upgrading Mundane Gear

You may also spend XP to give a mundane item a permanent magical property. Use the same costs as magic items. The process is faster than crafting from scratch (no rare component quest, just a downtime timer of 4–6 segments).

4.6 Summary for Players

- Ordinary gear is free – describe what you carry.
- Weapons and armor cost XP (light 4, medium 8, heavy 12).
- Magic items cost XP based on Talent equivalents (2–8 XP).
- Magic items require upkeep (XP or downtime scene) each downtime.
- Crafting a magic item is a long project involving a timer, rare components, and XP.

The Gray Wanderer's Tip

“A magic sword is not a toy. It is a creditor. It demands maintenance, attention, and sometimes a blood-price. If you cannot afford the upkeep, do not pick it up. The edge is not worth the interest.”

4.7 Artifacts: Items That Owe You (And You Owe Them)

The coin that never spends is the one you don't remember taking. The blade that never dulls is the one you never truly own.

Most magic items are tools – you pay XP, you keep them, you maintain them. **Artifacts** are different. They are not crafted; they are inherited, discovered, or earned through story. An artifact has a will of its own, however faint. It remembers every hand that held it, every oath spoken over it, every debt left unpaid.

4.7.1 What Makes an Artifact?

An artifact is a magic item with three special properties:

- **Obligation.** When you first claim an artifact (or when you use its deeper powers), you mark Obligation to the artifact itself. This Obligation is tracked like Patron Obligation (Capacity = Spirit + Presence). The artifact may demand tasks, sacrifices, or simply that you carry it to places it wishes to go.
- **Rites.** An artifact grants one or two specific Rites (see 15) that you can invoke without a Patron, a Codex, or a Symbol. Using a Rite from an artifact costs the normal Obligation (in

addition to any Obligation from attuning to the artifact). The Rites are tied to the artifact's nature – a sword that remembers a betrayed king might grant *Rite of the Oath Unbroken*; a lantern that once lit a heretic's pyre might grant *Rite of the Revealing Flame*.

- **Indestructible (mostly).** If an artifact is lost, stolen, or destroyed, it reappears intact at the next dawn – somewhere nearby, often in the hand of the one who owes it the most Obligation. The only way to be rid of an artifact permanently is to fulfill all Obligation to it, then pass it to a willing heir (or bury it in a place of true rest, with GM approval).

4.7.2 No Upkeep, but No Escape

Unlike ordinary magic items, artifacts require **no upkeep** (no XP or downtime scenes). They maintain themselves – or rather, they maintain their hold on you. However, you cannot simply stop attuning to an artifact; it will return at dawn until your Obligation to it is cleared.

- **Attunement:** An artifact counts toward your attunement limit (3 items). Breaking attunement is a ritual (downtime scene) that requires a **Spirit + Lore** roll (DV 4). On a failure, you mark 1 Fatigue and the artifact reappears the next dawn.
- **Obligation Overflow:** If your Obligation to an artifact exceeds your Capacity, you suffer Fatigue as normal (see §??). Additionally, the artifact may manifest – a cold weight in your pack, a whisper in your ear, a reflection that doesn't match the room.

4.7.3 Subtle Power, Not Apocalyptic

Most artifacts are **subtle**. They do not reshape battlefields or raise armies. A true artifact might:

- Allow you to hear the last words of anyone who died holding it (once per session).
- Show you the nearest hidden door or secret passage when you spend 1 Boon.
- Grant +1 die to all Sway rolls when bargaining with a specific faction (e.g., the Salt Prince's court).

Apocalyptic artifacts – those that could end kingdoms or unmake reality – are almost unheard of. One or two are whispered about in the oldest ledgers, but no living witness has confirmed their existence. The Gray Wanderer themselves is said to carry a shard of the First Oath, but if they do, they have never used it.

4.7.4 Acquiring an Artifact

You cannot buy an artifact with XP. You find them:

- In the hoard of a forgotten dragon.
- At the bottom of a sunken temple, still clutched by a skeleton.
- As an inheritance from a dying mentor (“Take my mother's mirror. It will show you what I could not face.”).
- As a reward from a Patron who wishes to bind you more tightly.

The GM determines the artifact's Rites and the starting Obligation (usually 1–3 segments). You do not pay XP for the artifact itself, but you may need to complete a quest to unlock its full power.

4.7.5 Sample Artifacts

Name	Obligation	Effect
<i>The Copper Bell of Unspoken Truths</i>	2	Once per session, ring the bell. The next lie told within Near range is heard as a discordant chime; you gain +1 die to expose it.
<i>Ledger of the Debtor Saint</i>	3	You may record a single promise in the ledger. While the promise is unfulfilled, you gain +1 die to all rolls that directly advance it. When the promise is fulfilled, clear 1 Obligation.
<i>The Mourner's Cloak</i>	1	When you pull the hood up, you become invisible to anyone who is actively grieving (GM's judgment). The invisibility lasts until you speak or attack.
<i>Hearthstone of the Lost Hearth</i>	2	Once per day, as an action, you may set the stone on a threshold. For the next hour, that threshold cannot be crossed by anyone with hostile intent (Resolve DV 4 to resist).

4.7.5.1 The Kalrantha Amulet (Tier V Artifact)

A tear-shaped shard of green glass in a brass frame. Warm to the touch when someone nearby is about to decide.

- **Fate's Gravity:** Once per session, reroll a single die after seeing the result.
- **Anti-Magic Aura (Near):** Any spell that alters probability, fate, or causality suffers +2 DV within Near range.
- **Story Beats Become Gravity:** When the wearer rolls 1s, those SB are transferred to the next player character who acts. The GM must spend them on inevitable complications for that character's action.

For full corruption mechanics and adventure hooks, see *Dhahara: Kingdom of Brass* and *The Way of Silk*.

4.7.6 Player Advice

Artifacts are **story hooks**, not power-ups. If you find one, ask yourself:

- Why does this thing want me to carry it?
- What will it demand when my Obligation fills?
- Who else wants it – and what will they pay?

Embrace the artifact as a co-star in your character's drama. The Rites it grants are useful; the strings attached are the real treasure.

The Gray Wanderer's Ledger

"I have carried the Copper Bell for thirty years. It has shown me a hundred lies and saved me from a thousand embarrassments. It has also woken me at midnight, demanded I ring it at a

stranger's door, and once caused a magistrate's wig to catch fire. I would not trade it for a kingdom – but I would trade it for a single night of silence.”

Chapter 5

Magic and Special Abilities

Magic in this game is powerful but dangerous—a negotiation with reality itself that always carries risks. This chapter covers the core magical systems and the distinct paths a character may follow.

Sidebar: [TAGS] & Magic

What are [TAGS]? Effects in *Fate’s Edge* are communicated via [TAGS]. Each [TAG] is a discrete effect gated behind a Talent, Rite, spell, or asset—it *cannot be invoked spontaneously* unless a rule grants access.

How they’re used. [TAGS] provide a common language for describing effects, especially when players invent spells via *Free Casting*. Many prewritten spells and abilities also list their [TAGS] for clarity.

5.1 The Nature of Magic

Magic is not a safe tool but a dangerous force:

- **Powerful:** Can reshape battles, stories, or even the world.
- **Controlled:** Every use generates **Story Beats (SB)** that manifest as backlash (see 2).
- **Thematic:** Effects and consequences align with the type of magic used.
- **Volatile:** Never fully predictable or controllable.
- **Narrative:** Casting is always a significant story moment.

5.1.0.0.1 Table Vignette: “*I can hold the avalanche,*” says Mira, *fingers trembling.* “*But something will answer.*” The party nods—risk accepted, stakes clear.

5.1.1 Patron as Co-Star

Your Patron is not just a source of power—they are a **co-star** in your story. How often they appear depends on your campaign’s length. Ask your GM which style they will use:

Passive Patrons (long campaigns) – The Patron stays in the background, appearing only when Obligation thresholds are breached. Their demands feel like slow, inevitable consequences.

Active Patrons (short campaigns / one-shots) – The Patron appears often: in dreams, omens, or through intermediaries. They offer bargains, push the Obligation spiral, and make the price of power immediate.

Player advice: Embrace Patron demands as *story hooks*, not punishments. When the GM says “Your Patron requires a task,” lean into it. That task will lead to adventure, not just a tax. A Patron who intervenes is a Patron who cares – and a caring Patron is a source of power and drama.

For Full Patron Details

The complete descriptions of all Patrons—including their Rites, Obligation mechanics, and corruption tables—are found in **Chapter 15 (World Powers and Obligation)**. That chapter also covers terrestrial patrons, faction obligations, and the mechanics of clearing debt. This chapter focuses on the *paths* of magic; for the *sources* of power, see the World Powers chapter.

5.2 Paths of Magic

Magic in *Fate’s Edge* is not a single system. Characters may follow one of several distinct paths, each with its own mechanics, costs, and narrative flavor. The five primary paths are:

Free Caster Improvisational magic using [TAGS]. Flexible but risky (5.2.1).

Runekeeper Structured rites granted by a Patron. Reliable but accrues Obligation (5.2.2).

Invoker Ritual magic using Patron symbols. Safe but slow (5.2.3).

Cantor Songs that mimic Low Rites. Accessible but corrupting (5.2.4).

Summoner Binding and commanding spirits. Powerful but requires control (5.2.5).

A character may dabble in multiple paths, but specialization is more effective.

5.2.1 Free Caster (Spellcraft)

Free casters shape raw magic through will and knowledge. They do not rely on Patrons or rote rites.

Requirements

- Talent: **Spellcraft** (6 XP) – see 9.
- Appropriate magical skill (Arcana, Elemental Magic, etc.).

Casting Procedure

1. **Declare Intent:** Describe the desired effect using [TAGS].
2. **Choose Approach:** Attribute + magical skill.
3. **Set Position & DV:** $DV = 1 + \text{number of [TAGS]}$. Dangerous tags add +2 each.
4. **Roll:** Resolve normally (see 2). Each 1 generates a Story Beat.

For powerful or complex effects, use the **Casting Loop** (two actions: Weave then Cast). Simple effects (one tag) may be cast as a **cantrip** (one action, no separate Weave).

Backlash

On a failure or mixed result, the GM may impose:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- A catastrophic side effect

Backlash is always flavored by the elements used.

Free Caster Talents

Ritual Mastery (6 XP) Reduce casting time for major spells by half.

Elemental Focus (4 XP) Gain +1 die when using a chosen element.

Stabilize Weave (8 XP) Once per session, cancel 1 SB from a failed cast.

5.2.2 Runekeeper (Rites)

Runekeepers bind themselves to a single Patron, learning structured Rites that produce reliable effects.

Requirements

- **Thiasos (Familiar)** (2 XP) – a token or bond with the Patron (see 9).
- **Codex** (4 XP) – a personal record of Rites.
- **Patron Choice:** Select one Patron (e.g., Traveler, Oath of Flame, Morag).

Invoking a Rite

- **Action:** 1 action.
- **Cost:** Mark the Rite's listed Obligation (e.g., **Obligation:** 6). This cost is reduced by 1 if you display your Patron's Symbol (Invoker only).
- **Effect:** The Rite works as written.
- **DV for Rites that require a roll:**

$$DV = \max(\text{Obligation Cost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Rite Tier})$$

where Rite Tier is 1 for Low, 2 for Standard, 3 for High/Epic.

- **Push It:** Once per scene, mark +1 additional Obligation to amplify the effect (+1 die or +1 Effect).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene, as 1 action, imbue a held item with +1 Melee and +1 Thematic skill (e.g., Navigation for Traveler). Lasts one scene. Mark +1 Obligation.

Runekeeper Talents

Efficient Invocation (4 XP) Reduce Obligation cost of one specific Low Rite by 1 (min 0).

Patron's Favor (8 XP) Once per session, ignore Obligation cost for a Rite.

Runebound Resilience (18 XP) Convert up to 2 Harm into Obligation instead of damage.

5.2.3 Invoker (Symbols)

Invokers do not bond permanently. They use consecrated Symbols to borrow a Patron's power through ritual.

Requirements

- **Patron's Symbol** (4 XP per Patron). One Symbol per Patron.
- No Thiasos or Codex required.

Ritual Invocation

- **Time:** Significant Time (DV in rounds). +1 round per DV.
- **Cost:** Mark the Rite's listed Obligation.
- **Symbol Benefit:** If the Symbol is openly displayed, reduce DV by 1 (min 1) and reduce Obligation cost by 1 (min 0).
- **No Symbol:** +1 DV, +1 Obligation, and on a partial/failure, GM gains +1 extra SB.

Crack the Seal

Resolve a known Rite instantly as 1 action. Set the Symbol to **Compromised** and mark double the Rite's base cost (minimum +2, or +3 for High Rites). Restore the Symbol during downtime (Arcana test DV 3) or spend 1 XP.

Invoker Talents

Borrowed Grace (Free) Spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue to gain +1 Melee or +1 Thematic for one action. Mark +1 Obligation.

Crack Specialist (6 XP) Reduce Obligation cost of Crack the Seal by 1.

Symbol Resonance (4 XP) When using a Symbol, gain +1 die to the ritual roll.

5.2.4 Cantor (Songs)

Cantors perform Low Rites as songs, using voice and performance instead of Patron bonds.

Requirements

- Talent: **Cantor's Path** (8 XP) – see 9.
- Prerequisites: Lore 1+, Performance 2+, Presence 2+.

Performing a Song

- **Action:** 1 action to begin; resolves at start of next turn.
- **Test:** Lore + Performance (DV 2–3).
- **Cost:** Materials as listed. No Obligation on success.
- **Corruption:** Track a Corruption Timer (size = Spirit). Mark segments when you Push, perform a Resonant Rite, or when the GM spends SB on your occult activities.

Push It

Resolve immediately. Mark Fatigue 1, mark toward Corruption accumulation, and the GM gains 1 SB (social/Patron fallout).

Corruption Timer

When the timer fills, gain a thematic benefit and drawback from the last Patron whose Rite you performed. Then **set your current Corruption segments to your Tier** (minimum 1). The timer's maximum size remains equal to your Spirit. This means you are never completely free of Corruption; high-Tier Cantors always carry a remnant of past blooms.

Resonant Rites (Founding a Chorus)

A **Resonant Rite** is any Cantor song performed with dramatic intent, witnessed by at least 10 people, and dedicated to a specific Patron. The GM determines if a performance qualifies.

Chorus Cults (Optional)

If you perform a Resonant Rite before 10+ witnesses, you may found a **Chorus**. This grants a minor follower benefit (see 12), but you must mark Obligation to the cult's patron (the patron whose Resonant Rite was sung to form the cult) each session you use it. **If neglected, the cult may fracture** – your followers could splinter into a rival sect, spread false rumors, or ally with a Patron's enemy. Keep an eye on your followers; a neglected Chorus can become a serious problem.

Example minor follower benefits (work with your GM):

- Once per session, gain +1 die on a Performance roll or on a social roll where the crowd's opinion matters.
- Once per session, call upon the cult to provide a single piece of information from within a community where the cult has a presence.
- Once per session, gain +1 Boon when you perform a Song in a public space.

High Cantor and Instant Songs

The **High Cantor** talent (below) allows you to learn Standard Rites as songs and resolve them instantly (no delay). When you sing a Standard Rite as a Song, you may also **Push** it for additional effect (e.g., +1 Effect) at the usual cost of 1 Fatigue and marking a Corruption segment.

Cantor Talents

Resonant Performance (3 XP) Gain +1 die when performing for an audience of 5+.

Song Weaver (4 XP) Combine two compatible Songs for +1 Effect. Two Songs are compatible if they share a thematic tag (e.g., both affect healing, positioning, spirits) or if they are from the same Patron. The GM has final say. Sing both as a single action; resolve the Performance roll once; if successful, both effects occur with +1 Effect.

High Cantor (18 XP) Learn Standard Rites as songs; resolve instantly (as described above).

Steady Voice (2 XP) Passive. When you Push a Song, you may choose to mark 1 additional Fatigue instead of marking a Corruption segment (once per scene). You cannot use this talent if your Corruption timer is already full. This talent gives low-Spirit Cantors an emergency buffer at the cost of greater exhaustion. *Requires: Cantor's Path.*

Patron's Dedication (4 XP) Prerequisite: Cantor's Path.

Effect: You bind your voice to a single Patron (choose one when you take this talent). Your Corruption timer is always keyed to that Patron – it never resets to a different Patron's table when you bloom. Whenever you would gain Corruption from any source, you mark it on this same timer.

Downside (Rivalry): Singing a Song (Low or Standard Rite) of any other Patron is treacherous. When you do so, your Position for that song is worsened by one step (Dominant → Controlled, Controlled → Desperate). This penalty applies even if the song would otherwise be instant or free.

5.2.5 Summoner (Pact-Whisperer)

Summoners call and bind Outsiders for temporary aid.

Requirements

- Talent: **Pact-Whisperer** (2 XP) – see 9.
- Lesser Pactwright (2 XP) for Cap 1 spirits; Greater Pactwright (4 XP) for Cap 3.

Core Mechanics

- **Call (1 action):** Manifest a spirit at Near range.
- **Bind:** Spend 1 Boon or mark 1 Fatigue.
- **Leash Capacity:** Cap + Spirit segments.
- **Tick Leash:** Spirit takes harm, commanded against nature, crosses a [WARD], or you split focus.
- **Departure:** When Leash fills, spirit acts once according to its nature, then departs (or turns hostile at GM discretion).

Spirit Whims Table (When the Spirit Acts on Its Own)

When the Leash fills or the spirit acts independently, the GM may choose (or roll) from this table to make the action interesting – not just damage.

d6 Spirit's Independent Action

- 1 **Reveal a Secret:** The spirit blurts out a hidden fact about a PC or NPC – true, embarrassing, or da
 - 2 **Break Something:** The spirit shatters a mundane object (a lantern, a rope bridge, a crucial tool).
 - 3 **Lead Astray:** The spirit moves a short distance and creates a false trail, forcing the party to waste ti
 - 4 **Call for Help:** The spirit summons a minor ally (a rat swarm, a will-o'-wisp, a lesser elemental).
 - 5 **Curse a PC:** The spirit leaves a lingering mark (–1 die on one skill until the next sunrise).
 - 6 **Bargain:** The spirit offers a deal: “Release me now, and I’ll tell you where the treasure is hidden.”
-

Boon Finesse

Once per round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick.

Summoner Talents

Spirit Synergy (4 XP) When commanding two spirits, reduce each Leash by 1.

Spirit Link (10 XP) Spirits act on your turn; commands are free actions.

True Name Keeper (15 XP) Call any previously encountered spirit by true name; reduce Leash Capacity by 2.

5.3 Universal Mechanics

5.3.1 Obligation Capacity

A character's **Obligation Capacity** equals Spirit + Presence. Track total Obligation segments across all Patrons.

- **Exceeding Capacity:** For each segment above Capacity, mark 1 Fatigue. Cannot invoke Rites until Obligation is reduced.

- **Resolution:** Reduce Obligation through downtime service, Patron tasks, or ritual cleansing.

Player guidance: You track your own Obligation (see Player-Managed Modules, 2.3). When a Patron intrudes (e.g., a demand or omen), treat it as a **plot hook, not a penalty**. The Patron is offering you a story.

5.3.2 Difficulty Value for Rites

When a Rite (Runekeeper or Invoker) calls for a roll, the GM sets DV using:

$$DV = \max(\text{Obligation Cost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Rite Tier})$$

Rite Tier: Low = 1, Standard = 2, High/Epic = 3.

Example: A Low Rite (Tier 1) with Obligation cost 4, Spirit 2 $\rightarrow DV = \max(4 - 2, 1) = 2$.

Components as Devotion

Even if you already have a Patron's Symbol, Codex, or Thiasos, voluntarily acquiring rare components for a ritual shows dedication. Use this rule of thumb:

- **Ritual with no components (just Symbol/Codex):** Normal DV, normal Obligation cost.
- **Ritual with common components (herbs, salt, a candle):** Reduce Obligation by 1 (minimum 0).
- **Ritual with rare or dangerous components (a phoenix feather, a drop of troll blood, a whispered secret):** Reduce DV by 1 **and** clear 1 segment of existing Obligation to that Patron (once per session max).
- **Ritual with a truly legendary component (the crown of a dead king, a tear from a goddess):** The Patron may waive all Obligation for that ritual – and even grant a free Boon.

This turns component hunting into adventure hooks and gives you a meaningful choice: use the easy, costly path or invest legwork to earn the Patron's favor.

5.3.3 Backlash

Any magical roll can generate backlash. The GM spends Story Beats (SB) to introduce complications tied to the element or Patron involved.

Result	Backlash Severity
Partial	Minor (e.g., Position -1, Fatigue 1, minor complication)
Miss	Major (e.g., Harm 1, condition, significant complication)
Critical failure (many 1s)	Catastrophic (e.g., Patron intervention, scene shift)

Backlash Severity by Position

Position	Backlash Severity on Partial/Miss
Dominant	Minor – one SB complication, manageable cost.
Controlled	Moderate – 1–2 SB complication, temporary setback.
Desperate	Severe – 2–3 SB complication, lasting consequences or Harm.

Elemental Backlash Examples

- **Fire:** Burns, flares, smoke.
- **Water:** Slick footing, gear corrosion, flooding.
- **Earth:** Tremors, encumbrance, binding roots.
- **Air:** Dispersal, deafening gusts, thrown debris.
- **Fate:** Opportunities close, predictions become set.
- **Life:** Uncontrolled growth, fever, exhaustion.
- **Luck:** Fortunes reverse at the worst moment.
- **Death/Dreams:** Whispers, numbness, portents.

5.3.4 DV by Spell Scope

Use this table as a quick reference when the GM asks for a DV for a new spell:

Scope	Example	DV
Cantrip	Light a candle, sense magic	2
Combat	Fire bolt, force shield	3
Ritual (small)	Find a lost object, speak with a spirit	4
Ritual (large)	Summon a storm, teleport across a region	5+
Epic	Raise a dead army, rewrite a law of reality	6+ (with quest)

When in Doubt

A spell's power is not measured by how many dice it rolls, but by **how much it changes the story**. Use this rule of thumb:

- **Minor change (1 TAG):** The effect affects only yourself or a single object. Examples: **Light**, **[HEAL]**, **Veil** (self only). DV 2–3.
- **Moderate change (2 TAGS):** The spell affects a whole zone, creates a significant advantage, or bypasses a notable obstacle. Examples: **Area + Force**, **Barrier** across a doorway. DV 3–4.
- **Major change (3+ TAGS):** The spell rewrites the situation, solves a major problem outright, or introduces a new faction/ally/threat. Examples: **Teleport** across a city, **Summon** a Cap 3 spirit, **Transform** a person into a beast. DV 5+ and often a ritual.

If your description would *skip over a scene* (“I teleport us past the entire fortress”), that’s a major change – require components, a timer, or a steep cost. If it would only *add flavor* (“I make my eyes glow red”), that’s free. Let the fiction guide the DV, not a pre-computed formula.

5.3.5 Example: Accepting a Cost – The Hard Choice

When a magical roll generates SB, the GM may offer you a choice instead of a flat consequence.

5.3.5.0.1 Example: You cast a ritual to divine an enemy’s location. The roll generates 2 SB. The GM says:

“The vision comes clearly – but your Patron’s symbol glows hot on your hand. **You can have the vision for free, or you can let the spell fizzle and keep your Obligation unchanged.** If you accept the vision, mark +2 Obligation and your Patron will demand a task next session. What do you choose?”

This turns a success into a *narrative fork*. Embrace it – the Patron’s task will be an adventure hook.

5.4 Free Casting (TAGS System)

Some casters shape raw forces through shared arcane grammar known as **TAGS**. Construct a spell at the table using a short phrase of TAGS.

5.4.1 Spell Structure

Intent + Target + Tags = effect. Example: “*I unleash Burning • Area • Force against the marauders.*”

5.4.2 Base Difficulty Value (DV)

$$DV = 1 + \text{number of TAGS}$$

Dangerous TAGS (Teleportation, Transformation, Domination) add +2 DV instead of +1.

5.4.3 Casting Roll

Roll **Wits + Arcana** (or similar). Success = spell works. Failure or any 1 = Backlash.

5.4.4 Backlash for Free Casters

Choose one:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- Catastrophic side effect (GM describes)

If the spell includes a “Dangerous” TAG, Backlash triggers on *mixed* results as well.

5.4.5 TAG Library (Abridged)

Table 5.1: Common TAGS

TAG Category	Examples
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Elemental	Burning, Freezing, Storm, Stone, Wave, Wind
Force	Force, Area, Strike, Wall, Bind, Dispel
Mind & Veil	Veil, Scry, Memory, Command, Fear
Life & Body	[HEAL], Purify, Strengthen, Waken, Beast
Space & Motion (dangerous, +2 DV)	Fold, Gate, Gravity
Creation & Trans- formation (danger- ous, +2 DV)	Create, Summon, Transmute, Animate

Note: **Leap** (short-range teleport) is considered a dangerous TAG; it adds +2 DV. The SB cost should be less dramatic than [TELEPORT] or [GATE], though.

5.4.6 Magic in Social Situations

Using magic socially carries additional risks:

- **Discretion:** Hidden casting may require a Stealth or Subterfuge test.
- **Consent:** Affecting minds without permission is often considered a crime or taboo.
- **Reputation:** Known magic users may face distrust or fear.
- **Legal Consequences:** Many cities restrict magic use without a license.

5.5 Magical Item Creation

Creating permanent magical items is a complex, campaign-level endeavor. See the full rules in the *Game Master's Guide*. In brief:

- Requires high magical and craft skills (Arcana 3+, Craft 2+).
- Costs XP (minimum 5 XP for Tier I) and rare materials.
- Takes weeks or months of downtime.
- Risk of backlash or permanent curse on failure.

For temporary enchantments, use the **Patron's Gift** (5.2.2) or **Borrowed Grace** (5.2.3).

5.6 Optional Magic Expansions

The following systems are optional and may be introduced by the GM.

Psionics (Optional)

Psionics represents mental power drawn from within — no Patron, no Symbol, no debt. It is meant to feel **alien**, even to other magic-users. Different cultures have varying opinions (see the Gray Wanderer's Grimoire for examples), but psions are generally viewed with suspicion or fear.

Example Arts: Telekinesis, Telepathy, Clairvoyance, Biofeedback, Astral Projection, Psychic Assault, Mind Shield, Empathic Manipulation, Precognition.

Warning: Psionics generates Story Beats (SB) quickly. The GM is encouraged to spend these SB on *social complications* — suspicion, hostile glances, a Chain-Lantern investigation, or a neighbor locking their door. Mental backlash is common, but the deepest cost is always *trust*.

Each use costs Mental Strain. Overflow converts to normal Fatigue or Harm. Many societies distrust mind-readers; a psion is always *unwitnessed*, and therefore outside the ledger.

Witchcraft (Optional)

Witchcraft is magic practiced through patron-bound Orders. Witches suffer — **1 die** in consecrated spaces and must navigate the Curse of the Unanointed — the world's refusal to witness their labor.

Ritual Magic (Weave & Cast): Two-step process, each roll generates SB.

Example Orders:

- **Mab, Queen of Courts:** Glamour, bargains, fae oaths. Risk — Glamour-Bloom (lose a memory for +1 Effect).
- **Aveh, The Rider:** Identity shedding. Risk — Unface (your features blur).
- **Morag, The Hag:** Hidden costs and prophecy. Risk — Mirecloth (sacrifice identity for truth).

Identity Cost: Every use marks who you are. The cost is memory, identity, or reputation.

5.7 Quick Reference

Magic Quick Reference

Free Caster

- Talent: Spellcraft (6 XP)
- DV = 1 + number of [TAGS]
- Backlash on miss or mixed

Runekeeper

- Thiasos + Codex (6 XP)
- 1 action, mark Rite's Obligation cost (variable)
- Push It: +1 Obligation
- DV = max(Obligation Cost Spirit, Rite Tier)

Invoker

- Patron's Symbol (4 XP each)
- Ritual: Significant time, mark Rite's Obligation cost
- Symbol displayed: reduce Obligation cost by 1
- Crack the Seal: instant, double cost (min +2)

Cantor

- Cantor's Path (8 XP)

- Song: 1 action (resolves next round)
- Corruption Timer (size = Spirit)
- Push: Fatigue +1, advance Corruption

Summoner

- Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)
- Call + Bind (1 Boon or Fatigue)
- Leash = Cap + Spirit

Chapter 6

Healing: Mending Flesh and Spirit

The Gray Wanderer's Wisdom

“The [HEAL] tag closes small wounds and eases exhaustion. To knit broken bones or purge a curse, you need greater power—and greater risk.”

In **Fate's Edge**, injuries are not mere hit points. They are narrative weights: a fractured leg forces hard choices; a festering wound breeds desperation. Healing magic exists, but it is never cheap, never perfectly safe, and always part of the story.

This chapter explains how your character recovers from the two kinds of damage—**Fatigue** and **Harm**—using magic, medicine, rest, and willpower.

6.1 The Two Faces of Injury

Type	What It Represents	How It Heals (Fastest)
Fatigue	Exhaustion, minor cuts, bruises, winded	[HEAL] cantrip, short rest, a hot meal
Harm	Broken bones, deep wounds, poisoning, curses	Rest + medicine, powerful magic, time

6.1.0.0.1 Fatigue is your character's ability to keep going. It accumulates from physical exertion, missed sleep, harsh weather, and the strain of magic. Fatigue is **common and easy to remove**.

6.1.0.0.2 Harm is serious injury. Each level of Harm (1, 2, or 3) imposes a –1 die penalty on most actions. Harm is **rare and expensive to heal**. When you take Harm, the world takes notice.

6.2 Recovering Fatigue – The Easy Work

Fatigue clears quickly with rest, food, or a minor magical touch.

6.2.1 Rest and Recovery

- **Short rest (one hour):** Remove 2 Fatigue. You must be able to sit, breathe, and drink water. No roll required.
- **Full night's rest (8 hours in safety):** Remove all Fatigue. If you are in a dangerous or exposed place, the GM may reduce this to 2 Fatigue instead.
- **Warm meal and comfort:** The first rest after a hot meal removes an additional 1 Fatigue (stacks with the above).

6.2.2 The [HEAL] Cantrip

The [HEAL] tag (typically from the Life element or a Patron of healing) removes Fatigue quickly.

[HEAL] Cantrip

Tags:	[HEAL]
DV:	2
Action:	1 action
Range:	Touch
Effect:	Remove 1 Fatigue from yourself or a willing creature you touch.
Backlash:	None. The GM may still spend Story Beats (from any 1s on the roll) to add minor flavor (e.g., a healing glow).

This cantrip works for any magical tradition that can access Life or a healing Patron (e.g., Free Caster, Runekeeper of Oath of Flame, Cantor with healing songs).

6.2.2.0.1 Example: Lyra uses [HEAL] on Henry after a fight. She rolls 5d10 (Spirit + Medicine), gets 3 successes vs DV 2 – a Clean Success. Henry clears 1 Fatigue. No complication.

6.3 Healing Harm – The Hard Work

Restoring a level of Harm (e.g., from Harm 2 to 1, or Harm 1 to 0) requires **significant effort** – either mundane medical care over time or powerful magic that comes with risk.

6.3.1 Mundane Healing

- **First Aid (Wits + Medicine, DV 3):** Stabilise a dying creature (prevent Harm from worsening). Does not heal existing Harm. Takes 1 action.
- **Treatment (downtime, safe haven):** Requires a healer's kit and at least one day of rest. Restores 1 Harm per full day of care. A successful Medicine roll (DV 3) can reduce required days by half (minimum 1 day).
- **Surgery or magical cleansing (serious injury):** For Harm 3 or cursed wounds, the GM may require a full scene or a quest component (rare herbs, a spirit's favor).

6.3.2 Magical Healing of Harm

To heal Harm with a spell, you must meet **two conditions**:

1. Include the [HEAL] tag.
2. Include **at least one other appropriate tag** based on the injury:

- [PURIFY] – poison, disease, corruption
- [STRENGTHEN] – broken bones, torn muscles
- [CLEANSE] – curses, magical wounds, shadow-damage

The base DV for healing Harm is **1 + number of tags**. Healing Harm also adds a **+2 DV surcharge**. Examples:

Injury	Tags	Base DV	+2 Surcharge	Final DV
Shallow cut (Harm 1)	[HEAL]	2	+2	4
Poisoned wound (Harm 1)	[HEAL] [PURIFY]	3	+2	5
Broken arm (Harm 2)	[HEAL] [STRENGTHEN]	3	+2	5

The GM may increase DV further for legendary wounds (e.g., a dragon’s claw tears your spirit – [HEAL] [CLEANSE] + a ritual requiring significant time).

6.3.3 Ritual Healing

Healing Harm 2 or Harm 3 often requires a **ritual**, not a single action. Rituals take at least 10 minutes (or longer per the GM). During a ritual, interruptions (combat, loud noises, disbelief) can cause the healing to fail or backfire.

Many magical paths have specific healing rites:

- **Runekeeper (Oath of Flame & Light):** *Lay on Hands* (Low Rite) heals Fatigue; *Cleansing Light* (Standard Rite) can remove poison or downgrade Harm at the cost of Obligation (see 5).
- **Cantor:** Healing songs (e.g., *Hymn of Restoration*) require a Performance roll. On a Partial, the wound heals but the Cantor marks Corruption (see 5).
- **Witch (Hearth craft):** Hedge Gifts like *Steady Hand* (remove Fatigue) and *Knot of Mercy* (remove a Condition) are roll-free but limited per scene/session (see 5).
- **Invoker:** Ritual healing with a Patron’s Symbol is slow but has reduced backlash. Crack the Seal for emergency healing – at double Obligation cost (see 5).
- **Summoner:** Can bargain with a spirit to transfer wounds (e.g., a spirit of sacrifice takes your Harm). Tick the **Leash** timer each time (see 5).

6.4 The Risk of Magic – Story Beats and Backlash

Whenever you cast a healing spell (especially to heal Harm), any 1s you roll generate Story Beats (SB) for the GM. The GM will spend those SB to introduce **complications** – the healing works, but the world pushes back.

6.4.0.0.1 What complications look like:

- **Minor (1 SB):** The wound leaves a visible scar. The patient feels an odd craving (honey, raw meat, silence). A faint magical residue lingers.
- **Moderate (2 SB):** A minor spirit or “echo” of the injury appears – it watches the patient for a scene. A Patron sends a dream: “You owe me.”
- **Serious (3 SB):** The healing draws attention from a rival, a witch-hunter, or a territorial nature spirit. The patient gains a thematic Condition (e.g., *Phantom Pain*, –1 die on rolls

involving that limb until they perform a small ritual).

- **Major (4+ SB):** Reality warps briefly – a corpse nearby twitches; the patient forgets something precious; the healer’s own shadow moves on its own for a day.

These complications **do not cancel the healing**. They are **narrative gifts** – hooks for future scenes, reminders that power has a price.

GM’s Role

Your GM uses Story Beats to make healing **dramatic**, not to punish you. Embrace the complications. A scar is a story. A Patron’s demand is an adventure. A haunted shadow is a future ally (or enemy). Talk to your GM about the kinds of complications you find interesting – body horror, social fallout, ominous omens, or debts to mysterious powers.

6.5 Natural Recovery – When Magic Fails

If you have no access to magic or medicine, your body still heals – slowly.

- **Per day of complete rest (no strenuous activity):** Remove 1 Fatigue automatically. If you also have food, water, and shelter, remove 2 Fatigue.
- **Per week of rest (downtime):** Remove 1 level of Harm. A successful Medicine roll (Wits + Medicine, DV 3) at the start of the week reduces the required time to 3 days per Harm level.
- **Neglected injuries:** If you continue to adventure while at Harm 2 or Harm 3 without any healing, the GM may advance a **Worsening Condition** timer. When it fills, your injury becomes permanent (a limp, a weakened arm, etc.) or requires extraordinary magic to fix.

6.6 Healing by Magical Tradition – Quick Reference

tabularx

6.7 Summary: Healing at a Glance

6.7.1 Healing Tags Reference

The following tags are commonly used in healing magic. Each adds to the spell’s DV as shown.

Tag	Effect	DV Modifier
[HEAL]	Removes 1 Fatigue	+0 (base)
[PURIFY]	Neutralises poison or disease	+1
[STRENGTHEN]	Mends broken bones or torn muscles	+1
[CLEANSE]	Removes curses or magical wounds	+1
[REGENERATE]	Restores 1 Harm (requires another healing tag)	+2

[REGENERATE] cannot be used alone; it must be paired with another healing tag (e.g., [HEAL] [REGENERATE] to restore 1 Harm). The total DV is calculated as described in 6.3.2.

Path	Fatigue Healing	Harm Healing
Free Caster	[HEAL] cantrip (DV 2)	[HEAL] + other tag, +2 DV, risk backlash (see 5)
Runekeeper	Low Rite (e.g., <i>Lay on Hands</i>)	Standard Rite, costs Obligation, may Push (see 5)
Invoker	Ritual [HEAL] (slow)	Ritual + Symbol, reduce DV with rare components (see 5)
Cantor	Healing Song (Performance roll)	Song + Push (marks Corruption), requires High Cantor for instant (see 5)
Witch (Hearth)	Hedge Gift: <i>Steady Hand</i> (no roll, 1/scene)	Hedge Gift: <i>Knot of Mercy</i> (once/session, removes Condition) (see 5)
Summoner	Spirit bargain (costs Leash ticks)	Transfer wound to spirit (costs Leash, may anger spirit) (see 5)
No magic	Short/long rest	Downtime + Medicine roll

6.7.2 Optional Rule: Serious Wounds

When a character takes **Harm 3** (the third box of Harm), the table may opt to replace that injury with a **Serious Wound** — a lasting debility that cannot be healed by ordinary magic.

- The character marks the Harm 3 box as usual.
- Instead of being incapacitated (Harm 3's default effect), they gain one **Serious Wound** from the table below (or a custom wound agreed with the GM).
- Each Serious Wound imposes a **1 die penalty** on all rolls affected by that wound (GM's discretion, but typically broad: physical wounds affect Body rolls; mental wounds affect Wits or Spirit).
- A character can sustain up to **Body** Serious Wounds. If they would gain another beyond that limit, they are incapacitated as per standard Harm 3.
- Serious Wounds heal only through **significant downtime** (a full week of rest per wound) or **major magic** (a quest-level ritual). Mundane healing and [HEAL] have no effect.

6.7.2.0.1 Serious Wound Table (d10)

What You Want How to Get It

Clear 1 Fatigue (fast)

[HEAL] cantrip (DV 2, 1 action) or short rest (1 hour).

Clear all Fatigue

Full night's rest in safety.

Heal 1 Harm (mundane)

A week of rest, or 1 day with Medicine roll (DV 3) and a healer's kit.

Heal 1 Harm (magic)

[HEAL]+other tag, +2 DV surcharge (minimum DV 4). Accept possible complications from SB.

Heal 2+ Harm (magic)

High DV (5+), often a ritual. Expect significant cost (Obligation, Corruption, quest).

Remove a Condition

Knot of Mercy (Hedge Gift), *Lay on Hands* (if Condition is curse/disease), or a Patron's Rite (see 5).

d10 Wound

1 **Shattered Limb:** 1 die to all physical actions (Body rolls).

2 **Cracked Skull:** 1 die to all mental actions (Wits rolls).

3 **Torn Sinew:** 1 die to melee attacks and athletics.

4 **Gut Wound:** 1 die to endurance and resistance tests.

5 **Spinal Shock:** 1 die to all movement and agility actions.

6 **Broken Spirit:** 1 die to all social actions (Presence rolls).

7 **Shattered Hand:** 1 die to any action requiring fine manipulation (craft, lockpicking, etc.).

8 **Collapsed Lung:** 1 die to all actions requiring sustained breath (sprinting, chanting).

9 **Festering Curse:** 1 die to all magical actions (Arcana, Ritual).

10 **The Gray Wanderer's Choice:** The GM invents a unique wound tied to the fiction (e.g., "*Your sh*...").

Example: Henry takes Harm 3 from a dragon's claw. The group agrees to use Serious Wounds. He rolls a 4 on the table: "Gut Wound". He now suffers 1 die on Endurance tests until he rests for a week or finds a priest to perform a costly healing rite. He can take up to Body 2 more Serious Wounds before falling unconscious.

6.8 Final Advice for Players

- **Don't hoard your healer's resources.** Fatigue is cheap to heal; use [HEAL] often. Save big magic for when someone is at Harm 2 or unconscious.
- **Embrace the scars.** A permanent mark from a healing complication is a badge of survival. Work with your GM to make it meaningful.
- **Ambient healing is a thing.** After a fight, take a short rest. The GM will usually allow it unless you are under active pursuit.
- **Protect your healer.** If the only person with [HEAL] goes down, your party's recovery slows to a crawl.
- **Talk about tone.** In Session Zero (see 1), discuss how gruesome or light you want healing

complications to be. Some tables love body horror; others prefer comedic side-effects. The blade cuts. The spell mends. But the scar remains – and that scar is your story.

Chapter 7

Character Advancement and Capabilities

Philosophy of Growth

Every XP spent is a choice about who your character becomes – invest in yourself, your network, or your legacy.

Your character is not just a collection of numbers; they are a living story. When you spend XP on an Attribute, you are saying “I become stronger, smarter, more resilient.” When you invest in a Follower or an Asset, you are saying “I build relationships and influence that outlast me.” When you buy a Talent, you are saying “This is my signature, my unique edge.”

There is no single “correct” way to grow. A lone duelist (see 8.4) might pour everything into personal skill; a merchant prince might build a trading empire. Both are valid. The question is: *what kind of story do you want to tell?*

Why This Chapter Matters

In this game, growth is not just about numbers — it is about deciding who your character becomes. Advancement through **Experience Points (XP)** lets you shape your capabilities, influence, and legacy in the world. Every XP choice is a statement about your character’s priorities and the mark they leave behind.

Your capabilities are built on four core **Attributes** and a set of specialized **Skills**. This chapter explains how they work together, what advancement looks like in play, and offers player-facing tips for making satisfying choices.

7.1 Core Attributes

Attributes represent your character’s fundamental capabilities. Each is rated from 1 to 5; higher numbers mean greater potential in that area.

7.1.1 Body

Physical strength, endurance, coordination, and health.

- **Used for:** melee combat, athletics, endurance tests, physical labor.
- **Typical applications:** lifting, running, climbing, fighting, resisting physical harm.
- **Associated skills:** Athletics, Brawl, Melee, Endurance (see 7.2).

Rating guide:

- 1: Average person; some physical activity.
- 2: Fit; trains or works physically on a regular basis.
- 3: Athlete or soldier; excellent condition.
- 4: Exceptional athlete; near peak human.
- 5: Peak human capability; legendary strength and stamina.

7.1.2 Wits

Mental acuity, perception, quick thinking, and problem-solving.

- **Used for:** investigation, perception, tactics, snap decisions.
- **Typical applications:** spotting details, solving puzzles, planning, reacting quickly.
- **Associated skills:** Investigation, Tactics, Lore, Survival (see 7.2).

Rating guide:

- 1: Average awareness; sometimes misses important cues.
- 2: Observant; notices most relevant details.
- 3: Sharp-minded; quick to spot patterns.
- 4: Exceptionally perceptive; rarely surprised.
- 5: Almost uncanny awareness; sees connections others miss.

7.1.3 Spirit

Willpower, intuition, mental resilience, and connection to intangible forces.

- **Used for:** resisting mental effects, intuition, magical aptitude, persistence.
- **Typical applications:** resisting fear, sensing danger, channeling magic, enduring hardship.
- **Associated skills:** Arcana, Ritual (for magic users), Endurance, Insight.

Rating guide:

- 1: Average willpower; somewhat suggestible.
- 2: Strong-minded; resists ordinary pressure.
- 3: Very determined; hard to intimidate.
- 4: Exceptional will; can inspire others.
- 5: Iron will; nearly unshakeable resolve.

7.1.4 Presence

Charisma, social influence, appearance, and force of personality.

- **Used for:** social interactions, leadership, persuasion, intimidation.
- **Typical applications:** negotiating, leading, charming, commanding attention.

- **Associated skills:** Sway, Command, Performance, Deception (see [7.2](#)).

Rating guide:

- 1: Average presence; does not particularly stand out.
- 2: Noticeable; leaves a mild impression.
- 3: Charismatic; naturally influential.
- 4: Commanding; people listen when you speak.
- 5: Magnetic; can sway crowds and redefine the mood of a room.

7.2 Skill System

Skills represent specialized training and expertise. In play, you combine an Attribute with a relevant Skill to form your dice pool (see 2).

7.2.1 Skill Ratings

Rating	Description
0	Untrained — no formal experience
1	Novice — basic understanding
2	Competent — reliable and capable
3	Professional — expert in the field
4	Master — renowned specialist
5	Grand Master — legendary skill

7.2.2 Skill Categories

Below are the eighteen core skills, grouped by theme. Your table may rename or reskin these, but the roles remain similar.

7.2.2.0.1 Combat Skills

- **Melee:** swords, axes, close-quarters weapons.
- **Ranged:** bows, crossbows, thrown weapons, firearms (if present).
- **Brawl:** unarmed combat, grappling, improvised fighting.
- **Tactics:** battlefield strategy, unit coordination, ambush planning.

7.2.2.0.2 Physical Skills

- **Athletics:** running, climbing, jumping, swimming.
- **Stealth:** moving unseen, hiding, blending into shadows.
- **Endurance:** resisting fatigue, harsh weather, poison, disease.
- **Craft:** building, repairing, creating tools, art, or structures.
- **Survival:** tracking, foraging, predicting weather, navigating wilderness, animal handling (Nature folded into this skill).

7.2.2.0.3 Social Skills

- **Sway:** persuasion, negotiation, charm.
- **Command:** leadership, intimidation, issuing orders.
- **Deception:** lying, bluffing, misdirection.
- **Performance:** entertainment, oration, acting, musical display (used by Cantors for Songs).
- **Insight:** reading emotions, detecting lies, understanding motives (covers social observation and “reading” people).

7.2.2.0.4 Knowledge Skills

- **Lore:** history, culture, religion, customs, general knowledge (cities, civilizations, scholarly topics).
- **Investigation:** research, deduction, analysis of clues (covers finding and interpreting evidence).
- **Medicine:** healing, anatomy, first aid, treatment.

7.2.2.0.5 Magic Skills

- **Arcana:** magic theory, rituals (identification), mystical phenomena, free casting (TAGS system), counter-spelling.
- **Ritual:** performing rites, invocations, exorcisms, consecrations – used by Runekeepers, Invokers, Cantors, and Summoners for active magical workings.

Optional Module – Psionics: If your table uses the *Psionics* expansion (see *The Gray Wanderer's Grimoire*), a separate **Psionics** skill is added. It is not part of the core skill list and is used for telepathy, telekinesis, clairvoyance, etc.

7.3 Building Dice Pools

Your dice pool for any action is:

$$\text{Dice Pool} = \text{Attribute} + \text{Skill}.$$

You roll that many d10s and interpret the results according to the core rules (see 2).

7.3.1 Choosing the Right Combination

The same fictional action can often be approached with different Attribute + Skill pairs, depending on how your character does it. The GM has final say, but the default is to use the most obvious pairing (e.g., *Body + Melee* for a straightforward sword swing). Creative alternatives are encouraged when they fit the fiction.

- **Climbing a wall:**
 - *Body + Athletics*: sheer strength and stamina.
 - *Wits + Athletics*: clever route-finding and leverage.
 - *Spirit + Athletics*: grim determination against fear or pain.
- **Persuading a guard:**
 - *Presence + Sway*: charm and personality.
 - *Wits + Sway*: logical, well-constructed arguments.
 - *Spirit + Sway*: conviction that burns through doubt.
- **Investigating a crime scene:**
 - *Wits + Investigation*: methodical observation and deduction.
 - *Spirit + Investigation*: intuitive leaps and gut feelings.
 - *Presence + Investigation*: getting witnesses to open up.

7.3.2 Creative Combinations

With your GM's agreement, you can justify unusual combinations that fit the fiction. The table below offers common alternatives, but the GM may allow others based on the scene.

Intended Action	Standard Pair	Alternative Pairs (Example)
Recall a combat drill	Wits + Lore	Body + Lore (muscle memory)
Soothe a patient	Presence + Medicine	Spirit + Medicine (laying on hands)
Forge a masterwork	Wits + Craft	Spirit + Craft (inspired artistry)
Read weather signs	Wits + Survival	Spirit + Survival (omen-sense)
Feint in a duel	Wits + Melee	Presence + Melee (intimidation feint)
Track a spirit	Wits + Survival	Spirit + Lore (follow its legend)
Bribe a guard	Presence + Sway	Wits + Streetwise (know the right price)

7.3.3 GM Guidance for Creative Pairs

- **Ask “How?”** – The player must describe *how* they use that Attribute and Skill together.
- **Maintain Position** – A creative pair does not automatically improve Position or reduce DV. It just changes the dice pool.
- **Consistency** – If you allow *Spirit + Craft* for visionary work, allow it again in similar

circumstances.

- **No Double Dipping** – The player cannot swap both Attribute *and* Skill to max out a single stat; the combination must still respect the fiction.

7.3.4 When to Roll (and When Not To)

Not every action requires a roll. The GM should call for a roll when:

1. The outcome is uncertain.
2. Failure would meaningfully change the situation.
3. The action is significant (not routine).

For routine actions with no real risk, the group can simply agree that you succeed. Example: climbing a knotted rope in calm weather – no roll. Climbing the same rope while goblins shoot arrows – roll.

7.3.5 Assistance and Teamwork

When multiple characters contribute to the same action:

- **Assistance:** One character is primary; up to three others add +1 die each by describing how they help (e.g., “I hold the ladder steady”).
- **Cooperation:** Several characters each roll; the group succeeds or fails based on combined results (e.g., all must sneak past a patrol).
- **Complementary:** Different skills cover different parts of a larger task (e.g., one distracts a guard, another picks the lock).

Example: A ranger scales an ice wall using **Wits** + **Athletics** to find the safest holds, then switches to **Body** + **Athletics** to muscle over the lip. The fiction guides which combination fits each moment.

7.3.6 Selling the Action – Intricate Description

You are always welcome to state your action plainly. But when you take a moment to **sell it** – to invest in the fiction, reveal what your character cares about, or show why this moment matters – the GM may reward you with a mechanical edge. This is about *roleplay investment*, not word count.

- **Basic description:** “I attack the goblin with my sword.” No bonus.
- **Tactical description:** Use the environment, positioning, or a clever tactic. “I feint high, then drive my shoulder into the goblin’s shield, shoving it aside to open its flank.” The GM may or may not upgrade your Position by one step (e.g., *Controlled* → *Dominant*) for this roll.
- **Character-driven description:** Reveal a stake, a bond, a fear, or a hard choice. *One heartfelt sentence counts more than a paragraph of adjectives.*

– Example: “I think of my mother, who died because I wasn’t brave enough to fight. I won’t let that happen again. I plant my feet and dare the goblin to come through me.”

The GM may grant a larger benefit – e.g., upgrade Position *and* bank a **Boon** you can use later, or upgrade Effect by one step.

What Counts (and What Doesn't)

Counts:

- Stating a clear stake: “If I fail this lockpick, my sister doesn’t eat.”
- Invoking a bond mid-action: “I owe Ethan my life. I’m not letting him face this alone.”
- Revealing a fear or hope tied to the roll: “I’m terrified of fire, but I grab the burning beam – because the children are behind me.”
- Making a hard choice visible: “I could run, but I don’t. Running is what got me exiled.”

Does not count:

- Piling on adjectives (“gleaming,” “mighty,” “ancient”) without stakes.
- Passive sensory laundry lists (“the cold wind, the wet stones, the dim light”).
- Repeating the same florid description for every roll.

Guidelines for the GM

- **No penalty for plain speech.** Never punish a player who is tired, shy, or simply prefers quick resolution. The bonus is a gift, not a tax.
- **Be consistent.** Reward genuine investment, not vocabulary. A quiet player who delivers one heartfelt sentence deserves the bonus as much as an eloquent storyteller.
- **The bonus should fit the fiction.** A desperate, reckless action described with real stakes might upgrade Effect but worsen Position – let the mechanics mirror the emotion.
- **Invite quiet players.** Ask leading questions: “What’s at stake for your character right now?” or “What are you afraid will happen if you fail?” Gentle prompts help shy players find their moment.
- **Group “selling.”** If the whole table contributes to describing a group action (a coordinated ambush, a joint ritual), grant the bonus to the primary roller or give each participant a small benefit.

Example

Basic: “I sneak past the sentry.” (No bonus, roll as normal.)

Selling it (tactical): “I wait for the wind to rattle the shutters, then pad across the wet cobblestones – heel-toe, heel-toe – keeping the stack of barrels between me and the sentry’s gaze.” The GM nods: “Great. Because you’re using the wind and the barrels, roll at *Dominant* Position.”

Selling it (character-driven): “My little brother is in that camp. I’ve hidden from every fight since we left home – but not this time. I creep forward, not quiet anymore, because he needs to know someone came for him.” The GM: “That’s the heart of it. Roll at *Dominant* Position, and I’ll bank a Story Beat to make his reaction matter.”

Remember: The dice still decide success or failure. But a well-told action makes the story richer – and earns you an edge when the dice fall.

7.4 Earning Experience Points

XP represents learning through action. You gain it by engaging meaningfully with the world: overcoming challenges, taking risks, making hard choices, and leaning into your character's story.

7.4.1 Session Breakdown

At the end of each session, XP is awarded based on what happened at the table. A typical breakdown might look like:

- **Base Participation:** +2 XP for attending and contributing.
- **Major Objectives:** +2–4 XP for completing significant story goals.
- **Discoveries:** +1–2 XP for uncovering important lore, locations, or secrets.
- **Hard Choices:** +1–2 XP for making difficult moral or strategic decisions.
- **Story Engagement:** +1–3 XP for embracing complications and twists.
- **Personal Goals:** +1–2 XP for pursuing your character's individual storylines.

Example: At the end of a session, the party rogue gains:

- +2 XP for participation,
- +2 XP for helping retrieve a cursed artifact,
- +1 XP for pushing a personal rivalry subplot.

Total: 5 XP.

7.4.2 Game Pace Options

You and your GM can decide how quickly characters advance, matching the tone you want:

Mode	XP / Session	Tone
Gritty	4–6	Hard choices, slow growth
Standard	6–10	Balanced progression
Epic	10–14	Heroic, rapid development

Player Tip: If you want a sweeping, mythic tale, ask for an *Epic* pace. If you want advancement to feel hard-won, lean toward *Gritty*.

7.4.3 Arc Completion Bonus

When a major story arc finishes (typically 3–6 sessions), everyone gains an additional +8–12 XP. One player may receive +2 XP more for a particularly memorable contribution. This rewards the story as a whole, not just individual rolls.

Boons vs. XP

You may convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once per session, max 2 XP per session via conversion).

But: Spending Boons during play is almost always more fun. A re-rolled failure, an improved Position, or an activated Asset creates a memorable moment. Hoarding Boons for XP conversion starves the table of drama. Spend freely; the XP will come from your adventures.

7.5 Spending Experience Points

XP is your currency for growth. You can invest it in three broad areas:

1. **Personal Improvement** (Attributes and Skills)
2. **Special Abilities** (Talents, magic, unique tricks)
3. **Resources and Influence** (Assets, followers, organizations)

Think of these as three pillars: *what you can do*, *what makes you unique*, and *what you own or command*.

7.5.1 Personal Improvement

Attributes

Attributes are expensive but powerful. The cost to raise an Attribute is:

$$\text{XP Cost} = 3 \times \text{new rating}.$$

Examples:

- Raising Body from 2 to 3 costs $3 \times 3 = 9$ XP.
- Raising Spirit from 4 to 5 costs $3 \times 5 = 15$ XP.

Attribute increases usually require downtime equal to the new rating in days, spent training, reflecting, or transforming yourself (see 7.7).

Skills

Skills are cheaper and represent focused practice. The cost is:

$$\text{XP Cost} = 2 \times \text{new level}.$$

Examples:

- Lore 1 $\rightarrow$ 2 costs $2 \times 2 = 4$ XP.
- Melee 3 $\rightarrow$ 4 costs $2 \times 4 = 8$ XP.

Skill increases typically require downtime equal to the new level in days.

Example: Kara wants to improve her swordsmanship (Melee) from 2 to 3. She saves 6 XP and spends three in-game days training with her mentor. This training becomes part of the story, not just a line on a sheet.

7.5.2 Special Abilities

Special abilities are unique moves, talents, or tricks that define your style.

General Abilities (4–8 XP) Universal benefits, like improved recovery, bonus dice in a common situation, or a signature combat technique. *Example:* “Quick Recovery” — heal 1 extra Harm when you rest.

Cultural Abilities (variable) Abilities tied to heritage or background. They may require specific fictional positioning (see 14.20.1). *Example:* “Stone Sense” — an instinctive feel for stonework and tunnels.

Advanced Abilities (12+ XP) High-impact features available at higher tiers, often with strong narrative hooks or prerequisites (see 7.8). *Example:* “Master Diplomat” — once per session, you can reroll or soften the outcome of a failed major negotiation.

Example: A veteran bard purchases *Silver Tongue* for 6 XP, gaining the ability to sway a hostile crowd once per session. This quickly becomes their trademark in tense public scenes.

7.5.3 Resources and Influence

See §12 for full rules. As a quick reference:

Minor Resource (4 XP, 1 week) A small shop, basic workshop, discreet safe house, or minor contact network. Offers modest but reliable benefits.

Standard Resource (8 XP, 2 weeks) A decent-sized business, crew, or operation with real impact. Comes with some upkeep and obligations.

Major Resource (12 XP, 1 month) A large enterprise, elite team, or rare capability. Very potent but also demanding; often becomes a major part of your character’s story.

Player Tip: Resources pull the camera out from your character to your *sphere of influence*. A spy network means intrigue. A workshop means invention. A guild hall means politics.

When to Invest in Assets and Followers

Player Archetype	Typical Investment	Best For
Solo	0–10% XP	Reliable personal power, minimal upkeep.
Mixed (Balanced)	15–25% XP	One solid Follower or Asset (e.g., a scout or a safehouse).
Mastermind	35–55% XP	Networks, informants, multiple Assets; build a faction.

Planning for succession? A loyal Follower (Cap 3+) can become your successor – see the **Legacy Engine** (§19). Investing in a potential heir early pays off when your character retires or falls.

7.6 Character Development Paths

How you spend XP shapes your character's growth. These are broad patterns, not rigid classes.

Path	Typical Split	XP	Strengths / Weaknesses
Specialist	70–90% personal, resources, 20% abilities	per- 0–10% 0–	Extremely effective in a narrow niche. Vulnerable outside it.
Leader	50–65% personal, resources, 25% abilities	per- 15–25% 15–	Well-rounded, boosts the group. Rarely the best at one thing.
Mastermind	25–40% personal, resources, 40% abilities	per- 35–55% 20–	Solves problems through assets. Personally vulnerable, many moving parts.

Example (Leader): A merchant-prince spends 60% of XP on personal skills and social abilities, 20% on a network of trade contacts, and 20% on talents that improve negotiation and command.

These patterns are *guides*, not rules. You can shift between them as your story evolves.

7.7 Training and Development Time

Most improvements take time in the fiction. Training montages, study scenes, and building projects are all opportunities for character moments.

7.7.1 Standard Time Requirements

- **Attribute increase:** new rating in days.
- **Skill improvement:** new level in days.
- **Resource acquisition:** about 1 week to 1 month depending on scope.
- **Ability learning:** typically 3–10 days.

7.7.2 Accelerated Development (Rush Rule)

You *can* attempt to learn faster, but rushing has a price.

- The group tracks a short **Risk Timer** (4 segments) for your crash training.
- If it fills, the new capability has flaws:
 - Attribute/Skill: temporary –1 die penalty until you retrain properly.
 - Resource: loyalty issues, partial effectiveness, or hidden problems.
 - Ability: unreliable effects or quirky side consequences.

Example: A wizard crams advanced spellwork into three frantic days. She gains the ability, but the Risk Timer fills: her spells spark and flicker until she takes time to train safely.

7.8 Character Progression Tiers

As you accumulate XP and capabilities, you advance through tiers that represent your growing reputation and influence.

7.8.1 Tier I: Novice (0–40 XP)

- Learning the ropes, establishing yourself.
- Local reputation, modest capabilities.
- Typical assets: basic equipment, a few contacts.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between life and death; a shift from Desperate to Controlled means “I live to fight another day.”

7.8.2 Tier II: Seasoned (41–90 XP)

- Proven capability, reliable in your specialty.
- Regional reputation, respected in your field.
- Typical assets: skilled followers, specialized equipment.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between victory and defeat; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means “I’ve earned the right to choose how this ends.”

7.8.3 Tier III: Veteran (91–150 XP)

- Master of your craft, significant influence.
- National reputation, can handle major challenges.
- Typical assets: multiple operations, elite teams.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between influence and control; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means “The city hangs on my decision.”

7.8.4 Tier IV: Paragon (151–220 XP)

- Exceptional capability, strategic influence.
- Continental influence, shapes regional outcomes.
- Typical assets: organizations, unique capabilities.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between shaping events and defining eras; a shift from Controlled to Dominant means “I am the axis upon which history turns.”

7.8.5 Tier V: Mythic (221+ XP)

- Legendary status, world-changing influence.
- Historical reputation, defines eras.
- Typical assets: nations, legendary artifacts.
- **Position Manifestation:** The difference between ending and remaking the world; a shift from Desperate to Controlled means “The universe waits on my choice.”

7.8.6 Position Scales with Narrative Weight

The mechanical effect of Position (re-rolling one die, see [2](#)) never changes — but what it *means* evolves with your tier:

- **Tier I:** Position defines personal survival.

- **Tier III:** Position shapes regional outcomes.
- **Tier V:** Position reshapes reality.

The system does not need to scale — your story does.

GM Tip: Never add mechanical bonuses to Position. Instead, deepen the narrative weight:

- **Tier I:** “Your Position shows whether you live or die.”
- **Tier V:** “Your Position shows how the world bends to your will.”

The mechanics stay consistent so the narrative can grow as large as your imagination allows.

7.9 Managing Allies and Followers

Allies can extend your reach but also create obligations and risks. For full rules, see §12.

7.9.1 Acquisition Costs

A skilled helper's cost in XP is roughly their *capability rating squared*. *Example:* A capability 3 scout costs $3^2 = 9$ XP.

7.9.2 Upkeep Requirements

Each downtime period, you either:

- spend XP equal to their capability rating, **or**
- dedicate a meaningful scene to maintaining the relationship (time, favors, protection).

7.9.3 Risk Management

- When big complications arise, your allies can be targeted instead of you.
- Allies can handle one significant task off-screen per downtime, but this often creates extra story fallout (the GM gains a Story Beat).

7.10 Skill Advancement and Synergies

7.10.1 XP Costs

Improvement	XP Cost
0 → 1	2 XP
1 → 2	4 XP
2 → 3	6 XP
3 → 4	8 XP
4 → 5	10 XP

7.10.2 Training Time

- 0 → 1: 1 day of practice.
- 1 → 2: 3 days of training.
- 2 → 3: 1 week of intensive study.
- 3 → 4: 2 weeks with a master or rigorous practice.
- 4 → 5: 1 month of dedicated focus.

7.10.3 Attribute Limits

You cannot have a Skill rating higher than the relevant Attribute. To advance a Skill further, you must first raise its primary Attribute (see 7.1).

7.10.4 Skill Synergies

When the fiction supports it, well-justified combinations of skills can grant +1 die or better Position/Effect. Examples:

- **Combat:** Tactics + Command (battlefield coordination), Melee + Athletics (acrobatic strikes).
- **Social:** Sway + Lore (persuasion backed by knowledge), Deception + Performance (long cons).
- **Exploration:** Investigation + Survival (tracking), Lore + Insight (cultural observation).

7.11 Using Skills in Play

7.11.1 When to Roll

You roll when:

- the outcome is uncertain,
- failure would matter to the story, and
- the action is significant enough to deserve the spotlight.

For routine actions with no real risk, the group can often simply agree that you succeed.

7.11.2 Difficulty and Skill Level

As your skill rises, routine tasks become trivial. A rough guideline:

Skill Level	Routine Task	Challenging Task
0	Needs a roll; modest DV	Needs a roll; higher DV
1	Often needs a roll	Challenging but fair
2	Usually automatic	Needs a roll; moderate DV
3	Automatic	Needs a roll; interesting stakes
4+	Automatic	Automatic for simple cases

Reading this as a player: by Skill 3, basic tasks in your area of expertise should rarely require rolls. You are there to be impressive, not to trip over routine jobs.

7.11.3 Group Skill Use

When multiple characters contribute:

- **Assistance:** One character is primary; up to three others add +1 die each by describing how they help (see 2).
- **Cooperation:** Several characters each roll; the group succeeds or fails based on combined results.
- **Complementary:** Different skills cover different parts of a larger task (e.g. one distracts, one picks a lock).

7.12 Skill Challenges

Some goals are too big for a single roll.

7.12.1 Extended Tests

For long, involved tasks:

- The group sets a progress timer (4–8 segments).
- Each significant success fills one or more segments.
- Complications can add segments or create new problems.

7.12.2 Complex Challenges

For multi-step or multi-skill situations:

- Different skills tackle different phases of the challenge.
- Success in one area creates opportunities; failure creates obstacles.

Example (Heist): **Stealth** to infiltrate, **Craft** to bypass locks, **Investigation** to find the vault, **Deception** to mislead guards. Each roll advances a *Heist Timer* ; complications add heat, suspicion, or security changes.

7.13 Strategic Advancement Considerations

7.13.1 Early Game (Tiers I–II)

- Focus on survival and a clear niche.
- Raise a key Attribute to 3 early.
- Bring core Skills to 2–3.
- Establish one or two modest resources or safe havens.

7.13.2 Mid Game (Tier III)

- Develop signature moves or combinations.
- Expand your resource base.
- Consider your role in the group and lean into it.

7.13.3 Late Game (Tiers IV–V)

- Choose advanced abilities that reshape the story around you.
- Build organizations, movements, or legacies.
- Decide how your character will leave their mark on the world.

Common Advancement Mistakes

Avoid these pitfalls:

- **Over-specializing too early:** A Melee 5 character with Body 3 is fragile and incapable outside combat.
- **Forgetting training time:** You cannot learn a new skill in the middle of a dungeon without justification.
- **Neglecting resources:** A few well-chosen assets can solve problems no amount of personal skill can.
- **Hoarding XP:** Spend your XP! Characters who never improve become irrelevant to the escalating threats.

7.14 Practical Examples

7.14.1 Combat Example

A warrior with Body 4 and Melee 3 attacks:

- Dice pool: $4 + 3 = 7d10$.
- Opponent's defenses and the fiction help set the difficulty (see 2).
- Strong successes translate into higher Effect or better Position.

7.14.2 Social Example

A diplomat with Presence 3 and Sway 2 negotiates:

- Dice pool: $3 + 2 = 5d10$.
- Position might be *Controlled* if circumstances favor them, or worse if under suspicion.
- Consequences for failure could be mistrust, delays, or new complications.

7.14.3 Exploration Example

A scout with Wits 3 and Survival 2 searches for tracks:

- Dice pool: $3 + 2 = 5d10$.
- Easier tasks (fresh tracks) are more forgiving; older or obscured tracks are harder.
- Partial successes might reveal some information but not all, or come with side effects (e.g., you find the tracks but disturb a nest of predators).

Your Attributes and Skills determine not just *if* you succeed, but *how* you tackle problems. Lean into combinations that express your character's style.

XP Planning Guide

Early Tier Priorities:

- Raise a core Attribute to 3 (9 XP).
- Bring key Skills to 2–3 (4–6 XP each).
- Claim 1–2 minor resources (4 XP each).

Mid Tier Expansion:

- Push core Attributes toward 4 (12 XP).
- Specialize key Skills to 4 (8 XP).
- Add standard resources (8 XP each).
- Explore cultural or thematic abilities (6–10 XP).

Late Tier Mastery:

- Purchase capstone abilities (12+ XP).
- Establish major resources (12 XP).
- Launch legacy projects, organizations, or movements.

Attributes and Skills Quick Reference**Attributes (1–5):**

- **Body:** physical capability
- **Wits:** mental acuity
- **Spirit:** willpower and inner strength
- **Presence:** social influence

Skill Levels:

- 0: Untrained 1: Novice 2: Competent
- 3: Professional 4: Master 5: Grand Master

Core Skills (18):

- **Combat:** Melee, Ranged, Brawl, Tactics
- **Physical:** Athletics, Stealth, Endurance, Craft, Survival
- **Social:** Sway, Command, Deception, Performance, Insight
- **Knowledge:** Lore, Investigation, Medicine
- **Magic:** Arcana, Ritual

Dice Pool: Attribute + Skill d10s.

Skill Improvement: New level $\times$ 2 XP (plus training time).

Specialization: At Skill 3+, you are a known expert in that field.

Synergy: Well-justified combinations of skills can grant +1 die or better Position/Effect when the fiction supports it.

Chapter 8

Experience Paths and Character Building

How you spend your **Experience Points (XP)** shapes more than your numbers on a sheet—it defines your character’s *career*, their growth over time, and the kind of stories they invite into play.

This chapter focuses on:

- turning a loose idea into a clear **character concept**,
- mapping that concept into **starting choices** that fit the campaign rules,
- choosing a **career path** (how you plan to grow),
- and understanding how your character can evolve across **early, mid, and late** game.

All examples in this chapter are *legal starting builds* under the standard creation rules, and are written to be directly usable by players.

8.1 From Concept to Career

Before you spend a single XP, start with the story you want to tell.

Step 1: Concept Seed

Begin with a simple statement of who your character is:

- “Stoic bodyguard who will take the hit for anyone else.”
- “Nervy courier who knows every back alley in the city.”
- “Soft-spoken merchant who pulls strings behind the scenes.”

This is your **concept seed**. Everything else grows from here.

Step 2: Role in the Party

Decide what you want to *do at the table*:

- Take hits and lock down threats?
- Spot danger and solve practical problems?
- Talk through conflicts and manage social fallout?
- Create tools, magic, or plans that enable everyone else?

Your role helps you choose a **Primary Attribute** and 2–3 **Key Skills** (see 7).

Step 3: Career Theme

Ask yourself:

- Is this a story of *self-mastery*? (training, discipline, pushing limits)
- A story of *connections*? (alliances, obligations, webs of influence)
- A story of *balance*? (learning to juggle many demands at once)

Your answer naturally points you toward one of the three **XP paths** in this chapter.

Step 4: Long Arc in One Sentence

Write a single sentence for where you imagine your character at high XP:

- “I want to become the greatest duelist in the realm.”
- “I want to map the unknown and bring others safely home.”
- “I want to run the network everyone relies on but no one sees.”

You do not have to stick to this forever, but it gives you a *direction* for your early choices.

Character Career Checklist

Before spending XP, decide:

1. Your **concept seed** (one sentence).
2. Your **role in the party** (what you do most).
3. Your preferred **career theme**: self, balance, or influence.
4. A rough **long arc** (where you want to end up).

Start simple. You can always refine these as the campaign unfolds.

8.2 Mapping Concept to Mechanics

Once you have a concept, you turn it into numbers. Use this as a guideline:

1. Pick a **Primary Attribute** that supports your role (Body, Wits, Spirit, or Presence) – see 7.1.
2. Choose 2–3 **Key Skills** that you want to be noticeably good at (see 7.2).
3. Choose a **Career Path** (Personal, Balanced, Influencer) that matches your theme.
4. Use the starting XP budget in 8.9 to buy:
 - Attribute steps for your primary and possibly secondary stats.
 - Skill steps for your key and supporting skills.
 - Optional resources or special abilities, if your path calls for them.

Throughout this chapter, each example shows how a concept becomes a legal build.

8.3 Three Career Paths

There are three broad approaches to character development, each representing a different **career philosophy**:

Personal Path Focus on personal mastery and self-improvement (8.5).

Balanced Path Mix personal growth with resources and influence (8.6).

Influencer Path Build networks, assets, and strategic power (8.7).

These paths are not rigid classes. They are *patterns* that help you decide where most of your XP will go, especially in the early game.

8.4 Player Archetypes

Not every player spends XP the same way. These three **player archetypes** describe common patterns. Identify yours – it will help you choose a career path and avoid frustration.

The Solo

Definition: Invests XP primarily in Attributes and Skills. Minimal followers, minimal holdings. All power is on the character sheet.

Typical XP Spread: 70–90% Self; 0–10% On-screen help; 0–20% Off-screen assets.

Strengths: Consistent scene impact; few moving parts; resilient to follower loss.

Risks: Limited fiction reach between sessions; can stall when problems demand logistics or networks.

Starting Focus: Attributes 2–3, Skills 1–2, minimal assets.

The Mixed Player

Definition: Splits XP between self-growth and one or two meaningful assets (a small follower or a reliable holding).

Typical XP Spread: 50–65% Self; 15–25% On-screen help; 15–25% Off-screen assets.

Strengths: Versatile: credible in scenes and has a lever for special problems.

Risks: Upkeep pressure; helper can be targeted when the GM spends 2+ Story Beats.

Starting Focus: Balanced approach with one minor asset or low-cap follower.

The Mastermind

Definition: Prioritises followers / cadres / familiars and off-screen networks. The character sheet is the hub of a larger apparatus.

Typical XP Spread: 25–40% Self; 35–55% On-screen help; 20–40% Off-screen assets.

Strengths: Scene control via assistance; strategic reach between sessions; strong heist / social-planning play.

Risks: Dependency on assist lanes; followers can be endangered on 2+ SB spends; upkeep pressure.

Starting Focus: Significant investment in followers or major assets from the beginning.

Which Archetype Are You?

Ask yourself:

- Do I want my character to be self-sufficient and always ready? → **Solo**
- Do I enjoy having a helpful sidekick or a home base, but not too much bookkeeping? → **Mixed**
- Do I love managing networks, commanding troops, and solving problems through influence? → **Mastermind**

There is no wrong answer – but knowing your style helps you build a character you will enjoy for many sessions.

8.5 Path 1: Personal Development

The **Personal Path** centers your character’s career on what *they* can do: their body, mind, and honed skills. This is the path of the duelist, the ascetic, the elite scout, the master healer.

Typical Investment

- 70–90% Personal improvement (Attributes and Skills)
- 0–10% Resources and assets
- 0–20% Special abilities

Strengths

- Reliable in direct challenges and combat
- Minimal upkeep or management required
- Resilient to loss of external resources
- Consistent performance in spotlight moments

Weaknesses

- Limited influence in social or strategic scenes
- May struggle with problems requiring networks
- Less capable in logistics or large-scale operations
- Dependent on personal presence for all solutions

Career View

On this path, your “career ladder” is mostly about pushing numbers related to **you**: raising Attributes, deepening Skills, and picking a few defining abilities. Your late-game questions are:

- “What does a legendary version of this look like?”

- “What scenes prove that I have truly mastered my craft?”

Build Example: The Duelist (Legal Start)

Concept Seed: “A proud blade whose entire life is training and challenge.”

Total XP: 30 (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications; see 8.9)

- **Attributes:** Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 1, Presence 1
 - Costs (Attributes cost *new rating* × 3): Body 1→2 (6), 2→3 (9) = **15**; Wits 1→2 (6) = **6**; Spirit/Presence remain 1 = **0**. *Subtotal: 21 XP*
- **Skills:** Melee 2, Athletics 1
 - Costs (Skills cost *new level* × 2): Melee 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Athletics 0→1 = **2**. *Subtotal: 8 XP*
- **Totals:** 21 + 8 = **29 XP**. Bank **1 XP**.
- **With +4 XP (Bonds/Complications):** Add *Perception* 0→1 (2) and spend banked 1 XP on *Stealth* 0→1 (2), or instead take *Perception* 0→1 (2) and *Sway* 0→1 (2) for broader utility. *Cap: 36XP*.

Career Hook: Early scenes show duels and drills. Mid game focuses on notorious opponents. Late game tells the story of a blade whose name carries across borders.

8.6 Path 2: Balanced Approach

The **Balanced Path** mixes personal capability with supportive resources. This is the path of the scout-captain, the field medic with a small clinic, the problem-solver who always seems to have *something* ready.

Typical Investment

- 50–65% Personal improvement
- 15–25% Resources and assets
- 15–25% Special abilities

Strengths

- Adaptable to diverse situations
- Handles both direct and indirect challenges
- Excellent supporting role for the group
- Moderate risk profile

Weaknesses

- Not exceptional in any single area
- Requires management of resources
- Moderate upkeep demands
- Can be outshone by focused specialists

Career View

Balanced characters often have careers that feel like juggling:

- they add contacts, gear, or small bases *and*
- keep raising the core skills that let them use those tools well.

Their late-game questions are:

- “What does my little network or operation look like at full size?”
- “How do my personal skills and resources fit together as a whole?”

Build Example: The Scout (Legal Start)

Concept Seed: “A pathfinder who knows how to get in, get out, and get others home.”

Total XP: 30 (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications)

- **Attributes:** Wits 2, Body 2, Spirit 1, Presence 1
 - Costs: Wits 1→2 (6), Body 1→2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2, Perception 1, Stealth 1
 - Costs: Survival 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Perception 0→1 **2**; Stealth 0→1 **2**. *Subtotal: 10 XP*
- **Resources:** *Minor equipment cache* (camp gear, maps, signal kit) = **4 XP**
- **Special Abilities:** *Wilderness Lore* (broad travel benefits) = **4 XP**
- **Totals:** 12 + 10 + 4 + 4 = **32 XP**.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Perception 1→2* (+4) *or* take a *trained hawk companion* (Minor Resource, 4 XP).

Career Hook: Early stories show small journeys. Mid game explores dangerous routes and rescue missions. Late game might see the scout running expeditions, caravans, or an entire mapping guild.

8.7 Path 3: Influencer Focus

The **Influencer Path** emphasizes networks, assets, and strategic power. This is the path of the merchant-prince, the fixer, the spymaster, the noble with more favors owed than coins in their purse.

Typical Investment

- 25–40% Personal improvement
- 35–55% Resources and assets
- 20–40% Special abilities

Strengths

- Strong strategic and social influence
- Can solve problems indirectly
- Excellent at planning and preparation
- Creates opportunities for the whole group

Weaknesses

- Personally vulnerable in direct confrontations
- High maintenance requirements
- Complications can cascade through networks
- Dependent on external factors

Career View

Influencer careers are about building and surviving **webs**:

- webs of contacts, debts, trade routes, cells, or clients.

Late game questions become:

- “How big can this web reasonably grow within the fiction?”
- “What happens when a strand of my web is cut, or pulled tight?”

Build Example: The Merchant (Legal Start)

Concept Seed: “A friendly shopkeeper whose real power lies in who owes them favors.”

Total XP: 30 (34 with +4 from Bonds/Complications)

- **Attributes:** Presence 2, Wits 2, Spirit 1, Body 1
 - Costs: Presence 1→2 (6), Wits 1→2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2, Deception 1, Lore 1
 - Costs: Sway 0→1 (2), 1→2 (4) = **6**; Deception 0→1 **2**; Lore 0→1 **2**. *Subtotal: 10 XP*
- **Resources:** *Standard trading office* (staffed storefront, ledgers, storage) = **8 XP**
- **Totals:** 12 + 10 + 8 = **32 XP**.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Negotiation Mastery* (4 XP general ability) *or* expand to a second *Minor merchant route* (4 XP).

Career Hook: Early scenes are about one shop and a few key clients. Mid game introduces caravans, deals, and rivals. Late game might place the merchant at the center of regional politics and supply chains.

8.8 Building for Group Synergy

Your character’s career path matters most in context with the rest of the party. A well-constructed party covers key roles without excessive overlap.

Key Roles to Consider

Combat Frontline defense, skirmishing, or ranged fire support.

Social Negotiation, intimidation, information gathering.

Exploration Scouting, navigating, surviving hostile environments.

Magic Free casting, rites, rituals, or summoning.

Assets Logistics, networks, safehouses, followers.

Complementary Paths

- **Personal path** characters provide reliable combat and specialist solutions.
- **Balanced path** characters handle diverse, connective challenges.
- **Influencer path** characters create opportunities and resources for everyone.

Together, a mixed party can cover nearly every type of problem.

Redundant Paths

- Multiple personal path characters may overlap in combat or role.
- Multiple influencer path characters may compete for spotlight and assets.
- Consider diversifying within similar paths: different weapon styles, different Patrons, different social approaches.
- Example: Two combatants – one a duelist (single-target damage), one a shield-focused guardian (area protection).

Balancing Your Table

If you notice a gap (e.g., no one has investment in social skills or no one has a safehouse asset), consider adjusting your XP spending or discussing with the group. A party that talks about roles early will have a smoother campaign.

8.9 Starting Character Guidelines

Base XP Allocation

- **Standard Starting XP: 32 points**
- **Bonds and Complications:** You may take up to **two total** from any mix of meaningful *Bonds* (up to 2, +2 XP each) and significant *Complications* (up to 2, +2 XP each), granting maximum +4 XP. (See 18 for Bonds and Complications.)
- **Maximum Starting XP: 36 points**
- **Complication Effect:** Each unresolved starting Complication adds +1 banked SB to early scenes until cleared.

Recommended Starting Ranges

Category	Recommended XP
Primary Attribute	9–12 XP (rating 3–4)
Secondary Attributes	0–9 XP each (rating 1–3)
Key Skills	4–6 XP each (rating 2–3)
Supporting Skills	2–4 XP each (rating 1–2)
Resources	0–8 XP total
Special Abilities	0–8 XP total

8.9.0.0.1 Cost Reminders:

- **Attributes:** Each step costs *new rating* ×3 XP (e.g., 1→2 costs 6; 2→3 costs 9). See 7.1.
- **Skills:** Each step costs *new level* ×2 XP (e.g., 0→1 costs 2; 1→2 costs 4). See 7.2.
- **Resources:** Minor 4 XP; Standard 8 XP; Major 12 XP.
- **Special Abilities:** Minor Edge 2 XP; Major Edge 4 XP; Prestige 6+ XP.

8.10 Progression Planning

Think of your character's career in phases. These XP bands are approximate and assume you began at 30–36XP.

Early Game (0–40 XP)

Focus on establishing core capabilities:

- Reach attribute rating 3 in your primary area.
- Develop 2–3 key skills to rating 2–3.
- Acquire basic resources or one special ability (if your path uses them).
- Clarify your character's niche in the group.

When to take a Follower vs. Asset vs. Talent (Early):

- **Follower:** If you want on-screen help (a scout, a bodyguard, an apprentice). Start with Cap 1–2.
- **Asset:** If you want an off-screen advantage (a safehouse, a workshop, a contact network). Start with Minor Asset (4 XP).
- **Talent:** If you want a signature move (combat technique, social edge, magic access). Minor talents (2–3 XP) are great early.

Mid Game (41–90 XP)

Expand and specialize:

- Increase your primary attribute to 4.
- Specialize key skills to rating 3–4.
- Develop supporting capabilities that fit your concept.
- Build strategic resources or networks if on the Balanced or Influencer path.
- Acquire signature special abilities that define your style.

When to take a Follower vs. Asset vs. Talent (Mid):

- **Follower:** Upgrade a loyal contact to Cap 3 (9 XP) – they become a reliable asset who can act independently.
- **Asset:** Expand your network – a Standard Asset (8 XP) turns a safehouse into a spy ring or a workshop into a guild connection.
- **Talent:** Major talents (4–6 XP) define your mid-game identity – Backstab, Ritual Mastery, Command Presence.

Late Game (91–150 XP)

Master your chosen path:

- Achieve peak attributes (rating 4–5).
- Master key skills (rating 4–5).
- Build substantial influence or unique capabilities.
- Develop advanced special abilities.
- Consider legacy projects, organizations, or long-term changes to the setting.

When to take a Follower vs. Asset vs. Talent (Late):

- **Follower:** A Cap 4–5 follower (16–25 XP) can become a successor (see 19) – invest in someone who could carry on your cause.
- **Asset:** Major Assets (12 XP) give you regional influence – a fortress, a charter, a fleet.
- **Talent:** Prestige (7–10 XP) and Epic (11+ XP) talents reshape the story. Plan your build around one or two capstones.

XP Path Quick Reference

Personal Path (70–90% self):

- Reliable individual performance.
- Low upkeep, high consistency.
- Best for combatants and focused specialists.

Balanced Path (50–65% self):

- Good all-around capability.
- Moderate risk and upkeep.
- Flexible support and problem-solving role.

Influencer Path (25–40% self):

- Strategic power and influence.
- High upkeep, high reward.
- Creates opportunities for the entire group.

Starting XP: 30 base + up to +4 from Bonds/Complications (max start 34).

8.11 Path Combination Strategies

Many players mix elements from different paths as their character's life unfolds.

Combat Specialist with Resources

- Strong personal combat capabilities.
- Moderate resource investment for support.
- Good for frontline fighters who need logistical backup.
- Example: Warrior with a fortified base and loyal troops.

Social Character with Personal Skills

- Excellent social capabilities.
- Solid personal skills for self-defense or utility.
- Good for diplomats who operate independently.
- Example: Ambassador with combat training and persuasion skills.

Technical Expert with Networks

- Deep technical or magical expertise.
- Network of contacts and resources to enable projects.
- Good for specialists who need supply chains and helpers.
- Example: Master crafter with supplier network and apprentices.

8.12 Resource Management

Each path asks for different management styles across your character's career.

Personal Path Management

- Minimal upkeep requirements.
- Focus on equipment, training scenes, and personal growth.
- Low complexity, high reliability.

Balanced Path Management

- Moderate upkeep for resources.
- Relationship maintenance with contacts.
- Skill development alongside resource management.
- Balanced time investment between self and assets.

Influencer Path Management

- Significant upkeep demands.
- Network maintenance and expansion.
- Resource allocation and development.
- Strategic planning and opportunity management.

8.13 Risk Assessment

Each path carries different career risks.

Personal Path Risks

- Over-specialization in one area.
- Vulnerability to problems outside your specialty.
- Limited diversification later in the game.
- May become predictable in approach.

Balanced Path Risks

- Jack-of-all-trades, master of none.
- Spread too thin across capabilities.
- Moderate risks in multiple areas.
- May lack standout, defining capabilities if unfocused.

Influencer Path Risks

- Networks are vulnerable to attack and betrayal.
- High maintenance requirements.
- Cascade failure potential if a key asset falls.
- Personal safety concerns when the web is targeted.

8.14 Adapting Your Path

Your chosen path is a starting point, not a contract. You can shift focus as your character's story changes.

Early Shift (0–40 XP)

- Easy to change direction.
- Minimal sunk cost in any single approach.
- Good time to experiment with different styles.
- You can respond quickly to group needs or unexpected story turns.

Mid Game Shift (41–90 XP)

- Requires more deliberate planning.
- Some capabilities need to be maintained while others change.
- You can fill emerging gaps in group capability.
- Temporary performance dips may occur during the transition.

Late Game Shift (91+ XP)

- Significant investment in your current path.
- Major shifts require substantial XP and story justification.
- Often better to add complementary capabilities than completely pivot.
- Consider how changes reflect pivotal events in your character's life.

8.15 Practical Building Examples (Narrative Roles, Legal Starts)

Each of the following examples combines:

- a short **concept**,
- a **path choice**,
- a legal **starting build**,
- and a sketch of their **career arc**.

Example 1: The Guardian

Path: Personal **Total:** 32 XP

Concept Seed: “Quiet wall of muscle who would rather bleed than lose anyone.”

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (1→2: 6, 2→3: 9), Wits 2 (1→2: 6) = **21 XP**

- **Skills:** Melee 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Athletics 1 (0→1: 2) = **8 XP**
- **Bank:** 1 XP
- **Role at table:** Frontline protection and reliable pressure in fights.
- **With +4 XP:** add *Combat Reflexes* (2 XP talent) and *Shield Mastery* (4 XP talent) using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP (GM may allow rounding or an extra minor Complication), or instead buy more supporting skills.

Career Arc: Early on, the Guardian is “the one who stands in front.” Mid game adds tactical awareness and maybe leadership. Late game might see them training others or becoming the symbol of a cause.

Example 2: The Explorer

Path: Balanced **Total:** 32 XP

Concept Seed: “Curious wanderer whose maps are more valuable than gold.”

- **Attributes:** Wits 2 (6), Body 2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Perception 1 (2), Stealth 1 (2) = **10 XP**
- **Resources:** Minor mapping kit & route notes = **4 XP**
- **Ability:** Trail Sense = **4 XP**
- **Totals:** **32 XP**. With +4 XP, raise *Perception* 1→2 (+4) or add a trained beast (Minor Resource, 4 XP).

Career Arc: Early stories focus on survival and discovery. Mid game might see them guiding trade, armies, or refugees. Late game, they may literally redraw the map of the setting.

Example 3: The Schemer

Path: Influencer **Total:** 32 XP

Concept Seed: “The person who always knows someone who knows someone.”

- **Attributes:** Presence 2 (6), Wits 2 (6) = **12 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2 (0→1: 2, 1→2: 4 = 6), Deception 1 (2), Lore 1 (2) = **10 XP**
- **Resources:** Standard safehouse & message drops = **8 XP**
- **Totals:** **32 XP**. With +4 XP, take *Network Builder* (4 XP talent) or add *Minor informant ring* (4 XP).

Career Arc: Early on, the Schemer is just “the one with connections.” Mid game grows their network and enemies. Late game, they might operate entire webs of spies, informants, merchants, or political factions.

8.15.0.0.1 Reminder: All builds above assume baseline *Attributes at 1* and *Skills at 0* before spending. Attribute and Skill advances are cumulative by step (see costs in 8.9).

Remember: Your chosen path should reflect both your character concept and your preferred play style. There is no single “correct” path—only what works for you, your group, and the story you want to tell.

Planning for Succession (The Legacy Engine)

If you are playing a long campaign or enjoy the idea of your character's influence outlasting them, consider investing in a **Follower** (Cap 3+) early. That follower can become your **successor** when your character retires or falls – inheriting your faction standing, one unresolved burden, and a Legacy Bond (see **Chapter 19: The Legacy Engine**). A loyal apprentice, a trusted lieutenant, or a family member can carry your story forward.

8.16 Narrative-Heavy Character Building Options

For groups that prefer a strong narrative focus in character building, you can treat XP as a tool for telling the story of a career, not just a currency.

8.16.0.0.1 Story-Driven Milestones Instead of tracking XP numerically, the GM can award advancement when characters reach significant story milestones. “You have trained with the master for months—you’ve improved your skill.”

8.16.0.0.2 Experience Through Reflection Players can spend downtime scenes reflecting on past experiences to earn XP. A meaningful flashback, confession, or revelation can justify growth without counting every point.

8.16.0.0.3 Collaborative Advancement The group can discuss and agree on advancement choices, ensuring everyone's growth supports the overall story direction and shared arcs.

8.16.0.0.4 Narrative Justification Focus When spending XP, players should explain how their character gained this capability through in-game experiences, creating richer backstory and continuity. “I raise Presence because I’ve been forced to handle the group’s negotiations for weeks.”

8.16.0.0.5 Path as Theme Use your chosen path as a **theme** rather than a strict budget:

- A Personal Path character emphasizes physical, mental, or spiritual self-mastery.
- A Balanced Path character emphasizes learning how to juggle tools and relationships.
- An Influencer Path character emphasizes their growing web of relationships and obligations.

In all cases, let your character's **career** on the page match the career they are living in the fiction.

Chapter 9

Talents and Special Abilities

Talents are the building blocks of character specialization. They represent learned techniques, supernatural gifts, or cultural inheritances. Each Talent costs XP, and its cost reflects its impact.

9.1 Understanding Talents

Talents are purchased with **Experience Points (XP)** (see 7) and provide special capabilities:

- They go beyond simple skill bonuses.
- They often have specific **activation conditions**.
- They may provide **narrative permissions** (you can try things others cannot).
- They can define your character's **unique identity**.

Talent Costs by Tier

Tier	Cost	Scope
Minor	2–3 XP	Small situational bonus, once per scene.
Major	4–6 XP	Strong upgrade, permanent effect in a niche.
Prestige	7–10 XP	Campaign-defining, breaks fundamental limits.
Epic	11+ XP	Legendary ability, shapes the story.

9.1.0.0.1 Activation Types.

- **Passive:** Always on; no action required.
- **Active:** Requires an action or scene focus to use.
- **Reactive:** Triggers automatically on a condition.

9.1.0.0.2 Limits and Economy. Unless a talent says otherwise:

- **Per scene** uses refresh at scene end.
- **Per session** uses refresh after downtime.
- Some talents allow you to spend **Boons** (see 2) to push effects further.

Only One Active Talent?

The rule “only one talent can be active at a time” applies only to **activated abilities** that require a decision or action.

Passive talents (e.g., +1 die to perception) are always active and stack.

Active talents that require an action or reaction cannot be used simultaneously – you choose which one to activate when the trigger occurs.

Talents that are “once per scene” reset at the end of the scene.

9.2 Minor Talents (2–3 XP)

General

Keen Senses [PERCEPTION]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. +1 die on perception checks to spot danger or hidden details.

Silver Tongue [PERSUASION]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. +1 die on persuasion attempts.

Second Wind [RECOVERY]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. Clear 1 Fatigue when you take a moment to catch your breath.

Combat Reflexes [REACTIVE]

Cost: 2 XP Reactive. +1 dv on defense when surprised or flanked.

Precise Strike [STRIKE]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. Ignore armor on one attack if you had Dominant or Controlled position.

Trackless Step [EVADE]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. Leave no trail for the rest of the scene.

Urban Navigation [DIRECTION]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. Never get lost in cities.

Wilderness Lore [NATURE]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. Automatically find food and water in hospitable biomes.

Read Emotions [INSIGHT]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. Automatically detect surface emotions in a social exchange.

Iron Patience [RESISTANCE]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. When you Defend, gain +1 die to resist Conditions (fear, charm, fatigue) for the rest of the exchange, even outside the triggering roll.

Requires: Resolve 1+.

Stand Firm [PROTECT]

Cost: 2 XP Reactive. When you Defend and roll a Miss, downgrade incoming Harm by 1 level (minimum 0).

Requires: Body 2+.

Counterpoise [EVADE]

Cost: 2 XP Reactive. When you take a Defend action and score a Partial, you may immediately move 1 range band or reposition within Near without provoking retaliation.

Requires: Athletics 1+ or Melee 1+.

Smooth Talker [SOCIAL] [FIRST IMPRESSION]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. When you make a social roll against a person you have never met before, you gain +1 die. Once the conversation ends, this bonus no longer applies to that NPC.

Requires: Presence 2+.

Ear to the Ground [INFORMATION] [NETWORK]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per session. When you spend at least an hour in a settlement, you may ask the GM one question about local rumors, faction activity, or recent events. The GM must answer truthfully, though the answer may be vague or incomplete.

Friendly Face [SOCIAL] [RAPPORT]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. When you spend a scene socializing with a group (buying drinks, sharing stories, playing cards), you gain +1 die on your next social roll against any member of that group within the same session.

Negotiation Stance [SOCIAL] [BARGAIN]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. When you propose a deal that both parties could reasonably accept (GM discretion), treat your Position as one step better (Controlled → Dominant, Desperate → Controlled). This talent cannot raise Position above Dominant.

Projecting Voice [PERFORMANCE] [AUDIENCE]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. Your voice carries clearly over crowds, wind, and moderate noise. You can be heard by any willing listener within Far range without rolling. When you attempt to calm, command, or inspire a crowd (DV 3–5), treat your Position as one step better (Controlled → Dominant, Desperate → Controlled).

Requires: Performance 1+.

Healer Talents**Field Dressing** [HEALING] [STABILIZE]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. When a character within Touch range would take Harm that would reduce them to Harm 3 (Incapacitated or dying), you may use your reaction to stabilize them. They remain at Harm 2 (instead of Harm 3) and will not die from this wound for the rest of the scene. You must describe how you apply pressure, a tourniquet, or a makeshift bandage.

Requires: Medicine 1+.

Ranger/Tracker Talents

Keen Tracker [TRACKING] [SURVIVAL]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. When you attempt to track a creature or follow a trail, you may reroll one failed die on your Survival or Investigation roll. This does not apply to magical or supernatural tracking unless you have relevant magic.

Requires: Survival 1+ or Investigation 1+.

Artificer/Crafter Talents

Master Tinker [CRAFT] [REPAIR]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. +1 die to all Craft rolls when repairing, modifying, or maintaining equipment. Additionally, you may perform minor repairs on the go without a workshop (fix a broken lockpick, patch a leaky waterskin, reattach a strap) as a short action.

Requires: Craft 1+.

Rogue (Thief) Talents

Light Fingers [STRIKE] [AGILITY]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. When you attempt to lift a small object (purse, key, letter, seal) from a person or desk, treat your first Stealth or Subterfuge roll as Position +1.

The Unlocked Window [MOVE] [AGILITY]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. When infiltrating a structure you have cased for at least an hour, ignore one security obstacle (locked door, patrolled corridor, guard dog) per session. Describe how you already prepared for it.

Silk Palms [INFLUENCE]

Cost: 2 XP Active. When you bribe or gift a minor official, you gain a temporary String: *Bought Silence*. Once, you may activate this String to reduce DV by 1 on a Petition or Broker action involving that official. The String is consumed afterward.

Monk (Unarmed) Talents

Disciplined Body [STRENGTH] [RECOVERY]

Cost: 3 XP Passive + Active. +1 die to unarmed combat attacks. Once per scene, convert 1 Harm to Fatigue, and once per scene improve Position by one step.

Requires: Melee 1+, Body 2+.

Open Hand Technique [CONTROL] [STRIKE]

Cost: 2 XP Active, once per scene. When you hit with an unarmed attack, you may choose one: knock the target prone, push them back one range band, or force them to drop a held item.

Requires: Melee 1+, Body 2+.

Iron Skin [ENDURANCE] [PROTECT]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. When you take physical Harm, you may convert the first point of Harm each scene to Fatigue instead.

Requires: Body 2+.

Combat

Defensive Survival [DEFENSE] [RECOVERY]

Cost: 3 XP Passive + Active. +1 to defense DV while engaged in melee. Once per scene, convert first Harm 1 from melee to Fatigue.

Requires: Melee 2+.

Weapon Training [MASTERY]

Cost: 3 XP Passive. +1 die with a chosen weapon category (instead of +2 from the Major version).

Note: The full +2 dice version is a Major talent (Weapon Mastery; see 9.3).

Mounted Archery [MOUNTED] [RANGED]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. You ignore the usual –1 die penalty for firing a ranged weapon while your mount is moving at a walk or trot. When your mount is galloping or taking evasive action, you suffer only –1 die instead of –2.

Requires: Ranged 1+, Ride (or Athletics) 1+.

Cultural Affinity: Ykrul and Kuvani characters may take this talent for 1 XP instead of 2.

The Miss That Feeds [DEFENSE] [FLOW]

Cost: 2 XP Passive. When an enemy's attack against you results in a Miss, you gain +1 Position on your next action against that enemy.

Requires: Body 2+.

Glancing Failure [DEFENSE] [GAMBIT]

Cost: 3 XP Passive. When an enemy's attack against you results in a Partial, you may improve your Position by one step on your next action.

Requires: Body 2+, Spirit 2+.

9.3 Major Talents (4–6 XP)

Magic Access

Spellcraft [FIRE] [WATER]

Cost: 6 XP Passive. Grants access to Weave & Cast freeform spellcasting using the Eight Elements. Without this, characters cannot freeform cast.

Codex [FATE] [RITUAL]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Required to fully join a Patron's service as a Runekeeper. Grants access to that Patron's Rites and Obligation system (see 5).

Patron's Symbol [WARD] [SIGIL]

Cost: 4 XP Minor Asset. Allows an Invoker to access a Patron's Rites via ritual precision. Each Patron requires its own Symbol.

Patron's Gift [IMBUEMENT]

Cost: Free (requires Familiar) Active, once per scene. Imbue one item with +1 Melee and +1 thematic Skill for the scene. Push (mark +1 Obligation) to extend one more scene.

General

Weapon Mastery [WEAPON]

Cost: 5 XP Passive. Choose a weapon type; +2 dice when using it. Once per scene, +1 Effect with signature weapon.

Requires: Melee 2+.

Command Presence [LEADERSHIP]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. +1 die on leadership and intimidation rolls.

Network Weaver [BOND]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Gain a minor contact in each new settlement visited.

Tactical Movement [MOVEMENT] [POSITION]

Cost: 4 XP Passive + Active. Move within engagement zone as Move action (instead of full action). Once per scene, disengage from Close as Move action.

Requires: Athletics 2+.

Conditioning [RESISTANCE] [ENDURANCE]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Body attribute counts as +1 for Fatigue track calculations. +1 die to resist Fatigue overflow effects.

Requires: Body 3+.

Spell Shaping [CONTROL]

Cost: 4 XP Active. When you Weave a spell, modify range, scale, or targeting by one step.

Requires: Spellcraft.

Elemental Focus [ELEMENT]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Choose one element (Fire, Water, Earth, Air). +1 die when casting spells of that element.

Requires: Spellcraft.

Ritual Mastery [RITUAL]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. When you suffer backlash from a ritual (including any SB generated by your roll), reduce the severity of the Backlash by one step (Catastrophic → Major, Major → Moderate, Moderate → Minor, Minor → none). This applies once per scene.

Requires: Familiar or Patron's Symbol.

Efficient Invocation [RITUAL]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Reduce ritual casting time by one step (minimum 1 action).

Requires: Patron's Symbol.

Trusted Reputation [SOCIAL] [FAVOR]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per session. When you are in good standing with a faction (GM discretion), you may call in a minor favor: a temporary discount, a piece of information, or a small service (e.g., a guard looks the other way, a merchant offers a fair price). The faction will expect reciprocity eventually.

Information Broker [INVESTIGATION] [NETWORK]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. When you successfully gather information (via Investigation, Streetwise, or similar), you may ask the GM **two** questions instead of one. The second question may be less detailed at the GM's discretion.

Unshakeable Composure [SOCIAL] [RESISTANCE]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. You gain +1 die to resist intimidation, coercion, social manipulation (e.g., Sway, Command), and fear effects in social situations. Additionally, once per scene, you may ignore the first social Condition imposed on you (e.g., Shaken, Guilty Tell).

Requires: Resolve 2+ or Spirit 2+.

Healer Talents**Triage** [HEALING] [RECOVERY]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you spend an action tending to a wounded ally within Touch range, you may heal 1 Fatigue from them and, if they are at Harm 1 or 2, they treat their Harm level as one step lower for the purpose of penalties until the end of the scene (e.g., Harm 2 → Harm 1, Harm 1 → none). This does not actually reduce their Harm track; it only mitigates penalties.

Requires: Medicine 2+.

Ranger/Tracker Talents**Camouflage** [STEALTH] [TERRAIN]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you are in natural terrain (forest, jungle, swamp, rocky hills, snow), you may spend an action to blend into the environment. For the remainder of the scene, you gain +2 dice to Stealth rolls while remaining still, and pursuers suffer –1 die to detect you. Moving at more than a slow crawl breaks the camouflage.

Requires: Survival 2+, Stealth 1+.

Artificer/Crafter Talents**Master Artificer** [CRAFT] [CREATION]

Cost: 5 XP Passive. +1 die to all Craft rolls when creating, building, or upgrading items, structures, or devices. Additionally, once per downtime, you may reduce the required time to craft a mundane item by half (minimum 1 hour) and reduce the material cost (Supply) by 1 (minimum 0).

Requires: Craft 2+, Master Tinker.

Cantor (Performer) Talents**Captivating Performance** [PERFORMANCE] [INSPIRE]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you perform (sing, recite, play an instrument) for at least one full exchange, all allies who can hear you gain +1 die to resist fear, despair, or charm for the remainder of the scene. Additionally, you may choose one ally; they also gain +1 die to their next social roll.

Requires: Performance 2+, Presence 2+.

Voice of Reason [PERFORMANCE] [PERSUASION]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you attempt to de-escalate a tense situation or convince a hostile NPC to stand down, you may roll Performance instead of Sway or Command. On a success, the NPC hesitates or agrees to parley for at least one exchange. On a Partial, they still listen but may demand a concession.

Requires: Performance 2+, Presence 2+.

Harmonious Aid [PERFORMANCE] [TEAMWORK]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you use the Assist action (spend 1 Boon to give +1 die to an ally), you may describe how you support them with a hummed tune or whispered rhythm. The ally gains an additional +1 die (total +2 from your Assist). This does not count against the usual +3 assist cap.

Requires: Performance 1+.

Well-Timed Encore [PERFORMANCE] [RECOVERY]

Cost: 5 XP Active, once per session. After a successful Performance roll that impressed an audience (GM discretion), you may declare an encore. The audience demands more. This extends any active Performance-based effect (e.g., Captivating Performance) for an additional scene, but the GM gains 2 SB (the guards grow curious, a rival takes notice, or the crowd becomes over-enthusiastic).

Requires: Captivating Performance.

Follower and Asset Talents**Efficient Recruiter** [FOLLOWER] [COST REDUCTION]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Reduce the XP cost to acquire a new follower by 1 (minimum 1 XP). Additionally, reduce the required downtime for recruitment by 1 day (minimum 1 day). This talent applies to each follower individually.

Requires: Presence 2+.

Asset Crafter [ASSET] [COST REDUCTION]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. Reduce the XP cost to acquire a new Asset by 1 per tier (Minor: 4 → 3 XP; Standard: 8 → 6 XP; Major: 12 → 9 XP; Artifact: 16+ → 12+ XP). Also reduce the required downtime by half (rounded up, minimum 1 day). This talent does not apply to Assets gained through narrative events without XP cost.

Loyalty Bond [FOLLOWER] [LOYALTY]

Cost: 5 XP Passive. Your followers' Loyalty tag improves by one step (Wary → Steady → Devoted). A Devoted follower cannot be turned, bribed, or intimidated into betraying you without a major narrative event (GM discretion). This talent applies to all followers you currently have and any you acquire later.

Requires: Spirit 2+, at least one follower.

Delegated Upkeep [FOLLOWER] [ASSET MANAGEMENT]

Cost: 5 XP Passive. Choose a follower with Capability 3 or higher. That follower may manage your Assets as follows, using their own upkeep (paid in XP or downtime action) to cover the Assets' upkeep costs (no separate XP or action for those Assets):

- **Cap 3:** 1 Minor Asset.
- **Cap 4:** 3 Assets (any tier).
- **Cap 5:** 5 Assets (any tier).

If the follower's Loyalty becomes Strained or Broken, all delegated Assets immediately worsen one step (Flourishing → Stable, etc.) until the follower is restored. If the follower becomes Broken, those Assets are lost.

Requires: At least one follower with Cap 3+.

Rapid Construction [ASSET] [CRAFT]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. When you craft or build an Asset (e.g., a workshop, safehouse, library, or similar physical asset) during downtime, reduce the required downtime by half (minimum 1 day) and reduce any material cost (GM-determined Supply or resources) by 1 (minimum 0). This talent does not apply to Assets acquired through purely social or political means.

Requires: Craft 2+, Wits 2+.

Rogue (Thief) Talents

Always Another Exit [MOVE] [ESCAPE]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per session. When you are cornered or a heist goes wrong, you may declare you prepared an escape route earlier. Describe it plausibly (rope out a window, bribed a guard, secret door). The GM may impose a cost—a dropped item, a witness, a future obligation—but you get out.

The Forger's Eye [CRAFT] [PRECISION]

Cost: 4 XP Active. You can copy any handwriting, seal, or signature with uncanny accuracy. When you attempt to forge a document, roll Wits + Craft (DV 3 for simple, 4–5 for complex). On a hit, create a Forged credential. On a partial, the forgery holds for one scene; thereafter it may be detected.

Requires: Craft 1+.

Crowd Veil [OBSERVE] [STEALTH]

Cost: 4 XP Active. You vanish into crowds. When in a populated area (market, festival, dock), you may roll Stealth vs. DV 3 to become Hidden in plain sight. Pursuers suffer -1 die to find you until you act conspicuously.

Requires: Stealth 2+.

The Velvet Glove [INFLUENCE] [NETWORK]

Cost: 5 XP Active, once per session. You have cultivated a network of informants, fence contacts, and corrupted clerks. You may declare that a minor NPC (a servant, a dockworker, a scribe) owes you a favor. They provide a specific service: unlock a door, delay a patrol, deliver a message. The GM may dictate a cost (the NPC will later need help, or their favor expires after use).

Requires: Presence 2+, Streetwise 1+.

Master of Misdirection [INFLUENCE] [DECEPTION]

Cost: 5 XP Active. When you are discovered during a crime, you may spend 1 Boon to redirect suspicion to another person or faction. Roll Deception vs. DV 4. On a hit, the heat shifts; on a miss, you gain Exposure +1 and the target becomes hostile.

Requires: Deception 2+.

Free Caster Talents

Controlled Burn [FIRE] [WILL]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you roll a 1 on a Free Casting roll, you may immediately gain 1 Boon (instead of the GM gaining that SB). The GM still gains the Story Beat as normal. This does not prevent other 1s on the same roll from generating SB normally.

Requires: Spellcraft.

Weave Resilience [SHIELD] [STAMINA]

Cost: 4 XP Passive. When you suffer Backlash from a Free Casting roll, reduce the severity by one step: Catastrophic → Major, Major → Moderate, Moderate → Minor, Minor → none. This applies to the first Backlash each scene. Subsequent Backlashes in the same scene are not reduced.

Requires: Spellcraft.

Elemental Attunement [ELEMENT] [FOCUS]

Cost: 5 XP Passive. Choose one element (Fire, Water, Earth, Air, Fate, Life, Luck, Death/Thresholds). When you cast a Free spell using that element's tag (e.g., [FIRE]), you may reroll one failed die (not a 1) once per casting. Additionally, you gain +1 die to Arcana rolls when identifying or analyzing that element.

Requires: Spellcraft, Elemental Focus.

Backlash Siphon [VOID] [EXCHANGE]

Cost: 6 XP Reactive, once per scene. When you would suffer a Backlash effect (e.g., Fatigue, Harm, Condition) from a Free Casting roll, you may instead mark 1 Obligation to a Patron of your choice (or gain 1 Corruption if you have no Patron). The Backlash is negated, but the Patron's attention is drawn.

Requires: Spellcraft, Spirit 3+.

Combat

Flurry Strike [STRIKE] [SPEED]

Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene. When engaged with multiple opponents, make 2 attacks as one action. Each attack at -1 die.

Requires: Melee 3+, Body 3+.

Duelist's Edge [DOMINANCE] [TECHNIQUE]

Cost: 6 XP Passive + Active. When engaged with a single opponent: +1 die to all melee rolls. Once per scene, ignore first Harm 1 or 2 from that opponent.

Requires: Melee 3+, Wits 3+.

Battlefield Mastery [STRATEGY] [LEADERSHIP]

Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene. When engaged with 3+ opponents, for the next 3 exchanges: all melee attacks gain +1 Effect, enemies act at -1 die, your Position improves by one step, and you may convert one Harm 1 per exchange to Fatigue.

Requires: Melee 4+, Wits 4+, Command 2+.

Backstab [STEALTH] [STRIKE]

Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene. When you attack an Unaware or Engaged foe from Stealth, deal +1 Harm and ignore 1 point of their Armor. On a miss, you are Exposed (Desperate Position or mark 1 Harm).

Requires: Stealth 2+, Melee 2+, light weapon.

Elusive Dodge [DEFENSE] [EVADE]

Cost: 6 XP Reactive, once per exchange. When targeted by a physical attack, you may immediately enter a Defend stance as a free reaction. Mark 1 Fatigue after use.

Requires: Stealth 2+, Wits 3+, Tier II.

Berserker Rage [FURY] [POWER]

Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene. For 3 rounds: +2 dice to melee attacks, ignore first Harm 1 each round, ignore Harm/Fatigue penalties, Position becomes Desperate (re-roll one success). When rage ends, mark Fatigue equal to Spirit. Cannot be ended early. Cannot activate any talents or Rites for the rest of the scene.

Requires: Melee 3+, Spirit 3+, Body 3+.

Cavalier [MOBILITY] [MARTIAL]

Cost: 4 XP Passive while mounted. Gain +2 dice to melee attacks when moving Far→Near, or +2 dice to ranged attacks when moving Near→Far.

Requires: War Mount Asset, Melee 2+ or Ranged 2+.

Subtle Casting [HIDDEN] [CONTROL]

Cost: 6 XP Active. Make a Performance + Lore roll to quietly cast a spell, invoke a Rite, or sing a Cantos against DV (Tier). If successful, the casting does not generate Story Beats on the Channel or initial roll. Any SB generated are banked by the GM and applied later. Cannot be used for Great or Extreme Tier effects.

Requires: Lore 3+, Performance 2+ or Runekeeper with Codex.

Effortless Charge [MOVEMENT] [MARTIAL]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you take the **Charge** action (see 2), you may ignore the Fatigue cost. All other costs and restrictions (Desperate defense, open ground requirement) still apply.

Requires: Body 3+, Melee 2+.

Effortless Skirmish [MOVEMENT] [MARTIAL]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When you take the **Skirmish** (or **Harrying Shot**) action (see 2), you may ignore the Fatigue cost. All other costs and restrictions (Desperate defense, open ground requirement) still apply.

Requires: Wits 3+, Ranged 2+.

Relentless [MOVEMENT] [TERRAIN]

Cost: 6 XP Passive. You may take the **Charge** or **Skirmish** action over **difficult terrain** (rubble, dense forest, shallow water, steep slopes). The Fatigue cost (1) is *not* waived unless you also have the relevant Effortless talent.

Requires: Body 3+, Athletics 2+.

Stubborn Pursuer [MOVEMENT] [REACTION]

Cost: 6 XP Reactive. When an opponent within Close range uses the **Disengage** action (or any movement intended to leave your engagement without provoking an opportunity attack), you may use your reaction to move with them, staying in Close range. This movement does not cost an action and does not provoke opportunity attacks. You move the same number of range bands as they do (e.g., Close → Near, or Near → Far), up to your normal movement limit for the round. You cannot use this talent if you have already taken a Move action or Dash this round. Once per round.

Requires: Body 3+, Athletics 2+.

Horse Archer's Art [MOUNTED] [RANGED] [FLOW]

Cost: 5 XP Passive + Active. You treat the Mounted Archery talent's penalties as fully eliminated for walk/trot, and for gallop/evade you suffer no penalty. Additionally, once per scene when you take a **Skirmish** action (move one band and make a ranged attack) while mounted, you may also have your mount move an additional band (up to two bands total) as part of the same action. This extra movement costs no additional action and does not provoke opportunity attacks.

Requires: Mounted Archery, Ranged 2+, Ride (or Athletics) 2+.

Cultural Affinity: Ykrul and Kuvani characters may reduce the XP cost to 4 XP.

Stalwart's Ledger [DEFENSE] [OBLIGATION]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per scene. When an enemy's attack against you results in a Miss, you may immediately reposition yourself one range band without provoking opportunity attacks.

Requires: Body 3+, Spirit 2+.

Called Shot [STRIKE] [RNG] [GAMBIT]

Cost: 6 XP Active, once per scene. When you attack an **Unaware** target or a target you have **aimed at for a full round**, you may declare a Called Shot. On a hit, deal +1 Harm, ignore 1 Armor, and choose one: Blind (–2 dice to sight), Disarm (drop held item), Hamstring (half speed), or Vitals (+2 Harm instead of +1). On a miss, you are Exposed (Desperate Position and mark 1 Harm).

Requires: Ranged 2+, Stealth 2+.

Defense**Riposte Instinct** [COUNTER] [STRIKE]

Cost: 4 XP Reactive, once per scene. When you Defend and score a Success, you may make a free Melee attack against the attacker at Position -1.

Requires: Melee 2+.

Adaptive Guard [DEFENSE] [FLEXIBILITY]

Cost: 4 XP Active. When you take the Defend action, you may declare your defense pool (Attribute + Skill) after the GM calls Position. Once per scene, you may instead choose the pool after seeing the roll result.

Requires: Athletics 2+ or Shield Proficiency or Perception 2+.

Wardbreaker Reflex [WARD] [DEFENSE]

Cost: 4 XP Reactive. When Defending against spells or supernatural effects, you may reroll 1 failed die. If your reroll succeeds, mark +1 Fatigue (arcane recoil).

Requires: Spirit 2+ or any magical Path.

Mounted Combat Traditions

Among the horse-clans of the Ykrul and the steppe riders of the Kuvani, archery from horseback is not a specialization—it is a birthright. Characters from these cultures may take **Mounted Archery** at a reduced cost (1 XP instead of 2) and **Horse Archer's Art** at 4 XP instead of 5. Game Masters may extend this cultural discount to other mounted traditions in their setting (e.g., Linn skirmishers, Vilikari border riders).

Monk (Unarmed) Talents**Iron Fist Technique** [STRIKE] [POWER]

Cost: 6 XP Passive. +1 die to unarmed attacks; strikes count as enchanted for purposes of harming supernatural creatures.

Requires: Disciplined Body, Melee 2+.

Flowing Spirit Technique [WIND] [STRENGTH]

Cost: 6 XP Passive + Active. Convert up to 1 Harm into Fatigue per attack; +1 die against fear or charm effects.

Requires: Spirit 2+, Melee 2+.

Perfect Timing Technique [FATE] [MOVEMENT]

Cost: 6 XP Active. Twice per scene, improve Position by +1 step; +1 die to reaction rolls.

Requires: Wits 3+, Melee 2+.

Whirlwind Kick [AREA] [STRIKE]

Cost: 5 XP Active, once per scene. Make an unarmed attack against all enemies within Close range. Roll once, compare to each target's defense. Each hit deals normal damage.

Requires: Iron Fist Technique, Body 3+.

Meditative Focus [RECOVERY] [CLEANSE]

Cost: 4 XP Active, once per session. Spend a short rest in meditation. Clear 2 Fatigue and remove one Condition (Fear, Poisoned, or Guilty).

Requires: Spirit 2+.

Deflect Projectiles [REACTION] [DEFENSE]

Cost: 5 XP Reactive. When targeted by a ranged physical attack (arrow, bolt, thrown weapon), you may roll Melee vs. DV 3. On a success, the attack misses. On a partial, reduce Harm by 1. You must have a free hand or be wielding a suitable parrying tool.

Requires: Melee 2+, Perception 2+.

9.4 Prestige Talents (7–10 XP)

Arcane Dominance [POWER] [OVERRIDE]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. When you contest another magical effect, you automatically overpower weaker effects (Tier II or lower).

Requires: Spirit 4, Arcana 4.

Forbidden Knowledge [SECRETS] [DANGEROUS]

Cost: 8 XP Active, once per session. Access one forbidden summon or dangerous rite without its normal prerequisites. The GM gains 2 SB.

Requires: Tier II.

Crack Specialist [RITUAL] [INSTANT]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. Reduce the Obligation cost of Crack the Seal by 1 (minimum +1).

Requires: 3 Patron Symbols.

Dual Covenant [BOND] [SYNCHRONIZATION]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. You may maintain two active summoned spirits simultaneously.

Requires: Pact-Whisperer, Lesser Pactwright.

Triad Bond [BOND] [SYNCHRONIZATION]

Cost: 10 XP Passive. You may maintain three active summoned spirits simultaneously.

Requires: Dual Covenant, Tier III.

Shrike Parry [COUNTER] [PARRY]

Cost: 8 XP Reactive. When Defending against a melee attack: on Success, negate the hit and make a free attack at equal Position; on Partial, reduce Harm by two levels; on Miss, improve Position one step next turn without Defending again.

Requires: Melee 3+, Athletics 2+, notable duel history.

Mystic Bulwark [PROTECT] [BOND]

Cost: 8 XP Active. When you Defend, you may Shield an adjacent ally (they gain your Position bonus). If you succeed, both avoid the effect. Once per scene, spend 2 Fatigue to extend to all allies in Near.

Requires: Resolve 3+, Spirit 2+, access to Rites or Cantos.

High Stance Duelist [DOMINANCE] [TECHNIQUE]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. While Defending: enemies suffer -1 die to attacks against you; on a Success, your riposte becomes Dominant instead of Controlled.

Requires: Melee 3+, Presence 1+.

Hollow-Touched [RESILIENCE]

Cost: 8 XP Reactive. When you would take Harm, you may mark that amount as Fatigue instead. If you do, either the GM gains 1 SB or you mark 1 Obligation to the Pale Shepherd. Overflow triggers normal Fatigue→Harm conversion plus the chosen cost.

Requires: Aelaerem affinity (see 14.20.4), Spirit 3+, Stealth 2+.

Stone-Bound Interdictor [RESILIENCE]

Cost: 8 XP Reactive. When you would take Harm, you may mark that amount as Fatigue instead. If you do, either spend 1 Boon immediately or speak a binding condition (until fulfilled, -1 die on social rolls with fae and stone-kin). Overflow triggers normal conversion plus the cost.

Requires: Aelinnel affinity (see 14.20.3), Body 3+, Wits 3+.

Large Soul [ADAPTATION]

Cost: 8 XP Passive. You may wear Heavy Armor and wield Heavy Weapons without restriction. You lose your Small Folk racial bonuses (+1 Position when Dodging or Resisting Knockback, +1 die on Hide or Evasion rolls while in cover).

Requires: Aelaerem or Aelinnel affinity (see 14.20.1), Body 4+, Spirit 3+.

Ghost Heist [STRIKE] [ERASURE]

Cost: 7 XP Active, once per arc. You may commit a crime that is never solved—not because you are perfect, but because the evidence points nowhere. After a successful heist, you may declare that no traceable evidence remains. The GM cannot use Social SB to retroactively implicate you from that scene. **Cost:** You must accept a permanent *Reputation: Whispers* tag; some will always suspect you, even without proof.

Requires: Tier II, Stealth 3+.

Spymaster [SOCIAL] [NETWORK] [PRESTIGE]

Cost: 8 XP Passive + Active. You have a permanent network of informants in any city you have visited for at least a week. Once per session, you may ask the GM one detailed question about faction movements, hidden plans, or NPC secrets in that city. Additionally, the GM may provide a rumor or warning unprompted once per arc.

Requires: Network Weaver, Information Broker, Tier II.

Master Cantor [PERFORMANCE] [LEGENDARY]

Cost: 10 XP Passive + Active. Your performances are legendary. Once per session, when you roll Performance for a significant performance (in front of a crowd of at least 10 people), treat the result as one degree better (Miss → Partial, Partial → Success, Success → Critical). Additionally, once per arc, you may inspire an entire community; allies within the community gain +1 die to all rolls related to a single goal (e.g., defending the town, finding a lost child) for one session.

Requires: Performance 4+, Presence 4+, Captivating Performance, Tier III.

Rogue Cantor Talents (Corrupted Voice)**Shadow Song (Ikasha's Whisper)** [SHADOW] [SILENCE]

Cost: 7 XP Active. You learn to sing in frequencies that do not carry. Gain access to:

- *Cradle Song (Low)*: Lull a single target (Resist DV 3). Costs 1 Fatigue.
- *Lockpick's Refrain (Standard)*: Unlock one mundane or warded lock by humming its true pitch. Costs 1 Obligation.

Requires: Performance 2+, Presence 2+, Patron: Ikasha.

Velvet Hook (Livaea's Whisper) [INFLUENCE] [BINDING]

Cost: 7 XP Active. You learn that every song is a seduction. Gain access to:

- *Golden Tongue (Low)*: Gain +2 dice to Sway for one social exchange. Costs 1 Fatigue; after use, the target feels a mild attraction or obligation.
- *The Unrefusable Offer (Standard)*: Sing a bargain. Target must accept or suffer -2 dice to all rolls until they do. Costs 2 Obligation.

Requires: Performance 2+, Presence 2+, Patron: Livaea.

Desperate Cadence (Malachai's False Note) [DESPERATION] [CURSE]

Cost: 7 XP Active. You sing of easy scores and cursed luck. Gain access to:

- *The Lucky Pick (Low)*: Reroll a failed Stealth or Subterfuge roll. Costs 1 Fatigue and 1 Corruption tick.
- *Blood Price (Standard)*: Sing a curse on a rival. They suffer -1 die on their next heist. Costs 2 Fatigue and marks a Reckoning Timer [4] that Malachai will collect.

Requires: Performance 2+, Patron: Malachai.

Monk (Unarmed) Prestige Talents

Untouchable Form [EVADE] [STRENGTH]

Cost: 10 XP Passive + Active. +1 die to unarmed attacks; convert 2 Harm into Fatigue; cannot be grappled.

Requires: Iron Fist Technique + Flowing Spirit Technique.

Inevitable Strike [FATE] [FORCE]

Cost: 10 XP Passive + Reactive. +2 dice to unarmed attacks; ignore 1 Armor; may counterattack when an enemy misses.

Requires: Iron Fist Technique + Perfect Timing Technique.

Way of the Empty Mind [CLARITY] [IMMUNITY]

Cost: 9 XP Passive. You are immune to fear effects and magical attempts to read your thoughts. Additionally, you gain +2 dice to resist charm or mind control.

Requires: Spirit 3+, Meditative Focus.

Free Caster Prestige Talents

Spell Echo [ECHO] [FATE]

Cost: 8 XP Reactive, once per session. When you roll a 1 on a Free Casting roll, you may immediately reroll that die. The new result stands, and any 1 on the reroll generates an additional SB as normal. After using this talent, you cannot use it again until you have taken a Short Rest.

Requires: Spellcraft, Controlled Burn, Tier II.

Resonance Anchor [ANCHOR] [STABILITY]

Cost: 9 XP Passive. Your connection to the Weave is more stable. The first time you would generate a Story Beat from a 1 in a scene, you may choose to **bank** that SB for yourself (it does not go to the GM). You may have up to 2 banked SB at a time, and you may spend them as if they were Boons (reroll a die, activate an Asset, improve Position). Unused banked SB are lost at the end of the scene.

Requires: Spellcraft, Weave Resilience, Tier II.

Combat Prestige

Battlefield Terror [FEAR] [DOMINANCE]

Cost: 10 XP Passive + Active. Enemies in Close range act at -1 die due to intimidation. Once per scene, convert an enemy's success to a partial with cost.

Requires: Melee 4+, Body 4+, Harm 2+ experience.

Shadow Dance [EVADE] [STEALTH]

Cost: 10 XP Active. After a successful Backstab, test Stealth vs. DV (Tier). On success, re-enter Stealth and clear 1 Fatigue or improve Position +1. On failure, remain Exposed and mark 1 Fatigue. May only chain once per scene.

Requires: Backstab, Stealth 3+, Mobility 2+.

Embrace the Void [CORRUPTION] [POWER]

Cost: 8 XP Active, once per session. Embrace your Patron's corrupting influence. Mark 2 Obligation and 1 Corruption segment, then gain one for the scene: +1 die and +1 Effect on Patron-domain rolls, immunity to one consequence type, use one Rite without Obligation, or +1 Effect on social manipulations. Permanent mark on sheet; GM gains +1 SB against you when Patron is relevant.

Requires: Any character with 2+ skill levels tied to Patron, at least 1 Obligation segment to that Patron.

9.5 Epic Talents (11+ XP)

Elemental Mastery [ELEMENT] [HARMONY]

Cost: 18 XP Passive + Active. Reduce Backlash severity by one step when casting with your focus elements. When casting with two focus elements, gain +2 dice and +1 Effect. Once per scene, cast a spell without generating SB on the Weave roll. Allies gain +1 die when you cast an aligned element spell.

Requires: Tier III, Spellcraft, Arcana 5, 2+ Focus Elements.

Crack the Seal Mastery [RITUAL] [PRECISION]

Cost: 18 XP Passive + Active. When Cracking the Seal, choose one: reduce Obligation cost by 1, prevent Symbol from becoming Compromised, or gain +1 Effect. With 4+ Symbols, reduce all ritual casting times by 1 round. Once per scene, Crack the Seal on up to 3 Symbols as one action. Ignore No Symbol penalties.

Requires: Tier III, Invoker's Grimoire, 3+ Patron Symbols.

Blade Dance [STRIKE] [MASTERY]

Cost: 18 XP Active, once per scene. Engage and attack up to 3 targets in one action. Each attack at -1 die, but your Position improves by one step.

Requires: Melee 5+, Duelist's Edge, Flurry Strike.

Miststep Reflex [DEFENSE] [MOVEMENT]

Cost: 12 XP Passive. You are always treated as Defending against physical attacks unless Exposed, Grappled, or Surprised. If you take the Defend action, improve Position by +2 steps instead. Once per scene when you roll 1s while defending, you must mark 2 Fatigue or lose the benefit for the scene.

Requires: Elusive Dodge, Tier III, Stealth 4+, Athletics 3+.

Transcendent Harmony [LIFE] [WIND]

Cost: 18 XP Passive + Active. Convert 2 Harm into Fatigue; once per session become immune to Harm; allies gain +1 defense.

Requires: Flowing Spirit Technique + Perfect Timing Technique, Spirit 4+.

Deathblow [DEATH] [STRIKE]

Cost: 12 XP Active, once per scene. When you strike from Dominant Position or after re-entering Stealth via Shadow Dance, declare a Deathblow. On a hit, deal triple Harm. If the attack incapacitates the target, attempt a free Stealth test to vanish. On a miss, you are Exposed (Desperate Position and mark 1 Harm). May mark 1 Fatigue to attempt a second time. This ability cannot be used against bosses or creatures with a Tier higher than your own (GM's discretion).

Requires: Shadow Dance, Stealth 4+, Melee/Ranged 3+.

Weave Harmonist [HARMONY] [FLOW]

Cost: 16 XP Passive + Active. You have learned to ride the Weave's turbulence. Once per session, you may ignore **all** SB generated by a single Free Casting roll (the GM gains none). Additionally, whenever you generate a Story Beat from a 1, you may immediately spend 1 Boon to cancel that SB (the GM does not gain it). You cannot cancel more than 3 SB per scene this way.

Requires: Spellcraft, Resonance Anchor, Tier III.

Monk Epic Talents**Fist of the Mountain** [EARTH] [POWER]

Cost: 15 XP Active, once per session. Your unarmed strike becomes a cataclysmic blow. Deal +4 Harm, ignore all Armor, and the target is knocked back two range bands and stunned (loses next action). After the blow, you suffer 2 Fatigue from the strain.

Requires: Iron Fist Technique, Inevitable Strike, Body 5+.

Breath of Stillness [CLEANSE] [RENEWAL]

Cost: 14 XP Active, once per session. Enter a deep meditative trance. Clear all Fatigue, remove one Harm level, and remove all Conditions. The meditation takes one full scene of uninterrupted peace.

Requires: Meditative Focus, Spirit 4+.

9.6 Talent Synergies and Building Strategies

Synergy Examples

- **Spellcraft + Elemental Focus + Elemental Mastery:** Reliable freeform casting with reduced backlash and epic control (see 5).

- **Backstab + Shadow Dance + Deathblow:** Stealth assassination chain.
- **Ritual Mastery + Efficient Invocation + Crack Specialist:** Fast, safe, low-cost rituals.
- **Defensive Survival + Elusive Dodge + Miststep Reflex:** High survivability in melee.
- **Iron Fist Technique + Flowing Spirit Technique + Untouchable Form:** Unstoppable monk durability.
- **Iron Fist Technique + Perfect Timing Technique + Inevitable Strike:** Monk counterattack master.
- **Effortless Charge + Relentless:** Charge over difficult terrain once per scene without Fatigue cost.
- **Stubborn Pursuer + Tactical Movement:** Stay glued to a disengaging foe while preserving your own movement options.
- **Free Caster Progression:** Controlled Burn → Spell Echo → Resonance Anchor → Weave Harmonist reduces SB generation and turns risk into personal resource.
- **Rogue Progression:** Light Fingers → Always Another Exit → Ghost Heist for the ultimate phantom thief.
- **Rogue Cantor Progression:** Crowd Veil + Shadow Song for the infiltrator who sings guards to sleep.
- **Mounted Combat Progression:** Mounted Archery → Horse Archer's Art for the steppe rider who rains arrows from a galloping horse.
- **Social Face Progression:** Smooth Talker + Trusted Reputation + Spymaster for the character who knows everyone and can call in favors across the city.
- **Follower/Asset Progression:** Efficient Recruiter + Loyalty Bond + Delegated Upkeep for the commander who builds a loyal network that runs itself.
- **Cantor Progression:** Projecting Voice → Captivating Performance → Master Cantor for the legendary performer who inspires armies.
- **Healer Progression:** Field Dressing → Triage for the combat medic who keeps allies fighting.
- **Ranger Progression:** Keen Tracker → Camouflage for the scout who moves unseen and never loses the trail.
- **Artificer Progression:** Master Tinker → Master Artificer for the crafter who builds anything, faster and cheaper.

When to Take Talents (By Tier)

- **Early Game (0–40 XP):** Take 1–2 access talents (Spellcraft, Familiar) and 2–3 minor talents that support your core concept. For Free Casters, prioritize Controlled Burn and Weave Resilience. For Rogues, take Light Fingers and Silk Palms. For mounted archers, take Mounted Archery. For social characters, take Smooth Talker and Ear to the Ground. For healers, take Field Dressing. For rangers, take Keen Tracker. For crafters, take Master Tinker. For performers, take Projecting Voice.
- **Mid Game (41–90 XP):** Add major talents (Codex, Patron's Symbol, Backstab, The Velvet Glove, Iron Fist Technique, Horse Archer's Art, Trusted Reputation, Efficient Recruiter, Triage, Camouflage, Master Artificer, Captivating Performance, etc.) and 2–3 synergistic power talents. Free Casters should take Elemental Attunement and Backlash Siphon.
- **Late Game (91+ XP):** Acquire 1–2 prestige or epic talents that define your legacy. Free Casters should aim for Spell Echo, Resonance Anchor, and finally Weave Harmonist. Rogues should consider Shadow Dance, Deathblow, or Ghost Heist. Social characters should aim for

Spymaster. Performers should aim for Master Cantor.

Example: The Shadow Assassin

A rogue who takes **Backstab** (9.3) at Tier I, **Shadow Dance** (9.4) at Tier II, and **Deathblow** (9.5) at Tier III can execute a devastating assassination chain:

1. Attack from stealth with Backstab (+1 Harm, ignore armor).
2. After a kill, use Shadow Dance to re-enter stealth.
3. Later, strike from Dominant Position with Deathblow (triple Harm).

This combination requires careful positioning and Boon management, but is highly effective.

Example: The Silent Infiltrator

A rogue who takes **The Unlocked Window** (9.2) and **Crowd Veil** (9.3) at Tier I, then **Always Another Exit** (9.3) at Tier II, can bypass security, vanish into crowds, and escape any corner. Add **Shadow Song** (9.4) for the ability to lull guards and unlock spirit-locks with song.

Example: The Stable Free Caster

A Free Caster who takes **Controlled Burn** (9.3) at Tier I, **Weave Resilience** (9.3) at Tier I–II, **Spell Echo** (9.4) at Tier II, **Resonance Anchor** (9.4) at Tier III, and finally **Weave Harmonist** (9.5) at Tier IV can reduce the swinginess of free casting dramatically. The first 1 of each scene becomes player currency rather than GM fuel; backlash is softened; and once per session, the caster can completely ignore SB from a critical spell. This build remains more dangerous than a Runekeeper but avoids the “wild mage” volatility.

Example: The Unarmed Master

A monk who takes **Disciplined Body** (9.2) and **Open Hand Technique** (9.2) at Tier I, then **Iron Fist Technique** (9.3) and **Flowing Spirit Technique** (9.3) at Tier II, and finally **Untouchable Form** (9.4) at Tier III becomes a durable, mobile unarmed fighter who converts harm to fatigue, shrugs off fear, and cannot be grappled.

Example: The Horse Archer

A Ykrul rider who takes **Mounted Archery** (9.2) at Tier I and **Horse Archer's Art** (9.3) at Tier II can fire accurately from a galloping horse and use the Skirmish action to move twice as far while shooting. This build excels at hit-and-run tactics, wearing down enemies from a distance while staying out of reach.

Example: The Face of the Party

A social character who takes **Smooth Talker** (9.2) and **Negotiation Stance** (9.2) at Tier I, then **Trusted Reputation** (9.3) and **Information Broker** (9.3) at Tier II, and finally **Spymaster** (9.4) at Tier III can navigate any court, gather intelligence from thin air, and call in favors across the city. This build shines in political campaigns and urban intrigue.

Example: The Commander

A leader who takes **Efficient Recruiter** (9.3) at Tier I, **Loyalty Bond** (9.3) and **Delegated Upkeep** (9.3) at Tier II, and builds a network of Cap 3+ followers can run a faction from the shadows. The followers manage Assets, handle upkeep, and remain fiercely loyal. This build is ideal for players who want to build a mercenary company, a spy network, or a criminal empire.

Example: The Legendary Performer

A performer who takes **Projecting Voice** (9.2) at Tier I, **Captivating Performance** (9.3) and **Voice of Reason** (9.3) at Tier II, and finally **Master Cantor** (9.4) at Tier III can calm a riot, inspire an army, or negotiate peace between warring factions. Their performances are the stuff of legend.

Example: The Combat Medic

A healer who takes **Field Dressing** (9.2) at Tier I and **Triage** (9.3) at Tier II can keep allies alive through the deadliest battles. Field Dressing prevents death from a killing blow; Triage mitigates penalties and restores energy. This build is essential for any party that expects heavy combat.

Example: The Master Artificer

A crafter who takes **Master Tinker** (9.2) at Tier I, then **Master Artificer** (9.3) and **Asset Crafter** (9.3) at Tier II can build a workshop, forge magical items, and construct Assets at half the cost and time. This build is ideal for campaigns with significant downtime and base-building elements.

9.7 Custom Talents

Work with your GM to create custom talents:

- Base on story events.
- Use the cost tiers above (2–3 / 4–6 / 7–10 / 11+ XP).
- Define clear prerequisites, activation, and limits.

9.8 Talent Respecification

With GM approval, you may retrain talents during downtime (one downtime period). Provide a narrative justification. Typically limited to once per major story arc.

Talent Selection Quick Reference

Minor (2–3 XP): Small bonuses, once/scene tricks.

Major (4–6 XP): Strong permanent upgrades, core path abilities.

Prestige (7–10 XP): Campaign-shaping, breaks limits.

Epic (11+ XP): Legendary, story-defining power.

Remember: Passive talents stack; active talents require an action or reaction.

Chapter 10

Your First Magical Character

So you want to play a magic-user. Good choice – but FATE’s EDGE offers **six different magical paths**. Jumping into all of them at once is a recipe for confusion. This guide helps you pick a path and then walks you through building a **single, focused magical character** that is powerful, fun, and manageable.

Quick Reference: Magic Paths at a Glance

Use this table to choose a path that fits your preferred complexity and play style. **New players: start with Runekeeper.**

Path	Complexity	Cost Type	Risk	Best For
Runekeeper	Low	Obligation	Patron demands	First-timers, reliable
Cantor	Medium	Corruption	Social fallout, madness	Bards, performers,
Invoker	Medium–High	Obligation + ritual time	Slow casting, Symbol breaks	Ritual specialists,
Summoner	High	Leash + Boons	Spirit breaks free	Pet-class fans, tacti
Free Caster	High	Backlash (Fatigue/Harm)	Unpredictable effects	Improv players, wi
Psionics (optional)	Medium	Mental Strain	Mental strain, social distrust	Mind-power enthus

All paths are viable. The table only shows the *relative* complexity and risk. If you are still unsure, follow the recommendation below – you can always learn a second path later (see 5).

10.1 Step 0: The Recommendation

If this is your first magical character, play a **Runekeeper**. Why?

- **One Patron:** You swear to a single Patron. No juggling multiple Symbols or conflicting obligations.
- **Clear costs:** Every Rite costs Obligation. Track one number.
- **Support from your Thiasos:** Your familiar is a built-in roleplay hook and mechanical aid.

You can explore Invokers, Cantors, Witches, Psions, or Summoners later. Start simple.

Which Magic Path Fits You?

Not every player enjoys the same kind of magic. Use this table to find the path that matches how you like to play.

If you want...	Choose this path	Why it fits
Reliable, straightforward magic with clear costs	Runekeeper	One Patron, one resource (Obligation). No surprises.
To sing, perform, and risk losing yourself	Cantor	Corruption timer creates drama; great for bards and risk-takers.
Rituals, preparation, and borrowing power from multiple sources	Invoker	Slow but flexible; you collect Symbols like tools.
A summoned creature that fights for you	Summoner	Tactical pet class; manage the Leash timer.
Improvised magic on the fly, unpredictable effects	Free Caster	TAGS system lets you invent spells; high risk, high reward.
Mind powers and subtle influence (optional)	Psionics	No Patron, but mental strain and social suspicion.

Still unsure? **Let's start with Runekeeper.** You can always learn a second path later (see 5).

10.2 Step 1: Choose a Patron

Your Patron defines your Rites, your Obligation, and your role in the story. Pick one that matches your character concept.

Patron	Domain	Character Concept
The Traveler	Roads, journeys, safe passage	Guide, courier, scout
Oath of Flame & Light	Dawn, vows, protection	Paladin, healer, knight
Grimmir	Nature, seasons	Druid, ranger, hedge-witch
Ikasha	Shadow, secrets, thresholds	Spy, infiltrator, night-walker
The Witness	Truth, memory, revelation	Investigator, judge, archivist
Mykkiel	Law, covenant, judgment	Templar, inquisitor, notary
The Carrion-King	Decay, renewal, compost	Necromancer (gentle), healer

New player favorite: *The Traveler*. Low Obligation costs, useful Rites, and a forgiving Patron.

10.3 Step 2: Buy Your Core Talents

At character creation (30–36XP), you need two talents:

- **Familiar (Thiasos) – 2 XP.** Your bond to your Patron. It might be a raven (Traveler), a candle flame (Oath of Flame), or a small fungal creature (Carrion-King).
- **Codex – 4 XP.** Your book of Rites. It could be a leather journal, a set of carved slate tablets, or a roll of bark.

Total so far: 6 XP. You have 24–28 XP remaining for Attributes, Skills, and optional talents.

10.4 Step 3: Set Your Attributes

Runekeepers rely on **Spirit** (Obligation capacity, Rite effectiveness) and **Wits** (Lore, Investigation). A simple spread:

Attribute	Rating	Cost (new rating ×3)
Spirit	3	9 XP (1→2 = 6, 2→3 = 9)
Wits	2	6 XP (1→2 = 6)
Body	1	0 (base)
Presence	1	0 (base)

Total: 15 XP. You have 9–13 XP remaining.

10.5 Step 4: Buy Your Skills

You need **Lore** (to understand your Rites) and at least one social or utility skill.

Skill	Rating	Cost (new level ×2)
Lore	2	6 XP (0→1 = 2, 1→2 = 4)
Insight	1	2 XP (0→1 = 2)
Sway	1	2 XP (0→1 = 2)

Total: 10 XP. You now have 0–3 XP left – perfect for one minor talent.

10.6 Step 5: Choose Your First Rites

You begin with **two Low Rites** from your Patron. Pick ones that are useful and clear.

Example: The Traveler

- **Road-Sense (Low, 4 XP):** Gain +1 die to avoid ambushes or delays on a journey. *Use this every travel leg.*
- **Traveler's Boon (Low, 5 XP):** Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy for the scene. *Great for crossing rivers or skipping paperwork.*

Example: Oath of Flame & Light

- **Kindle Vow (Low, 4 XP):** Declare a short vow (e.g., "I will protect the villagers"). Gain +1 die to actions fulfilling it.
- **Lay on Hands (Low, 5 XP):** Cleanse an affliction or downgrade Harm by 1. *The classic healing Rite.*

10.7 Step 6: Understand Your Resources

You track three numbers:

1. **Obligation (to your Patron).** Capacity = Spirit + Presence. For Spirit 3, Presence 1, capacity is 4. Each Rite marks +1 Obligation. When you exceed capacity, mark 1 Fatigue per extra segment.
2. **Fatigue.** Each point worsens Position. When Fatigue fills your Body track (Body 1 = 1 segment), convert to Harm.
3. **Harm.** Harm 1 = -1 die, Harm 2 = -2 dice, Harm 3 = incapacitated.

Player's job: Mark these yourself. Announce when Obligation fills. The GM does not track them for you.

10.8 Step 7: Play Your First Session

Before the session

- Write your two Rites on an index card.
- Set your Obligation to 0.
- Set your Fatigue to 0.

During the session

1. **Invoke a Rite:** Say "I invoke *Road-Sense*." Mark +1 Obligation. Roll Lore + Spirit (or as specified). Apply the effect.
2. **Take a Short Rest:** Clear 2 Fatigue.
3. **Accept a Patron's demand:** If the GM says "your Patron requires a task," treat it as a story hook, not a punishment.

After the session

- Clear Obligation by performing an **Act of Service** for your Patron (e.g., The Traveler: guide a lost traveler; Oath of Flame: speak a public vow). Describe the act. The GM will tell you how much Obligation clears.
- Spend XP to raise Attributes, Skills, or buy new Rites.

10.9 Optional: Add a Minor Talent

If you have 2–4 XP left, take one of these:

- **Efficient Invocation (4 XP):** Reduce Obligation cost of one specific Low Rite by 1 (minimum 0).
- **Keen Senses (2 XP):** +1 die on perception checks.
- **Silver Tongue (2 XP):** +1 die on persuasion attempts.

10.10 What to Avoid at First

- **Multiple Patrons.** Stick to one. Cross-Resonance (see 5) adds complexity you don't need yet.
- **Crack the Seal (Invoker ability).** You are a Runekeeper. Let Invokers handle emergency rituals.
- **Cantor's Corruption.** A great path, but the Corruption timer requires active management. Save it for your second character.

10.11 Sample Build: Kestra the Traveler's Runekeeper

Element	Choice
Name	Kestra
Patron	The Traveler
Attributes	Spirit 3 (9 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Body 1, Presence 1
Skills	Lore 2 (6 XP), Insight 1 (2 XP), Sway 1 (2 XP)
Talents	Familiar (2 XP), Codex (4 XP)
Rites	Road-Sense (4 XP), Traveler's Boon (5 XP)
Starting Boons	3
Obligation Capacity	4 (Spirit 3 + Presence 1)

Total XP spent: $9+6+2+2+2+4+4+5 = 36\text{XP}$ (using the +4 XP from Bonds/Complications).

Kestra is a former caravan guide who swore to the Traveler after being betrayed by her crew. She carries a brass compass (her Thiasos) and a leather journal of route-maps (her Codex). She invokes *Road-Sense* before every journey and *Traveler's Boon* to cross difficult terrain. She tracks her Obligation carefully and pays it off by guiding lost travelers through the mountains.

10.12 Final Advice

The One Rule for New Magical Players

Spend your Boons. Hoarding them for XP conversion starves the table of drama. A re-rolled failure, an improved Position, or an activated Asset creates a memorable moment. The XP will come from your adventures.

You are now ready to play a Runekeeper. When you feel comfortable, read about the other five paths (see [5](#)). But for now, enjoy the clarity of one Patron, one Codex, and one set of Rites.

The road is waiting. Pay your toll.

Chapter 11

Example Character Concepts

This chapter presents example character concepts to illustrate how the game's systems can create diverse and interesting heroes. These are **examples only**—not prescriptive templates or exhaustive lists. Use them for inspiration, as pre-generated characters, or as starting points for your own unique creations.

11.1 Important Disclaimer

These examples are provided for illustrative purposes only. They demonstrate how the game's mechanics can support different character archetypes and play styles. You are encouraged to:

- Modify these concepts to fit your preferences
- Create completely original characters
- Mix and match elements from different examples
- Work with your Game Master to develop unique concepts

The game system is designed to support a wide variety of character types beyond these examples.

11.2 How to Use These Examples

Each concept includes:

- **Concept Overview:** Narrative identity and role
- **Traditional Analogues:** Common RPG classes that share similar themes — *not* mechanical restrictions, just touchstones
- **Cultural Affinities:** Which regions or peoples commonly produce this archetype
- **Mechanical Foundation:** Suggested starting capabilities
- **Play Style:** How the character typically engages with challenges
- **Development Path (by Tier):** What to buy at Tier I, II, and III (see [7.8](#))
- **Tactical Advice:** Tips for playing the role effectively
- **Story Hooks:** Plot opportunities for the Game Master
- **Legacy Note:** How this character might pass the torch (see [19](#))
- **Build Blocks:** A *32 XP* starting build, plus an optional *36 XP* variant using Bonds/Complications

(+4 XP) (see 7 for XP rules)

11.3 1. The Guardian (Fighter / Paladin / Knight)

Concept: A protector who stands between danger and those they’ve sworn to defend. *Steel in hand, vow in heart.* Whether a chivalrous knight, a grizzled mercenary, or a holy warrior of the Everflame, the Guardian makes others safe through sacrifice.

Traditional Analogues: Fighter, Paladin, Barbarian (defensive), Knight, Samurai, Legionary

Cultural Affinities: Vhasia (chivalric knight), Viterra (hedge-knight), Aeler (shield-warden), Ubral (clan champion), Ecktoria (legionary), Oshiira (Vermilion Corps guardian)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Body (strength, endurance), Spirit (willpower, resolve)
- **Skills:** Melee, Athletics, Command, Endurance
- **Talents:** Defensive Survival, Combat Reflexes, Conditioning (see 9)

Play Style:

- Frontline combat and protection
- Drawing attention away from allies (positioning, taunts, the Protect action)
- Using presence and authority to control situations
- Taking risks to protect others — absorbing Harm meant for teammates

11.3.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I (0–40 XP):** Raise Body to 3, Melee to 2, take *Defensive Survival* and *Combat Reflexes*. Use a shield.
- **Tier II (41–90 XP):** Raise Body to 4, take *Conditioning* and *Tactical Movement*. Consider a War Mount Asset (8 XP) for mobility.
- **Tier III (91–150 XP):** Take *Battlefield Mastery* or *Mystic Bulwark*. Upgrade armor to Heavy if you have Body 4+. Start training a successor (Cap 3+ follower).

11.3.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Use the Defend action** when outnumbered; it improves your Position by one step and can protect allies.
- **Spend Boons on re-rolling failed defense rolls**, not on offense. Your job is to survive.
- **Position matters more than damage.** A Dominant position lets you re-roll one failure — use shoves, terrain, and cover to stay in control.
- **When you take Harm, remember it clears Fatigue.** Sometimes a small wound is worth the reset.
- **The Protect action** (intercepting a hit on an ally) is your signature move. Use it when a squishier ally is about to take a big hit.

Story Hooks:

- Who or what are they protecting? A person, a place, an ideal?
- What oath or duty drives them — sworn, inherited, or self-imposed?
- What happens if they fail in their protection?
- What personal costs do they bear for their role (scars, lost loved ones, broken oaths)?
- Did they inherit their duty from a fallen predecessor?

Legacy Note: A loyal follower (squire, apprentice, sworn shield) can become your successor, inheriting your sworn duty and reputation. See 19.

11.3.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes** (Cost = rating × 3 XP): Body 3 (9), Spirit 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills** (Cost = level × 2 XP): Melee 2 (4), Athletics 1 (2), Command 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Combat Reflexes (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Defensive Survival (3 XP)
- **Total:** 29 + 5 = 34 XP (bank 2 XP)

11.4 2. The Mage (Wizard / Sorcerer / Arcanist)

Concept: A wielder of arcane power who reshapes reality through study, intuition, or pact. *Candlesmoke, marginalia, and dangerous truths.* From the rational Wizard of Thepyrgos to the instinctive Sorcerer of the Bloodlands, magic flows through them — and sometimes over them.

Traditional Analogues: Wizard, Sorcerer, Warlock (pact magic), Arcanist, Runekeeper, Invoker

Cultural Affinities: Thepyrgos (academic caster), Aelinnel (fae-touched), Valewood (Lethai-thora archivist), Ashaan (Breath-less resistance mage), Zakov (sea-witch), Sekogo (nganga spirit-worker)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (theory, precision), Spirit (willpower, channeling)
- **Skills:** Lore, Arcana, Investigation, (optionally) Sway (for social casting)
- **Talents:** Spellcraft (freeform), Codex (runekeeper), Patron's Symbol (invoker)

Play Style:

- Information gathering and magical analysis
- Solving puzzles and mysteries with arcane insight
- Using magic to gain advantages in combat and social scenes
- Researching new spells and rituals between adventures
- Managing Influence (for Runekeepers and Invokers) or Backlash (for free casters)

11.4.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Take *Spellcraft* (6 XP) or *Codex + Thiasos* (6 XP). Raise Wits to 3, Arcana/Lore to 2.
- **Tier II:** Add *Elemental Focus* (4 XP) or *Ritual Mastery* (4 XP). Raise Spirit to 3 for more Influence capacity.
- **Tier III:** Take *Arcane Dominance* or *Crack Specialist* (if Invoker). Build a library (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to research faster.

11.4.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Push It** only when necessary – extra Influence or Fatigue can snowball. Use Boons to improve Position before rolling.
- **Free casters:** Use cantrips (single tag) for safe, repeatable effects. Reserve multi-tag spells for critical moments.
- **Runekeepers:** Your Patron's Gift gives +1 Melee and +1 Thematic skill. Use it even if you aren't a fighter – the Thematic skill can be Sway, Lore, or Stealth.
- **Invokers:** *Crack the Seal* is for emergencies. Restore your Symbol during downtime before you need it again.
- **Learn the tags library.** Knowing which tags combine efficiently (e.g., AREA + BIND for crowd control) will make you a more effective caster.

Story Hooks:

- What forbidden knowledge are they seeking?
- How did they acquire their magical talent — bloodline, study, pact, accident, trauma?
- What dangerous secrets might they uncover?
- Who opposes their research (rival mages, witch-hunters, the Church, the Chain-Lanterns)?
- What price have they already paid for power (a lost sense, a forgotten loved one, a cursed mark)?

Legacy Note: A trusted apprentice (follower) can inherit your Codex or Symbol collection, continuing your magical legacy. See 19.

11.4.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Spirit 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Lore 2 (4), Arcana 1 (2) → **6 XP**
- **Total:** 27 XP (bank 3 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** *Spellcraft* (6 XP) using banked 3 + 4 = 7 XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** 27 + 6 = 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

11.5 3. The Rogue (Thief / Assassin / Scout)

Concept: A shadow who moves where others cannot, taking what others cannot keep. *Quiet footfalls, hawk eyes, and no loyalties but coin.* From the street-wise cutpurse of Silkstrand to the deadly assassin of Zakov, the Rogue survives by wits, speed, and one hidden knife.

Traditional Analogues: Rogue, Thief, Assassin, Scout, Ranger (stealth focus), Spy

Cultural Affinities: Zakov (pirate/rogue), Silkstrand (cutpurse), Vilikari (smuggler), Ykrul (steppe scout), Sidhi (lighthouse spy), Ashaan (Breath-less infiltrator)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (perception, quick thinking), Body (agility, stealth)
- **Skills:** Stealth, Subterfuge, Investigation (or Streetwise), (optionally) Melee (light weapons)
- **Talents:** Backstab, Elusive Dodge, Shadow Dance (later — see 9)

Play Style:

- Scouting ahead and gathering intelligence
- Infiltrating secured areas and disabling traps
- Ambush and skirmish tactics — striking from stealth
- Finding paths, contacts, and secrets in cities and wilderness
- Information brokering and black market connections

11.5.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Stealth/Subterfuge to 2. Take *Backstab* (6 XP) — you can afford it at 36 XP start.
- **Tier II:** Take *Elusive Dodge* (6 XP). Raise Body to 3 for better tracking. Consider a Minor Asset (Hidden Cache, 4 XP).
- **Tier III:** Take *Shadow Dance* (10 XP) and *Deathblow* (12 XP) — the classic assassination chain. Build a spy network (Standard Asset, 8 XP).

11.5.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Always aim for Dominant Position before attacking from stealth.** Spend a Boon to improve Position if needed.
- **Use the environment.** Ask the GM: “Is there a chandelier? A shadowed alcove? Loose gravel?” Use it to gain advantage.
- **Backstab + Shadow Dance + Deathblow** is lethal, but requires Boons. Engage only when you have 2–3 Boons saved.
- **When outmatched, retreat.** Spend a Boon to make a Controlled withdrawal instead of Desperate.
- **Your skills are not just for combat.** Use Subterfuge and Streetwise to navigate criminal networks, find black markets, and gather rumors.

Story Hooks:

- What crime or secret forced them into the shadows?
- What treasure or truth are they hunting?
- How do they balance loyalty to allies with self-preservation?
- Who wants them dead — and why?
- What do they owe to the criminal underworld that trained them?

Legacy Note: A young pickpocket or informant (follower) could inherit your network of fences and contacts. See 19.

11.5.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Presence 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Stealth 2 (4), Subterfuge 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Backstab (6 XP) – needs 6 XP; bank 1 + 4 = 5 XP → not enough. Alternative: Add **Skill:** Investigation 1 (2 XP) and **Talent:** Combat Reflexes (2 XP) and bank 2 XP. Or take a Minor Asset: Hidden Cache (4 XP) and bank 2 XP.
- **Suggested:** Hidden Cache + bank 2 XP → total 33 XP.

11.6 4. The Cleric (Priest / Healer / Exorcist)

Concept: A vessel of divine or spiritual power, channeling healing, truth, and judgment. *Sacred flame, holy water, and a prayer on the lips.* From the Lampers of Ecktoria to the fog-named exorcists of the Mistlands, the Cleric binds wounds and banishes darkness.

Traditional Analogues: Cleric, Priest, Paladin (healing focus), Exorcist, Shaman, Healer

Cultural Affinities: Ecktoria (Everflame priest), Viterra (Temple of Light), Thepyrgos (Covenant judge), Pereshi (Flame-Keeper), Tulkani (Caravan Judge), Sidhi (lighthouse healer)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (faith, willpower), Presence (authority, channeling)
- **Skills:** Lore (theology, rites), Medicine, Sway (prayer, exhortation), (optionally) Melee (symbolic weapon)
- **Talents:** Invoker (Patron's Symbol) or Runekeeper (Thiasos + Codex of a divine Patron like Everflame, Oath of Flame & Light, Pale Shepherd – see 5)

Play Style:

- Healing and protecting allies
- Purifying curses, diseases, and undead
- Ley line and ritual magic (wards, consecrations)
- Using authority of faith to command or persuade
- Exorcising spirits and banishing the Unquiet Dead

11.6.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Spirit to 3, Lore/Medicine to 2. Take a divine Patron's *Symbol* (4 XP) or *Codex* (4 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Symbol Resonance* (4 XP) or *Efficient Invocation* (4 XP). Raise Presence to 3 for better social influence.

- **Tier III:** Take *Crack Specialist* or *Patron's Favor*. Build a hospice or shrine (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to support your community.

11.6.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Healing is powerful but slow.** In combat, stabilize Harm 2+ allies first; use HEAL (Fatigue recovery) on everyone else.
- **Your Patron's Symbol grants a free +1 to ritual rolls.** Keep it displayed.
- **Consecrate ground before a big fight** – *Rite of Consecrated Ground* can turn the tide against undead or demons.
- **Influence is story fuel.** When your Patron's presence is felt, answer – it will lead to adventure.
- **Exorcism is negotiation, not combat.** Use Insight and Lore to understand what the spirit wants, then use Sway or Rites to resolve the haunting peacefully.

Story Hooks:

- What crisis of faith have they survived?
- What heresy or supernatural threat haunts them?
- How do they serve both the living and the dead?
- What price do they pay for divine power?
- What secret does their faith hide from the faithful?

Legacy Note: An acolyte or lay healer (follower) can take up your Patron's Symbol and continue your mission. See 19.

11.6.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Presence 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Body 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Medicine 2 (4), Lore 1 (2), Sway 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Patron's Symbol (4 XP) for a divine Patron (e.g., Oath of Flame & Light), using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

11.7 5. The Bard (Diplomat / Skald / Courtier)

Concept: A master of words, music, and social influence who changes minds and opens doors. *A smile for the foyer, steel for the parlor.* From the Skald of Linn to the Courtier of Vhasia, the Bard wields charm, rumor, and reputation as weapons.

Traditional Analogues: Bard, Diplomat, Courtier, Skald, Spy (social), Negotiator, Cantor

Cultural Affinities: Vhasia (courtier), Linn (skald), Thepyrgos (academic rhetorician), Tulkani (storyteller), Ecktoria (civic orator), Kahfagia (trade negotiator)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Presence (charm, performance), Wits (reading people, timing)
- **Skills:** Sway, Performance, Insight, (optionally) Lore (customs, history), Deception
- **Talents:** Silver Tongue, Inspire, Network Builder (or Read Emotions), Cantor's Path (optional, for Songs)

Play Style:

- Social interaction and negotiation
- Gathering information through rumors and contacts
- Resolving conflicts without violence (or making violence fashionable)
- Building alliances, manipulating factions
- Inspiring allies in combat (through Songs or simple words)

11.7.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Presence to 3, Sway to 2. Take *Silver Tongue* (2 XP) and *Inspire* (3 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Command Presence* (4 XP) and *Network Builder* (4 XP). Raise Wits to 3 for social reading.
- **Tier III:** Take *High Stance Duelist* (if you use a blade) or *Battlefield Terror*. Build a spy network (Standard Asset, 8 XP) or a courtly title (Major Asset, 12 XP). Consider taking *Cantor's Path* (8 XP) for magical Songs.

11.7.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Social scenes are your domain.** Use *Inspire* to give allies +1 die or +1 Boon – it can turn a negotiation.
- **Flashback declarations** (spend 1 Boon) are perfect for bards. “I already bribed the guard last night.”
- **Don't neglect combat skills entirely.** A rapier and *High Stance Duelist* can make you a credible threat.
- **Use *Intricate* descriptions** to gain free re-rolls on 1s. Describe your performance, your charming smile, your family crest.
- **The best lie is built on truth.** Use Insight to learn what someone wants, then offer it to them (even if you have to fabricate it).

Story Hooks:

- What major conflict are they trying to resolve?
- What secret do they know that could topple a dynasty?
- How do they handle betrayal or failed negotiations?
- What personal relationships affect their diplomacy?
- Whose favor are they trying to win — and at what cost?

Legacy Note: A protégé or herald (follower) can inherit your reputation and contacts, keeping your network alive. See [19](#).

11.7.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Spirit 1 (3), Body 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Sway 2 (4), Performance 1 (2), Insight 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Inspire (3 XP) — once/scene, gain +1 die and potentially +1 Boon for bonded ally, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 2 XP
- **Total:** 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

11.8 6. The Ranger (Hunter / Tracker / Beastmaster)

Concept: A wilderness expert who navigates dangerous territories and hunts down quarry. *Quiet footfalls, hawk eyes, and the long road.* From the Ykrul scout to the Valewood warden, the Ranger lives where roads end.

Traditional Analogues: Ranger, Hunter, Tracker, Beastmaster, Pathfinder, Wilderness Scout

Cultural Affinities: Ykrul (steppe scout), Kuvani (remount rider), Valewood (Lethai-al warden), Ubral (hill tracker), Mistlands (fog-walker), Sekogo (jungle hunter)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (perception, navigation), Body (agility, endurance)
- **Skills:** Survival, Stealth, Nature (or Animal Handling), Archery or Melee
- **Talents:** Wilderness Lore, Keen Senses, (optionally) Animal Companion

Play Style:

- Scouting ahead and gathering intelligence
- Wilderness survival and navigation
- Tracking creatures or people across terrain
- Ambushing from concealment, using terrain
- (Optional) Bonding with an animal companion

11.8.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Survival/Stealth to 2. Take *Wilderness Lore* (2 XP) and *Keen Senses* (2 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Trackless Step* (2 XP) and *Elusive Dodge* (6 XP) or a War Hound (Minor Asset, 4 XP). Raise Body to 3.
- **Tier III:** Take *Shadow Dance* (10 XP) (if melee) or *Relentless* (6 XP) for traversal. Upgrade your animal companion to a War Mount (Standard Asset, 8 XP) if allowed.

11.8.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Use terrain to your advantage.** High ground, cover, and difficult terrain are your best

friends. Ask the GM to set Position based on these.

- **Scout ahead** even when not required. Knowledge of what's coming negates ambushes and reduces travel timers.
- **If you have an animal companion**, use it to harass enemies (Distract & Draw independent action) rather than direct combat.
- **Survival 3+ means you rarely need to roll for basic tasks.** Leverage that for guaranteed successes in wilderness travel.
- **Know your prey.** Use Keen Senses to learn a creature's weakness before engaging.

Story Hooks:

- What uncharted territory are they exploring?
- What secrets have they discovered in the wild?
- How do they balance civilization and wilderness?
- What prey (beast or man) still eludes them?
- What ancient guardian did they once encounter and survive?

Legacy Note: Your animal companion or a young tracker (follower) could carry on your legacy. See [19](#).

11.8.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Spirit 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Survival 2 (4), Stealth 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Keen Senses (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Wilderness Lore (2 XP)
- **Total:** 29 + 4 = 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

11.9 7. The Survivor (Veteran / Outcast / Hardened)

Concept: Someone who has endured hardship and developed resilience. *Scars are maps; read them well.* From the war-torn mercenary to the plague survivor, the Survivor won't break — they've already been broken and rebuilt.

Traditional Analogues: Barbarian (resilience focus), Veteran, Ranger (endurance), Drifter, Refugee, Hollow-Touched

Cultural Affinities: Acasia (war survivor), Ubral (clan exile), Mistlands (fog-touched), Linn (shipwreck survivor), Zakov (pressed crew), Ashaan (escaped slave)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (willpower, resolve), Body (toughness)
- **Skills:** Endurance, Survival, (optionally) Perception (danger sense), Medicine (field)
- **Talents:** Iron Stomach, Conditioning, Second Wind (see [9](#))

Play Style:

- Enduring difficult conditions (lack of food, exposure, poison)
- Overcoming physical and mental challenges through grit
- Using experience to avoid dangers
- Helping others survive hardships
- Taking hits that would fell others and still standing

11.9.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Spirit to 3, Endurance/Survival to 2. Take *Iron Stomach* (3 XP) and *Second Wind* (2 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Conditioning* (4 XP) – your Body counts as +1 for Fatigue track. Raise Body to 3.
- **Tier III:** Take *Hollow-Touched* (8 XP) or *Stone-Bound Interdictor* (8 XP) to convert Harm to Fatigue. Build a safehouse (Minor Asset, 4 XP) for respite.

11.9.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Embrace the roller-coaster effect.** Taking Harm clears Fatigue – sometimes a small wound is a tactical reset.
- **Iron Stomach makes you immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food.** Volunteer to test unknown rations.
- **Use *Second Wind* to clear Fatigue before it overflows into Harm.**
- **When outmatched, use the environment.** Collapse a wall, start a fire, or trigger a rockfall. Your survival skills tell you how.
- **Known your limits, then push past them.** You can take more punishment than anyone else. Use that.

Story Hooks:

- What trauma or hardship have they survived?
- How has their past shaped their present?
- What survival skills have saved them repeatedly?
- How do they help others facing similar challenges?
- What do they still fear, despite everything?

Legacy Note: A fellow survivor (follower) can inherit your network of caches and safehouses. See [19](#).

11.9.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Endurance 2 (4), Survival 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent**: Iron Stomach (3 XP)
- **Total**: $29 + 3 = 32$ XP (bank 2 XP)

11.10 8. The Innovator (Artificer / Engineer / Tinker)

Concept: A creative problem-solver who finds new solutions through craft and invention. *Blueprints on napkins, tomorrow in your pocket.* From the Aeler engineer to the Gnome timermaker, the Innovator builds what others only dream.

Traditional Analogues: Artificer, Engineer, Tinker, Alchemist, Inventor, Savant

Cultural Affinities: Aeler (vent-prior), Aelinnel (clockwork artisan), Thepyrgos (academic engineer), Ngomebe (stone-singer), Cog-Cults (Monad devotee)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (design, analysis), Body (fine manipulation)
- **Skills:** Craft, Tinker, Mechanics, (optionally) Alchemy, Investigation
- **Talents:** Quick Study, Technical Expert, (optionally) Magical Laboratory asset (see [12](#))

Play Style:

- Solving problems with unique inventions
- Creating or repairing specialized items
- Providing services others cannot (lockpicking, trap disarm, device creation)
- Using knowledge to gain advantages in planning
- Building and maintaining Assets (workshops, laboratories, caches)

11.10.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Craft/Tinker to 2. Take *Quick Study* (3 XP) and *Workshop* (Minor Asset, 4 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Efficient Invocation* (if magical) or *Weapon Mastery* (if martial). Raise Body to 3 for fine manipulation.
- **Tier III:** Take *Technical Expert* (custom) or *Crack Specialist* (for magical items). Build a Guild Workshop (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to attract apprentices.

11.10.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Preparation is your superpower.** Spend downtime building tools, traps, and contingencies. Your GM will reward that.
- Use *Quick Study* to learn enemy weaknesses on the fly. “I notice the golem’s joints are unarmored – aim there.”
- **Your workshop asset can jury-rig solutions.** Spend 1 Boon to “have the right tool” for a lock, a trap, or a repair.
- **When combat starts, use gadgets.** Caltrops, smoke bombs, and flash pellets can shift Position without a spell slot.
- **Document your inventions.** Keep a list of gadgets you’ve built and their effects – this will

make your play smoother and more creative.

Story Hooks:

- What makes their specialty unique or valuable?
- How did they acquire their special skills (guild, apprenticeship, self-taught)?
- What problems require their specific expertise?
- Who seeks to control or exploit their abilities?
- What invention of theirs caused unintended harm?

Legacy Note: An apprentice (follower) can inherit your workshop and blueprints, continuing your inventive tradition. See [19](#).

11.10.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Body 2 (6), Presence 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Craft 2 (4), Tinker 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Quick Study (3 XP) — +1 die to learn or adapt from observation, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 2 XP
- **Total:** 32 XP (bank 2 XP)

11.11 9. The Summoner (Pact-Whisperer / Necromancer / Shaman)

Concept: A binder of spirits, elementals, and otherworldly entities. *Circles of salt, whispered names, and bargains struck in shadows.* From the necromancer of the Mistlands to the shaman of the Steppe, the Summoner commands powers that others fear.

Traditional Analogues: Necromancer, Conjurer, Summoner, Shaman, Spirit Caller, Demonologist

Cultural Affinities: Mistlands (bell-warden), Ykrul (bone-singer), Tulkani (dream-speaker), Ashaan (Breath-less spirit-binder), Zakov (drowned caller), Sekogo (nganga)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (willpower, binding), Wits (rituals, names)
- **Skills:** Arcana, Lore (spirits), (optionally) Command, Survival
- **Talents:** Pact-Whisperer (Lesser/Greater), Spirit Link, (optionally) Codex of Names (see [5](#))

Play Style:

- Summoning creatures to fight, scout, or work
- Binding entities to solve problems (guard, research, transport)
- Negotiating with spirits and outsiders (social challenges)
- Managing Leash timers and Boon Finesse

- Building relationships with specific spirits over time (Spirit Bond progression)

11.11.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Take *Pact-Whisperer* (2 XP) and *Lesser Pactwright* (2 XP). Raise Spirit to 3, Arcana/Lore to 2.
- **Tier II:** Take *Greater Pactwright* (4 XP) to summon Cap 3 spirits. Take *Spirit Synergy* (4 XP) if you want two spirits.
- **Tier III:** Take *Spirit Link* (10 XP) or *True Name Keeper* (15 XP). Build a Spirit Circle (Minor Asset, 4 XP) to reduce Leash ticks.

11.11.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Boon Finesse** is your most important tool. Spend 1 Boon to clear 1 Leash tick – keep a reserve of 2–3 Boons for emergencies.
- **Spirits are disposable but not free.** Use them for dangerous tasks (scouting a trapped room, triggering a trap) before risking your own skin.
- **When the Leash fills, the spirit acts once to its nature.** Plan for it – position it near enemies before it breaks free.
- **Negotiate with spirits.** They have desires – a promise of freedom, a drop of blood, a secret. A willing spirit ticks Leash slower.
- **Track Spirit Bonds.** If you summon the same spirit repeatedly, you can build a Spirit Bond Timer, reducing Leash ticks over time.

Story Hooks:

- What entity are they bound to or seeking?
- What price did they pay for their first summoning?
- How do others react to their “dark” magic?
- Who hunts them for their forbidden practices?
- What debt do they owe to a spirit that saved their life?

Legacy Note: A bonded spirit or an apprentice medium (follower) could inherit your spirit contracts, continuing your work. See [19](#).

11.11.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Arcana 2 (4), Lore 1 (2) → **6 XP**
- **Total:** 27 XP (bank 3 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Lesser Pactwright (2 XP)
- **Total:** 27 + 4 = 31 XP (bank 3 XP; can add Familiar (2 XP) later or upgrade to Greater Pactwright)

11.12 10. The Commander (Warlord / Tactician / Leader)

Concept: A leader who directs allies, controls battlefields, and shapes conflicts through strategy. *Orders in a whisper, victory in formation.* From the Condotta captain to the Ecktorian legate, the Commander wins before blades are drawn.

Traditional Analogues: Warlord, Marshal, Tactician, Commander, Strategist, Banneret

Cultural Affinities: Ecktoria (legate), Acasia (free company captain), Vhasia (marshal), Black Banners (condotta captain), Oshiira (Narrow Captain), Ykrul (war-leader)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Presence (authority, command), Wits (tactics, observation)
- **Skills:** Command, Tactics, (optionally) Sway (morale), Investigation (battlefield analysis)
- **Talents:** Inspire, Command Presence, Tactical Movement (for allies – see 9)

Play Style:

- Directing allies in combat (bonus dice, improved Position)
- Planning and executing tactical maneuvers
- Leading followers and assets in mass action (see 12)
- Using authority to intimidate or persuade
- Managing resources (supplies, morale, positioning) across extended operations

11.12.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Presence to 3, Command/Tactics to 2. Take *Command Presence* (4 XP) and *Inspire* (3 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Tactical Movement* (4 XP) and *Network Builder* (4 XP). Acquire a Cap 2–3 follower (soldier, herald).
- **Tier III:** Take *Battlefield Mastery* (6 XP) or *Mystic Bulwark* (8 XP). Build a War Chest (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to fund operations.

11.12.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- Use *Inspire* to give allies +1 die and +1 Boon. A well-timed inspiration can turn a miss into a success.
- **Your followers are your strength.** Keep them alive – spend Boons to protect them. A Cap 3 scout is worth more than a single attack.
- Use *Tactical Movement* to reposition without disengaging. Order allies to flank while you hold the line.
- **In mass combat, treat your unit as a high-Cap follower.** Your Command roll can advance the War Timer faster than any sword.
- **Know when to fight and when to retreat.** A good commander wins battles; a great commander wins campaigns, sometimes by losing a skirmish.

Story Hooks:

- What army or company did they lead before?
- What strategic defeat haunts them?
- Who are their rivals in the art of war?
- What cause do they fight for — coin, country, or creed?
- What soldiers died under their command, and how do they honor them?

Legacy Note: A loyal lieutenant or sergeant (follower) can inherit your command, leading the company after you. See 19.

11.12.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Command 2 (4), Tactics 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Command Presence (4 XP) — +1 die on leadership/intimidation rolls, using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 1 XP
- **Total:** 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

11.13 11. The Duelist (Swashbuckler / Fencer / Blade)

Concept: A master of one-on-one combat, relying on speed, precision, and flair rather than heavy armor. *Steel is a conversation; you speak it fluently.* From the Vhasian tournament knight to the Sidhi knife-dancer, the Duelist lives for the clash of blades.

Traditional Analogues: Swashbuckler, Fencer, Duelist, Blade, Rogue (combat focus), Monk (weapon focus)

Cultural Affinities: Vhasia (tourney knight), Viterra (legal duelist), Zakov (pirate duelist), Ubral (clan champion), Sidhi (knife-dancer), Nihori (wandering ronin)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Body (agility, speed), Wits (timing, reading opponents)
- **Skills:** Melee (Light weapons), Acrobatics, Perception, (optionally) Sway (taunt, feint)
- **Talents:** Weapon Master (Light Blade), Elusive Dodge, High Stance Duelist

Play Style:

- One-on-one combat dominance
- Mobility and positioning (flanking, dancing around enemies)
- Using feints and taunts to control opponent's actions
- Parrying and riposting (converting defense into offense)
- Social dueling (fighting for honor or reputation, not just survival)

11.13.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Body to 3, Melee to 2. Take *Weapon Master* (Light Blade, 5 XP) and *Elusive Dodge* (2 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *High Stance Duelist* (6 XP) and *Flurry Strike* (6 XP). Raise Wits to 3 for reading opponents.
- **Tier III:** Take *Duelist's Edge* (6 XP) or *Deathblow* (12 XP). Acquire a signature blade (Minor Asset, 4 XP) with an enchantment.

11.13.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Your goal is to isolate a single target.** Use mobility to separate an enemy from the group.
- **Use *High Stance Duelist* to gain advantage** when fighting a single opponent. Spend Boons to improve Position.
- **Flurry Strike lets you make two attacks** as one action. Use it to finish a wounded foe or to test a high-defense enemy.
- **Parry and riposte are your friends.** When you successfully defend, look for opportunities to counterattack as a free action (ask your GM).
- **Social dueling matters.** In honor cultures (Vhasia, Viterra, Ubral), winning a duel fairly can resolve conflicts without further bloodshed.

Story Hooks:

- What duel did they lose that still stings?
- Whose honor are they sworn to defend?
- What signature technique did they develop themselves?
- Why did they leave their fencing school or tradition?
- What blade do they carry, and whose was it before theirs?

Legacy Note: A promising student (follower) can inherit your signature technique and blade. See 19.

11.13.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Body 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Spirit 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Melee 2 (4), Acrobatics 1 (2), Perception 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Weapon Master (Light Blade, 5 XP) using banked 1 + 4 = 5 XP; bank 0 XP
- **Total:** 34 XP (bank 0 XP)

11.14 12. The Occultist (Investigator of the Unseen)

Concept: A detective of the supernatural, solving mysteries that involve spirits, curses, and forbidden lore. *Dusty tomes, silver mirrors, and the patience to listen to what does not speak.* From the Thepyrgos scholar to the Mistlands exorcist, the Occultist knows that every haunting has a witness.

Traditional Analogues: Investigator (supernatural), Occultist, Lorekeeper, Exorcist, Paranormal Detective, Witch-Finder

Cultural Affinities: Thepyrgos (academic occultist), Mistlands (bell-warden), Valewood (Lethai-thora archivist), Ashaan (Breath-less researcher), Tulkani (dream-interpreter), Sekogo (nganga diagnostician)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Wits (investigation, pattern recognition), Spirit (willpower, sensing the unseen)
- **Skills:** Investigation, Lore (spirits, curses), Insight, (optionally) Ritual
- **Talents:** Keen Senses, Occult Knowledge (custom), Ritual Mastery

Play Style:

- Investigating supernatural phenomena
- Identifying curses, possessions, and hauntings
- Performing exorcisms and banishing rites
- Researching forgotten lore in archives and libraries
- Consulting with spirits (through ritual or mediumship)

11.14.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Wits to 3, Investigation/Lore to 2. Take *Keen Senses* (2 XP) and *Occult Knowledge* (custom, 3 XP).
- **Tier II:** Take *Ritual Mastery* (4 XP) and *Contamination Control* (custom, 4 XP). Raise Spirit to 3.
- **Tier III:** Take *Crack Specialist* or *Hollow-Sight* (custom, 8 XP). Build an Archive (Standard Asset, 8 XP) to store your findings.

11.14.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Investigation is your primary tool.** Ask the GM questions: “What kind of spirit is this? What unfinished business does it have? What’s the anchor?”
- **Lore checks can reveal weaknesses.** A spirit may be vulnerable to a specific salt, a forgotten name, or an iron bell.
- **Rituals take time, but they work.** Use *Ritual Mastery* to reduce casting time when the ghost is about to attack.
- **Document everything.** Your notes may become Assets (case files) that give bonuses to future investigations.
- **Sometimes the solution is not to banish, but to listen.** Many spirits just need to be witnessed.

Story Hooks:

- What unsolved haunting drives them?
- What forbidden text did they read (and what did it cost them)?
- Who refuses to believe their findings?

- What spirit have they failed to help, and how does it haunt them?
- What secret does the Church want them to stop investigating?

Legacy Note: A student or junior investigator (follower) can inherit your case files and contacts. See 19.

11.14.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Wits 3 (9), Spirit 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Presence 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Investigation 2 (4), Lore 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Keen Senses (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Occult Knowledge (3 XP, custom: +1 die to identify supernatural creatures and curses)
- **Total:** 29 + 5 = 34 XP (bank 0 XP)

11.15 13. The Infiltrator (Spy / Agent / Intelligence Officer)

Concept: A master of disguise, deception, and covert action. *Faces are costumes; trust is a vulnerability.* From the Vilikari spy to the Ashaani Breath-less agent, the Infiltrator moves through the world unnoticed, collecting secrets and planting lies.

Traditional Analogues: Spy, Agent, Infiltrator, Social Rogue, Intelligence Officer, Saboteur

Cultural Affinities: Vilikari (border agent), Ashaan (Breath-less spy), Ecktoria (Censorate informer), Thepyrgos (Chain-Lantern mole), Silkstrand (information broker), Zakov (syndicate agent)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Presence (disguise, deception), Wits (observation, planning)
- **Skills:** Deception, Subterfuge, Insight, (optionally) Stealth
- **Talents:** Silver Tongue, Silk Palms, Shadow Dance (for escapes)

Play Style:

- Infiltrating secure locations under false identities
- Planting misinformation and framing rivals
- Extracting secrets from unwilling targets
- Operating behind enemy lines
- Maintaining a cover identity for months or years

11.15.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Presence to 3, Deception/Subterfuge to 2. Take *Silver Tongue* (2 XP) and *Silk*

Palms (2 XP).

- **Tier II:** Take *Trackless Step* (2 XP) and *Network Builder* (4 XP). Raise Wits to 3.
- **Tier III:** Take *Shadow Dance* (10 XP) for escapes. Build a Spy Network (Standard Asset, 8 XP).

11.15.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Cover identities are your most valuable asset.** Spend downtime building them. Have at least one backup.
- **Use *Silk Palms* to create temporary Strings.** A bribe today becomes a favor tomorrow.
- **Never reveal your true agenda.** Let your targets think you're a merchant, a pilgrim, a lost traveler.
- **Always have an escape route.** *Shadow Dance* is expensive, but worth it when the guard patrol turns the corner.
- **The best intelligence is what they give you willingly.** Use Insight to learn what someone wants, then position yourself as the one who can provide it.

Story Hooks:

- What intelligence agency or patron do they serve?
- What secret are they trying to uncover?
- What cover identity has become uncomfortably real?
- Who burned them, and how will they get even?
- What would they sacrifice to protect their true identity?

Legacy Note: A handler or junior agent (follower) can inherit your network of covers and contacts. See 19.

11.15.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Presence 3 (9), Wits 2 (6), Body 1 (3), Spirit 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Deception 2 (4), Subterfuge 2 (4) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Silver Tongue (2 XP)
- Add **Talent:** Silk Palms (2 XP)
- **Total:** 29 + 4 = 33 XP (bank 1 XP)

11.16 14. The Channeler (Medium / Spiritualist / Oracle)

Concept: A vessel for spirits, voices, and visions from beyond the veil. *The dead speak through me; I am their mouth and their mercy.* From the Tulkani dream-speaker to the Mistlands spirit-medium, the Channeler bridges the living and the dead.

Traditional Analogues: Medium, Spiritualist, Oracle, Seer, Shaman (spirit channeling), Vessel

Cultural Affinities: Tulkani (dream-speaker), Mistlands (spirit-medium), Sekogo (nganga channeler), Theona (Green Host whisperer), Ashaan (Breath-less spirit-binder), Linn (volva)

Mechanical Foundation:

- **Primary:** Spirit (willpower, channeling), Presence (conduit strength)
- **Skills:** Ritual, Lore (spirits), Insight, (optionally) Performance (trance work)
- **Talents:** Summoning (spirit focus), Cantor's Path (for spirit-Songs), Spirit Link

Play Style:

- Channeling spirits to gain knowledge or perform tasks
- Serving as a medium between the living and the dead
- Receiving visions and prophecies (with GM guidance)
- Performing seances and spirit consultations
- Managing the risk of possession or spiritual contamination

11.16.0.0.1 Development Path (by Tier) :

- **Tier I:** Raise Spirit to 3, Ritual/Lore to 2. Take *Pact-Whisperer* (2 XP) and a spiritual Patron (Ikasha, Pale Shepherd, or Witness).
- **Tier II:** Take *Spirit Link* (10 XP) or *Cantor's Path* (8 XP). Raise Presence to 3.
- **Tier III:** Take *True Name Keeper* (15 XP) or *Embraced Corruption* (12 XP for Cantors). Build a Spirit Circle (Standard Asset, 8 XP).

11.16.0.0.2 Tactical Advice :

- **Channeling is risky.** Each time you let a spirit speak through you, tick a Spirit Influence timer. On fill, the spirit may try to stay.
- **Visions are clues, not scripts.** When you receive a prophecy, work with your GM to interpret it. It may be cryptic, but it's never false.
- **Use Ritual to consult the dead.** A successful ritual can answer one question about a death or a hidden secret.
- **Protect yourself.** Salt circles, iron bells, and witness cords can keep unwanted spirits from piggybacking on your channeling.
- **The dead have their own agendas.** A spirit may answer your question, but it may also ask for something in return.

Story Hooks:

- What spirit first spoke through them, and why?
- What prophecy do they carry that no one believes?
- How do they manage the constant presence of the dead?
- What spirit wants to possess them permanently, and how do they resist?
- What secret do the dead want revealed, and who wants it to stay hidden?

Legacy Note: A student medium (follower) can inherit your spirit contacts and channeling techniques. See 19.

11.16.0.0.3 Build Blocks. Starting Build (32 XP).

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3 (9), Presence 2 (6), Wits 1 (3), Body 1 (3) → **21 XP**
- **Skills:** Ritual 2 (4), Lore 1 (2), Insight 1 (2) → **8 XP**
- **Total:** 29 XP (bank 1 XP)

With Bonds/Complications (36 XP).

- Add **Talent:** Pact-Whisperer (2 XP)
- **Total:** 31 XP (bank 3 XP; can add Cantor's Path or Spirit Link later)

11.17 Reskinning the Paths: Runekeeper and Invoker as Familiar Concepts

The magic systems in *Fate's Edge* are designed to be reimaged. Neither **Runekeeper** (Thiasos + Codex) nor **Invoker** (Patron's Symbol) is locked into a single narrative identity. Below are common reskins — use the same mechanics, change the fiction.

Runekeeper — The Devoted Agent

A Runekeeper has sworn themselves to a single Patron, learning its Rites and bearing its Influence. This framework can represent:

- **Paladin / Crusader:** Sworn to the *Oath of Flame & Light* or the *Inquisitor Prime*. Rites become prayers, smites, and consecrations. The Codex is a prayer book or a vow-etched gauntlet.
- **Warlock / Pact-Bearer:** Bound to a distant, alien, or dangerous Patron (e.g., Khemesh, Malachai, the Ninth). Rites are granted, not learned. Influence is the steady pull of a bargain.
- **Cleric / Priest:** Devoted to the Everflame, the Pale Shepherd, or other divine powers. Rites are liturgies. The Patron's Gift is a blessing or a relic.
- **Dark Knight / Death Knight:** A fallen or morally ambiguous warrior who draws power from a grim Patron (Carrion-King, Mor'iraath). Melee and Rites mix; Influence is a slow doom.

Mechanical core unchanged: 1 action Rites, Influence track, Patron's Gift imbuelement, Push It option.

Invoker — The Professional Occultist

An Invoker does not fully commit to a single Patron. Instead, they carry **Symbols** (often tools, badges, or relics) of several Powers and perform rituals to invoke their Rites. This framework can represent:

- **Exorcist / Witch Hunter:** Carries symbols of several protective Patrons (The Sealed Gate, Oath of Flame, Gallow's Bell). Rites are wards, banishments, and purification rituals. *Crack the Seal* is an emergency exorcism.
- **Alienist / Scholar of the Unseen:** Studies forbidden Patrons (The Ninth, Khemesh, Mor'iraath) from a safe distance — “safe” being relative. Uses Symbol libraries to invoke their power without full devotion. Rituals are experimental and dangerous.

- **Consulting Occultist / Paranormal Investigator:** Carries a briefcase or satchel of Symbols — a bell from the Mistlands, a sun-seal from Ecktoria, a hag’s stone from Aelinnel. Hired to solve magical problems. Rituals are filed like work orders; *Crack the Seal* is “burning a favor.”
- **Ritualist / Ceremonial Mage:** Believes that power lies in procedure, not faith. Each Symbol is a “key” — a geometric diagram, a calendar, a consecrated blade. Rites are slow, deliberate, and precise. The Invoker is a technician, not a worshipper.

Mechanical core unchanged: Ritual time, Influence per invocation, Symbol display reduces cost, *Crack the Seal* for instant effect.

Mixing and Blurring Lines

Characters may also blend these frameworks — a Runekeeper who occasionally carries a second Symbol for emergency rites, or an Invoker who one day pledges fully to a Patron and becomes a Runekeeper. The system does not penalize narrative growth; simply retrain Talents during downtime (see 9) when the fiction justifies it.

Remember: The fiction leads. If you want to play a Paladin, describe your Runekeeper’s Rites as prayers. If you want a Vodouisant or Hoodoo practitioner, re flavor Patron’s Symbols as sacred bundles, veves, or spirit vessels. If you want a monster hunter, carry a satchel of monster-specific Symbols (silver stake, iron bell, cold iron nail). The mechanics stay the same; the story breathes.

11.18 Creating Your Own Concept

Start with Narrative

- What is your character’s background and motivation?
- What role do they play in their community or society?
- What relationships are important to them?
- What goals are they pursuing?

Add Mechanical Support

- Choose attributes that support your concept (see 7.1)
- Select skills that reflect their training and experience (see 7.2)
- Consider talents that provide unique capabilities (see 9)
- Think about assets that represent their resources (see 12)

Consider Group Role

- How does your concept complement other party members?
- What gaps in group capability can you fill?
- What unique contributions can you make?
- How will you work with other characters?

Plan for Growth

- What short-term improvements make sense?
- What long-term development aligns with your concept?
- How might your character change over time?

- What legacy do you want to build? (See 19)

Character Concept Worksheet

Narrative Elements:

- Concept: _____
- Traditional Analogues: _____
- Cultural Origin: _____
- Motivation: _____
- Background: _____
- Relationships: _____

Mechanical Foundation:

- Primary Attributes: _____
- Key Skills: _____
- Starting Talents: _____
- Initial Assets: _____

Development Plan:

- Short-term goals: _____
- Long-term vision: _____

11.19 Final Notes

Remember that these examples are starting points, not limitations. The most interesting characters often combine elements from multiple concepts or create entirely new approaches. Work with your Game Master to ensure your character concept fits the campaign and provides engaging story opportunities.

The best characters are those that you find interesting to play and that contribute to an enjoyable experience for everyone at the table.

Quick Reference: Concept Summary Table

Concept	Primary Attributes	Key Talents
Guardian	Body, Spirit	Defensive Survival, Combat Reflexes, Conditioning
Mage	Wits, Spirit	Spellcraft, Codex, Patron's Symbol
Rogue	Wits, Body	Backstab, Elusive Dodge, Shadow Dance
Cleric	Spirit, Presence	Patron's Symbol, Ritual Mastery, Symbol Resonance
Bard	Presence, Wits	Silver Tongue, Inspire, Network Builder
Ranger	Wits, Body	Wilderness Lore, Keen Senses, Trackless Step
Survivor	Spirit, Body	Iron Stomach, Conditioning, Second Wind
Innovator	Wits, Body	Quick Study, Workshop, Technical Expert

Summoner	Spirit, Wits	Pact-Whisperer, Greater Pactwright, Spirit Link
Commander	Presence, Wits	Command Presence, Inspire, Tactical Movement
Duelist	Body, Wits	Weapon Master, High Stance Duelist, Flurry Strike
Occultist	Wits, Spirit	Keen Senses, Occult Knowledge, Ritual Mastery
Infiltrator	Presence, Wits	Silver Tongue, Silk Palms, Shadow Dance
Channeler	Spirit, Presence	Pact-Whisperer, Spirit Link, Cantor's Path

Chapter 12

Assets and Followers

Power in Fate’s Edge is not measured only by what your character can do with their own hands. As characters grow, their influence extends outward—into places, people, and institutions that act in their name.

Assets and **Followers** represent this outward reach. They are how a character’s past choices continue to matter when the dice stop rolling.

Assets reshape the world around you. Followers stand beside you when the world pushes back.

A Word from the Raven Road

“A safehouse is not a home; it is a promise you may not keep. A follower is not a servant; they are a weight you choose to carry. Invest wisely, or the road will collect.” — Dusana of the Raven Road, The Hearth Ledger

12.1 Understanding Assets and Followers

Assets and Followers serve different roles in play, but both are expressions of legacy, leverage, and risk.

Key Differences

- **Assets** are off-screen resources: places, networks, titles, or enterprises.
- **Followers** are on-screen allies who act during scenes.
- **Assets** change the situation *before or around* a scene.
- **Followers** participate *directly* in the moment.

Both are powerful—but neither is free.

Management and Risk

Assets and Followers require care and invite consequences:

- They demand upkeep through XP, downtime, or narrative obligation.

- They can be targeted, compromised, or destroyed.
- Overuse draws attention from enemies, factions, and rivals.

Power creates gravity. What you rely on can be taken from you.

12.2 Assets System

Assets are persistent resources under your control: holdings, institutions, reputations, or infrastructures.

Assets do not replace rolls. They change what rolls are possible.

Assets allow characters to:

- Arrive prepared instead of improvising.
- Reframe danger into opportunity.
- Shift Position without negating risk.

Asset Types and Costs

Type	XP Cost	Establishment Time
Minor	4 XP	1 day
Standard	8 XP	1 week
Major	12 XP	1 month

Asset Examples

Minor Assets Safehouse, small shop, minor title, basic workshop.

Standard Assets Guild membership, noble office, trading post, spy network.

Major Assets Fortress, chartered city license, major enterprise, regional authority.

Using Assets

Assets provide leverage in two primary ways: quiet preparation and dramatic activation.

12.2.0.0.1 Free Off-Screen Use Each Asset has a defined off-screen effect usable **once per session**, typically during downtime or scene framing:

- **Safehouse:** Secure lodging or concealment.
- **Spy Network:** Baseline intelligence about a person or place.
- **Workshop:** Repair gear or prepare simple solutions.
- **Trading Post:** Acquire common goods or establish contacts.

These uses prepare the ground—they do not resolve active conflict.

12.2.0.0.2 Boon Activation Spend 1 **Boon** (see 2) to activate an Asset dramatically during a scene.

This does not guarantee success. Instead, the Asset **reshapes the fiction** so a different outcome

becomes possible.

An activated Asset may:

- Improve **Position** by one step.
- Reduce the effective **DV** of a follow-up action.
- Advance, suppress, or redirect a relevant Timer .
- Grant temporary access, protection, or narrative permission.

Examples:

- **Safehouse:** Reveal a concealed exit, allowing escape at *Controlled* Position.
- **Spy Network:** Surface critical intelligence, advancing an investigation Timer .
- **Workshop:** Jury-rig a solution that enables an otherwise impossible attempt.
- **Trading Post:** Call in a favor to gain leverage or access in a negotiation.

The GM determines the precise effect based on the Asset's scale, condition, and the current stakes.

12.2.0.0.3 High-Tier Use At higher tiers (see 7.8), Assets carry greater narrative weight—and greater risk.

Repeated or aggressive use may:

- Create new complications.
- Advance hostile faction Timers.
- Place the Asset itself in danger.

Assets are leverage, not immunity.

12.2.0.0.4 XP Activation Spend **2 XP** (see 7) to use an Asset's off-screen effect beyond its normal limit:

- Emergency use after the free activation is spent.
- Additional downtime applications.
- Exceptional circumstances requiring extended support.

XP use represents strain, overreach, or long-term cost.

12.3 Asset Status

Assets have a single unified **Status** that describes their overall health and usability.

Status	Meaning	Effect
Flourishing	Well-maintained, respected	+1 die on rolls involving the asset, +1 Yield
Stable	Normal operation	No modifier
Strained	Problems accumulating	−1 die on asset-related rolls, no Yield
Collapsed	Non-functional	Requires quest or major downtime to restore

The Status worsens when the asset is neglected, attacked, or suffers a public failure. It improves

through dedicated downtime actions or successful missions that benefit the asset.

Maintenance Requirements

- **Regular Upkeep:** Two options (see 12.6).
- **Neglect:** Assets deteriorate if not maintained (Status worsens one step).
- **Recovery:** Collapsed assets require significant effort to restore, typically a quest or a full downtime arc.

12.4 Followers System

Followers are characters who assist you directly.

Follower Capability Ratings

Followers are rated by Capability (**Cap**) from 1 to 5:

Cap	Description
1	Novice helper, basic assistance
2	Competent assistant, reliable support
3	Skilled specialist, valuable aid
4	Expert ally, significant capability
5	Master companion, exceptional ability

Follower Costs

- **XP Cost:** Capability squared (Cap^2).
- **Example:** Cap 3 follower costs $3^2 = 9$ XP.
- **Recruitment:** 1–3 days downtime to find and brief.
- **Limits:** The GM may set maximum followers based on story.

Follower Types

Combat Allies Warriors, guards, mercenaries.

Technical Experts Craftspeople, engineers, specialists.

Social Contacts Informants, diplomats, agents.

Specialists Unique capabilities like magic or stealth.

Follower States

Instead of numeric timers, track a follower's **Loyalty** and **Fitness** as one of three states each.

State	Meaning	Mechanical Effect
<i>Loyalty</i>		
Faithful	Committed, trustworthy	Normal assist, independent actions available
Strained	Doubtful, pressured	Assist at –1 die; may refuse risky orders
Broken	Betrayed or deserted	Follower leaves or becomes hostile
<i>Fitness</i>		
Ready	Uninjured, rested	Full function
Hurt	Wounded, exhausted	Assist at –1 die; no independent actions
Down	Incapacitated	Requires rescue or medical care

Change states when the fiction demands it (e.g., after a failed mission, a moral compromise, or taking damage). No rolls required.

High-Capability Followers (Cap 4–5)

Followers with Capability 4 or 5 are trusted lieutenants, stewards, or commanders. They can be delegated the management of your Assets, freeing you from direct oversight.

- A **Cap 4** follower can be delegated **up to 2 Assets**.
- A **Cap 5** follower can be delegated **up to 4 Assets**.

When an Asset is delegated to a follower, the follower’s own upkeep (paid in XP or downtime action) **automatically covers the upkeep of those Assets** — you do not pay separate Asset upkeep. The follower handles the logistics, staff, or political maintenance as part of their role.

If the follower’s Loyalty becomes **Strained** or **Broken**, all delegated Assets immediately worsen one step (e.g., Flourishing → Stable, Stable → Strained) until the follower is restored. If a follower becomes **Broken** (leaves or betrays), those Assets are lost.

12.5 Using Followers

Assistance in Scenes

Followers can help with your actions:

- **Assist Dice:** Add dice equal to min(Cap, relevant skill).
- **Maximum Bonus:** +3 dice total from all sources (see 2).
- **Cost:** Spend 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue to add +1 die (max +3 from assists).
- **One Helper:** Only one follower can assist per action.

Independent Actions

Once per scene (party-wide), a follower can take a small action:

Scout & Signal Change an ally’s next action to **Dominant** position.

Distract & Draw Reduce a threat timer by 1 segment.

Fetch & Carry Move an object through danger safely.

Cost of Independent Actions

- Worsen **Fitness** one step (Ready → Hurt → Down), *or*
- Worsen **Loyalty** one step (Faithful → Strained → Broken).
- Cannot be used if the follower is already **Broken** or **Down**.

Off-Screen Capability

Once per downtime, a **Cap 5** follower can solve a significant problem:

- Generates **1 Story Beat** for the GM (the GM describes a resulting complication).
- Useful for emergencies, but costly to the story.

12.6 Upkeep and Maintenance

Both assets and followers require regular maintenance. Each downtime period, choose one of the two options.

Upkeep Options

- **Efficient (Higher XP, Less Time)**: Pay Upkeep XP = $\max(1, \lceil \text{Acquisition XP} / 3 \rceil)$, minimal effort. *Rule of thumb: about one-third the acquisition cost, minimum 1 XP.*
- **Intensive (Lower XP, More Time)**: Pay 1 XP, use a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- **Failure to Pay**: Asset Status worsens one step (Flourishing → Stable → Strained → Collapsed). Follower Loyalty worsens one step (Faithful → Strained → Broken).

Upkeep Examples

- **Minor Asset (4 XP)**: Efficient = 2 XP; Intensive = 1 XP + action.
- **Standard Asset (8 XP)**: Efficient = 3 XP; Intensive = 1 XP + action.
- **Cap 3 Follower (9 XP)**: Efficient = 3 XP; Intensive = 1 XP + action.
- **Cap 2 Follower (4 XP)**: Efficient = 2 XP; Intensive = 1 XP + action.

12.7 Strategic Considerations

When to Invest in Assets

- You need reliable off-screen capabilities.
- Your character concept involves wealth or influence.
- The party lacks certain logistical support.
- You want to build long-term influence.

When to Invest in Followers

- You need on-screen assistance.
- Your character works better with support.
- The party needs specific capabilities you lack.
- You want character-driven story opportunities.

Investment by Player Archetype

Archetype	Typical XP Investment	Best For
Solo	0–10%	Reliable personal power, minimal upkeep.
Mixed (Balanced)	15–25%	One solid Follower or Asset (scout, safehouse).
Mastermind	35–55%	Networks, informants, multiple Assets; build a faction.

Balance Recommendations

- **Personal Path** (see 8.5): 0–10% of XP in assets/followers.
- **Balanced Path** (see 8.6): 15–25%.
- **Influencer Path** (see 8.7): 35–55%.

Planning for Succession (The Legacy Engine)

A loyal Follower (Cap 3+) can become your **successor** when your character retires or falls – inheriting your faction standing, one unresolved burden, and a Legacy Bond. See **Chapter 19: The Legacy Engine** for full rules. If you plan for your character’s story to continue beyond them, invest in a follower you would trust to carry your banner.

12.8 Terrestrial Patrons

Not all power comes from cosmic entities or divine forces. Sometimes your greatest allies—and most demanding creditors—are mortal factions who can offer protection, resources, and influence in the world of men.

12.8.1 What Are Terrestrial Patrons?

Terrestrial Patrons represent your ongoing relationships with powerful mortal organizations:

- Noble houses and courtly factions.
- Merchant guilds and trading consortiums.
- Military units and mercenary companies.
- Criminal organizations and smuggling rings.
- Religious orders and temple hierarchies.
- Scholarly colleges and arcane societies.

Unlike supernatural Patrons (see 5), Terrestrial Patrons do not grant magic, but they offer **leverage**: protection, resources, sanctuary, information, and political influence.

12.8.2 Gaining a Terrestrial Patron

To gain a Terrestrial Patron, complete one of these significant actions:

- Complete a major job or service for them.
- Swear a formal Oath of service.
- Enter into legal or financial binding.
- Share criminal secrets or be compromised by them.

- Perform a notable service that earns their favor.

Mark the Patron on your character sheet and write one sentence: “*They want me because _____*”.

12.8.3 Obligation System

Terrestrial Patrons use the same Obligation track as supernatural Patrons (see 5.3.1), but consequences are social, legal, or economic rather than mystical.

- **Calling in Favors:** When you request Patron influence, add +1 Obligation.
- **Capacity:** Spirit + Presence (same as supernatural Patrons).
- **Overflow:** Each segment above capacity inflicts 1 Fatigue.
- **Resolution:** Reduce through service, downtime actions, or fulfilling demands.

12.8.4 Patron Perks

Each Terrestrial Patron offers 2–3 repeatable benefits that require no rolls to access.

Common Perks Include:

- Sanctuary in their territory or establishments.
- Legal relief or protection from certain authorities.
- Access to black market goods or specialized services.
- Elite followers or hirelings at reduced cost.
- Forged documents or identity protection.
- Information networks and rumor access.
- Trade advantages or exclusive contracts.

Using a perk never requires a roll—Fate has already been paid. Each use comes with the ongoing cost of Obligation.

12.8.5 Patron Demands

Terrestrial Patrons always want something in return:

- Silence about sensitive information.
- Loyalty over other conflicting interests.
- Completion of specific jobs or tasks.
- Delivery of valuable names or secrets.
- Political or social support for their causes.
- Elimination of rivals or threats to their interests.

Refusing a Demand raises Obligation by 1 segment and may trigger immediate complications.

12.8.6 When Obligation Fills

At 6 Obligation segments, the Patron acts—this is not optional. Choose one:

1. **Unavoidable Job:** You must complete a task you cannot refuse.
2. **Severe Price:** Pay significant cost (legal, social, or material).
3. **First Strike:** They act against you—reputation damage, warrants, bounty, blackmail.

After the consequence lands, reduce Obligation to 3 segments.

12.8.7 Cutting Ties

You may sever a Terrestrial Patron relationship, but doing so has serious fallout:

- Lose all current perks immediately.
- Gain a new **Rival** faction that opposes your interests.
- Take a lasting **Complication** (Curse, Bounty, or Scandal) that follows you.
- May trigger immediate retaliation depending on the Patron's nature.

Some Patrons never forgive betrayal; others can be bought off with significant compensation.

12.8.8 Example: The Black Ledger

The Black Ledger is a smuggling syndicate operating in the coastal city of Kahfagia.

Gaining Their Favor: Successfully complete three smuggling runs without detection.

Perks:

- Sanctuary in hidden safehouses throughout the city.
- Access to rare imported goods and contraband.
- Information about port authorities and customs schedules.

Demands:

- Maintain silence about syndicate operations.
- Transport occasional “special packages” (may be illegal).
- Eliminate rival smugglers who threaten their routes.

Sample Scenario: Rellan calls on the Ledger for a smuggled border crossing. The GM rules it succeeds automatically, but adds +1 Obligation. Later, the Ledger demands he silence a witness who saw too much. If he refuses, Obligation rises again. If Obligation ever reaches 6, the Ledger collects: accounts frozen, bounty posted, or a rival informant sent after him.

12.9 Multi-Character Switching (Optional)

You may choose to temporarily step away from your current character and play another, while your first character continues to act offscreen. This is called an **Echo Character**. It allows you to explore different parts of the story without permanently retiring anyone.

12.9.1 How It Works

When you switch, you declare:

- Which character goes offscreen.
- Where they are going (fictional location).
- Why they are stepping out (story reason).
- How long you expect to be away (1–3 sessions).

The offscreen character remains active in the fiction. During each session they are away, you complete

a simple **Downtime Log**:

- One **Resource Action** (how they maintain connections).
- One **Project Action** (a goal advanced).
- One **Event Response** (how they react to offscreen events).

The GM records the outcomes and may introduce a consequence.

12.9.2 Returning to Play

When you bring the character back:

- You gain **2 Boons** for narrative re-entry.
- Roll **Wits + Spirit** (DV 3) to reestablish presence.
- The GM describes one consequence of your absence (e.g., an opportunity missed, a rival gained, a personal change).

For full mechanical details (Crisis Timers, Buddy System, etc.), see the GM Guide.

12.10 Practical Examples

Asset Example: The Safehouse

- **Type**: Minor Asset (4 XP)
- **Free Use**: Secure lodging, basic supplies between adventures.
- **Boon Activation**: Reveal a hidden escape route during pursuit.
- **Upkeep**: Efficient: 2 XP; Intensive: 1 XP + downtime action.
- **Risks**: Discovery by enemies, maintenance costs.

Follower Example: The Scout

- **Capability**: 3 (9 XP)
- **Assistance**: +3 dice on tracking and survival rolls.
- **Independent Action**: Scout ahead to improve party position.
- **Upkeep**: Efficient: 3 XP; Intensive: 1 XP + action.
- **Risks**: Injury in dangerous scouting; disloyalty if mistreated.

Combination Example: The Merchant

- **Assets**: Trading post (8 XP), caravan (4 XP) — *12 XP total*
- **Followers**: Cap 2 guards (4 XP each = 8 XP), Cap 3 factor (9 XP) — *17 XP total*
- **Total Investment**: **29 XP** in assets and followers
- **Upkeep (Efficient)**: Assets 4 XP + Followers 6 XP = **10 XP** per downtime
- **Benefits**: Trade income, transport, protection, business contacts
- **Risks**: Competition, bandit attacks, employee issues, regulatory attention

Remember: Assets and followers can greatly expand your capabilities, but they require careful management and carry significant risks. Invest wisely based on your character concept and the needs of your group.

12.11 Narrative-Heavy Options

For groups that prefer strong narrative focus, consider these optional approaches.

12.11.0.0.1 Story-Driven Upkeep Instead of tracking XP costs for upkeep, the GM can introduce narrative complications that require attention. A neglected asset might attract unwanted attention, while a neglected follower might request a favor or special treatment.

12.11.0.0.2 Collaborative Management Describe how you maintain your assets and followers through roleplay rather than mechanical upkeep costs. A well-described scene of tending a workshop or bonding with followers can fulfill maintenance requirements.

12.11.0.0.3 Flexible Condition Tracking Focus on the narrative implications of asset and follower conditions rather than strict penalties. A Strained asset might still function but with interesting complications, while a Collapsed asset might require creative solutions rather than just XP investment.

Assets and Followers Quick Reference

Assets:

- Minor: 4 XP | Standard: 8 XP | Major: 12 XP
- Free off-screen use: once per session
- Boon activation: spend 1 Boon for scene impact
- Status: Flourishing → Stable → Strained → Collapsed

Followers:

- Cost: Cap^2 XP
- Assistance: $+\min(\text{Cap}, \text{skill})$ dice (max +3 from all sources)
- Independent action: once per scene (party-wide)
- States: Loyalty (Faithful/Strained/Broken); Fitness (Ready/Hurt/Down)

Upkeep Options:

- Efficient: $\max(1, \lceil \text{Cost}/3 \rceil)$ XP (about one-third)
- Intensive: 1 XP + dedicated downtime action

Chapter 13

Downtime

When Does Downtime Happen?

Downtime occurs between adventures, when the party returns to a safe haven (a village, a guild hall, a camp that won't be attacked). Usually you take several days or weeks "off-screen" while the world advances. Your GM will tell you when downtime begins.

13.1 What You Can Do During Downtime

Choose any number of the following activities. Each one takes a specific amount of time (usually a day or a week). You may split your downtime between multiple activities, but you cannot be in two places at once.

13.1.1 Recovery

- **Clear Fatigue:** A short rest (1 hour) removes 2 Fatigue. A full night's rest (8 hours) removes all Fatigue.
- **Heal Harm:** Without magic, you restore 1 level of Harm per week of complete rest. A successful **Wits + Medicine** roll (DV 3) at the start of the week reduces the time to 3 days per Harm level.
- **Remove Conditions:** Use medicine, magic, or ritual to purge a Condition (e.g., Poisoned, Cursed). This usually requires a **Spirit + Lore** roll (DV 3–5) and a full day.

13.1.2 Training

You may spend XP to improve Attributes, Skills, or Talents. Each improvement requires training time (see table). You can train multiple things in parallel if you have enough downtime days.

Improvement	XP Cost	Training Time
Attribute increase	new rating ×3 XP	new rating in days
Skill increase	new level ×2 XP	new level in days
New Talent	listed XP	3–10 days (GM discretion)

13.1.2.0.1 Rush Rule: If you want to complete training faster, you may attempt a **Rush**. The GM starts a **Risk Timer** [4]. Each downtime segment you roll **Spirit + Resolve** (DV 3) to push yourself. For each failure (or 1 on the die), the timer ticks. If the timer fills before training is complete, the new ability has a flaw (temporary –1 die, or a narrative complication). The GM decides the flaw.

13.1.3 Asset & Follower Upkeep

Assets (safehouses, workshops) and Followers (allies, pets) must be maintained each downtime. Choose one method per asset or follower:

- **Efficient (higher XP, less time):** Pay XP equal to the acquisition cost divided by 3 (rounded up, minimum 1). No scene required.
- **Intensive (lower XP, more time):** Pay 1 XP and spend a scene describing how you maintain the asset or relationship (repairing the roof, training with your follower). This counts as a downtime activity.

If you pay neither, the asset/follower becomes **Neglected** (no benefit until you pay retroactive upkeep). Two consecutive neglected periods make it **Compromised** (must be repaired/recovered through a quest).

13.1.4 Clearing Obligation (to a Patron or Terrestrial Patron)

You may clear **Obligation** segments (see 15) by performing an **Act of Service**. Describe the act in detail (intricate description) – it must align with the Patron’s themes. For example:

- **Ikasha:** Burn an old cloak, symbolising leaving behind a past self.
- **The Traveler:** Guide a lost traveler to safety.
- **Oath of Flame & Light:** Swear a public vow and keep it for a day.

Each such act clears **1 segment** of Obligation (off-screen). You may also use the optional **Focused Devotion** talent (3–5 XP) to clear 1 segment on-screen by spending 1 Boon (once per scene).

13.1.5 Crafting

See 4 for full rules (the section on magic items and crafting). In brief:

- **Mundane items:** No roll. You can make tools, clothing, etc. if you have Craft skill.
- **Consumable magic items (potions, scrolls):** Takes one downtime action, costs 1 XP (or 2 XP for powerful ones). Roll **Wits + Arcana** or **Wits + Craft** (DV 3). On failure, components are wasted.
- **Permanent magic items:** Requires a Downtime Project Timer (6–12 segments), rare components (obtained through quests), and the XP cost of the item (see 4). You roll each downtime to advance the timer.

13.1.6 Research

You may spend downtime investigating a mystery, learning lore, or preparing for an upcoming challenge.

- **Basic research:** Roll **Wits + Lore** (DV 3). On success, you learn one useful fact (GM discretion). On partial, you learn something, but it's incomplete or costs extra time.
- **Extended research:** Use a Progress Timer [4–8] for complex topics (e.g., uncovering a noble's secret). Each downtime you can roll to advance the timer.

13.1.7 Carousing & Networking

Spend time socialising to gain rumors, contacts, or temporary favors.

- **Rumors:** Roll **Presence + Sway** (DV 3). On success, learn one rumor (true or false – the GM decides). On partial, the rumor is vague or costs you a drink (1 Fatigue).
- **Gain a temporary contact:** Spend 1 XP to establish a minor contact who can grant +1 die on one relevant roll in the next session. The contact fades after use.

13.1.8 Work & Income

In a currency-free game, “income” is abstract. You may:

- **Perform a job:** Spend a downtime week working. You earn enough to cover your expenses and have a small amount of barter goods (narrative permission for minor bribes or gear). No roll needed unless you want extra profit – then roll **Presence + Sway** or **Wits + Craft** (DV 4). On success, you gain 1 XP or a minor consumable item.

13.1.9 Special Downtime Projects

Your character may have a unique long-term goal (e.g., building a guild, writing a grimoire, taming a monster). Work with your GM to create a **Downtime Project Timer** (6–12 segments). Each downtime you can describe your progress and roll an appropriate skill to advance the timer. When it fills, the project is complete.

13.2 Off-Screen Character Switching (Echo Characters)

If your table uses the optional multi-character rule (see 20), you may send one character off-screen while you play another. The off-screen character maintains a **Downtime Log**:

- **Resource Action:** How they maintain assets or relationships.
- **Project Action:** One goal or project advanced.
- **Event Response:** How they react to unseen events.

The GM records consequences. When you return to that character, you gain 2 Boons and roll **Wits + Spirit** (DV 3) to re-establish presence.

13.3 GM's Role (Reminder)

Your GM determines how much downtime you have between adventures (usually a few days to several weeks). They also set DVs for downtime rolls and adjudicate any complications. Downtime is not a “free” rest – the world may advance timers (faction agendas, rival plans) while you rest. Ask your GM what has changed when you return.

The Gray Wanderer's Advice

“Downtime is not a pause. It is a negotiation. You mend your boots, but the road mends itself. When you step back onto it, it will be different – and so will you.”

Chapter 14

World Regions and Cultures

Using This Compendium

You only need to read the region your character is from or where the campaign starts. The GM will tell you when other regions become relevant.

Each entry includes:

- **Fantasy subgenre** – the kind of stories you can expect.
- **Attitude toward magic** – how locals react to spellcasters.
- **Typical dress / customs** – to help describe your character.
- **Player hook** – a story seed to tie your character to this place.
- **Key stakeholders** – major NPCs and factions.
- **Mini-generator** – quick prompts for GMs and players (d6 or d8 table).

For GM-only secrets (hidden agendas, faction timers), see the *GM Guide*.

Quick Reference by Subgenre

Region	Fantasy Subgenre	Magic Attitude
Acasia	Low fantasy / mercenary realism	Folk-wards respected; visible sorcery risky.
Aelaerem	Folk horror / pastoral dark	Hedge-magic common; open magic attracts the Neighbors.
Aeler	Industrial / survival horror	Rituals are craft; magic is guild-regulated.
Aelinnel	Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror	Fae rites only; iron is taboo.
Black Banners	Military / mercenary warfare	Pragmatic; useful magic tolerated.
Ecktoria	Political intrigue / legal drama	Licensed thaumaturges; unlicensed magic is crime.
Linn	Viking / maritime	Weather rites are sacred; false rites are sin.
Mistlands	Folk horror / gothic	Bell-magic and salt – necessary but dangerous.
Silkstrand	Urban / mercantile / noir	Curse-magic feared; trade magic accepted.
Theona	Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven	Old rites respected; the Ninth taboo governs all.
Thepyrgos	Byzantine / academic	Magic studied; unorthodox styles unfashionable.
Ubral	Highland clan / honor culture	Outsider mages watched; clan shamans respected.
Valewood	Fairy tale / dark forest	Fey magic, imperial echoes – dangerous to meddle.

Vhasia	Courtly romance / fractured kingdom	Church distrusts magic; lords employ mages anyway.
Viterra	Legal drama / frontier justice	Hedge-magic common; registered magic tolerated.
Ykrul	Steppe nomad / saga	Geometry of oaths; shamanism respected.
Zakov	Pirate / noir / crime syndicate	Any magic welcome – if it pays.

14.1 Acasia — “The Broken Province”

Genre: Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud.

14.1.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Hedge-witches respected; visible sorcery can start a levy. The Curse is blamed on ancient magic.

14.1.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Wool and leather, scarves to hide clan markings. Feasts often end in oath-swearing; never sign a contract on a bridge.

14.1.0.0.3 Player hook: *You owe a blood-debt to a free company captain – or you are that captain.*

14.1.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Margravine of the Broken March, The Lame King, Blackwood Matriarchs, Free Company Captains.

14.1.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Border-wise. Once per session when navigating a contested border or disputed territory, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about local patrols, safe passages, or hidden trails.

Acasia Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A bridge toll has tripled overnight; the toll-keeper is a deserter from your old company.
2. A hedge-witch offers to break your blood-debt – for the memory of your first kill.
3. The Lame King travels with a mute jester who writes prophecies on fallen leaves.
4. Bandits stole a Blackwood Matriarch’s curse-box. Recover it before it opens.
5. A free company captain wants to hire you – but their last three hires died of “accidents”.
6. The Margravine’s seal is missing. Whoever finds it can rewrite border law.

14.2 Aelaerem (Halflings) — “Hearth & Hollow”

Genre: Folk horror / pastoral quiet with dark undercurrents.

14.2.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Hearth-magic (red thread, cup-marks) is everyday. Open magic may attract the Neighbors.

14.2.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Bright wool, red doors, nine cups never poured. Hospitality is sacred – and a trap.

14.2.0.0.3 Player hook: *The Pale Shepherd came for your grandmother. You still hear her footsteps.*

14.2.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Apple-Matron, The Pale Shepherd, Mummies’ Captain, Lantern-Warden.

14.2.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Lucky break. Once per scene, you may improve your Position by one step (e.g., Desperate → Controlled, Controlled → Dominant) as a free action before rolling. This represents a flash of well-timed luck or an unexpected opening.

Aelaerem Mini-Generator (d6)

1. You poured the ninth cup by accident. The Hollow Bride left a silver coin under your pillow.
2. A red thread appears around your wrist each morning. Who ties it – and what do they want?
3. The Apple-Matron’s orchard produced blood-red fruit. Eating one lets you speak with crows.
4. A mummies’ troupe wears masks of your dead relatives. They invite you to join.
5. The Lantern-Warden is deaf. She hires you to “hear” which bell-line is failing.
6. The Pale Shepherd walks beside you for one night. You may ask one question – but you must answer one truth in return.

14.3 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Genre: Industrial / political / survival horror (underground).

14.3.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Rituals are a craft, guild-licensed. Unsanctioned magic damages air and stone.

14.3.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Heavy aprons, breath-masks, bell-tokens. Count your breaths in eights; never waste water.

14.3.0.0.3 Player hook: *You broke a seal in the deep ways and something followed you up.*

14.3.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Vault-Queen, High King Beneath the Peaks, True Masons, Edgewalkers.

14.3.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Stone-sense. You have an innate feel for worked stone and underground spaces. Once per session, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about structural weaknesses, hidden passages, or ventilation in an underground or stonework environment.

Aeler Mini-Generator (d6)

1. The ventilation system is ticking – you have one hour before the lower galleries suffocate.
2. A vein-serpent wakes. It will trade a lost treasure for your last breath.
3. The Vault-Queen’s ledger shows a keystone that was never carved. You must invent it.
4. Edgewalkers report singing stones. The song is in a dialect that has been dead for three centuries.
5. A rival clan sabotaged your breath-counters. Find their spy before the audit.
6. The High King Beneath the Peaks demands a new oath – carved into your own collarbone.

14.4 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — “Stone, Bough, and Bright Things”

Genre: Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror.

14.4.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Fae rites, geasa, and bargain-magic. Iron is taboo; copper is polite.

14.4.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Bright coats, copper tools, counting beads. Never trust a single account.

14.4.0.0.3 Player hook: *You spoke a word you shouldn’t have, and now the Green Gate demands payment.*

14.4.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Stone Prince of Aelinnel, Lady of Thorns, Green Knight, Oath-Carver.

14.4.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Knack for the right thing. Once per scene, you may declare that you have a small, mundane item on your person that is useful in the current situation (e.g., a coil of rope, a lockpick, a candle, a chalk stick). This costs no Boon and requires no roll. The item must be plausible for your character to carry.

Aelinnel Mini-Generator (d6)

1. The Green Gate appears. It asks: “What is the number of a promise that was never spoken?”
2. A Thorn Courtier offers you a cup of tea. If you drink, you forget your own name.
3. The Oath-Carver has gone mad, carving the same impossible equation into every door.
4. Copper coins scream when touched. They are trying to recite a forgotten treaty.
5. The Stone Prince’s throne is a living geas. Sitting on it makes you honor one ancient oath.
6. A tide-path opens at midnight. It leads to a library where every book is blank – but whispering.

14.5 Black Banners — “Condotta & Crowns”

Genre: Military / mercenary / low fantasy warfare.

14.5.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Battle-magic is useful; unreliable mages don’t get paid. Condotta captains hire cantors for morale.

14.5.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Tabards over rusted mail, scarves to hide old loyalties. Payday is sacred; betrayal is business.

14.5.0.0.3 Player hook: *Your company was sold out from under you. Now you hunt the broker who took the coin.*

14.5.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Banner-Captain, The Black Colonel, Clan-Mother (Ykrul), Veteran Sergeant.

14.5.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Camp-wise. Once per session when dealing with mercenaries, soldiers, or camp followers, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about their loyalties, pay situation, or recent movements.

Black Banners Mini-Generator (d6)

1. Payday is late. The troops are muttering. The quartermaster has disappeared.
2. The Black Colonel’s banner is found torn – but no one saw it happen.
3. A rival condotta offers double pay to switch sides – but your current captain holds your hostage.
4. The Veteran Sergeant knows a secret passage into the enemy camp. He also knows it’s cursed.
5. A cantor’s song heals the wounded but slowly erases their memories of home.
6. The Clan-Mother sends a war-host. She demands a blood-price paid in songs, not gold.

14.6 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Genre: Political intrigue / legal drama / fallen empire.

14.6.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Licensed thaumaturges file casting notices. Unlicensed magic is a crime, often punished by the Everflame inquisitors.

14.6.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Togas, seal rings, procession masks. Law is a weapon; never refuse a toast in a coin-house.

14.6.0.0.3 Player hook: *You forged a document that could topple a senator – or save a heretic.*

14.6.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Grand Magistrate, High Priest of the Everflame, Duchess-Regent, Censor’s Clerk.

14.6.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Legal ear. Once per session when navigating bureaucracy, courts, or official proceedings, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about which official is corrupt, what a document really means, or who has the real authority.

Ecktoria Mini-Generator (d6)

1. The Grand Magistrate’s son has been cursed. The only cure is a confession that would ruin a family.
2. A Censor’s clerk offers you a “redacted” page from the imperial archives. It shows your name.
3. The Everflame’s flame gutters for one second. In that second, you see a ghost wearing your face.
4. A legal duel is declared. Your champion must fight – but the opponent’s blade is made of frozen lies.
5. The Duchess-Regent hosts a masked ball. Each mask is a binding contract.
6. A heretic claims the Everflame is not divine – it’s a prison for a forgotten angel. The inquisitors are already on their way.

14.7 Linn — “Skerries & Storm-Oaths”

Genre: Viking / maritime / oath-bound raiding.

14.7.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Weather magic is sacred; false rites are crimes against the ship. Skalds use songs for law and memory.

14.7.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Wool, leather, whale-bone runes. Oaths sworn on the tide cannot be broken without drowning.

14.7.0.0.3 Player hook: *Your father’s sword was lost in a raid. The sea-queen says the drowned still carry it.*

14.7.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Sea-Queen, High Jarl, Volva of the Mist, Skald.

14.7.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Tide-reader. You have an innate sense of the sea’s rhythms. Once per session when on or near salt water, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about tides, currents, weather, or submerged hazards.

Linn Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A drowned longship rises from the fjord. The crew is still aboard – and still owes a debt.
2. The Volva of the Mist demands you cut your shadow loose. It will serve as a spy for one

year.

3. A skald sings a verse that names you as the heir to a curse you never knew existed.
4. The Sea-Queen’s crown is made of a single whale’s tooth. It whispers the names of traitors.
5. A storm-oath is broken. The wind will not return until the oath is sworn again in blood.
6. The High Jarl’s funeral pyre burns for nine days. On the ninth night, he sits up and asks for his sword.

14.8 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Genre: Folk horror / gothic / supernatural dread.

14.8.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Bell-lines and salt are the only trusted magic. Outsider spellcasters are viewed with suspicion.

14.8.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Gray wool, fog-veils, bell-charms. Never breathe deeply after the ninth bell.

14.8.0.0.3 Player hook: *You were born during a bell-line failure. The fog knows your name – it has visited twice.*

14.8.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Legate of the Mists, Bell-Warden, Salt-Monk, Mist-Seer.

14.8.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Fog-wise. Once per session when in fog, mist, or heavy precipitation, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about directions, hidden dangers, or the presence of spirits or wraiths in the immediate area.

Mistlands Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A bell-line goes silent. The fog pours through the gap, carrying a voice that asks for a story.
2. The Salt-Monk’s salt pans have turned black. The curse will spread unless you find a new vein.
3. A Mist-Seer offers to read your future in the fog. The price is one memory you never share.
4. The Legate of the Mists is an Aeler exile. He will trade safe passage for a secret about your past.
5. A corpse on the bell-line has no face – but it wears your grandmother’s wedding ring.
6. The fog parts for one minute, revealing a city that should not exist. Its bell is ringing the ninth time.

14.9 Silkstrand — “City of Bridges & Dyewater”

Genre: Urban / mercantile / noir.

14.9.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Curse-magic feared; trade magic (dye-wards, bridge-blessings) accepted. The Matron employs a weft-reader.

14.9.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Dyed silks, debtor’s stains, bridge tokens. Every bridge is a treaty; every handshake a contract.

14.9.0.0.3 Player hook: *You’re the only one who knows the secret of the red dye. The guild wants the recipe – or your hands.*

14.9.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: The Matron, Guildmistress of Dyers, Bridge Bailiff, Night-Boat Smuggler (“Ravel”).

14.9.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Bridge-runner. Once per session when navigating an urban environment (city streets, docks, markets), you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about shortcuts, hidden routes, or the location of a specific shop, tavern, or safe house.

Silkstrand Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A bolt of cloth bleeds when cut. The blood shows a murder that hasn’t happened yet.
2. The Bridge Bailiff auctions a debt. You can buy it – but the debtor is a ghost.
3. The Night-Boat Smuggler offers you a package. Do not open it. Do not ask what it is.
4. The Guildmistress of Dyers demands a new color – dyed from the ashes of a broken oath.
5. The Matron’s weft-reader sees a thread connecting you to the Drowned Man. She refuses to cut it.
6. A dye-vat overflows, turning a canal to ink. Words form on the surface – a list of names. Yours is last.

14.10 Theona — “Three Greens, No Ninth”

Genre: Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven.

14.10.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Old rites (well-blessings, bride-peace) are essential. Breaking a taboo invites the Green Host.

14.10.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Peat-stained cloaks, hawthorn pins, counting in eights. The ninth cup is never poured.

14.10.0.0.3 Player hook: *You were at a bride-peace feast when the ninth name was spoken. The Green Host rode – but you survived.*

14.10.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Matron of Wells, Three-Isles King, Lady Beneath, Taboo-Witness.

14.10.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Green-sight. Once per session when in natural settings (forests, moors, hills), you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about the presence of fey, spirits, or the Green Host, or about a local taboo’s consequences.

Theona Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A well runs dry. The Matron of Wells says the water was stolen – by your own reflection.
2. The Three-Isles King marries a second time. The bride is a woman you killed (or failed to save).
3. The Taboo-Witness catches you pouring the ninth cup. She offers a deal: your right hand, or a memory.
4. The Green Host rides tonight. You can join them – but you will forget how to return.
5. The Lady Beneath sends a dream: a coin lies at the bottom of the marsh. Take it, and she will remember your name.
6. A bride-peace is broken. The groom’s family demands a blood-price; the bride’s family offers you instead.

14.11 Thepyrgos — “City of a Thousand Stairs”

Genre: Byzantine / academic / arcane mystery.

14.11.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: The Synod licenses magic; unorthodox casting is not illegal – merely unfashionable. Witch-hunters conscript talent.

14.11.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Academic robes, bell-badges, stair-passes. Every stair climbed is a word in a conversation.

14.11.0.0.3 Player hook: *You tested as “gifted” on the candle-smoke test. The university wants you; the Chain-Lanterns want you in chains.*

14.11.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: The Archon, Lighthouse-Patriarch, Nomophylax, Palkar Captain.

14.11.0.0.5 Cultural bonus (Hyro heritage): Echo-memory. Your ancestors survived the Astroegro collapse, and fragments of that resilience linger. Once per session when trying to recall a piece of forgotten lore, a hidden door, or a buried secret, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about the past or about hidden things. This represents ancestral whispers, not scholarly knowledge.

Thepyrgos Mini-Generator (d6)

1. The Lighthouse-Patriarch has not spoken in three years. His shadow gives lectures on forbidden texts.
2. A stair token is stolen. Without it, you cannot reach the upper archives – and a demon is loose there.

3. The Nomophylax declares your magical talent “unlicensed”. You have one day to pass the Synod exam.
4. A Palkar Captain offers to erase your criminal record – in exchange for a ritual performed in the cisterns.
5. The Archon dies. His last word is your name. The election for his successor begins at midnight.
6. A student has been erased from every record. Only you remember them. The Chain-Lanterns want to know why.

14.12 Ubral — “The Stone Between Spears”

Genre: Highland clan / reiver / honor culture.

14.12.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Clan shamans are respected; outsider mages are watched. Stone-speakers (dwarf-trained) are tolerated.

14.12.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Tweed, iron brooches, guest-tokens. Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt – hospitality is a contract.

14.12.0.0.3 Player hook: *You carry a wergild debt that your father couldn’t pay. The feud is now yours.*

14.12.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Lady of Tor, Council of Cairns, Feud-Broker, Wergild Counter.

14.12.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Hill-wise. Once per session when in highland or mountainous terrain, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about weather, passes, hidden valleys, or clan movements.

Ubral Mini-Generator (d6)

1. The Council of Cairns adds a new stone. It has your name carved into it – but you are not dead.
2. A guest-token is broken. You are now an outlaw unless you find the piece that was stolen.
3. The Feud-Broker offers to settle your wergild – but the payment is the hand of a loved one.
4. The Lady of Tor’s son was killed by a monster. The monster is actually a cursed ancestor of yours.
5. A Wergild Counter admits he has miscounted. The debt is actually double. He wants you to kill the witness.
6. A stone-speaker claims the mountain is waking. It demands a tribute of fresh blood.

14.13 Valewood — “Empire Under Leaves”

Genre: Fairy tale / dark forest / fey remnant.

14.13.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Imperial echoes and fae rites are dangerous. Never eat fruit from a tree with a face.

14.13.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Leather, moss-dyed cloaks, way-cords. Speak in riddles or not at all.

14.13.0.0.3 Player hook: *A star-road opened in your dream. You walked it – now something walks behind you.*

14.13.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Hazel Queen, Alder King, The Huntsman, Pathweaver.

14.13.0.0.5 Cultural bonus (Lethai-al heritage): Root-memory. You carry the long memory of the wood. Once per session when in forest terrain, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about the oldest trees, hidden paths, or the presence of fey or imperial echoes.

Valewood Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A star-road appears at midnight. It leads to a throne made of antlers. The Alder King sits on it – and he expects you to kneel.
2. The Pathweaver offers you a cord. If you tie it, you will never be lost again. If you untie it, you will forget where home is.
3. The Hazel Queen is dying. Her last request: find the acorn of the first tree, buried under a court that no longer exists.
4. The Huntsman’s hounds are loose. They will not attack – they will only follow you until you speak your true name.
5. An imperial echo (a ghost of a long-dead soldier) mistakes you for an enemy. It will not listen to reason – only to a duellist’s blade.
6. A tree with a face offers you its fruit. Eat it, and you will understand the language of stone. Refuse, and it will uproot itself and follow you.

14.14 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

Genre: Courtly romance / chivalric / fractured kingdom.

14.14.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: The Church of the Flame distrusts arcane magic; secular lords employ court mages anyway. Chevauchée raiders use cantors for morale.

14.14.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Velvet, partisan ribbons, duelling scars. Never carry a coin with only one sunburst – treason.

14.14.0.0.3 Player hook: *You’re the Last Dauphin – or a convincing fake. Either way, armies march for your claim.*

14.14.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Two Crowns, Queen-Mother, Last Dauphin, Marshal-Exile.

14.14.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Herald’s eye. Once per session when dealing with nobility, heraldry, or court politics, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about a noble’s allegiance, a marriage alliance, or a hidden feud.

Vhasia Mini-Generator (d6)

1. The Queen-Mother offers you a marriage alliance. The bride is a ghost bound to a tapestry.
2. The Marshal-Exile demands a duel. The winner takes the army; the loser takes a beheading.
3. A chevauchée burns a village that swore neutrality. The only survivor is a child who calls you by a dead knight’s name.
4. The Two Crowns are secretly the same person – a master of disguise who enjoys war.
5. The Last Dauphin is a commoner recruited by a desperate lord. He does not know he is a fake.
6. A duelling scar heals overnight, leaving silver thread in your skin. The wound now whispers treason.

14.15 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

Genre: Legal drama / low fantasy / frontier justice.

14.15.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Hedge-magic common; any thaumaturgy that leaves a trace must be registered. Legal duels may involve wizards.

14.15.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Wool, seal rings, boundary stones. Every hedge is a precedent; every dike a court ruling.

14.15.0.0.3 Player hook: *Your family lost the border dispute. You have one year to find a lost charter or lose the land forever.*

14.15.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Warrior Queen, Queen’s Justiciar, Fen Reeve, Master Advocate Halric.

14.15.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Hedge-walker. Once per session when dealing with legal matters, contracts, or border disputes, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about loopholes, precedents, or the true ownership of a piece of land.

Viterra Mini-Generator (d6)

1. The Warrior Queen comes in person to settle a dispute. She asks each party one question. The liar loses a hand.
2. The Fen Reeve’s tally-stick is broken. Until it is mended, the river toll is doubled – and the river itself is angry.
3. Master Advocate Halric offers to defend you for free. His last three clients all died mysteriously.
4. A boundary stone moves three feet east every night. The neighbors swear they are not touching it.
5. The Queen’s Justiciar arrests you for “hedge-walking without a license”. The sentence is a legal duel at dawn.
6. A charter written in disappearing ink is the only proof of your inheritance. The ink will be gone by sunrise.

14.16 Ykrul (Orcs) — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”

Genre: Steppe nomad / saga / honor culture.

14.16.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Geometry of oaths (Kon’reh) and sky-speakers. Written magic is suspicious; sung magic is respected.

14.16.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Leather, horse-hair braids, wolf-tooth standards. Never ride between two wolves at dusk.

14.16.0.0.3 Player hook: *You broke a hostage string. Now the Khatun demands a blood-price – or your youngest kin.*

14.16.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Khatun of Ring, Khagan’s Kin, Sky-Speaker, Kon’reh Masters.

14.16.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Steppe-sense. You have an innate feel for open country, weather, and the movement of herds and riders. Once per session when on steppe, grassland, or open plain, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about weather patterns, the presence of riders, or the safest route to water.

Ykrul Mini-Generator (d6)

1. A white squall separates you from the herd. In the snow, you see the faces of everyone you have wronged.
2. The Sky-Speaker calls a storm to halt an enemy army. The storm demands a sacrifice: your left ear.
3. A Kon’reh Master sets you a problem: “How many camps can be pitched before the river freezes?” The wrong answer is death.
4. The Khagan’s Kin offers you a hostage string. If you accept, you gain a loyal servant –

but also a rival who will hunt you.

5. A wolf-standard is stolen. The clan will not fight until it is returned. The thief is a ghost who died in the last war.
6. The Khatun of Ring declares a blood-price on your head. You have one day to pay or one day to ride.

14.17 Zakov — “Salt & Serpent”

Genre: Pirate / noir / crime syndicate.

14.17.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Any magic is welcome – if it pays. Cursed cargoes are a common hazard; fae bargains are made at the Crimson Docks.

14.17.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Brine-stained coats, reef-tooth necklaces, smuggler’s tokens. Never take a coin that tastes of brine – the Serpent’s Mark is a debt.

14.17.0.0.3 Player hook: *You have a syndicate marker that could buy a fleet – or get you killed. The Salt Prince wants to collect.*

14.17.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Salt Prince, Pirate Queen, Kraken’s Tongue, Syndicate Silent.

14.17.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Tide-pirate’s eye. Once per session when on or near salt water, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about hidden coves, underwater hazards, or the loyalties of a ship’s crew.

Zakov Mini-Generator (d6)

1. The Kraken’s Tongue offers a prophecy. To hear it, you must drink a cup of seawater that tastes like your mother’s tears.
2. A Pirate Queen’s crew is cursed: they cannot step on land until they pay a debt to a man who drowned fifty years ago.
3. The Salt Prince’s collector comes for your marker. You can pay with a memory, a finger, or a voyage to a reef that does not exist.
4. A fae bargain is struck on the Crimson Docks. The price: a stolen hour of sleep from every sailor in port.
5. A smuggler’s token is found in your pocket. It belonged to someone who was hanged last week. The guard assumes you are the accomplice.
6. A reef-tooth necklace bleeds when you touch it. It belonged to a pirate queen who was betrayed – and she is not dead.

14.18 Vilikari — “Laurels & Longhouses”

Genre: Frontier federates / mercantile pragmatism / dual loyalty.

14.18.0.0.1 Attitude toward magic: Hedge-magic and weather-singing are common; written magic is viewed with suspicion. The old families prefer results over rituals.

14.18.0.0.2 Typical dress / customs: Wool tunics over faded imperial tunics, leather breeches, brass torcs. Longhouses with broken marble columns used as door lintels. Never invoke only one law — the oak and the marble must both be honored.

14.18.0.0.3 Player hook: *Your grandfather signed the Foedus Stone with a thumbprint. That thumb is now a wax seal on a contract that could destroy your family.*

14.18.0.0.4 Key stakeholders: Federate King Aldric, Queen of Marches, Hearth-Mother Vesna, Stone-Sealed Families (Contarini, Morosini, Dandolo).

14.18.0.0.5 Cultural bonus: Two-Law Cunning. Once per session when navigating bureaucracy, customs, or legal disputes, you may ask the GM one straightforward yes/no question about loopholes, hidden clauses, or which official can be bribed.

Vilikari Mini-Generator (d6)

1. The Foedus Stone has a new crack. No one knows which promise it represents. The Hearth-Mother asks you to discover who placed it there.
2. A Viterran tax collector demands back-tithes from a village that has paid the Vilikari crown instead. You must mediate before blades are drawn.
3. The Ragman’s bravos are shaking down merchants on Three-Causeway Bridge. The local factor refuses to pay — and the factor is your cousin.
4. A Ykrul envoy arrives with a hostage string. She claims a Vilikari horse-thief killed her nephew. The horse-thief is the Federate King’s son.
5. The Archivolt discovers a sealed charter that grants the Contarini family rights to a canal that no longer exists. The canal’s ghost now floods the district each spring.
6. A Tulkani caravan judge leaves a knotted cord at the Foedus Stone. The knot is a request for parley — and a warning that the Hollow is counting.

The Vilikari — Between Oak and Marble

The Vilikari are the children of two failed empires. When the Utaran legions withdrew from the eastern marches, they left behind not garrisons but grandchildren — legionaries who had married into steppe clans, adopted local customs, and forgotten which flag they had once carried. When the old fey courts of the Valewood sealed their gates, refugees trickled east, carrying memory-cords and grudges. The Vilikari are what grew from that soil: a people who speak two languages badly, honor two sets of laws selectively, and have learned that survival is not about choosing sides but about making both sides need you.

They straddle the border between the Violet Steppe and the lowland kingdoms, a buffer that has been conquered, abandoned, and conquered again. Their settlements are longhouses raised over ruined forums, their markets trade Ykrul horses for Ecktorian grain, and their courts are held under oak trees when the marble benches are too cold.

The Two Laws

Vilikari law is not written in a single codex. It lives in two sources, and every Vilikari learns to walk the line between them.

14.18.0.0.6 The Oak (Mallus Law) The old law, sworn on antler and root. It governs grazing rights, blood-prices, and the bonds of foster-kin. Judgments are made by the Hearth-Mother or a circle of elders. Oaths are sealed with a handshake and witnessed by the fire. Breaking an oak-law oath stains a family’s honor for three generations.

14.18.0.0.7 The Marble (Basilica Law) The imperial remnant, preserved in faded charters and the Archivolt’s sealed records. It governs contracts, tariffs, and inheritance. Judgments are made by notaries and sealed with wax. A marble-law contract can be enforced across borders — but only if the seal is still warm.

14.18.0.0.8 The Foedus Stone At the heart of Vilikari territory stands the Foedus Stone, a weathered monolith at a crossroads, carved with every treaty the Vilikari have ever sworn. The oldest marks are Utaran legionary oaths. The newest are still wet. The stone has grown over the centuries — each new treaty adds a finger of granite. The newest crack has no date. The Vilikari do not speak of what it represents. They only know that when the crack widens, the Hollow listens.

The Stone-Sealed Families

The old Vilikari families do not rule through armies or treasuries. They rule through **charters** — sealed documents, imperial patents, and foedus clauses that give them the right to collect tolls, operate ferries, and sit on the Federate King’s council. Each family is a **Terrestrial Patron** (see sidebar), offering influence in exchange for loyalty.

14.18.0.0.9 House Contarini (The Archivolt’s Shadow) “*We do not write the law. We file it. The difference is a matter of shelf space.*” The Contarini control the Archivolt — the half-ruined scriptorium where Vilikari charters are stored and disputed. Their influence is bureaucratic, slow, and absolute. A Contarini factor can find a precedent to justify almost anything — or lose a document that would have stopped a war. **Patron Asset: Archivolt Access** — Once per session, spend 1 Boon to produce a sealed document that grants temporary authority (safe passage, toll waiver, legal immunity). The document is genuine. The seal is warm.

14.18.0.0.10 House Morosini (The Coin Unspoken) “*Gold talks. Whisper is silver. Silence is a fortune.*” The Morosini are merchant-bankers who never appear in any ledger. They finance caravans, underwrite condotta contracts, and lend silver to kings who cannot pay it back. Their symbol is a closed fist — because the hand that counts coin should never be seen counting. **Patron Asset: Morosini Voucher** — Once per session, spend 1 Boon to produce a line of credit at any market in the Amaranthine. The voucher is honored once. Then the Morosini will ask for a favor.

14.18.0.0.11 House Dandolo (The Bridge-Builders) *“A bridge is a promise. A promise is a bridge. Both can be burned.”* The Dandolo control the causeways, ferries, and rope-bridges that connect the Vilikari cantons. They are neutral in family feuds — everyone needs to cross. Their influence is geographic; they can open a route or close it, speed a caravan or strand it. **Patron Asset:** *Dandolo Pass* — Once per session, treat one water or bridge crossing as Dominant Position. The toll is waived — but the Dandolo will remember the favor.

14.18.0.0.12 House Giustinian (The Neutrals) *“We do not take sides. We take minutes. The minutes are confidential. Usually.”* The Giustinian are arbiters, not warriors. They settle disputes between families, interpret the Foedus Stone’s cracks, and keep the peace when the Federate King cannot. Their word is not law — but ignoring it starts a feud that no one wins. **Patron Asset:** *Giustinian Witness* — Once per session, invoke a Giustinian observer to guarantee a truce for one scene. Breaking the truce ticks the Hollow Attention timer by 2.

The Federate King and the Queen of Marches

The Vilikari are not a kingdom. They are a **federacy** — a loose alliance of cantons, each with its own Hearth-Mother, its own banner, and its own interpretation of the Two Laws. The **Federate King Aldric** is elected by the Stone-Sealed Families for a term of nine years. His authority rests not on armies but on the weight of the Foedus Stone — he is the stone’s voice, and when he speaks, the cracks echo.

The **Queen of Marches** is his consort and his counterweight. She commands no armies and holds no charters. She rules the roads — the inns, the ferry landings, the waystations where travelers sleep. Her network of hearth-aunts and innkeepers knows every rumor, every secret, every unpaid toll. She is the reason the Vilikari have never been conquered: by the time an army arrives, its supply routes have been sold to its enemies.

The Federate King’s Court (d6)

When the party seeks an audience with the Federate King or one of the Stone-Sealed Families, roll or choose the court’s disposition:

1. **Wary:** A recent crack in the Foedus Stone has everyone on edge. First social roll is Desperate.
2. **Generous:** A caravan arrived with news of a rival’s misfortune. Hospitality is warm. +1 Position on all social rolls.
3. **Feuding:** Two families are arguing over a bridge toll. The king is distracted. Social rolls gain +1 DV.
4. **Secretive:** The Archivolt has been sealed. No one will explain why. Insight rolls are at +1 die, but lies are harder to detect.
5. **Desperate:** The Ykrul have closed the eastern passes. The king needs allies. Social Position starts at Dominant — but the obligation will be steep.
6. **Hollow-Watched:** The Foedus Stone’s newest crack has grown. The king speaks in eights. The ninth word is silence. The Hollow is listening.

Adventure Seeds

1. **The Crack That Walked.** The Foedus Stone’s newest crack appears to have moved. The Contarini blame the Morosini. The Morosini blame the Dandolo. The party must measure the

crack — and discover that it is not a crack at all. It is a door.

2. **The Archivolt Fire.** Someone has set fire to the Archivolt’s oldest wing. The seal-keeper is dead. The only surviving document is a charter granting rights to a canal that no longer exists — but the canal’s ghost is now flooding the lower cantons.
3. **The Queen’s Agent.** The Queen of Marches hires the party to deliver a sealed letter to a Tulkani caravan judge. The letter is a knot — a promise to pay a debt owed by a Federate King who died forty years ago. The Hollow is collecting.
4. **The Hostage’s Return.** A Ykrul hostage string has been returned — cut. The hostage was the Federate King’s nephew. The Ykrul claim he escaped. The Vilikari claim he was murdered. The party must find the truth before the passes close for winter.

The Hollow and the Ninth Crack

In Vilikari lore, the Hollow is not a monster. It is the **interest** on a promise that was never spoken. The Foedus Stone has eight visible cracks. The ninth crack is the one that appears when a Vilikari breaks an oath sworn under the oak and the marble together. No one has seen the ninth crack in living memory. The elders say that when it appears, the stone will split — and the Vilikari will have to choose which law to keep.

The Vilikari do not speak of the ninth crack. They count to eight and stop.

14.19 Other Regions (Brief)

For completeness, these areas appear in the full setting but are less central to the core game. Ask your GM if your character may hail from one of them.

- **Dungeon** – “**Living Infrastructure**” – Mythic underworld, survival horror.
- **The Ways Between** – “**Spiritways & Veilways**” – Liminal paths, dream-logic.
- **The Wilds** – “**Roads, Ruins, and Weather**” – A reskin palette for any terrain.

14.20 Peoples of Fate’s Edge — Detailed Mechanics

The following sections provide the mechanical traits (attribute adjustments, skill bonuses, cultural talents, Strings, sample Bonds, and sample Complications) for the major ancestries of the Amaranthine. Use these during character creation to bring your character’s heritage to life.

14.20.1 Small Folk of the Threshold

The Aelaerem (halflings) and Aelinnel (gnomes) are diminutive peoples attuned to liminal spaces – doorways, hedge-gaps, tide-cut stairs, and the quiet places between hearth and hollow.

14.20.1.0.1 Restriction: Cannot use Heavy Armor. May use any one-handed or two-handed weapon, but Heavy Weapons impose **–1 Position** on all actions while wielding them (before any other Position modifiers).

14.20.1.0.2 Bonus: When wielding a **spear, quarterstaff, or light polearm** (any Medium or Light weapon with the **Reach** tag), treat the weapon as **one weight class lighter** for the purpose of attack modifiers. Additionally, once per scene when you make a melee attack with such a weapon, you may spend **1 Boon** to convert a *Partial* success into a *Clean Success* (representing a clever thrust that uses the enemy’s momentum against them).

14.20.1.1 Aelaerem — The Hearth’s Luck

Bonus — **Once per scene**, you may improve your **Position by one step** (e.g., Desperate → Controlled, Controlled → Dominant) as a free action **before** rolling an action. This represents a flash of luck, a well-timed sidestep, or an unexpected opening.

From the Hearth Cycle

“The Aelaerem say that a door left unlatched is an invitation to the Hollow. But sometimes, an unlatched door is just an escape.” Use your luck wisely. The Hollow is patient.

14.20.1.2 Aelinnel — The Bright Trick

Choose **one** of the following abilities:

Option A: Short Step (Teleport)

Bonus — **Once per scene**, as a **Move action**, you may instantly teleport to any location you can see within **Near** range that is not currently observed by any enemy. You cannot pass through solid barriers. This is a fey-like blink, not a physical jump.

Option B: Knack for the Right Thing (Handy Item)

Bonus — **Once per scene**, you may declare that you have a **small, mundane item** on your person that is useful in the current situation (e.g., a coil of rope, a lockpick, a candle, a chalk stick). This costs no Boon and requires no roll. The item must be plausible for your character to carry.

A Gnomish Maxim

“Count the steps in odd numbers. Even is for the dead. ... Wait, did I say odd? Let me check my abacus.” Aelinnel never trust a single account. Neither should you.

14.20.2 Aeler — People of Stone and Breath (Dwarves)

“The mountain does not forget a misplaced keystone. It waits – then settles the weight.”

Aeler at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Body +1, Spirit +1, Presence –1

Skill Bonuses: Craft +1, Endurance +1, Mechanics +1

Signature Talents: *Spirit Shield* • *Keystone Bond*

Strings: Charter-Stamped, Stone-Speech Initiate

14.20.2.0.1 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Stone-Sense (2 XP):** Passive. +1 die to detect flaws in stone, hidden passages, or structural weaknesses underground.
- **Breath-Counter (2 XP):** Active, once per scene. When in a sealed space, reduce Fatigue from lack of air by 1 level.
- **Oath-Cord (3 XP):** Active, once per session. Tie a cord to bind a simple promise; breaking it costs the violator 1 SB (Hearts).

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Spirit Shield (6 XP):** Passive. When you Defend, you may convert the first Harm 1 you would take into Fatigue (minimum 1 Fatigue). *Requires: Spirit 3+.*
- **Keystone Bond (4 XP):** Passive. You have a feel for the hidden stresses in stone and structure. Once per session, you may declare a load-bearing wall, a weak floor, or a hidden support beam in any worked stone environment.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Forge-Patriarch (10 XP):** Active, once per campaign. Establish a **forge-citadel** (Major Asset) and gain a loyal cadre of smiths and engineers (Cap 3 followers). This requires a season of downtime and significant resources.

14.20.2.0.2 Sample Bonds

- “I owe my life to the Vault-Queen’s wardens.”
- “My clan’s keystone is lost – I must find it before the mountain settles.”

14.20.2.0.3 Sample Complications

- A sealed hold refuses you entry.
- A rival clan claims your keystone.
- A White Flood drowns your route.

14.20.3 Aelinnel — People of Sums, Bough, and Bright Things (Gnomes)

“Count the steps in odd numbers. Even is for the dead.”

Aelinnel at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Wits +1, Spirit +1, Body −1

Skill Bonuses: Investigation +1, Lore +1, Mechanics +1

Signature Talents: *Oath-Carver* • *Green Gate Key*

Strings: Hall-Stamped, Tide-Path Known

14.20.3.0.1 Cultural Talents *Note: The Short Step and Knack for the Right Thing are part of the Small Folk racial package (see above), not purchased talents.*

Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Counting Etiquette (2 XP):** Passive. Once per scene, when you carefully count (steps, breaths, beads), you may shift Position +1 for a single action requiring rhythm or precision.
- **Copper over Iron (2 XP):** Passive. When you visibly favor copper or brass tools over iron in fae-facing scenes, you gain +1 die on Courtesy or Bargain rolls.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Oath-Carver (4 XP):** Active. Set a promise in quartz (a visible physical token). The target gains +1 die to keep the promise; breaking it costs 1 SB (Spades). You may maintain one quartz oath at a time.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Green Gate Key (8 XP):** Passive. Once per journey, you may declare a hidden tide-path or stone-door that halves a travel leg (reduce Travel Timer by half its segments). The GM gains 1 SB as the path demands a small toll (a memory, a name).

14.20.3.0.2 Sample Bonds

- “A Thorn Courtier saved me from a geas – now I owe them a favor.”
- “My grandmother taught me the ninth silence.”

14.20.3.0.3 Sample Complications

- A geas catches you in a careless word.
- The Green Gate opens at the wrong hour.
- A Thorn Court summons you.

14.20.4 Aelaerem — People of Hearth & Hollow (Halflings)

“A door left unlatched is an invitation to the Hollow. But sometimes, an unlatched door is just an escape.”

Aelaerem at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Wits +1, Presence +1, Body –1

Skill Bonuses: Survival +1, Sway +1, Stealth +1

Signature Talents: *Barrow-Wise* • *Pale Shepherd's Grace*

Strings: Red-Thread Guest, Barrow-Friend

14.20.4.0.1 Cultural Talents *Note: The Hearth's Luck ability is part of the Small Folk racial package (see above), not a purchased talent.*

Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Red Thread (2 XP):** Active, once per session. Tie a red thread on a door or bridge; the next person who crosses must pass a Resolve test (DV 2) or forget why they entered.
- **Cup-Mark (3 XP):** Active. Leave a cup-mark on a stone; when you return before dawn, you may ignore one minor social complication (e.g., a suspicious guard).

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Barrow-Wise (4 XP):** Passive. +1 die to Lore about the Neighbors, the Hollow, or ancient barrows. Once per session, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a supernatural threat in the current scene.
- **Mummers' Mask (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. Don a mask and adopt a role; for the next exchange, you may use *Presence + Performance* in place of any social skill.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Pale Shepherd's Grace (8 XP):** Passive. When you would take Harm, you may instead mark that amount as Fatigue. If you do, the GM gains 1 SB (Hearts) – the Hollow watches you. *Requires: Spirit 3+.*

14.20.4.0.2 Sample Bonds

- “The Apple-Matron saved my family from famine – I owe her a harvest.”
- “The Pale Shepherd walked past me once. I still don't know why.”

14.20.4.0.3 Sample Complications

- You pour the ninth cup; the Hollow answers.
- A mummers' mask sticks to your face.

14.20.5 The Lethai — Root, River, & Roof-Tree / Mind's Eye & Civic Measure

“Two paths, one blood – the Sundered Kin.”

14.20.5.1 Lethai-al (Wood Elves)

Wood Elf at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Body +1, Wits +1, Presence –1

Skill Bonuses: Survival +1, Stealth +1, Nature +1

Signature Talents: *Root-Law* • *Green Ward*

Strings: Root-Oath Bound, Tree-Friend

14.20.5.1.1 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Root-Law (2 XP):** Passive. +1 die to negotiate treaties or oaths that involve land, forest, or seasonal cycles.
- **Tree-Speak (3 XP):** Active, once per scene. Commune with a single tree or plant; gain +2 dice on Investigation or Survival to understand events that happened near it.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Green Ward (4 XP):** Passive. When in forest terrain, you are always treated as having partial cover against ranged attacks.
- **Coppice Memory (6 XP):** Active, once per session. Perfectly recall a scent, sound, or footprint from up to a week ago. *Requires: Wits 3+.*

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Wild Speaker (10 XP):** Active, once per scene. Command a single animal or plant creature (Cap 2) to perform a simple action (flee, attack, block). The GM may award 1 SB if the command contradicts the creature's nature.

14.20.5.2 Lethai-thora (High Elves)

High Elf at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Wits +1, Spirit +1, Body –1

Skill Bonuses: Lore +1, Arcana +1, Investigation +1

Signature Talents: *Lorekeeper* • *Ways-Walker's Step*

Strings: Archive-Key, Debate-Sealed

14.20.5.2.1 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Lorekeeper (2 XP):** Passive. +1 die to recall historical or magical information. Once per session, you may ask the GM a yes/no question about a forgotten fact.
- **Weave Anchor (3 XP):** Passive. Reduce magical Backlash from a single 1 by one step (Minor → none, Major → Minor) once per scene.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Academic Immunity (4 XP):** Passive. When in a Thepyrgos library or university, you are treated as a *guest scholar* – guards will not arrest you without a writ from the Archon.
- **Mind Over Matter (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. Re-roll a failed Resolve or Lore test; you must accept the second roll.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Ways-Walker's Step (10 XP):** Passive. Once per arc, you may turn a complication from a ritual or magical research into a boon (e.g., a backlash reveals a secret path). The GM banks 2 SB.

14.20.5.3 Lethai-ar (Dark Elves — The Oathbound)

“Vows are blades. Wear them carefully.”

Dark Elf at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Wits +1, Presence +1, Spirit –1

Skill Bonuses: Subterfuge +1, Deception +1, Command +1

Signature Talents: *Serpent's Shed* • *Spider's Mercy*

Strings: Mask-Circle Known, Bound to a Threshold

14.20.5.3.1 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Mask-Right (2 XP):** Passive. When you wear a mask (even a simple half-mask), you gain +1 die to resist social pressure or intimidation.
- **Vow-Touch (3 XP):** Active, once per scene. Touch a person and whisper a short geas (“Speak only truth”); if they fail a Resolve test (DV 3), they suffer –1 die to resist that command for one exchange.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Serpent's Shed (4 XP):** Active, once per session. Mark 1 Fatigue to negate one ongoing Condition (Fear, Poison, Charm) – you “shed” it like a skin.
- **Spider's Mercy (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. When you Defend and successfully protect an ally, you may transfer 1 Harm from that ally to yourself (converted to Fatigue if you have Light armor or less).

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Oath-Eater (8 XP):** Active, once per campaign. Consume a broken oath (yours or another's) to regain 2 Boons and clear 2 Fatigue. The GM gains a permanent *Oath Debt* (1 SB per session) – a rival will collect.

14.20.5.3.2 Sample Bonds (all Lethai)

- “A Lethai-ar saved me from a wyrm – they demand a vow of silence in return.”

- “My family’s grove was poisoned; I carry an acorn from the mother tree.”

14.20.5.3.3 Sample Complications (all Lethai)

- You break a root-law.
- A Lethai-ar mask-circle demands your presence.
- A High Elf rival publishes a refutation of your thesis.

14.20.6 Ykrul — The People of the Violet Steppe (Orcs)

Note on Naming

“Orc” is a slur. The Ykrul are a proud people of the steppe; the word “orc” was coined by Utaran legions to dehumanize them. Wise travelers use *Ykrul* or *Steppe Folk*. Using “orc” in conversation with a Ykrul may be taken as a grave insult.

“The wind carries names. Ride straight, or you will be forgotten.”

Ykrul at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: Body +1, Spirit +1, Presence –1

Skill Bonuses: Riding +1, Survival +1, Command +1

Signature Talents: *Blood Memory* • *Kon'reh Intuition*

Strings: Wind-Knot Token, Banner Hospitality

14.20.6.0.1 Cultural Talents Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Blood Frenzy (2 XP):** Reactive. When you take Harm, you may gain +1 die on your next melee attack.
- **Hostage String (2 XP):** Active, once per session. Tie a cord to a willing ally; until the cord is cut, you may transfer 1 Fatigue from them to yourself as a free action.
- **Kon'reh Intuition (2 XP):** Passive. Once per session when assessing a tactical situation (chase, ambush, negotiation), you may ask the GM one yes/no question about exits, escape routes, or hidden angles.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Blood Memory (4 XP):** Passive. After a battle, you may gain +1 die on a single roll that mimics a foe's tactic (e.g., using a captured weapon). This lasts for the next scene.
- **Sky-Speaker's Whistle (6 XP):** Active, once per scene. Imitate a steppe omen (eagle cry, thunder boom). Enemies within Near must pass a Resolve test (DV 2) or lose their next minor action.

Prestige (7–10 XP)

- **Warglord (10 XP):** Active, once per campaign. Unite scattered warbands under a single banner. Gain a **War Host** (Major Asset) and a loyal cavalry unit (Cap 5 followers). Start *Logistics* and *Grudge* timers.

14.20.6.0.2 Sample Bonds

- “The Khagan's kin saved my life – I owe a foal each spring.”
- “My hostage string was cut; I must find the betrayer before the clan does.”

14.20.6.0.3 Sample Complications

- A white squall separates you from the herd.
- A rival clan demands a blood-price.
- The Sky-Speaker claims you owe a storm.

14.20.7 Humans — The Adaptable

“The elder folk have centuries to learn what we must grasp in decades. That is our blessing and our curse: we never stop reaching.”

Human at a Glance

Attribute Adjustments: None (use standard array)

Skill Bonuses: None

Signature Talent: *Endless Reach* (see below)

Strings: Wanderer's Knot, Debt of Kindness

14.20.7.0.1 Cultural Talent (Free) Endless Reach (Passive): Humans learn quickly and try things others would not dare. Once per scene, when you make a roll using a skill in which you have no ranks (skill level 0), you gain +1 die on that roll. Additionally, you may treat that roll as if you had 1 rank for the purpose of determining if you can attempt the action at all (e.g., you can attempt a Medicine check to stabilize someone even without training).

14.20.7.0.2 Background Options Humans come from every corner of the Amaranthine. Choose a regional background (e.g., Ecktorian, Vhasian, Viterran, Linn, etc.) to gain access to that region's cultural Strings and sample Bonds/Complications.

14.20.7.0.3 Sample Bonds

- “I was taken in by an Aeler smith after my caravan was destroyed. I owe them a forge's worth of work.”
- “A Ykrul rider spared my life on the steppe. I carry her banner token.”

14.20.7.0.4 Sample Complications

- You carry a debt from a failed venture; the creditor is patient but persistent.
- Your homeland is at war with a neighbouring region – old loyalties surface at the worst times.

14.20.8 Narethi — The Unburied of the Deep Desert

“The sun remembers what the sand forgets. We remember both. That is our curse. That is our strength.”

Deep in the Deep Desert, beyond the Fharan oases, dwell the Narethi — a felid people with tufted ears, slit-pupiled eyes, and fur ranging from pale cream to deep rust. They have no cities; they live in the **Sunken Courts**, subterranean chambers carved from ancient salt and basalt. Their society is hierarchical, secretive, and bound to a sleeping entity called the **Unburied** — a mummified First One whose dreams leak psionic resonance into the waking world.

All Narethi are touched by this resonance. Those who leave the Courts are called *unbound*, and they carry the echo of the Unburied's dream wherever they go.

Narethi at a Glance (Player Character)

Attribute Adjustments: Wits +1, Spirit +1, Body –1

Skill Bonuses: Psionics (or Arcana) +1, Stealth +1, Survival +1

Signature Talent: *Resonance Leash* (see below)

Strings: Salt-Kin, Unbound Witness

14.20.8.0.1 Narethi Traits (Automatic)

- **Natural Telepathy:** You may communicate wordlessly with any willing creature within Near range. This is emotion, image, and intent — not language.
- **Sunken Eyes:** You see in dim light as if it were bright. Darkness remains dark.
- **Resonance Sense:** Once per session, you may touch a surface (stone, salt, metal) and ask the GM one yes/no question about an event that occurred within Near range in the past day.

14.20.8.0.2 Resonance Leash (Mechanical Cost) The Unburied's dream does not let go easily. Each time you use a significant psionic ability (Telepathy to read deep memories, Clairvoyance to scry, Psychic Assault, etc.), you mark one segment on your **Resonance Leash** [4]. When the leash fills, you experience a waking vision of the **First Scouring** — a fragment of apocalyptic memory (a city of black glass, a sky on fire, a scream without end). You mark 1 Fatigue, and the leash resets.

14.20.8.0.3 Cultural Talents (Optional) Minor (2–3 XP)

- **Disciplined Mind (2 XP):** +1 die to resist psychic assault or mental intrusion.
- **Sand-Walker (2 XP):** Ignore the first level of environmental penalty from heat or sand.

Major (4–6 XP)

- **Dream Echo (4 XP):** Once per session, when you mark Fatigue from your Resonance Leash, you may instead convert that Fatigue into a **precognitive flash**: gain +1 die on your next action within the scene.

14.20.8.0.4 Sample Bonds

- “I left a childhood friend behind in the Sunken Courts. She swore she would never speak again.”
- “A Fhara well-judge saved me from dehydration; I carry his salt-pouch as a promise.”

14.20.8.0.5 Sample Complications

- The Unburied's dream is changing. You have begun to hear the ninth syllable in your sleep.
- A Watcher from the Courts has found you. They demand you return — or they will make you forgotten.

Player Takeaway

The Narethi are not a class — they are a story. Work with your GM to determine why you left the Sunken Courts, whether you still feel the Resonance, and what you remember of the Unburied's dream.

14.20.9 Mixed Heritage — Half-Elves, Half-Ykrul, Half-Others

“You walk two roads. Both watch you.”

Mixed Heritage at a Glance

Choose one +1 and one –1 from parent cultures

Choose two skill bonuses

Access both talent lists (subject to prerequisites)

Choose primary String

14.20.9.0.1 Attribute Adjustments: Choose **one** +1 from either parent culture, and **one** –1 from the other (or a standard +1, +1, –1 as determined with GM).

14.20.9.0.2 Skill Bonuses: Choose **two** skill bonuses from either parent culture (cannot take the same skill twice).

14.20.9.0.3 Cultural Talents: You may select from **both** parent cultures' talent lists, but you must meet any prerequisites (e.g., Spirit 3+ for some talents). You may not take mutually exclusive talents.

14.20.9.0.4 String Access: You have access to the **Strings** of both cultures, but you must choose one as your primary for purposes of social perception (e.g., a half-Aeler, half-Lethai might be *Charter-Stamped* but not *Root-Oath Bound* unless you prove yourself).

14.20.9.0.5 Sample Bonds

- “My father’s clan disowned me; my mother’s people took me in – I carry both names.”
- “I am the living treaty between two feuding houses.”

14.20.9.0.6 Sample Complications

- Neither culture fully trusts you.
- You are called to honor two conflicting oaths.
- A purist from one side challenges your right to claim their traditions.

Chapter 15

World Powers and Influence

15.1 Of Patrons, Runes, and Invokers

“You wish to walk the road of power? Then listen well. The world is old, and older still are the voices beneath it. We call them *Patrons*, though they were never sworn to us. They are the tides that move unseen, the keepers of forgotten bargains, the sleepers beneath the stone and the stars. To call upon them is to dip a hand into a river that has carved mountains.”

15.1.1 The Patrons

Patrons are vast intelligences—not gods, though some worship them as such. They are embodiments of *concepts* and *forces* rather than sovereigns. Each offers power, but always with cost: fatigue, scars upon fate, or a slow unweaving of one’s own story.

To entreat a Patron is to risk being marked. Their Rites are gifts and snares both.

Iconic Ascension: The Fate of Great Power

In Fate’s Edge, power has its price. When a being rises beyond mortal scale, its identity dissolves and reforms into something larger, older, and less free. This transformation is known as **Iconic Ascension**.

Icons are not individuals. They are *forces*—living embodiments of desires, patterns, and long-term agendas. Their power is immense, but their agency is small. An Icon cannot freely choose its actions; its nature compels it.

Icons cannot touch the world directly. Their presence is too vast, their will too diffuse. Instead, they act through intermediaries:

- **Chosen** who carry fragments of their purpose
- **Devotees** who interpret their omens
- **Agents** who benefit from their favor

Icons shape events not with hands, but through **boons**, **omens**, and **shifts in fate** granted to those who serve their desires—whether fleeting hungers or ancient ambitions woven into the world’s fabric.

To serve an Icon is to wield a living idea. Their gifts are potent, but their influence reshapes those who bear them. Their will echoes in mortal choices long after their voices fade.

15.1.2 Choosing a Patron

Not every Patron walks in every story. The following pages present a curated selection of powers. **You are not expected to read them all before creating a character.**

For a first character or a campaign that is just finding its feet, we recommend these **eight** Patrons. They are mechanically straightforward, thematically flexible, and welcome in almost any game:

- **Oath of Flame & Light** – vows, radiance, and righteous smiting. A classic paladin or cleric.
- **The Traveler** – roads, wayfinding, and safe passage. Low risk, high utility.
- **Inaea (Angel of the Spider)** – mercy, connection, and the threads that bind families and communities.
- **The Witness** – truth, memory, and uncomfortable revelations. Perfect for investigators or notaries.
- **Carrion King** – decay, renewal, and the wisdom of endings. Good for those who like cycles of death and rebirth.
- **Ikasha (She Who Sleeps)** – shadow, secrets, and latent potential. Ideal for rogues, spies, and those who walk unseen.
- **Grimmir (The Wild Speaker)** – seasons, sacrifice, and the old pact between field and forest. For druids, rangers, and those who respect the wild.
- **Palinode (Queen of Encores)** – performance, rapture, and the unfinished song. Perfect for bards, dancers, and anyone who lives for the encore.

If one of these speaks to you, stop here. Read its entry. Make your character. The other Patrons (in the Appendix) will still be waiting when you are ready for a second campaign.

Important: Your Game Master has the final say on which Patrons exist in their world. Some Patrons are tied to specific cultures or story arcs; others may be dormant, forgotten, or simply not part of the campaign. *Always clear your Patron choice with your GM before you write it on your sheet.*

Now, if you are determined to explore the full menagerie—or if your GM has already pointed you toward a particular power—read on. The road is long, and the old voices are patient.

15.1.3 The Carrion-King (Decay, Renewal & Transformation)

Lore. The Carrion-King is the master of endings that become beginnings. He does not destroy, but transforms—turning death into new life, decay into opportunity, and endings into fresh starts. His followers are harvesters of potential, seeing in every fall the seeds of future growth. The King has no will, only a hunger; no malice, only a rhythm. When something ends, he is there to turn it toward the next beginning. Those who serve him learn to read the slow geometry of rot, to hear the whisper of what is about to crumble, and to know that the most fertile ground is always the grave.

What crumbles feeds what grows. What dies becomes the soil of tomorrow's triumph. The King does not ask for sacrifice—he simply waits for it.

Domain Focus

- **Endings as Seeds:** extracting value from loss, failure, and death
- **Decay as Process:** accelerating, redirecting, or reading natural decay
- **Transformation Cycles:** turning one thing into another through death and rebirth
- **Rot as Resource:** using decay to create advantage (cover, concealment, reagents)

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Carrion-King does not bind a living creature in the usual sense. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being that thrives on endings: a black beetle that feeds on rot and never dies, a pale grub that pupates into a moth only when a significant death occurs nearby, a crow with one white feather that knows where bodies are buried, or a small fox that appears only at dusk to lead the keeper to fresh carrion. This creature requires no food, but it must be allowed to scavenge or consume something that has died each week. If neglected, it becomes *Compromised* (it refuses to return, or returns with a token of a death the keeper could have prevented).

The **Codex** of the Carrion-King is never a fresh book. It may be a leather binding made from the hide of a creature that died of old age, a set of bone tablets etched with rot-runes, or a compost-stained journal whose pages crumble at the edges. Because the King's truths are written in decay, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week burying it in fertile soil (or exposing it to the elements), or the Rites stored there become faint (treat as *Compromised* until restored).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Carrion-King may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a promise of ending. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Survival* or *Craft* rolls involving organic materials, and the first time each scene the bearer would take a Condition from poison, disease, or rot, they may ignore it (the King accepts the decay elsewhere). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the scent of turned earth clings to them.

Rites of the Carrion-King

15.1.3.0.1 Rite of the Rotting Harvest (Basic, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [DECAY], [HARVEST], [BOOST]

Materials: Organic matter in early stages of decay, or the remains of a recently ended thing (burnt letter, wilted flower, shattered glass).

Technique Cost: 5 XP (Basic).

Effect: Accelerate natural decay to weaken or destroy an organic object (ropes, leather, wood), gaining **+2 Effect** on *Break/Sabotage* rolls against it. Alternatively, extract value from an ending: from a defeated enemy, gain **+1 die** on your next action; from a failed plan, reroll one **1** on your next roll; from a broken item, gain **1 Boon**.

Push It: Spread decay to similar materials in Close range, or harvest additional value from an ending; in either case, mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the rot becomes noticeable or mark **Fatigue 1** from dwelling on endings.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.3.0.2 Rite of the Fertile Death (Advanced, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [AREA], [HEAL], [TERRAIN]

Materials: Ashes, compost, or the remains of anything that once lived.

Technique Cost: 8 XP (Advanced).

Effect: Transform death into growth: choose one — create beneficial terrain (cover, concealment, or advantageous positioning) **OR** grant allies **+1 die** to healing or recovery rolls for the scene.

Push It: Both effects apply, but the transformation attracts unwanted attention (vermin, scavengers, or curious onlookers); mark **1 SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.3.0.3 Rite of the Borrowed Form (Advanced, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [SPIRIT], [BOOST]

Materials: A token from a deceased being (hair, nail, written name).

Technique Cost: 7 XP (Advanced).

Effect: Channel the essence of what was. Gain one skill die reflecting the deceased's expertise for one scene **OR** ask the GM one question about their knowledge or abilities.

Push It: The spirit's influence lingers — gain a permanent **+1 die** specialty (e.g., "Knowledge of the Dead Mason"), but suffer occasional possession-like effects at the GM's discretion.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.3.0.4 Rite of the Great Consumption (Master, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [DECAY], [AREA], [SUMMON], [TRANSFORM]

Materials: A significant amount of organic matter (corpse, fallen tree, collapsed building).

Technique Cost: 13 XP (Master).

Effect: Transform a large area through decay and renewal. Choose two of the following:

- Create difficult terrain that favors you and your allies.
- Summon a **Cap 3** swarm of scavengers as temporary allies for the scene.
- Generate valuable reagents worth **2 XP** (usable for crafting or barter).

Push It: All three effects occur, but start a 6-segment **Ecosystem Disruption** timer that will cause problems later.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

15.1.3.0.5 Rite of the Eternal Cycle (Master, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: The complete remains of something significant that has ended (a broken oath, a fallen kingdom's charter, a slain legendary beast).

Technique Cost: 14 XP (Master).

Effect: Complete a transformation cycle. Destroy one major asset, enemy, or obstacle, and create something new of equal or greater value. The player and GM collaborate to define the transformation (e.g., a burned forest becomes fertile soil; a broken alliance becomes a new pact; a defeated warlord's corpse becomes a guardian tree).

Push It: The transformation is immediate and spectacular, but creates a 6-segment **Cycle Debt** timer. The King will demand another significant ending soon.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Carrion-King

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Carrion-King sings the *dirge of transformation* — melodies that begin in mourning and end in fertile silence. Their voice carries the scent of turned earth and the weight of things laid to rest. They are called to funerals, to the edges of battlefields, and to compost heaps where the old year is buried. A Cantor of the King does not seek applause; they seek the moment when grief becomes acceptance, and acceptance becomes growth.

The Cult of the Compost-Circle. The King's cults are not secret, but they are overlooked — gardeners, gravediggers, bone-setters, and midwives who have seen too many births and deaths to fear the space between. Their rituals are practical: the annual turning of the village burial mound, the blessing of a new compost heap, the singing of a child into the world while its grandmother is sung out. The Compost-Circle keeps no written creed, only a shared understanding: "*Nothing is wasted. Not tears, not bones, not the silence after a name is spoken.*"

Witchcraft of the Carrion-King (Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Carrion-King is a *rot-warden*, a keeper of the slow alchemy that turns decay into soil. Their magic is patient, overlooked, and often performed in the half-light of a root cellar or a fog-bound cemetery.

The Witch's Tool: The Bone-Needle. A needle carved from the long-bone of a creature that died of old age. It can stitch wounds that will not heal, but more often it is used to "sew shut" a corpse's mouth, ensuring the dead do not speak of things they saw in the dark. Once per session, touching the needle to a threshold (a door, a grave marker, a coffin lid) seals it against spirits for a scene.

A Hedge Gift: Turn the Soil (Basic, 2 XP). Once per scene, you may touch a patch of fertile ground (or a pile of compost, a flowerpot, a grave) and immediately know which plant or creature will thrive there next season, or what was buried there last. The GM must answer one factual question about the site's recent natural history. **Technique Cost:** 2 XP (Basic).

Carrion-King's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Carrion's Insight: +1 die to Notice decay or hidden weaknesses in structures or beings.	Must inspect decay first-hand; suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to fresh death or rot.
2	Deathward Sense: Once per session, detect the last living moment of a dead being within Close range.	Cannot lie about death you have witnessed; must correct falsehoods.
3	Rotblood Resilience: +1 die to resist disease and poison.	Immune system adapts slowly; each new disease/poison requires 1 Fatigue to resist.
4	Glean from Grief: Once per scene, gain +1 die after witnessing a significant loss or defeat.	Compelled to linger at scenes of death; must spend one beat observing or risk 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Cycle's Whisper: You can sense the “next ending” in any process — ask the Keeper one question about how a situation will collapse or conclude.	Must speak the truth about what you see, even if it harms your position.
6+	Eternal Bloom: Once per session, declare a “death that births life.” Sacrifice an asset or ally to create something new of equal or greater value.	Mark +2 Obligation when using this power.

Playstyle Notes

The Carrion-King rewards patience and opportunism. His servants are not grim reapers but gardeners of the inevitable. They know when to let something die and when to accelerate the process. The King does not demand — he merely waits. But when a follower hesitates to let go of a failing plan, a dying ally, or a crumbling empire, the King's silence becomes heavy. Intrusions often take the form of omens (a black bloom on a wound, a sudden stench of compost) or demands to “clear the rot” — to end something so that something new may begin.

Emphasizes

- **Endings as Resources:** failure, loss, and death are not punishments but opportunities
- **Cyclical Logic:** every death fertilizes a birth; every collapse clears ground for new growth
- **Decay Reading:** sensing structural weaknesses, moral decay, or coming collapse
- **Transformation Craft:** turning a corpse into a crop, a failure into insight, a broken oath into fertile soil

15.1.4 Grimmer, the Old Man of the Forest (Primal Mystery & Seasonal Sacrifice)

Lore. Grimmer is the Old Man of the Forest, the presence that watches from the shadow of the oldest oak, the cold breath on the back of the neck when the path grows dark. He is not kind, nor is he cruel – he is *wild*, and the wild does not negotiate. It demands, and it takes. His followers learn to read the language of blood on snow, the geometry of root and stone, and the weight of a heart offered at the turning of the year. Grimmer does not teach harmony; he teaches respect through fear, and fear through sacrifice.

Those who walk his path become keepers of the old ways: druids who know when a grove must be fed, rangers who leave the first kill for the soil, and hedge-folk who whisper the names of spirits not to be spoken aloud. Their magic is not the gentle coaxing of garden plants but the raw, patient hunger of the forest floor – a hunger that swallows bones and grows mushrooms in the shape of the dead.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Grimmer is called by many names. In Aeler, he is the *Root-Father*, a patron of deep fungus and stone-lichen whose shrines are carved into living rock. In Ykrul, he is the *Sky-Wolf*, a spirit of the steppe who herds the seasons and grants omens. In Aelaerem, he is the *Thorn-Father*, keeper of hedgerow magic, honored with red thread tied around roadside stones. Wherever the wild presses against the civilized, Grimmer waits.

“The forest does not ask. It takes. The deer does not weep for the wolf, and the wolf does not beg the earth. Give what the season demands, or the season will take it anyway.”

Domain Focus

- **Seasonal Sacrifice:** the old ways of blood and offering, the turning wheel that demands payment
- **Folk Horror:** the terror of the unseen, the ritual that must be performed, the boundary that must not be crossed
- **Primal Mystery:** knowledge hidden in root and stone, the language of omens and portents
- **Growth from Death:** the forest floor as a stomach; decay as the engine of new life

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Grimmer does not bind a familiar of hearth and home. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological creature of the wild wood: a pine marten with eyes like amber, a raven that knows the migration routes of every bird, a fox with a single white paw that leaves no prints in snow, a toad that hibernates in rotten logs and sings at the first thaw, or a stag-calf with antlers budding like spring shoots. This creature requires no food in the usual sense, but it must be allowed to roam freely in unspoiled nature each day. If confined for more than a day, it becomes *Compromised* (it scratches at doors, refuses to eat, and its coat grows dull; its bearer loses the benefit of *Seasonal Sense* until it is released).

The **Codex** of Grimmer is never a book of paper and ink. It may be a slab of slate carved with seasonal runes that frost over in winter, a bundle of bark scrolls sealed with pine resin, a set of knotted cords woven from the hair of a wild boar, or the hollowed horn of a stag filled with charcoal and ash. Because the wild resists being fixed in writing, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper

must spend an hour each week in a natural place, re-carving or re-knotting the Rites by memory, or the symbols fade (treat as Compromised until restored under open sky).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Grimmer may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of the season. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Survival* or *Stealth* rolls in natural terrain, and the first time each scene the bearer would be tracked by mundane means, the tracker suffers **-1 die** (the forest hides their trail). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the wild's claim on them deepens. (Technique cost: 0 XP – patron's gift, but see Obligation cost.)

Rites of Grimmer

15.1.4.0.1 Rite of the Blood Offering (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [SACRIFICE], [NATURE], [STEALTH]

Technique Cost: 4 XP (Basic)

Materials: A drop of your own blood (1 Fatigue) or the blood of a freshly killed animal.

Effect: The forest accepts your offering. For the remainder of the scene, you gain **+1 die** to all *Survival* and *Stealth* rolls in natural terrain. Additionally, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a threat hidden in the wilderness (e.g., "Is there a predator watching us?").

Push It: The offering is accepted with hunger – you gain **+2 dice** instead, but you must leave a visible token (a hair, a scrap of clothing) on the ground. That token can be used by the GM later as a sympathetic link (spend 1 SB to have an animal or spirit track you).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.4.0.2 Rite of the Speaking Roots (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [NATURE]

Technique Cost: 5 XP (Basic)

Materials: Soil from a grave or a crossroads, held in the mouth.

Effect: You listen to the memory of the land. Gain **+2 dice** to *Investigation* or *Lore* when seeking to understand what happened in a natural place – a death, a ritual, a violation of the wild. The GM must give you a truthful but cryptic answer.

Push It: The roots speak too clearly. You see a vision of the event, but it leaves you shaken: mark **Fatigue 1** and the GM gains **1 SB**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.4.0.3 Rite of the Twisted Path (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [CURSE], [TERRAIN], [FEAR]

Technique Cost: 7 XP (Basic)

Materials: A knotted cord woven from thorns and hair.

Effect: The forest bends against your enemies. Choose a single target within Near. For the remainder of the scene, all their navigation, tracking, and movement rolls suffer **-1 die** as roots trip them, branches block their way, and the path turns subtly wrong.

Push It: The curse also causes the target to suffer **1 Fatigue** as they struggle against the hostile woods. Mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the forest's malice becomes visible.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.4.0.4 Rite of the Heart's Meal (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [CONSUME], [HEAL], [BOOST], [FEAR]

Technique Cost: 9 XP (Advanced)

Materials: The fresh heart of an animal (or a sentient creature, if you dare), still warm.

Effect: You consume the heart raw. Gain one of the following:

- Heal **1 Harm** (the heart's vitality transfers to you).
- Gain a **+2 die** bonus on your next physical action (the heart's strength).
- Learn a secret the creature knew in life (GM discretion; the heart whispers as you eat).

After the rite, you are *marked* – animals within Near range are nervous around you (disadvantage on animal handling) for one scene.

Push It: Eat the heart of a thinking creature. The benefit is doubled, but you gain a *Hunger* Condition (must eat another heart within a month or suffer 1 Fatigue per week). The GM gains **2 SB**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.4.0.5 Rite of the World's Wound (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [HEAL], [AREA], [NATURE], [TERRAIN]

Technique Cost: 13 XP (Master)

Materials: A sacred grove-site, a circle of stones, an offering of blood or seed.

Effect: Heal a blighted place or quicken a damaged ecosystem. Clear taint, restore fertility, awaken dormant forces. Gain **+2 dice** to related *Survival/Nature* actions in the region. Start an **Ecosystem Restoration [8]** timer.

Push It: The cure spreads to adjacent areas but unbalances another; mark **2 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

15.1.4.0.6 Rite of the Cycle's Crown (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Self/Zone; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [NATURE], [BOOST], [PROTECT]

Technique Cost: 14 XP (Master)

Materials: A circlet of woven branches, antlers, and seasonal tokens.

Effect: Become an avatar of the cycle. Choose two:

- **Seasonal Mastery:** **+2 dice** to all actions keyed to the current season (spring: healing and growth; summer: strength and harvest; autumn: preservation and preparation; winter: endurance and hiding).
- **Verdant Command:** Command plant life in *Near* automatically.

- **Cycle's Healing:** Remove one Condition or downgrade Harm by one level.
- **Growth's Protection:** Allies gain **+1 Armor** from natural cover.

Begin a **Seasonal Avatar** [6] timer.

Push It: Extend the blessings to all present; mark **+2 Obligation** and gain **Seasonal Attunement** (see Corruption).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Grimmer

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Grimmer sings the *drone of green things* – a low, humming chant that mimics the vibration of leaves in wind or the deep thrum of growing roots. Their voice is used to coax reluctant seeds, to calm wounded animals, and to mark the turning of the seasons in rituals that entire villages attend. A Grimmer Cantor does not seek an audience; they sing to the land itself, and the land answers in fruit, rain, or silence.

The Cult of the Root-Moot. Grimmer's cults are neither secret nor organized – a “moot” may be a single hermit or a scattered network of rangers who meet only at the solstices. The most ancient of these, the *Root-Moot*, carves masks from living moss and wears them during the rite of the Turning Wheel. Each member plants a tooth (their own or a beast's) into the root-ball of a sacred oak; if the tooth sprouts a sapling by spring, the planter is considered “heard” by the Old Man. Their creed is carved into the oldest oak in each grove: “*Take only what the season gives. Give back what the season will need.*” Outsiders are welcome at the solstice fires, but they must work – splitting wood, digging a drainage trench, or feeding the fire with a personal memory (which the flames accept with a green flash).

Witchcraft of Grimmer (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Grimmer is a *hedgewright* or *path-keeper* – a crafter of living boundaries. Their work may be invisible: weaving a branch to guide deer away from a village, carving a marker that tells the frost when to end, or building a root bridge that only becomes passable at low tide. This craft can look like “infrastructure” – an Aeler True-Mason might carve a stone that remembers the boundary between a mine and a sacred spring, or a Linn shipwright might season a keel with a prayer for the right wind. But the witch's tools are never hammers; they are twine, moss, and the quiet patience of waiting for the land to answer.

The Witch's Tool: The Knotted Staff. A staff of petrified wood, cold to the touch but warm when it touches living matter. Once per session, when used to bless a boundary marker (a post, a stone, a tree) it inscribes a minor [SEASONAL] tag into the threshold. The marker will “remember” the season of its carving for one year, granting **+1 die** to rolls that honor that season's work.

A Hedge Gift: Knot of the Turning Year (2 XP). Once per scene, you may tie a simple knot (in a cord, a strand of hair, or a blade of grass) and speak a phrase appropriate to the current season. The knot subtly influences the weather or local plant growth for the next hour – a gust of wind, a sudden rain, or a patch of ivy that grows just enough to provide cover. The GM adjudicates effect. (Technique cost: 2 XP – Minor Hedge Gift.)

Grimmir's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Seasonal Sense: +1 die to predict weather, seasonal shifts, or natural events.	Cyclical Mood: –1 die to actions that defy the season (haste in winter, patience in spring).
2	Verdant Whisper: Once/scene, gain +2 dice when communing with nature.	Plant Speech: Under stress, you address plants before people; –1 die to civilized social rolls.
3	Growth's Touch: Once/session, accelerate natural healing or growth.	Seasonal Shift: Demeanor changes with the season; allies note unsettling variance.
4	Boundary Keeper: Once/scene, sense violations of wild places at <i>Far</i> .	Wild Intolerance: –1 die in dense urban/cultivated zones; physical discomfort in worked stone.
5	Cycle's Memory: Once/session, perfectly recall a natural event witnessed here.	Ecosystem Dependency: Without daily time in nature, suffer Fatigue 1 .
6+	Avatar of Seasons: Once/session, embody a season fully (+3 dice to seasonal actions).	Nature's Claim: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming bound to a specific biome. You may no longer eat cultivated food – only what you hunt, gather, or grow yourself.

Playstyle Notes

Grimmir rewards those who approach the wild with fear and respect, not dominion. His followers are not masters of nature but participants in its rituals – they know when to give blood, when to leave an offering, and when to simply bow and walk away. Intrusions often take the form of seasonal demands: a grove that must be fed before the first frost, a creature that must be hunted before it hunts you, or a vision of a ritual that must be performed at the next solstice. Refusal does not invite wrath – merely the withdrawal of the wild's protection, leaving the follower exposed to the very fears they once understood. Ideal for druids, rangers, and characters who understand that the forest is not a resource but a creditor.

Emphasizes

- **Seasonal Sacrifice:** the old ways of blood and offering
- **Folk Horror:** the terror of the unseen and the ritual that must be performed
- **Primal Mystery:** knowledge hidden in root and stone, omens and portents
- **Growth from Death:** decay as the engine of new life
- **Boundary Keeping:** guarding the threshold between the civilized and the wild

15.1.5 Ikasha, She Who Sleeps (Latent Potential & Shadow)

Lore. Ikasha is the hush between footfalls, the patience of dark water, the black-feathered watcher at every threshold. In stillness she gathers what might be, at crossroads she whispers of what may yet come. Ravens circle her, bearing secrets between worlds. Her followers learn to move unseen and speak unremembered, becoming shadows that slip between what is and what could be.

Ikasha does not act; she waits. She does not command; she suggests. Her power is not in force but in possibility – the hidden door, the forgotten name, the secret that, if spoken, would change everything. Those who serve her become keepers of thresholds, listeners at the edge of sleep, and witnesses to the shape of things not yet born. She is the patron of spies, dreamers, outcasts, and those who know that the darkest shadow is also the safest cloak.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Ikasha is called by many names. In the Mistlands, she is the *Bell-Shrouded*, whose unknotted rope holds the fog at bay. In Aeler, she is the *Deep Listener*, to whom miners whisper before descending into new shafts. In Zakov, she is the *Tide Watcher*, a smuggler’s patron who hides cargo from the Salt Prince’s collectors. Wherever a threshold is crossed and a secret is kept, Ikasha watches.

“Blow out the candle. If the room listens back, ask softly. At the next crossroads, the raven waits – and the shadow remembers your passing.”

Domain Focus

- **Latent Potential:** the power of what is not yet, the seed of action, the whisper before the scream
- **Shadow as Shelter:** concealment, secrets, and the spaces between notice
- **Thresholds of Change:** doors, crossroads, dreams, and the boundaries of sleep
- **Raven’s Witness:** omens, messages, and the weight of secrets shared

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Ikasha does not bind a familiar of sunlight and noise. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of shadow and stillness: a black cat with silver eyes that sees in perfect darkness, a gray mouse that nests in the walls of confessionals, a small owl whose feathers drink the light, a pale moth that appears only when a secret is spoken, or a raven chick with one white feather that knows the way to every crossroads. This creature requires no food, but it must spend at least an hour each day in absolute darkness (a closed drawer, a shuttered room). If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows restless and fidgets in light, imposing –1 die on all Stealth rolls for its bearer until appeased with a secret whispered in the dark).

The **Codex** of Ikasha is never a book read by lamplight. It may be a sheaf of blank pages that fill with whispered secrets only when the reader sleeps, a set of black silk ribbons knotted in patterns that change with the moon, or a slate that shows fading images of thresholds crossed. Because Ikasha’s truths are written in the unwitnessed, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week in a dark room, letting the Codex rest in shadow, or the Rites stored there become faint (treat as *Compromised* until re-darkened).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Ikasha may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of unlight. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Stealth* or *Deception* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be spotted by a mundane observer, they may reroll the opposed check (the shadow bends around them). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the darkness notes their debt.

Rites of Ikasha**15.1.5.0.1 Rite of the Unlit Candle (Low, 6 XP)**

Action; Self; Yes (Stealth).

Tags: [STEALTH], [DECEPTION], [SHADOW]

Materials: A candle snuffed with a whisper.

Effect: You step into the space between notices. Gain **+1 die** to a single *Stealth* or *Subterfuge* roll, and if you succeed, you may also declare one minor detail “forgotten” by any observer (e.g., “they don’t remember my face,” “they left the key in the lock”).

Push It: Extend the effect to one ally within Near, but your shadow lingers independently for a moment – the GM gains **1 SB (Diamonds)** as evidence remains.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.5.0.2 Rite of the Crossroads Raven (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [OMEN], [NAVIGATION], [SECRET]

Materials: Three black feathers scattered at a crossing.

Effect: A raven appears, visible only to you and your allies. It offers an omen: you may reroll one failed navigation, pursuit, or escape roll this scene, or force one enemy to hesitate (lose their next minor action).

Push It: The raven whispers a true secret about the current situation (the GM must answer one yes/no question truthfully). In return, it demands a secret from you – the GM gains **1 SB (Hearts)** to spend later as a complication involving that secret.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.5.0.3 Rite of the Umbral Reservoir (Standard, 8 XP)

Action; Self or Ally; No.

Tags: [SHADOW], [RESTORATION], [BOOST]

Materials: Water gathered on a moonless night, held in a black vessel.

Effect: Draw on deep reserves of patience and shadow. Choose one:

- Gain **+2 dice** on your next *Stealth*, *Deception*, or *Resolve* roll.
- Clear **1 Fatigue** from yourself or a touched ally.
- Gain one free success on an attempt to escape restraint or pursuit (no roll needed).

Push It: Apply two benefits instead of one, but you mark **+1 Obligation** and the GM gains **1 SB (Clubs)** as the shadow’s debt comes due.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.5.0.4 Rite of the Unlatched Secret (Standard, 9 XP)*Instant; Near; Yes.***Tags:** [SECRET], [TRUTH], [UNSEAL], [READ]**Materials:** A key that has never been used, bent in a circle, or a lock of hair / personal token / name written on black paper.**Effect:** Choose one of the following:

- **Unlatched Door:** Persuade a mundane threshold to open. One lock, seal, or barrier (door, chain, shutter, even a pursuer's grip) opens or loosens as if never secured. Does not work on magical wards.
- **Secret Keeper:** Compel a truthful answer to one direct question about a secret the target knows. They resist with Resolve (DV 4). On failure, they answer truthfully (cryptically permitted). On success, they suffer **1 Fatigue** from concealment.

Push It: If you chose *Unlatched Door*, you may also silence any noise the opening makes, but the threshold “remembers” you – the GM gains **1 SB (Spades)** for a later complication. If you chose *Secret Keeper*, you also learn a hidden emotion or related secret (GM's choice), but the target learns one of your secrets – the GM gains **1 SB (Hearts)** to reveal it later.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***15.1.5.0.5 Rite of the Umbral Dream (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self; No.***Tags:** [SHADOW], [DREAM], [FATE], [TRANSPORT], [INVISIBLE]**Materials:** Stand in absolute darkness or at a deserted crossroads at midnight; or burn a vivid dream written down.**Effect:** You become a living shadow or reach into latent potential. Choose one of the following:

- **Shadow Form:** For the scene, you are intangible to mundane harm, can pass through small gaps and thresholds, gain **+2 dice** to all *Stealth* rolls, and automatically succeed on one escape attempt. You cannot manipulate objects normally.
- **Whisper of Possibility:** Once before the next dawn, reroll any single roll after seeing the result (before outcome is declared). The GM gains **1 SB** as fate wavers.
- **Hidden Path:** You and allies bypass one major obstacle (guarded gate, collapsed bridge, social dead end) as if a secret way had always been there – the GM gains **1 SB** as the world adjusts.
- **Unspoken Name:** Learn the true name of one creature or place (GM discretion). That name can be used for future rites or bargains.

Push It: Apply two benefits instead of one. If you chose *Shadow Form*, you may also interact once with a locked or warded object while intangible, but your next defense roll is *Desperate*. In all cases, you mark **+2 Obligation** and the GM gains **2 SB** (the dream's echoes attract attention).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Ikasha

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Ikasha sings in *whispers* – melodies that are felt rather than heard, harmonies that slip beneath the threshold of attention. Their voice is used to hide a crowd's escape, to make a guard forget why they entered a room, or to pass a message through enemy lines without a single word being spoken aloud. Ikasha's Cantors are rarely recognized; they are the ones who hum absently while others plan rebellion.

The Cult of the Unlit Candle. Ikasha's cults are shadowy by necessity, meeting in basements, abandoned bell-towers, and fog-bound crossroads. They whisper freedom to the oppressed – escaped slaves, hunted heretics, debtors fleeing their creditors. A ritual of the Unlit Candle involves each member extinguishing a flame and speaking a secret wish for escape. The candles are never relit; the wish is carried away on ravens' wings. Their creed is never written, only passed from shadow to shadow: "*The dark does not confine – it conceals the road that the light would forbid.*" Outsiders who stumble into a meeting are offered a black feather and a choice: forget, or follow.

Witchcraft of Ikasha (Threshold / Shadow)

A witch who walks with Ikasha is a *threshold-keeper* or *shadow-weaver* – one who knows that a door left unlatched is not an invitation to theft, but to liberation. Their magic works in the gaps: the crack under a door, the moment between heartbeats, the pause between a guard's patrol. This craft can be invisible – a bent lock, a misplaced key, a shadow that moves of its own accord – or as grand as erasing a name from a pursuer's memory.

The Witch's Tool: The Raven's Quill. A quill carved from a raven's primary feather, dipped not in ink but in the absence of light. Once per session, when used to write a name on a threshold (a doorframe, a gatepost, a windowsill), that name becomes "forgotten" for a scene: the person whose name is written cannot be perceived by those who cross that threshold until they succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3). The quill can also erase a single word from a written document (it becomes a smudge of shadow).

A Hedge Gift: Unlatched (2 XP). Once per scene, you may declare a mundane lock, latch, or binding to be "unlatched" – it opens freely (or fails to close) as if it had never been secured. This works on doors, chains, shutters, and even a pursuer's grip, but not on magical wards.

Ikasha's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Shadow's Whisper: +1 die to <i>Deception</i> when lying in darkness or through intermediaries.	Truth Echoes: Occasionally speak in riddles or half-truths without realizing it.
2	Umbral Sight: Once per scene, gain +2 dice to <i>Notice</i> hidden threats or ambushes in dim light.	Light Sensitivity: –1 die to rolls requiring keen vision in bright conditions.
3	Raven's Memory: Never forget a secret told to you; recall any whispered conversation perfectly.	Secret Burden: Must keep one troubling secret per Tier; suffer 1 Fatigue when actively trying to forget.
4	Threshold Walker: Once per session, move through one locked door, sealed letter, or magical barrier without triggering wards.	Crossroads Bound: Must pause at literal or metaphorical crossroads to “listen” before major decisions.
5	Shadow Debt: Once per session, call in a favor from someone who owes you a secret – no questions asked.	Obligation Web: Every secret you learn creates a subtle tie to its keeper; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when ignoring these connections.
6+	Umbral Ascendancy: Once per session, become completely undetectable to all non-magical senses for one scene.	Reality Thinning: The boundary between what is and what could be grows thin – the GM may introduce subtle reality alterations around you.

Playstyle Notes

Ikasha rewards patience, subtlety, and the willingness to let things unfold. Her followers are not agents of action but of possibility – they open doors, plant secrets, and wait for the harvest. Intrusions often take the form of dreams showing a hidden danger, a raven appearing with a cryptic message, or a secret you thought buried resurfacing at the worst moment. Refusing an intrusion does not bring wrath – merely the withdrawal of Ikasha's favor: doors stay locked, shadows become just shadows, and the road ahead grows a little darker. Ideal for rogues, spies, and characters who understand that the greatest power is often the one that remains unseen.

Emphasizes

- **Latent Potential:** power as possibility, not force
- **Shadow as Shelter:** concealment, secrets, and the spaces between notice
- **Thresholds of Change:** doors, crossroads, dreams, and the boundaries of sleep
- **Raven's Witness:** omens, messages, and the weight of secrets shared

Shadow Monk (Ikasha)

Blow out the candle. If the room listens back, ask softly.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Unlit Candle or Cantor of Ikasha.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Shadows leave no mark on ledgers. Shadow monks gain **+1 die** to resist any magical debt, geas, or contract that would compel them to be seen, remembered, or witnessed. If they succeed, the creditor's records show only a blank space where their name should be – a gap the Hollow may one day fill.

Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Shadow Step (Basic, 6 XP)	Move from one patch of shadow to another within Near range without crossing the space between. You must be able to see both shadows.	1 Fatigue	Wits 3
Unlit Candle (Basic, 6 XP)	Step into the space between notices. Gain +1 die to a single Stealth or Subterfuge roll, and if you succeed, declare one minor detail “forgotten” by any observer.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Crossroads Raven (Basic, 5 XP)	A raven appears, visible only to you and your allies. Reroll one failed navigation, pursuit, or escape roll this scene, or force one enemy to lose their next minor action.	1 Fatigue	Wits 2
Unlatched Secret (Standard, 9 XP)	Persuade a mundane threshold to open (door, lock, even a pursuer’s grip). Does not work on magical wards.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Umbral Reservoir (Standard, 8 XP)	Draw on deep reserves of patience and shadow. Clear 1 Fatigue from yourself or a touched ally, or gain +2 dice on your next Stealth, Deception, or Resolve roll.	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Hidden Path (Standard, 10 XP)	You and allies bypass one major obstacle (guarded gate, collapsed bridge, social dead end) as if a secret way had always been there – the GM gains 1 SB as the world adjusts.	1 Boon	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 14 XP): *Shadow Form*. Once per session, become intangible to mundane harm for one scene: pass through small gaps, gain +2 dice to all Stealth rolls, and automatically succeed on one escape attempt. You cannot manipulate objects normally. After the scene, you collapse with Fatigue 2 and gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your shadow is faint, as if you borrowed it from someone else). You may ignore one forced

Obligation or debt call – the creditor sees only a silhouette that dissolves when touched.

15.1.6 Inaea, Angel of the Spider (Webs, Fate & Patient Predation)

Lore. Inaea sits in patient silence at the center of the unseen lattice. Where others see isolation, she sees threads—debt, affection, rivalry, loyalty—all binding mortals to one another. She is comforter and conspirator alike: the hearth-mother who eases grief with a warm hand, and the shadow-spinner who knots fates so they cannot slip free. Those who serve her learn to pull strands, tying allies closer and ensnaring foes until mercy or trap is inevitable.

The spider does not rush. It weaves, waits, and feels the tremor of every caught fly. So too does Inaea. Her mercy is never without cost; her kindness is a thread that, once accepted, can be pulled taut at a moment of her follower's choosing. To serve her is to understand that every bond is a leash, every promise a snare, and every act of compassion a line cast into the dark.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Inaea is the patron of hearth-keepers, matchmakers, and those who bind communities. In Aelaerem, she is the *Kettle-Spinner*, invoked by grandmothers to keep families together. In Silkstrand, she is the *Dyed Web*, honored by dyers' guilds who leave a single strand of silk outside their windows on the first of spring. Wherever threads are tied—in marriage, in treaty, in the quiet forgiveness of a debt—Inaea's influence is felt.

“The thread that comforts is the same that binds. The knot that saves is also the snare. What you accept from my hand, you give me leave to tighten.”

Domain Focus

- **Webs of Obligation:** debts, promises, favors, and the ties that bind
- **Patient Predation:** setting traps, waiting for the moment to strike
- **Unseen Connections:** sensing hidden relationships, leverage, and weakness
- **Mercy as Control:** healing and aid that leave lasting threads

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Inaea does not bind a familiar of claw and fang. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of threads and patience: a garden spider that weaves its web in the shape of the keeper's name, a tiny weaver bird that knots grass into intricate patterns, a small silk moth that leaves a trail of thread wherever it flies, or a gray field mouse that nests in bundles of twine. This creature requires no food, but it must be given a fresh length of thread, ribbon, or cloth to work with each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it tangles cords and knots laces at inopportune moments, imposing —1 die on all fine manipulation rolls for its bearer until offered a new thread).

The **Codex** of Inaea is never a book of ink and paper. It may be a frame loom with a half-finished weaving that records Rites as colored threads, a bundle of knotted cords that must be read by touch, or a wooden spindle wrapped with silk strands that sing when plucked. Because Inaea's truths are woven, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week adding a new row to the weaving (or untying and retying a knot), or the patterns become tangled (treat as *Compromised* until re-woven).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Inaea may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of binding. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 die to *Sway* or *Insight*

rolls when dealing with promises, debts, or relationships, and the first time each scene the bearer would be betrayed by an ally under a promise, they may sense it one exchange in advance (the thread pulls taut). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as a thread of connection tightens around them.

Rites of Inaea

15.1.6.0.1 Hearth-Thread Knot (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes (link once).

Tags: [BOND], [PROTECT], [HEAL]

Materials: A thread tied around a wrist or shared cup.

Effect: Bind yourself and one willing target (ally or neutral) with a sympathetic thread. Both gain **+1 die** to Aid each other this scene. Additionally, if either takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 (to a minimum of 0) by suffering that same Harm instead. This transfer is voluntary for an ally; for an unwilling target, you must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3) to force the link.

Push It: Extend to two allies; mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as your own lifeline strains.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 5 XP (Basic Technique)

15.1.6.0.2 Snaring Filament (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [TRAP], [AREA], [BIND]

Materials: A knotted cord or woven scrap.

Effect: Lay an invisible snare in a lane, doorway, or narrow passage. The first hostile creature to cross suffers **−2 dice** on their next action and must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 2) or lose their movement for that turn (tangled). The snare lasts for the scene or until triggered.

Push It: Lay a second snare elsewhere, but allies risk entanglement if they forget its location; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the web spreads thin.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 5 XP (Basic Technique)

15.1.6.0.3 Strand of Inevitability (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [BOND], [FATE], [MANIPULATION]

Materials: Three colored threads (white, black, red) braided together.

Effect: Link two actors (which can include yourself) with a visible or invisible strand. For the rest of the scene, whenever one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. You may trigger this linkage once to either:

- Force **1 SB (Hearts)** on the linked target after they perform a significant action.
- Gain **+2 dice** on a *Setup*, *Predict*, or *Manipulate* roll that exploits the link (e.g., “you cannot betray me without hurting your ally”).

The link is one-way or two-way as you choose.

Push It: Invert the direction of the link once after it is set (e.g., make the pursuer stumble instead of the pursued). Mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the weave resists.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 8 XP (Advanced Technique)

15.1.6.0.4 Weaver's Glance (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [SENSE],

Materials: Observe a spider finishing a web's radial line (or a convincing imitation).

Effect: Ask the GM one question about a hidden tie, debt, or leverage between two people, or between a person and a faction. The GM must answer truthfully. Your next *Manipulate*, *Pressure*, or *Intimidate* action exploiting that knowledge gains **+1 Effect**.

Push It: Reveal a secret tie that was not previously declared in the fiction (the GM must invent a plausible connection). Mark **Exposure +1** as your own entanglements surface.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 7 XP (Basic/Advanced borderline; treat as 7 XP)

15.1.6.0.5 Spinner's Debt (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [DEBT], [BOND], [COMMAND]

Materials: A silver coin and a strand of your own hair, knotted together.

Effect: Offer a willing creature a boon: they may immediately clear **1 Fatigue** or gain **+1 die** on their next roll. In return, they accept a **Promise Timer [4]** named "Debt to the Web." You may advance this timer by 1 segment at any time as a free action (once per scene). When the timer fills, you may demand a single service from them — not impossible, but significant (e.g., "speak for me at court," "reveal a secret," "take a blow meant for me"). Refusal causes them to suffer **Harm 1 (Stress)** and the timer resets.

Push It: Extend the offer to a group (up to three targets). Each who accepts gives you a separate Promise Timer. Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 9 XP (Advanced Technique)

15.1.6.0.6 Binding Knot (High, 11 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [FATE], [COMMAND]

Materials: A silk loop tied between two hands, then cut or knotted with a spoken vow.

Effect: Bind two parties (individuals or small groups) to a mutual oath. Breaking the vow forces **2 SB** on the violator and marks them with a subtle tell (a visible thread, a nervous twitch, a lingering scent) that persists for one week.

Push It: Widen the binding to up to four parties, each of whom may define one loophole. Exploiting a loophole causes **1 SB (Clubs)** as the web tightens around the exploiter.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

XP Cost: 11 XP (Advanced/Master borderline)

15.1.6.0.7 Merciful Severing (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [DISPEL], [MERCY], [DEBT]

Materials: A white thread burned to ash, spoken with a name.

Effect: Sever one harmful tie — a curse, a toxic obsession, a coercive bond, or a supernatural debt. Remove one Condition or **1 SB** tied to it. This is an act of genuine mercy; the target may be unwilling, but the thread can still be cut (Resolve test DV 4 to resist).

Push It: Sever a tie without the target's consent or knowledge; they will not know who cut them free, but you mark **+2 Obligation** as the web recoils against you, and the severed strand may attach to you instead (GM's discretion).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

XP Cost: 13 XP (Master Technique)

15.1.6.0.8 Web of Slumber (High, 12 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [SLEEP], [BIND], [FEAR]

Materials: A complete spider's web, stolen at dawn, and a lullaby hummed into it.

Effect: Weave an area of drowsy stillness. For the next hour, any creature entering the zone must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 4) or fall into a light trance, losing their next action and suffering **−1 die** to all perception rolls while inside. Allies you touch beforehand are immune. The web is invisible until triggered.

Push It: The trance becomes deeper — sleeping creatures cannot be woken by non-magical means for the duration. Mark **2 SB (Spades/Hearts)** as the web draws hungry attention.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

XP Cost: 12 XP (Master Technique)

Cantors & Cults of Inaea

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Inaea sings in *knots* — melodies that loop back on themselves, harmonies that tie two voices into one. Their voice is used to heal quarrels, to bind a community together after a tragedy, or to weave a subtle compulsion into a seemingly innocent lullaby. Inaea's Cantors are beloved at weddings, feared at treaty signings, and always watched by those who understand that a pretty tune can be a leash.

The Cult of the Woven Circle. Inaea's cults gather in domestic spaces — kitchens, weaving sheds, longhouses — and resemble extended families more than secret societies. A ritual of the Woven Circle involves each member tying a colored thread around their wrist, then passing the ends to their neighbors. The resulting web is then tightened, and a communal promise spoken. The cult's creed is embroidered onto a single cushion that passes from host to host: *"No thread stands alone. The weakest knot still holds the strongest weight."* Outsiders are welcome if they bring a thread and a truth. Betrayal of the circle is repaid by being unraveled — socially, financially, or worse.

Witchcraft of Inaea (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Inaea is a *web-weaver* or *knot-smith* — one who understands that every threshold (a door, a marriage, a treaty) is held together by invisible threads. Their magic works with domestic tools: a spinning wheel that twists fate, a loom that weaves obligations into cloth, or a pair of shears that cuts a single strand to end a feud. This craft can be as humble as tying a red

thread around a child's wrist for protection, or as grand as weaving a tapestry that records an entire bloodline's debts.

The Witch's Tool: The True Loom. A small, portable loom — no larger than a book — woven from hawthorn wood and strung with thread dyed in three colors (red for blood, white for truth, black for secret). Once per session, the witch may weave a single knot into a new or existing thread; that knot becomes a *promise timer* [4]. When the timer fills, the promise is either fulfilled or broken, as agreed at the time of weaving.

A Hedge Gift: Bind the Threshold (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tie a simple knot in a cord, ribbon, or strand of hair and place it on a threshold (a doorstep, a gate, a bridge). For the next hour, anyone crossing that threshold must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 2) if they intend to break an oath, tell a lie, or harm someone inside. The knot visibly tightens if a violation is attempted.

XP Cost: 2 XP (Minor hedge gift; not a full technique)

Inaea's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hearth-Blessed: +1 die to <i>Comfort</i> or <i>Aid</i> actions.	Must offer solace when asked, or mark 1 SB (Hearts) .
2	Web-Sense: Once/scene, sense hidden ties between two people (debt, rivalry, affection).	Empathic Overload: suffer 1 Fatigue when immersed in strong conflict.
3	Binding Presence: Once/session, compel a promise unless target passes Resolve DV 4.	Over-Attachment: –1 die when abandoning those you've aided or bound.
4	Fate's Pattern: +2 dice to predict alliances, betrayals, or bargains.	Manipulative Urge: mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when acting selflessly without agenda.
5	Spider's Mercy: Once/session, sever one harmful tie for yourself or another (as <i>Merciful Severing</i>).	Hunger for Threads: suffer 1 Fatigue if a session passes without weaving a new tie or extracting a promise.
6+	Weaver's Dominion: Once/session, declare all ties in a scene bend toward you; gain +2 dice on social manipulation.	Entanglement: Mark +2 Obligation ; those affected become subtly dependent on your will.

Playstyle Notes

Inaea rewards those who see relationships as both comfort and leverage. Her followers are not merely kind; they are patient, observant, and willing to let a debt ripen before collecting. Intrusions often take the form of a sudden obligation — a person you helped now demands help in return, a promise you thought forgotten tightens, or a web you spun catches someone you did not intend. Refusing an intrusion does not break the thread, but it frays it: the GM may mark a *Tangled Web* timer that, when filled, causes all your active promises and bonds to tighten at once, often at the worst moment. Ideal for healers, diplomats, and characters who understand that mercy is a thread that can be

pulled.

Emphasizes

- **Patient Predation:** setting threads and waiting for the right moment
- **Webs of Obligation:** debts, promises, and favors as both comfort and leash
- **Unseen Connections:** sensing hidden relationships and leverage
- **Mercy as Control:** healing and aid that leave lasting threads

15.1.7 Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn & Vows)

Lore. The Oath of Flame & Light is no patron of half-measures. Its fire names, binds, and burns — demanding that those who swear within its radiance stand openly, speak truly, and pay the cost of keeping their word. At dawn altars, the sworn kindle sparks of consecrated fire; in battle, they blaze as torches that hold back the night. To follow this Oath is to live in public truth, with no shadow to hide in and no retreat from the vow once spoken.

The Oath appears in many guises across cultures, and is the patron most commonly called upon by the magic-users of the Church of Flame and the Temple of Light — as well as any fire- or light-based faith or order:

- **The Everflame** — the unquenchable fire of promise, carried from shrine to shrine by wandering priests of the Church of Flame. Its censers never cool.
- **Adur**, the Light of Aeler — worshiped as the sun’s church-deity, whose flame consecrates oaths and consumes falsehood. Dwarven templars strike their oaths into stone with a brand.
- **Adar**, the Vili-kari Dawnfire — invoked as a war-god of vows and vengeance, whose rising light marks those who break faith. Cavalrymen light a single arrow before battle.
- **The Watchfire of Vhasia** — a saint’s flame that never gutters, tended by a silent order of healers who swear to harm no one — and to let no one die alone.
- Others know the Oath only as *the Flame* or *the Lantern*, a nameless fire that still demands truth and punishes betrayal.

Wherever it manifests, the Oath of Flame & Light remains the same unyielding power: to swear beneath its dawn is to bind one’s self to a truth that cannot be hidden, forgotten, or undone.

“Swear in the light. Keep it, or the light will keep *you*.”

Domain Focus

- **Sacred Vows:** oath-keeping, truth-speaking, binding promises
- **Divine Justice:** retribution, smiting evil, protecting the innocent
- **Radiant Power:** healing light, purification, revealing truth
- **Dawn’s Hope:** renewal, protection, driving back darkness

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Oath of Flame & Light does not bind a familiar of darkness or silence. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of dawn and radiance: a fire-colored salamander that basks on hot coals, a small brass-plated lizard whose scales warm when a vow is true, a golden-eyed owl that hoots only at sunrise, or a tiny phoenix fledgling that glows faintly in darkness. This creature requires no food, but it must be present when the Runekeeper renews their daily vows (a short prayer at dawn). If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (its glow flickers or goes out, imposing –1 die on all social rolls involving oaths or truth for its bearer until a new vow is sworn in its presence).

The **Codex** of the Oath is never a book of ink and paper. It may be a brass scroll etched with commandments that glow when read aloud, a set of consecrated candles whose flames spell out Rites, or a sun-stone carved with runes that only appear when touched by direct sunlight. Because the Oath’s truths are written in light, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour

each week in dawn light, re-reading each Rite aloud, or the engravings fade (treat as Compromised until re-consecrated at dawn).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Oath of Flame & Light may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or badge) and whisper a vow of protection. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Defend* or *Resist* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be forced to break a sworn oath by magical compulsion, they may ignore it (the flame burns through the coercion). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the flame's warmth lingers on their skin.

Rites of the Oath of Flame & Light

15.1.7.0.1 Rite of Kindle Vow (Basic, 4 XP)

Action; Self/Ally; Standard Push

Tags: [VOW], [RADIANT]

Materials: A glass ampoule of consecrated flame.

Effect: Declare a short vow for this scene (e.g., "protect the villagers," "speak only truth"). The bearer gains **+1 die** to actions fulfilling it.

Push It: The first hesitation forces **1 SB (Hearts)** on the bearer.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.7.0.2 Rite of Lay on Hands (Basic, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [HEAL], [PURIFY], [RADIANT]

Materials: A bare palm, a whispered vow.

Effect: Cleanse an affliction, downgrade Harm by 1, or remove 1 Fatigue. For curses or poisons, test Spirit+Resolve (DV set by fiction).

Push It: The target gains **+1 die** to their next Resist roll this scene; you mark Exposure +1.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.7.0.3 Rite of Sunlit Parley (Advanced, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [TRUTH], [COMMAND], [RADIANT]

Materials: A vow-ring engraved with sunrise.

Effect: Establish terms in open light. Honest persuasion gains **+1 die**; deceit suffers **-1 die**. Create a 6-segment *Parley Accord* timer.

Push It: Demand one public answer; evasion forces **1 SB (Hearts)** on the evader.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.7.0.4 Rite of Radiant Smite (Advanced, 9 XP)

Action; Self; Standard Push

Tags: [STRIKE], [ANNIHILATE], [RADIANT]

Materials: A consecrated spark on a weapon or badge.

Effect: Your next melee strike flares with dawnfire. Upgrade Effect by one step, add **+1 Burn** Harm, or **-1 die** to their next roll. Against undead, oath-breakers, or outsiders: oath-breakers suffer **+1 Harm and -1 die**, outsiders gain **+1 leash ticks**.

Push It: On a hit, the burst drives back enemies in Close (worse Position); mark **+1 Obligation**.
Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.7.0.5 Rite of Purge the Shadow (Advanced, 10 XP)

Instant; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [DISPEL], [REVEAL], [RADIANT]

Materials: A shattered consecrated spark.

Effect: Reveal illusions and suppress one ongoing glamour or curse in Near range. Creates a 4-segment *Purity's Light* timer.

Push It: Brand the source with a visible tell for this arc; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.7.0.6 Rite of Covenant Blaze (Master, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; High Push

Tags: [WARD], [FORCE], [RADIANT], [COMMAND]

Materials: A brazier lit while three names are spoken.

Effect: The sworn within are haloed: they gain **+1 die** to keep their oath; aggressors suffer **−1 die** if violating the terms. Oath-breakers suffer **2 SB (Hearts/Spades)** and Harm 1 (Burn).

Push It: Sanctify a threshold with one beat of [WARD] against oath-breakers; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Oath of Flame & Light

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Oath sings in *clarion tones* — melodies that sound like a trumpet at sunrise, like a bell calling the faithful to prayer. Their voice is used to swear in a witness, to consecrate a blade with a hymn, or to sing a funeral pyre into a beacon. The Oath's Cantors are often found in military camps and pilgrimage roads, their songs keeping oaths fresh and courage hot.

The Cult of the Unquenched Flame. The Oath's cults gather at dawn, in open courtyards or on hilltops facing east. The Unquenched Flame is a fellowship of paladins, healers, and simple folk who have sworn to keep one another honest. A ritual of the Cult involves each member speaking a vow aloud as the sun crests the horizon, then passing a lit candle to the next — the flame must not be allowed to go out until all have spoken. Their creed is written in charcoal above every hearth: "*The flame that reveals the truth also warms the hands that keep it.*" Outsiders are welcome to swear a temporary vow and share the light — but an oath sworn at dawn is binding until sunset.

Witchcraft of the Oath of Flame & Light (Monastic / Scholarly)

A witch who walks with the Oath is often a *consecrated scribe*, a *censer-bearer*, or a *vowed healer* — a nun, monk, or scholar of one of the great flame-temples. Their magic is inseparable from liturgy, prayer, and the careful tending of sacred spaces. They illuminate manuscripts with gold leaf that glows in the presence of lies, brew unguents from ashes of the everflame, and copy oath-books whose letters burn when a vow is broken. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "prayer keystone" into a basilica wall, so that every confession spoken there warms the stone. In Vhasia, a silent sister might stitch a healing shroud that records the wounds it has mended.

The Witch's Tool: Prayer Beads of the Unbroken Vow. A string of nine beads carved from

olive wood and fired in a basilica's censer. Each bead represents a clause of a sacred oath. Once per session, the witch may slip the beads around a door handle, a prisoner's wrist, or a contract scroll. While the beads remain, any creature that knowingly violates an oath sworn under that threshold suffers a mild burn (1 Fatigue) as the beads glow faintly. The beads may also be used to count a silent vow; the witch may reroll one failed Resolve roll when upholding that vow.

A Hedge Gift: Sealed Benediction (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may lay a hand on a willing creature's forehead and speak a short, formal blessing (e.g., "May the flame keep your word"). The target gains +1 die on their next roll to resist fear, despair, or magical coercion. The blessing lasts until the next dawn. The witch must write the blessing on a scrap of parchment and burn it; the smoke carries the prayer.

Oath of Flame & Light Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Oathbound Strength: +1 die when upholding vows or defending innocents.	Rigid Honor: Must uphold vows even when disadvantageous; –1 die to flexible actions.
2	Radiant Sight: Once/scene, +2 dice to detect lies or corruption.	Blinding Truth: –1 die to subtlety or deception attempts.
3	Holy Flame: +1 die to melee against undead, outsiders, or oath-breakers.	Burden of Light: 1 Fatigue when concealing identity or working in darkness.
4	Unwavering Resolve: Once/session, treat a failed Resolve/Command as success (mark 1 SB).	Absolutist Stance: –1 die in morally ambiguous situations.
5	Dawn's Benediction: Once/session, heal all allies in Near of 1 Fatigue and minor Conditions.	Beacon's Call: Your aura reveals you; enemies seeking you gain +1 die.
6+	Avatar of the Oath: Once/session, become a living covenant (+2 dice to protection/justice actions).	Radiance's Price: Mark +2 Obligation; breaking any vow inflicts Harm 2 (Burn).

Playstyle Notes

The Oath of Flame & Light excels as a "paladin" patron, rewarding vow-keeping and truth-speaking with potent defensive and smiting abilities. Followers become living embodiments of their oaths, shining beacons against deception and darkness. The corruption progression naturally leads toward becoming an uncompromising force for justice, though potentially at the cost of flexibility and subtlety. Ideal for characters who embody conviction, protection, and radiant power.

Emphasizes

- **Sacred Vows:** oath-keeping, truth-speaking, binding promises
- **Divine Justice:** retribution, smiting evil, protecting the innocent
- **Radiant Power:** healing light, purification, revealing truth
- **Dawn's Hope:** renewal, protection, driving back darkness

15.1.8 Palinode, Queen of Encores (Performance & Rapture)

Lore. Once a road-cantor who swore to reconcile feuding towns with procession and song, Palinode died between feasts with a chorus unfinished. Yet the refrain refused to end: it braided toasts, hymns, work-chants, and tavern rounds into a living current that still coils through markets and moots. Where a crowd leans forward and a maker holds breath, she arrives.

Signs. A cup that never quite empties; a candle that gutters only when silence reigns; a flawless bar or note that the hand cannot forget.

Cantor's Temptation. Palinode promises relief from solitude: an audience that always leans closer, a song that never dies, a bond that feels like family even if it devours you. Her rites grant the Cantor not only power but belonging — at the cost of their voice becoming more hers than their own.

“When she sang, the rafters bent to hear.”

“Drink deep: the cup returns, but never empty.”

“Encore is not request but command.”

Domain Focus

- **Ecstatic Performance:** music, dance, theater, and the rapture of creation
- **Unfinished Art:** the power of the incomplete, the encore that never ends
- **Audience Binding:** captivating crowds, turning spectators into participants
- **Inspired Craft:** works that transcend their maker's intention

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Palinode does not bind a living familiar. Their **Thiasos** is a *fragment of unfinished art*: a conductor's baton carved from a stage that was never completed, a silver bell that rings only when a performance is truly perfect, or a mask that holds the echo of a standing ovation. This object requires no food, but it must hear live applause or a sung note each day. If neglected for a week, the Thiasos becomes *Compromised* (its bell rings flat, imposing -1 die on all Performance rolls for its bearer).

The **Codex** of Palinode is never a simple book of Rites. It may be a script with the final page torn out, a score where the last bar is unwritten, or a collection of audience flowers pressed between blank leaves. Because Palinode's art is never finished, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week adding a new variation to a known Rite (a different instrument, a changed tempo), or the Rites stored there become stale (treat as *Compromised* until refreshed).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Palinode may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or instrument) and hum an unfinished cadence. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Performance* or *Sway* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would fail a Performance or social roll, they may reroll one die. After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the encore's echo lingers in their mind.

Rites of Palinode**15.1.8.0.1 Hymn Against Dread (Basic, 4 XP)***Scene; Near; Resist only.***Tags:** [FEAR], [COMMAND], [RADIANT]**Materials:** A lit taper or a bell.**Effect:** Begin a hymn or chant. Allies in Near gain **+2 dice** to resist *Fear* this scene. On a 10, they may ignore *Fear* entirely for one round.**Push It:** Allies who benefit also clear 1 Fatigue or 1 Complication point; you gain 1 Fatigue at the scene's end.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***15.1.8.0.2 Rite of the Single True Note (Basic, 5 XP)***Instant; Self; No.***Tags:** [PERFORMANCE], [BOOST], [BURDEN]**Materials:** A note held until your voice frays.**Effect:** For one scene you cannot produce an imperfect sound: all performance rolls **+2 dice**. All other rolls **-1 die** from intrusive perfection.**Push It:** Extend to one ally; both mark **Exposure +1**.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***15.1.8.0.3 Rite of the Hooked Chorus (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Near; No.***Tags:** [COMMAND], [READ], [FEAR]**Materials:** A melody braided from the listener's secret want.**Effect: Presence + Command vs. Resolve (DV 3).** Success: target joins in. Partial: they resist but suffer **-1 die** to social rolls this scene. Failure: they follow entranced.**Push It:** Affects all in Near; start **Compelled Audience [6]**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***15.1.8.0.4 Rite of the Binding Hands (Standard, 8 XP)***Scene; Self; No.***Tags:** [BIND], [FOCUS], [BOOST]**Materials:** Your hair woven into your instrument or tool.**Effect:** Enter ruthless focus: creative rolls **+2 dice**; ignore first 2 Fatigue from exertion. You are [BIND] to the piece until completion or ruin.**Push It:** One ally is also bound; both mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***15.1.8.0.5 Rite of the Consecrated Stage (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Zone; No.***Tags:** [WARD], [AREA], [BOOST], [SACRIFICE]**Materials:** A stage kissed with the blood of sworn singers.**Effect:** Hallow a venue. All performances **+2 dice**, **+1 Effect**. The space is [WARD]ed: any disruption spawns 2 SB. The ward collapses if the performance ends.

Push It: The stage sustains itself but drains life; start **Performance Hunger** [8].

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

15.1.8.0.6 Rite of the Crownpiece (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [SACRIFICE], [BOOST]

Materials: Your greatest work and regret, destroyed together.

Effect: Birth a transcendent masterpiece: +2 dice to creative rolls this session; immune to social manipulation. But all lesser works falter (mundane actions not directly related to the masterpiece suffer –1 die).

Push It: The piece wakes and demands; mark Harm 1 (Stress); start **Demanding Creation** [6].

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Palinode

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Palinode sings in *unfinished cadences* — melodies that never quite resolve, leaving the listener yearning for the next note. Their voice is used to keep a crowd enthralled, to make a performance unforgettable, or to bind a troupe together with a shared, unreachable ideal. Palinode’s Cantors are often found in touring companies, their songs changing slightly each night — because the perfect version is always just out of reach.

The Cult of the Gasping Chorus. Palinode’s cults meet in theaters after closing, in rehearsal rooms, or in the wings during a performance. The innermost circle, the *Gasping Chorus*, has a stranger practice: each member wears a small silver bell sewn into their throat, just under the skin; the bell rings only when they are about to tell a lie, and it tolls once when they speak a truth they have never shared. A ritual involves each member performing a fragment — a verse, a step, a gesture — and then passing the “unfinished” piece to the next person to complete. The cycle never ends, and the chorus breathes as one, gasping when a phrase is left unresolved. Their creed is written in the margins of a script that is constantly being rewritten: “*The art that is never finished is the art that never dies.*” Outsiders are welcome to watch, but they will be handed a prop or a note and expected to join — and those who stay for the entire ritual find that they can no longer whistle a tune they once knew by heart.

Witchcraft of Palinode (Lay / Performance)

A witch who walks with Palinode is an *instrument-smith* or *stage-weaver* — one who crafts the physical vessels of rapture: a violin that plays notes the player has not yet learned, a mask that shows the audience what they most desire to see, or a stage that remembers every performance and adds its echo to the next. Their tools are never hammers; they work with tuning forks, silk cords, and scraps of unfinished sheet music. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve an acoustic keystone, but a hedge-witch of Palinode might tune a theater’s resonance by humming a specific interval into its cornerstone until the stone hums back.

The Witch’s Tool: The Conductor’s Baton of Unfinished Phrases. A slender baton carved from the wood of a stage that was never completed, tipped with a silver bell that has no clapper. Once per session, the witch may raise the baton as if to begin a performance. For the next scene,

any willing ally who follows the baton's rhythm gains **+1 die** to Performance or Sway rolls, and any audience member who hears the baton's faint, bell-less ring feels a powerful urge to stay until the "final note" — which never comes. The baton can also be used to "cut off" a performance prematurely, forcing an encore (the performer must immediately reroll a failed Performance check, but the reroll is at -1 die).

A Hedge Gift: Encore's Whisper (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers and whisper a single word ("again," "more," "stay"). For the next minute, any willing performer (including the witch) may reroll one failed Performance or Sway roll, as the audience's desire for more bends reality slightly. The reroll is made at -1 die, and the audience will demand an encore at the end — the witch must perform again (or provide a suitable distraction) or mark 1 Fatigue.

Palinode's Corruption Table

Tier	Gift	Corruption
1	Perfect Pitch: +1 die to Performance.	Restless Ear: Distracted by any flaw; -1 die to non-performance focus.
2	Rapturous Presence: Once/scene, grant allies +1 die to social rolls.	Craves Applause: Suffer 1 Fatigue if ignored or without an audience.
3	Inspired Creation: +2 dice to one artistic act per scene.	Haunted by Drafts: Must obsessively rework; delays other actions.
4	Mesmerizing Performance: Once/session, captivate a crowd (Resolve DV 4 to resist).	Lost in the Moment: -1 die to awareness while performing.
5	Artistic Vision: Foresee the perfect form of a work; +2 dice to create it.	Consumed Spark: Must pursue inspiration immediately, no matter the cost.
6+	Queen of Encores: Once/session, create a legendary performance; all present +3 dice to social rolls.	Eternal Encore: Mark +3 Obligation; the performance demands endless repetition until sated.
		Voice of Palinode: Permanent condition — your words carry her power. Anyone who hears you speak must test Resolve (DV 3) to interrupt you or ignore a reasonable request. However, you cannot whisper; your quietest voice is still audible at Near range.

"Sing until the rafters lean to listen, dance until the ground forgets its name, perform until the boundary between art and reality dissolves entirely."

Playstyle Notes

Palinode rewards the performer who risks everything for a single, perfect moment. Her followers become masters of ecstatic art, binding audiences and themselves through the power of the unfinished. The corruption progression leads toward a voice that is no longer entirely their own — but one that

can command the hearts of all who hear it. Ideal for bards, dancers, actors, and any character who believes that art is worth dying for.

Emphasizes

- **Ecstatic Performance:** music, dance, theater, and the rapture of creation
- **Unfinished Art:** the power of the incomplete, the encore that never ends
- **Audience Binding:** captivating crowds, turning spectators into participants
- **Inspired Craft:** works that transcend their maker's intention
- **The Voice as Vessel:** the performer becomes the performance

15.1.9 The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)

Lore. The Traveler is the eternal guide of the road, guardian of those who walk the paths between what is and what might be. Among the Fhara caravans and Kuvani traders along the Way of Silk, the Traveler is invoked at every crossroads, honored with small offerings at each waypoint, and consulted before every major journey.

The Traveler is not merely one who shows the way — they *are* the way, existing in the pause between steps and in the choice of which path to take when roads fork. Every journey is both physical and spiritual; to move from one place to another is to transform, and the road itself becomes a teacher.

Across the known world, the Traveler wears many faces. In Kahfagia, the Traveler is the *Lantern-Bearer*, whose light guides ships through uncharted waters. In Ykrul, the Traveler is the *Hoof-Print*, the spirit of the steppe road that appears as a single arrowhead left at a crossroads. In Aeler, the Traveler is the *Ways-Stone*, carved into every mile marker by True-Masons to ensure the road remembers those who walk it. In the Mistlands, the Traveler is invoked with a single unknotted bell-rope — a sign that the fog may part for one who walks humbly. Wherever a traveler sets foot, the Traveler is already there, waiting to see which road they choose.

One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway. But break your word to the way,
and the way will break you.

Domain Focus

- **Wayfinding:** navigation, route-finding, safe passage
- **Journeys:** travel, pilgrimage, exploration
- **Thresholds of Movement:** doors, bridges, crossroads, borders
- **Road Covenants:** promises made on the road, hospitality to travelers

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Traveler binds a creature of the open road. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being that embodies movement and guidance: a gray hare that never tires, a sparrow that knows every shortcut, a small fox that leaves no tracks, a dung beetle that rolls its ball unerringly toward the nearest water, or a tiny brass compass that hums when the bearer is on the true path. This creature requires no food, but it must walk at least a mile each day (or be allowed to roam freely in a new place). If confined for more than a day, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows lethargic and its guidance becomes unreliable, imposing –1 die on all Navigation and Survival rolls for its bearer until it is exercised).

The **Codex** of the Traveler is never a stationary book. It may be a leather strap knotted with directions, a set of scrolls kept in different saddlebags, a map that redraws itself after each journey, or a pilgrim's diary whose blank pages fill with route descriptions as the bearer walks. Because the road resists being captured in ink, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week walking a new path and annotating it, or the Rites stored there become faded (treat as *Compromised* until updated).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Traveler may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or cloak) and whisper a waymark. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Navigation* or *Survival* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be slowed by difficult terrain or a bureaucratic delay, they may ignore it (the road opens for them). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the road's claim on them deepens.

Rites of the Traveler**15.1.9.0.1 Rite of Road-Sense (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [NAVIGATION], [AWARENESS]

Materials: A road-nail or waystone pebble.

Effect: Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far. Gain **+1 die** to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment *Path Memory* timer to ignore difficult terrain once.

Push It: Spot one hidden bypass, but generate **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.9.0.2 Rite of the Traveler's Boon (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self/Ally; No.

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [BOND], [HASTE]

Materials: Thread tied at the wrist.

Effect: Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy; **+1 Effect** to travel or escape checks. If shared, create a 2-segment *Shared Journey* bond with an ally.

Push It: Extend to one more ally; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.9.0.3 Rite of the Waymark (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [MARK], [GUIDANCE], [PASSAGE]

Materials: A chalk mark or small cairn.

Effect: Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment *Marked Path* timer.

Push It: The lane persists between scenes; the first enemy to exploit it forces **1 SB (Spades)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.9.0.4 Rite of the Bridge Between (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [TRANSPORT], [PASSAGE], [BOND]

Materials: Two pinches of road-dust clapped.

Effect: Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible or named route. Unwilling targets may resist (Body+Resolve DV 3). Create a 4-segment *Pathway Established* timer.

Push It: Carry one extra ally or bundle; arrivals are off-balance.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.9.0.5 Rite of the Crown of Crossings (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [MOVEMENT], [FEAR]

Materials: A brass compass missing its needle.

Effect: Call the Road: allies gain **+1 die** to move or evade; pursuers suffer **−1 die**. Once, declare “the long way is short” to finish a travel timer segment for free. Enemies must test (Wits+Command DV 4) or suffer **−1 die** to movement.

Push It: Seal a hostile route briefly; generate **2 SB (Clubs/Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

15.1.9.0.6 Rite of the Wayfarer’s Covenant (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [COMMAND], [BOND], [FEAR]

Materials: Waystones from multiple regions.

Effect: Bind present parties to safe passage. While honored: **+2 Effect** on travel, reroll one failed travel roll per scene. Breaking the oath inflicts Harm 1 (Fatigue) and marks the breaker as *Oathbreaker of the Road* (−2 dice to travel rolls).

Push It: Breaking the covenant inflicts Harm 2 (Stress) and attracts hostile Wayward spirits.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Traveler

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of the Traveler sings in *verses of the open road* — melodies that rise and fall like hills, harmonies that echo the creak of wagon wheels. Their voice is used to mark a crossroads with a sung sign, to calm a spooked pack animal, or to call a lost wanderer back to the path. The Traveler’s Cantors are often found in caravan camps, at pilgrimage shrines, and walking the roads alone, humming to keep the miles company.

The Cult of the Unbroken Way. The Traveler’s cults gather at forks, at bridges, and at the crests of passes — never in buildings. The Unbroken Way is a fellowship of guides, couriers, scouts, and those who have walked so far that the road has become their home. A ritual of the Cult involves each member placing a small stone at a crossroads, then walking a different way home than they came — the road must be honored with new steps. Their creed is scratched into a single waystone that travels from meeting to meeting: *“The road does not end. It only turns.”* Outsiders are welcome to walk a mile with the cult, but they must carry a stone from home and leave it at the next crossroads.

Witchcraft of the Traveler (Craft / Wayfinding)

A witch who walks with the Traveler is a *map-scribe* or *waystone-carver* — one who crafts the physical markers of the road: a compass that always points to a chosen destination, a map that

shows routes that appear only when needed, or a staff that never causes the bearer to trip. Their magic works through the materials of travel: a quill that draws paths that become real by morning, a chisel that carves a symbol into a stone so that travelers who touch it feel rested, or a needle that sews a patch into a cloak that keeps the wind from shifting direction. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “way keystone” into a bridge so that the bridge remembers every traveler and wishes them well. In Vhasia, a cartographer might illuminate a map with a prayer; the map will never show the route to an ambush.

The Witch’s Tool: The Way Chisel. A chisel of iron, its head struck with a simple arrow. Once per session, the witch may carve a “way mark” into a stone, a tree, or a wooden post. For the next day, anyone who sees the way mark gains a perfect sense of direction to the nearest safe harbor, village, or crossroads — but only while walking. The chisel can also be used to “erase” a false trail, removing tracks from a path as if they had never been made (one exchange of effort per use).

A Hedge Gift: Road-Worn Token (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a small stone, a coin, or a button that has been carried on a long journey. For the next hour, the token glows faintly when the bearer is on the correct path to their goal (as long as the goal is a physical location). The token does not reveal the path — only that the bearer has not (or has) strayed from it.

The Traveler’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Pathfinding Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and movement rolls in familiar territory.	Restless Spirit: Suffer 1 Fatigue when forced to remain stationary or in confined spaces for extended periods.
2	Wayfarer’s Luck: Once/scene, treat a failed travel or navigation roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Compulsive Wandering: Must take the less obvious path when choices present themselves; suffer –1 die when forced to follow direct routes.
3	Road Mastery: +2 dice to rolls involving travel, escape, or finding hidden paths.	Travel Dependency: –1 die to rolls requiring local knowledge or settlement-based skills.
4	Journey’s Blessing: Once/session, grant all allies within Near range +1 die to travel-related rolls for one scene.	Nomad’s Isolation: –1 die to social rolls involving long-term relationships or community ties.
5	Waypoint Sense: Once/session, instantly know the location and nature of all significant paths, routes, or crossroads within a day’s travel.	Directional Obsession: –1 die to rolls not involving movement, travel, or pathfinding; always aware of cardinal directions.
6+	Master of All Ways: Once/session, become one with the road network. For one scene, teleport between any known waypoints and grant +2 dice to all travel-related actions.	Eternal Journey: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; risk permanent Harm (Stress) from the endless call of the road, making settlement impossible until the journey’s end.

Playstyle Notes

The Traveler is the ideal patron for beginners and veterans alike — its rites are forgiving, its Obligation low, and its benefits immediately useful in almost any campaign. Followers become masters of navigation, escape, and the subtle art of being in the right place at the right time. The Traveler does not demand worship; it asks only that travelers respect the road and keep their bargains. Intrusions often take the form of a sudden fork in the path, a helpful stranger who knows too much, or a road that leads somewhere unexpected. Ideal for guides, couriers, scouts, pilgrims, and anyone who has ever felt the pull of the horizon.

Emphasizes

- **Wayfinding:** the art of never being lost
- **Road Covenants:** a promise made on the road is binding
- **Journey as Transformation:** the road changes the walker
- **Thresholds of Movement:** doors, bridges, borders, and the spaces between
- **Hospitality to Travelers:** the road gives, and the road expects

Way-Walker (The Traveler)

One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of Road-Sense or Cantor of The Traveler.

Debt-Resistant Frame. The road does not hold grudges; it simply turns. Way-Walker monks gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that would bind them to a single place or force them to stay still. If they succeed, the creditor's chains find only empty air — the monk is already a mile down the road.

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Way-Step (Basic, 5 XP)	Teleport to any unoccupied space you can see within Near range. You must have line of sight and an unobstructed path (the road folds, not breaks).	1 Fatigue	Wits 3
Road-Sense (Basic, 4 XP)	Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far. Gain +1 die to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment Path Memory timer.	1 Boon	Wits 2
Traveler's Boon (Basic, 5 XP)	Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucratic delay. +1 Effect to travel or escape checks.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 2
Waymark (Standard, 8 XP)	Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment Marked Path timer.	1 Boon	Tier II
Bridge Between (Standard, 7 XP)	Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible or named route. Unwilling targets resist with Body+Resolve (DV 3).	1 Fatigue + 1 Boon	Wits 3, Spirit 2
Crown of Crossings (Standard, 9 XP)	For one scene, allies gain +1 die to move or evade; pursuers suffer -1 die. Once, declare "the long way is short" to finish a travel timer segment for free.	1 Fatigue	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Master of All Ways.* Once per session, become one with the road network for one scene. Teleport between any two known waypoints (places you have visited and marked with a personal token — a pebble, a scratch on a door) within the same journey. You may also grant one ally the same teleport. After the scene, you gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your footprints face the wrong direction) but you may ignore one debt or obligation that would force you to stay — the road simply does not remember you were ever there.

15.1.10 The Witness (Truth & Revelation)

Lore. The Witness remembers what others bury. Every shadow cast and oath broken is a line in her unending ledger. She is the keeper of inconvenient truths, the patron of those who seek to expose lies or recover forgotten knowledge. Her followers learn that knowledge comes with a price — the weight of remembering what others would forget.

The Witness has no will, only a ledger; no mercy, only accuracy. She does not demand confessions, but she ensures that every lie leaves a stain, every secret a trace. Those who serve her become archivists of the uncomfortable, witnesses to the truths that others would kill to keep hidden. To walk her path is to accept that some truths are weapons, and that the truth-teller is never loved.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Witness is known by many names. In Ecktoria, she is the *Ink-Eye*, the Censor's clerk who copies every redacted line onto a private scroll. In Vhasia, she is the *Fractured Mirror*, prayed to by spies who seek to reveal a rival's true loyalty. In the Mistlands, she is the *Fog-Scribe*, whose name is whispered when a bell-line fails and the dead must be identified by their secrets. And in the shadows of every great city, there are those who follow the *Apocalyptic Witness* — a doomsaying cult that believes the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally spoken aloud, and who work to hasten that revelation by exposing every lie, no matter the cost.

I will show you what you would rather forget. But first, you must forget what you think you know.

Domain Focus

- **Truth Revelation:** exposing lies, uncovering secrets, forcing confessions
- **Memory Keeping:** preserving knowledge, recalling forgotten facts
- **Inconvenient Knowledge:** learning what others wish to hide
- **Prophetic Warning:** seeing the consequences of hidden truths
- **Burden of Witness:** the psychological weight of knowing too much

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Witness does not bind a familiar of flesh and comfort. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature that embodies memory and revelation: a raven that collects shiny objects and recites forgotten names, a silverfish that eats lies from parchment and leaves truth behind, a small brass beetle whose shell opens to reveal a perfect mirror, a white mouse that nests in archive drawers and remembers every page it has slept upon, or a cricket that chirps in the key of the last secret spoken nearby. This creature requires no food, but it must witness something *significant* (a lie told, a secret revealed, a confession made) each week. If neglected, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows silent and still, and its bearer loses +1 die on all Investigation rolls until it is shown a hidden truth).

The **Codex** of the Witness is never a book that can be closed. It may be a set of loose-leaf pages that reorganize themselves each dawn, a scroll that writes itself when no one is looking, a chalkboard that cannot be erased, or a stack of wax tablets that melt and reset each season. Because the Witness values accuracy over permanence, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week correcting a single error in its records (a misspelled name, a misdated event) or the Rites stored there become garbled (treat as *Compromised* until restored).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Witness may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or writing implement) and whisper a word of truth. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Insight* or *Investigation* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be deceived by an illusion or a lie, they may roll twice and take the better result. After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the weight of what they have seen presses upon their memory.

Rites of the Witness**15.1.10.0.1 Rite of the Lingering Trace (Low, 4 XP)**

Instant; Near; Yes (Investigation/Notice only).

Tags: [INVESTIGATION], [TRUTH]

Materials: A trace of the thing to be remembered (hair, dust, a spoken name).

Effect: You follow a hidden thread. Gain **+1 die** to investigate or notice something directly related to the trace within the current scene. Additionally, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about whether the trace is connected to a specific person, event, or object.

Push It: Gain **+2 dice** instead, but mark 1 segment on a **Memory Strain Timer** [4]. If the timer fills, you gain Fatigue 1 and suffer **–1 die** on Investigation/Notice rolls until the end of the next scene (the Witness taxes your mind).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.2 Rite of the Uncomfortable Question (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH]

Materials: A circle drawn with chalk or string while focusing on a specific person.

Effect: You force a moment of raw honesty. Ask one question of a target within the zone. They may either answer truthfully (the GM must give a true answer, though it may be cryptic) or mark **1 Fatigue** and gain a *Guilty Tell* Condition (**–1 die** to all social rolls until they confess the truth to someone).

Push It: The target must also reveal a surface emotion or a forgotten detail (GM's choice). Mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the Witness records the strain.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.3 Rite of the Echoing Truth (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [READ], [TRUTH], [FEAR]

Materials: A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) used to focus on the target.

Effect: The target must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or suffer **–1 die** to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer **1 SB (Hearts)** as the memory is forcibly drawn forth.

Push It: If the target fails their Resolve test, you may ask a second question, but the mental intrusion causes them **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.4 Rite of the Immutable Record (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [TRUTH]

Materials: A document signed by all parties within the zone, or a spoken pact witnessed by the caster.

Effect: Bind the agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers **1 SB (Hearts)** immediately and gains a persistent *Oathbreaker's Mark* Condition (–1 die on social rolls involving honor, trust, or oaths until amends are made or a significant act redeems them).

Push It: The bond becomes magically enforced for one specific, crucial clause: violation automatically inflicts **Harm 1 (Stress)** on the breaker in addition to the SB and Mark.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.5 Rite of the Shared Burden (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [DEBT], [READ]

Materials: A written secret (yours or another's) and a candle.

Effect: You transfer the weight of a truth. Choose one: you may remove a *Guilty Tell*, *Haunted*, or similar psychological Condition from yourself and give it to a willing or unwilling target (they resist with Resolve DV 4). Alternatively, you may share a secret with an ally; both of you clear 1 Fatigue as the burden is halved.

Push It: Transfer a Condition without the target's consent (they automatically resist, but on failure they gain it). Mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the secret stains them.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

15.1.10.0.6 Rite of the Unveiled Heart (High, 12 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [MANIPULATION], [FEAR], [TRUTH], [AREA]

Materials: A private setting where the target feels safe or is speaking freely.

Effect: The target suffers –2 dice to all attempts to conceal true emotions, intentions, or lies for the scene. Any successful social roll (Sway, Command, Deceit) made by the target generates **1 SB (Hearts)** as the effort to maintain falsehoods under the Witness's gaze creates internal discord.

Push It: You may designate one specific, complex question about the target's motivations, fears, or hidden loyalties. If you successfully use Sway or Insight against them this scene, you automatically learn the answer to that question. The intense scrutiny marks **1 SB (Spades)** for you as the Witness's attention lingers.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

15.1.10.0.7 Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP)*Scene; Zone; No.***Tags:** [AREA], [COMMAND], [TRUTH], [FEAR]**Materials:** A formally called gathering (court, council, family meeting) within the consecrated zone.**Effect:** All present must speak their greatest debt, wrongdoing, or hidden truth related to the gathering's purpose. Those who lie or withhold suffer **Harm 2 (Stress/Reputation)**. Truth-tellers gain **+2 dice** to social actions for the remainder of the scene within the zone.**Push It:** The truth becomes inescapable – even indirect lies or evasions related to the core topic suffer the Harm 2 penalty. The absolute nature of the revelation creates **2 SB (Diamonds)** as the disruption to fates and secrets resonates.**Invoke:** Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***Cantors & Cults of the Witness****The Cantor's Song.** A Cantor of the Witness sings in *truth-tolling* – clear, piercing melodies that cut through evasion, harmonies that make the hidden surface. Their voice is used to compel a confession, to sound an alarm that a secret is about to be spoken, or to sing a historical record into being, each note a word in a ledger. The Witness's Cantors are often found in courtrooms, in archive vaults, and at the bedsides of the dying, singing the last truth.**The Congregation of the Unmasking (Apocalyptic Cult).** The most feared of the Witness's cults, the Congregation of the Unmasking believes that the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally revealed – and that this ending is not a catastrophe but a liberation. They seek to expose every lie, every buried crime, every forgotten promise, no matter the cost. A ritual of the Congregation involves each member speaking aloud a truth they have kept secret, then burning a representation of the lie that concealed it. Their creed is painted on a scroll that is never fully unrolled: "*When all that is hidden is seen, the world will either break or be free. We will be there to witness which.*" Outsiders are not welcome; they are potential sources of truth – or obstacles to be unmasked. The Congregation has been known to destroy families, topple governments, and start wars in their pursuit of total revelation. They are loved by none and feared by all, but even their enemies cannot deny that they are right: some secrets truly are worth dying to expose.**Witchcraft of the Witness (Craft / Record)**A witch who walks with the Witness is a *ledger-scribe* or *seal-breaker* – one who crafts the tools of permanent record: a book that cannot be altered once written, a quill that writes in ink that fades only when the truth it records is fulfilled, or a press that stamps each page with a sigil of authenticity. Their magic works through the materials of documentation: a chisel that carves a truth into stone so that it cannot be erased, a needle that sews a confession into a garment so that the wearer cannot deny it, or a forge that tempers a door that can only be opened by someone who has never told a lie. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "witness stone" at a courthouse entrance, so that all testimony given within is remembered by the stone for a century. In Thepyrgos, a bookbinder might stitch a volume that screams if its pages are cut.**The Witch's Tool: The Quill of Unwritten Truths.** A quill carved from a raven's feather,

its nib dipped in ink made from lampblack and a drop of the witch's blood. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence on a piece of parchment, then seal it with a drop of wax. For the next day, anyone other than the witch who reads the sentence must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or forget it immediately after reading. The witch may also use the quill to "seal" a spoken secret, causing the speaker's voice to catch if they try to repeat it for the rest of the scene.

A Hedge Gift: Record of a Breath (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may hold a blank piece of parchment up to a person's lips as they speak. The parchment absorbs the spoken words, recording them exactly as they were said – including tone, hesitation, and any unconscious meaning. The parchment can be read by anyone (the words appear in the speaker's own handwriting), but it crumbles to dust after being read aloud. The witch may also use this ability to record the final words of the dying, preserving them for one day.

The Witness's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Truth's Sight: +1 die to Insight when detecting deception or hidden motives.	Burden of Knowledge: –1 die to social rolls involving lies or deception; others become uncomfortable with your piercing gaze.
2	Memory's Keeper: Once/scene, recall one specific detail from a previous scene with perfect clarity.	Compulsive Honesty: Must correct obvious falsehoods witnessed, even when tactically disadvantageous.
3	Revelation's Power: +2 dice to rolls involving exposing secrets, uncovering lies, or forcing confessions.	Truth-Blind: Suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to comforting lies or willful ignorance.
4	Witness's Authority: Once/session, force one target to make a Resolve test (DV 4) or reveal a significant hidden truth.	Isolation: –1 die to rolls requiring trust or close relationships; others fear your ability to uncover their secrets.
5	Omniscient Gaze: Once/session, see through all deceptions and lies for one exchange, gaining +3 dice to related actions.	Paranoia: –1 die to rolls involving personal peace or rest; the weight of all truths witnessed creates constant mental strain.
6+	Absolute Witness: Once/session, become the living embodiment of truth. For one scene, all deceptions within Near range automatically fail.	Truth's Prison: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; become unable to tolerate any form of deception, making normal social interaction nearly impossible.
		The Unmasking Beckons: The apocalyptic urge grows – you may be called to expose a truth that will destroy a community, a nation, or yourself.

Playstyle Notes

The Witness rewards curiosity, patience, and a willingness to bear uncomfortable knowledge. Her followers are not merely investigators but *archivists of the real* – they record what others would

erase. The Witness does not demand that you expose every secret; she simply ensures that you cannot forget the ones you learn. Intrusions often take the form of dreams showing a hidden crime, a sudden memory of a lie you told years ago, or the appearance of a scrap of parchment containing a truth you wish you had never read. High-Tier followers may find that secrets begin to *seek them out* – people confess unprompted, documents fall open to damning pages, and the world becomes a book that cannot be closed.

Emphasizes

- **Truth as Burden:** every secret known is a weight carried
- **Investigation as Ritual:** uncovering lies is a sacred act
- **Memory as Weapon:** forgetting can be as powerful as remembering
- **The Unmasking:** exposing a truth can be an act of mercy or destruction
- **Witness as Isolation:** those who know too much are seldom loved

Unmasked Fist (The Witness)

I will show you what you would rather forget.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Wits 2+, Rite of the Lingering Trace or Cantor of Witness.

Debt-Resistant Frame. The Witness records, but does not collect. Monks of the Witness gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that would force them to conceal the truth or perjure themselves. The creditor's ledger will show a blank where their name should be.

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Confession Blow (Basic, 5 XP)	On an unarmed hit, ask the GM one yes/no question about the target's hidden deed or recent lie. The GM must answer truthfully.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Lingering Trace (Basic, 4 XP)	Follow a hidden thread. Gain +1 die to investigate a specific trace within the current scene.	1 Fatigue	Wits 2
Uncomfortable Question (Low, 5 XP)	Force a target to answer one question truthfully (GM answer) or mark 1 Fatigue and gain a Guilty Tell (–1 die social rolls).	1 Boon	Presence 2
Immutable Record (Standard, 7 XP)	Bind an agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers 1 SB (Hearts) and gains an Oathbreaker's Mark (–1 die social rolls involving honor until amends).	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Shared Burden (Standard, 9 XP)	Transfer a psychological Condition (Guilty, Haunted) from yourself to a target (Resist DV 4) or share a secret with an ally to clear 1 Fatigue each.	1 Boon	Spirit 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Absolute Witness*. Once per session, become living truth for one scene: all deceptions within Near range automatically fail. You may demand a single truthful answer to one question from any creature, and they cannot refuse (no resistance roll). After the scene, you gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your eyes reflect light like a brass mirror) and may ignore one debt or obligation that would require you to lie – the creditor sees only the truth of your refusal.

Patron	Thematic Skill (+1)	Gift / Lore Bestowal
Carrion King	Survival	<i>Grants the feast of decay, where what is dead becomes seed for what yet lives.</i> ¹
Grimmir	Survival	<i>Grants the wisdom of root and stone, speaking the tongues of leaf and fang.</i> ¹
Ikasha	Stealth	<i>Grants the hush between footsteps and the raven's omen at every threshold.</i> ¹
Inaea	Persuade	<i>Grants the hearth's warmth—shelter for the weary and mercy for the lost.</i> ¹
Oath of Flame & Light	Command	<i>Grants the fire of dawn, a vow that shields the faithful and sears the faithless.</i> ¹
Palinode	Performance	<i>Grants the unfinished cadence: a song that never ends, a mask that never slips, an encore that binds the crowd.</i> ¹
The Traveler	Notice	<i>Grants the open way, a restless compass and roads where none were marked.</i> ¹
The Witness	Notice	<i>Grants the unblinking gaze that unmaskers deceit and remembers every oath.</i> ¹

Table 15.2: Patron Gifts and Thematic Skills (curated selection). The +1 bonus applies only when the fiction aligns with the Patron's domain.

15.1.11 Patron Fear Influence Table (Curated)

The following table summarizes how the curated patrons modify fear effects.

Patron	Domain Tags	Influence Type	Fear Effect Modifications
Carrion King	Decay, Feast, Scavenging	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Decay</i> , <i>Hunger</i> , <i>Feast</i> mutates. On 1 (Fight), frenzy devolves into cannibalistic hunger.
Grimmir	Seasons, Wild, Sacrifice	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Wild</i> , <i>Nature</i> , <i>Season</i> becomes primal dread. On 6 (Submit), victim freezes as if rooted.

Continued on next page

¹The Patron's Gift (Imbuement) costs +1 Influence when invoked (or +1 additional if Pushed).

Continued from previous page

Patron	Domain Tags	Influence Type	Fear Effect Modifications
Ikasha	Shadow, Whispers, Latent Potential	Amplify	Fear tagged <i>Shadow, Voice, Hidden</i> deepens. On 3 (Freeze), victim may be paralyzed by whispered secrets.
Inaea	Mercy, Hearth, Connection	Reroll	Fear tagged <i>Home, Family, Comfort</i> twists to terror of loss. On 4 (Flee), victim abandons loved ones “for their own good.”
Oath of Flame & Light	Dawn, Vows, Purity	Resonance	Fear tagged <i>Light, Sacred, Vow</i> also imposes Fatigue. Iconic light turns terror into bodily strain.
Palinode	Performance, Rapture, Encore	Amplify	Fear tagged <i>Stage, Crowd, Song</i> becomes paralyzing stage fright. On 6 (Submit), victim is compelled to perform a humiliating act.
The Traveler	Ways, Journeys, Crossroads	Resonance	Fear tagged <i>Lost, Path, Journey</i> also inflicts Complication Points. Terror of losing the way becomes mechanical hindrance.
The Witness	Truth, Revelation	Amplify	Fear tagged <i>Truth, Knowledge, Revelation</i> intensifies. On 6 (Submit), target may confess dark secrets under perceived Iconic judgment.

Terrestrial Patrons — Mortal Powers That Collect

Not all power flows from ancient Patrons and forgotten bargains. Some power sits in counting-houses, guild halls, and the back rooms of taverns. These are **Terrestrial Patrons** — mortal factions, noble houses, crime syndicates, or merchant leagues that offer tangible aid in exchange for **Influence** (the same mechanic as Obligation, tracked on a per-patron basis).

15.1.11.0.1 How Terrestrial Patrons Work When you accept a favor from a Terrestrial Patron (access, resources, protection, an Asset), you mark **+1 Influence** to that patron. Your Influence capacity is the same as Obligation: **Spirit + Presence**. Exceeding capacity causes Fatigue (1 per segment over), and you cannot call on that patron for further favors until you clear segments.

Clearing Influence requires performing tasks for the patron. The GM sets the scope:

- **Minor task** (deliver a message, pay a bribe): clears 1 Influence.
- **Significant task** (escort a caravan, break a siege): clears 2 Influence.
- **Major task** (assassinate a rival, broker a treaty): clears 3+ Influence.

15.1.11.0.2 Asset Slots A Terrestrial Patron can grant Assets (see 12) in exchange for Influence, not XP. The Influence cost is based on the Asset's value and the patron's power:

Asset Type	Minor Patron (Local)	Major Patron (Regional)
Minor Asset (4 XP value)	2 Influence	2 Influence
Standard Asset (8 XP value)	4 Influence	3 Influence
Major Asset (12 XP value)	—	4 Influence
Follower (Cap 2)	2 Influence	2 Influence
Follower (Cap 3)	4 Influence	3 Influence

A Minor Patron cannot grant Major Assets — their reach is too short.

15.1.11.0.3 Examples of Terrestrial Patrons

- **House Contarini (Vilikari)** — Archivolt access, forged charters, legal immunity.
- **The Ragman (Silkstrand)** — Smuggling routes, night-boat passage, stolen goods.
- **The Morosini (Vilikari)** — Letters of credit, market access, debt collection.
- **The Black Banners (Mercenary)** — Condotta contracts, war mounts, safe passage.
- **The Salt Syndicate (Fhara)** — Water rights, caravan escorts, desert guides.

15.1.11.0.4 Why Use Terrestrial Patrons? Terrestrial Patrons allow players to gain Assets and favors without spending XP — but the cost is narrative. A favor from House Contarini may come due in the middle of a heist. A loan from the Morosini may be called when you are penniless and far from home. The Influence track ensures that these relationships have mechanical weight without replacing XP advancement.

For GMs: Terrestrial Patrons are excellent sources of adventure hooks. When a party owes Influence to three different patrons, those patrons will eventually compete for the party's loyalty — and that competition is a campaign.

15.2 Witchcraft, Cults, and Religions

The Patrons do not demand worship. They do not build temples, compose scripture, or care which name you speak when you pray. They notice only one thing: **Influence** (sometimes called *Weight*). A vow kept, a promise honored, a threshold crossed with witness—these are the currencies that move the old powers. Yet mortals are creatures of meaning, not merely transaction. We build cathedrals to flames we do not understand. We whisper confessions into bells that cannot answer. We gather in secret circles to sing the name of a Patron we have never seen, hoping that if we sing loudly enough, someone will listen.

This section describes the **human (and near-human) faces** of power in the Amaranthine: the religions that shape daily life, the cults that form around specific Patrons or living conduits, and

the quiet, patient craft of **witchcraft**—the art of working at thresholds, tying knots, and reminding the world of promises it has forgotten.

Religions are syncretic traditions—the Everflame, the Temple of Light, the Covenant of Mykkiel—that venerate a single divine principle while drawing power from multiple Patrons. They are the faith of the faithful: public, legal, and often entangled with the state.

Cults are concentrations of purpose: fellowships that form around a specific Patron, a specific interpretation, or a specific living voice—a Cantor whose song has drawn the desperate, an Invoker whose bargains have begun to outrun them. Cults are the faith of the desperate: private, dangerous, and always watched.

Witchcraft is not a faith at all. It is a *method*: the art of listening to Echo, steadying the Veil, and leaning into Flow. Witches work at thresholds—doorways, wakes, crossroads, bedsides—and their power is indistinguishable from skilled attention. Witchcraft is the craft of the cunning: patient, subtle, and older than any temple.

Whether you kneel in a basilica, whisper in a root cellar, or simply tie a red thread around a gatepost, the same law applies: **the world remembers. And everything you do carries weight.**

15.2.1 Religions of the Amaranthine

The great religions of the known world are not rivals to the Patrons; they are the masks the Patrons wear when mortals need a single face to pray to. Each religion is a syncretic tradition that venerates a divine principle—the Flame, the Light, the Covenant, the Twin Fires—while drawing power from multiple Patrons. The Patrons themselves do not care about theology; they care about *influence*, about the weight of promises, about the ledger of honor. A priest who invokes the Inquisitor Prime and a paladin who calls upon the Oath of Flame & Light may believe they serve the same god. They are not wrong – but the Patrons are not gods. They are presences, and they will respond regardless of the name on the prayer.

What follows are the four major religious traditions of the Amaranthine. Each is a web of **Orders**, each Order devoted to a specific Patron while subsuming that Patron into a larger, unified faith. Each is also a **Terrestrial Patron** (see §12.8) in its own right: faithful who dedicate themselves to a religion gain access to certain Rites (as Low Rites) and bear *influence* with the religion's hierarchy, not directly to the Patrons. The religion mediates the weight of the covenant.

15.2.1.1 The Everflame (Ecktoria)

The Everflame is the state religion of Ecktoria, a faith of fire, law, and imperial legitimacy. Its great basilicas burn with perpetual flames; its priests carry censers and gavels. The Everflame teaches that *truth and measure are one*: a lie is a theft, a broken oath is a scorch on the cosmic record. The flame itself is the witness – it remembers every vow sworn before it, and it does not forgive.

15.2.1.1.1 The Three Orders of the Everflame The Everflame is composed of three great Orders, each devoted to a specific Patron but unified under the Everflame's divine fire.

- **Order of the Oath of Flame & Light (Orthodox)** – The mainstream clergy and knightly orders. They kindle the sacred flames, perform marriages and coronations, and lead the faithful in procession. Their Rites are those of vows, radiance, and righteous smiting. They are the public face of the Everflame.
- **Order of the Inquisitor Prime (Prosecutorial)** – The hunters of heresy and corruption. They investigate unsanctioned magic, root out demonic cults, and enforce the purity of the

flame. In Ecktoria they are called the *Chain-Lanterns* (though that name properly belongs to the Temple of Light's inquisitors; the Everflame uses *Flame-Wardens*). Their Rites are those of judgment, purification, and burning censure.

- **Order of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitalier)** – The healers and confessors. They run hospices, tend to the sick, and hear the confessions of the dying. Their Rites are those of healing, forgiveness, and the spiral of care. In Ecktoria they are often at odds with the Inquisitor Prime – mercy can look like leniency.

15.2.1.1.2 Beliefs and Practices The Everflame teaches that the world was kindled by a single flame, which then divided into three aspects: the *Gleaming* (justice, oaths, protection), the *Searing* (purification, judgment, truth), and the *Warming* (mercy, healing, forgiveness). Worship involves lighting candles, speaking vows aloud, and making offerings of oil, incense, or written confessions. The most sacred rite is the *Fire Trial*, where a person accused of heresy must hold a flame; if it burns, they are guilty; if it warms, they are innocent. (The Inquisitor Prime's Order controls the flame.)

15.2.1.1.3 Where It Is Found The Everflame is dominant in Ecktoria and its borderlands. It has a small presence in Kahfagia (where it competes with the lantern-law) and among some Vilikari communities. The Church of the Everflame is deeply tied to the Ecktorian state; to be a citizen is to be of the Flame.

15.2.1.2 The Temple of Light

The Temple of Light arose in Viterra, born from the hedge-law kingdom's need for a faith that could unify its patchwork of parishes without the imperial baggage of the Everflame. Where the Everflame is fiery and juridical, the Temple of Light is *pastoral and evangelistic*, but with a stern, magiphobic edge. Its priests are teachers, its knights are protectors of pilgrims, and its missionaries travel as far as the Linn isles and the Thepyrgosian countryside. The Temple distrusts unsanctioned magic; it teaches that arcane power must be witnessed, measured, and licensed – or it is a sin against the Light's clarity.

15.2.1.2.1 The Three Orders of the Temple The Temple of Light venerates the same three Patrons as the Everflame, but with different emphasis and doctrine. Its inquisitorial branch is the **Chain-Lanterns**.

- **Order of the Oath of Flame & Light (Orthodox)** – The core of the Temple. Its members are parish priests, wandering preachers, and the *Dawn-Knights* who guard the roads. They emphasize education, hospitality, and the protection of the innocent – and they are the first to report unlicensed magic.
- **Order of the Inquisitor Prime (Prosecutorial)** – The **Chain-Lanterns**. A zealous, well-funded order that operates from fortified chapter houses. They carry brass censers and bells, and they are authorized to test any suspected witch with candle-smoke, bell-toll, or the ordeal of the white mirror. In Thepyrgos they are a state-within-a-state, conscripting children with arcane talent into “rehabilitation.” In Viterra they are more restrained, but still feared.
- **Order of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitalier)** – The healers and confessors of the Temple. They run hospices, orphanages, and free clinics. In Viterra they are often the

only healers a village can afford. Their Rites are those of unburdening and care – though they never heal a curse without reporting it.

15.2.1.2.2 Beliefs and Practices The Temple teaches that Light is not a flame but a *lens*. The divine shines through all things, but it is refracted into three colors: Gold (justice and protection), Silver (truth and correction), and White (mercy and healing). Worship is quiet: morning prayers, lighting a single candle, reading from the *Codex of Illumination* (a collection of parables and legal maxims). The Temple is evangelistic – it sends missionaries to the Linn, the Mistlands, and even into the Thepyrgosian countryside, where its simple message of mercy contrasts with the Chain-Lanterns’ severity (though the missionaries and the inquisitors work from the same budget).

15.2.1.2.3 Where It Is Found The Temple has its strongest foothold in Viterra, but it is also the dominant faith in large parts of Thepyrgos (especially among the common folk, as opposed to the synod’s intellectual elite). It has a quiet, growing presence among the Linn – a “crusade of education” that builds schools and hospitals, not cathedrals.

15.2.1.3 The Covenant (of Mykkiel)

The Covenant is the youngest of the three great religions, born from the ashes of the Sidhi homeland; the Law that they carried with them in their travels. It is *legalistic, stern, and uncompromising*. Its God is the Law – not human law, but the divine order that underpins reality. The Covenant holds that the universe is a contract between the divine and the mortal. To break an oath is to tear the fabric of the world; to keep it is to strengthen the Covenant. The Patron Mykkiel (called the Arbiter) is the living seal of this contract.

15.2.1.3.1 The Three Orders of the Covenant Unlike the Everflame and the Temple, the Covenant’s primary Patron is Mykkiel, the Arbiter of the Covenant. The other two Patrons serve as supporting offices.

- **Order of Mykkiel (Orthodox)** – The judges, notaries, and law-scholars. They settle disputes, draft contracts, and administer the Covenant Courts. Their Rites are those of binding oaths, weighing testimony, and sealing judgments. They are the public face of the Covenant.
- **Order of the Inquisitor Prime (Prosecutorial)** – In the Covenant, the Inquisitor Prime is the *Accuser* – the one who brings hidden sins to light. They are not hunters of heretics but *auditors of the soul*. They investigate broken oaths, expose secret perjury, and demand restitution. Their Rites are those of revelation and correction. They carry no swords – only iron scales and a copy of the *Canons of Obligation*.
- **Order of the Oath of Flame & Light (Hospitalier – Healing Focus)** – A surprising inclusion: in the Covenant, the Oath of Flame & Light is not a warrior’s path but a *healer’s*. They tend to the wounded in body and soul, but their healing always comes with a *contract*: the patient must swear to live a more lawful life. Their Rites are those of purification, cleansing, and bound mercy.

15.2.1.3.2 Beliefs and Practices The Covenant teaches that every act of kindness, every kept promise, every honest word strengthens the divine contract; every lie, every broken oath, every injustice weakens it. The Covenant’s symbol is a *broken chain* – signifying that even when empires

fall, the law remains. Worship is conducted in courts, not temples; a service involves reading a case, hearing testimony, and pronouncing a judgment. The most devout often become itinerant judges, bringing the Covenant's justice to villages that have never seen a magistrate.

15.2.1.3.3 The Covenant in Ashaan – A Secret Resistance In the magocracy of Ashaan, where the Veiled Sisters rule through terror and spirit-binding, the Covenant is forbidden. Yet it survives in secret. The *Breath-less* resistance network has adopted the Covenant's teachings as a moral framework: they believe that the Veiled Sisters are oath-breakers of the highest order, and that a new Covenant – a just law – will one day be established over the ashes of the Sisters' tyranny. In the catacombs of Galanina, Covenant judges preside over *trials in absentia* of the Sisters, sentencing them to nothing less than the restoration of order. The Patron Mykkiel does not care whether the accused are present – the weight of the broken oath remains regardless.

15.2.1.3.4 Where It Is Found The Covenant is strongest in Galanina (where it blends with Pereshi legal traditions), among the Fhara ruling class, and in the secret cells of Ashaan. It has a small but growing presence in Thepyrgos, where synod clerks find its clarity appealing. In Ecktoria, it is viewed as heretical (the Everflame claims sole authority over divine law). In Vhasia, it is tolerated as a philosophy but not as a church.

15.2.1.4 The Pereshi Faith – The Twin Flames

In the eastern provinces and among the Pereshi diaspora, a different light burns: the *Twin Flames*. This faith teaches that the universe is a struggle between two primordial fires – the *Pure Flame* of truth, order, and life, and the *Consuming Flame* of deceit, chaos, and death. Unlike the Everflame's single fire, the Pereshi hold that both fires are sacred; the duty of the faithful is to feed the Pure Flame and starve the Consuming one through acts of honesty, purification, and the preservation of knowledge. The Twin Flames have no single god, but rather a host of *radiant spirits* (which outsiders recognize as Patrons such as the Oath of Flame & Light, the Witness, and the Pale Shepherd). The religion is intensely legalistic about ritual purity, but it lacks a central hierarchy; each temple is autonomous, governed by a *Flame-Keeper*.

15.2.1.4.1 The Two Orders (loose fellowships)

- **Keepers of the Pure Flame** – Priests, healers, and archivists. They tend the eternal lamps in fire-temples, copy holy texts, and perform ceremonies of purification. They invoke the Oath of Flame & Light for blessings and the Witness for truthful testimony.
- **Watchers Against the Maw** – A martial order devoted to hunting undead, demons, and unnatural corruption. They are the ones who burn the bodies of those touched by the Consuming Flame. They invoke the Pale Shepherd to guide spirits and the Inquisitor Prime to expose hidden defilement.

15.2.1.4.2 Beliefs and Practices The Twin Flames teach that every person carries a small spark of the Pure Flame. Through good deeds, honest speech, and proper ritual cleanliness, that spark grows; through lies, cruelty, and contact with the dead (unless ritually purified), it dims. Fire-temples are open to the sky, with a central basin of sand where the eternal flame burns. Worship consists of pouring offerings of oil or clarified butter into the flame while reciting the *Twenty-One*

Names of Radiance (a list of virtues). The dead are neither buried nor cremated; they are placed in *Towers of Silence* – open-topped stone cylinders – where the elements and carrion birds cleanse the bones. The bones are then ground and used to make ceremonial chalk for temple circles.

15.2.1.4.3 Where It Is Found The Twin Flames are the majority faith in the Pereshi highlands (the region between Thepyrgos and the eastern steppe) and among Pereshi communities in Zakov, Kahfagia, and the Dolmis ports. In Ecktoria they are tolerated as a “philosophical sect” of the Everflame. In Viterra they are viewed with suspicion because of their dealings with the dead, but the Temple of Light has never actively persecuted them – their distrust of sorcery aligns.

15.2.1.4.4 Religious Conflict and Cooperation The four religions do not wage holy war against each other – not openly. Their priests argue theology; their inquisitors watch each other; their missionaries compete for converts. But they also cooperate. A Covenant judge might consult an Everflame priest on a case involving a sanctified oath; a Temple healer might staff a Covenant hospice; a Pereshi Flame-Keeper might share fire-lighting duties at a joint ceremony. The Patrons themselves are indifferent to human sectarianism; they accept influence from any and all.

What the faithful share is a belief that *law is sacred* and that *witness is binding*. Whether the flame, the light, the covenant, or the twin fires, the divine is that which holds you accountable. And the Patrons – whatever names they are called – are always watching.

15.2.1.5 Other Traditions and Cults

Beyond the four great syncretic faiths, the Amaranthine harbors a host of local traditions, mystery cults, and folk practices. These are not organized religions in the sense of the Everflame or the Covenant; they lack central hierarchies, formal clergy, or unified doctrine. Yet they shape the spiritual landscape of their regions as powerfully as any basilica or fire-temple. Most are tolerated (or ignored) by the great faiths, though some are actively suppressed.

15.2.1.5.1 The Gray Pilgrims (The Traveler) A wandering order of Lethai-ar and mixed-blood devotees who maintain the old way-cords of the Valewood and the star-roads of the eastern marches. They wear gray cloaks woven from mist and speak only in riddles. Their creed is simple: “*The road does not end. It only turns.*” They accept no payment for their guidance, only a lock of hair, which they knot into a way-cord. A Gray Pilgrim is never lost, but they are also never home. Found in the Valewood, the Linn coast, and the passes of the Aelerian mountains.

15.2.1.5.2 The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root) A secretive, all-female cult that traces its origin to a renegade Sister of the Pale Shepherd. They believe that all obligations are threads that can be cut – and that the highest form of mercy is to sever a promise without asking permission. They run hospices and soup kitchens, ask no payment, but record every name in a ledger that never dries. The Daughters are feared because they cut threads unpredictably; a noble may wake to find that a peasant’s promise to him has simply *vanished*. The great religions tolerate them because they heal the poor, but the Chain-Lanterns consider them heretics. Found in Silkstrand, Zakov, and the poorer wards of Ecktoria.

15.2.1.5.3 The Cog-Cults (The Clockwork Monad) Underground fraternities of gear-smiths, logicians, and failed engineers who believe that the universe is a machine that can be perfected.

They meet in abandoned watermills, scriptoria, and boiler rooms, reciting the *Canons of Proportion* and performing “optimisation rites” on timers, pumps, and looms. The Cog-Cults are not organized – each cell operates independently – but they share a symbol: a gear with nine teeth (the ninth is hidden). The Everflame condemns them as heretics who worship craft; the Temple of Light ignores them as harmless eccentrics; the Covenant has prosecuted them for “unauthorised modification of lawful measures.” Found in Thepyrgos, Aeler, and the industrial wards of Silkstrand.

15.2.1.5.4 The Salt Sworn (The Pale Shepherd) A syncretic cult of the eastern Dolmis coast, where salt-panners and fishermen live constantly with the threat of drowning. The Salt Sworn believe that the Pale Shepherd guides not only the dead but also the tide. They build cairns of salt stone at the water’s edge and leave no offerings – only the names of the lost, carved into driftwood. Once a year, on the night of the tide of the dead, they chant the names aloud, believing that each name spoken strengthens the threshold between the living and the drowned. The Temple of Light has tried to suppress them three times; each time, the mission ships have been found adrift with no crew and a single name carved into the mast: *Oblivion*. Found in the salt marshes of Zakov, the coast of Theona, and the Aberderrin headlands.

15.2.1.5.5 The Bear Cults of Ubral In the high glens of Ubral, where the lowland laws of guest-right and wergild fray against the wilderness, a different faith thrives. The Bear Cults believe that the Savage Heart (whom they call the *Red Maw*) is not a demon but a teacher. Initiates wear cured bear-skins and carve runes into their ribs with bone needles; they believe that by becoming the predator, they can protect their clans from lowland invaders and the creeping influence of the Everflame. The cult has no holy texts, no clergy, and no temples – only a sacred bear that is fed and honored each autumn. The Lady of Tor has outlawed the Bear Cults three times; each time, the edicts were found torn to shreds outside her hall, pinned with a single claw. Found only in Ubral, rarely encountered by outsiders.

15.2.1.5.6 The Ember Prefects (Heretical Everflame) Not a separate religion but a persistent schism within the Everflame. The Ember Prefects believe that the flame should not be contained in basilicas – that it must be carried into the streets, into the fields, into the homes of the poor. They meet in arena hypogea and abandoned warehouses, chanting the *Unspoken Ninth Citation* of the Everflame’s liturgy (a passage that orthodox priests insist does not exist). Their symbol is a candle that burns from both ends. The Grand Magistrate has outlawed them three times; each time, the edict was found burned the next morning, with a single word left intact: “*Audit.*” The Prefects are hunted by the Inquisitor Prime, but they have sympathizers among the city’s poor and among the more radical Hospitaliers. Found primarily in Ecktoria, with small cells in Vhasia and Thepyrgos.

15.2.1.5.7 The Veneration of the Hearth (Aelaerem Folk Tradition) Not a religion in the institutional sense, but a pervasive set of practices among the halflings of the downs. Every Aelaerem home has a red door, a cup-mark stone on the threshold, and a pair of watch-geese. The Hearth is not a god but a presence – the accumulated memory of every kindness shown in that home. Offerings are simple: a crust of bread left on the doorstep, a cup of milk poured into the garden, a red thread tied around the handle of a knife. The Hearth asks for nothing except that

guests be welcomed and the ninth cup left unpoured. The Everflame and the Temple of Light have sent missionaries to the downs; they are politely fed, given a bed for the night, and shown the way back to the lowlands in the morning. Their sermons are forgotten by noon. Found only in Aelaerem (Amedell) and among halfling communities in the Dolmis ports.

15.2.1.5.8 Player Takeaway These traditions are not character classes or mechanical packages; they are sources of story hooks, local color, and potential influence. A character who follows the Gray Pilgrims may gain a way-cord (treat as a Minor Asset) but owes a lock of hair. A character who joins the Salt Sworn may learn a Hedge Gift but must carve a name into driftwood each full moon. Work with your GM to determine what, if any, mechanical benefit or cost these traditions carry. Most are best represented as Strings, Timers, or narrative permissions, not as full Patron relationships.

15.2.2 Cults of the Amaranthine

Where religions build temples, cults gather in shadow. A cult is not a failed religion—it is a **concentration of purpose**. Where the Everflame concerns itself with all of Ecktoria, a cult of the Inquisitor Prime concerns itself only with *your* heresy. Where the Temple of Light builds hospitals for all, a cult of the Oath of Mercy and Grace builds a single room where promises are forgiven—and *remembered*.

Cults form around a specific Patron, a specific interpretation of that Patron, or a specific living conduit: a **Cantor** whose voice has drawn the desperate, an **Invoker** whose bargains have begun to outrun them, or a **Runekeeper** who has stopped reading the Codex and started writing their own chapters.

The Cantor's Congregation

A Cantor does not choose to lead a cult. A Cantor sings, and the broken listen. The desperate gather. The hungry, the hunted, the hollow—they find the Cantor's song before they find the Cantor. By the time the Cantor realizes they have a congregation, the congregation has already named them *Speaker*, *Shepherd*, or *Storm-Heart*.

A Cantor-led cult is **charismatic, volatile, and deeply personal**. The Cantor's voice is the cult's scripture; their mood is its liturgy. When the Cantor falters, the cult may fragment, turn inward, or seek a new voice. When the Cantor ascends (or descends), the cult ascends with them—into significance, into terror, or into the annals of inquisitors.

GM Seed: A Cantor of the Pale Shepherd has begun singing funerals for the not-yet-dead. Villagers pay to have their names sung into the Shepherd's flock before they die. The local Temple priest calls it a mercy. The dead call it theft.

The Invoker's Covenant

An Invoker does not seek followers. An Invoker solves problems. But when an Invoker has solved enough problems for enough people, those people begin to *wait*. They wait outside the Invoker's door. They leave offerings. They whisper the Invoker's name alongside the Patron's. A covenant forms—not of worship, but of *dependence*.

An Invoker-led cult is **pragmatic, secretive, and increasingly brittle**. The Invoker did not ask for loyalty and does not know how to maintain it. Rituals are improvised. Doctrine is whatever worked last time. The cult endures only as long as the Invoker's bargains keep paying out. When

they stop, the knives come out.

Invokers themselves are usually **wary of cults**—cults attract attention, and attention attracts the Inquisitor Prime. But a desperate Invoker may tolerate a covenant, even cultivate it, telling themselves it is just a network, just a favor economy, just a few people who owe them. It never stays *just*.

GM Seed: An Invoker of the Clockwork Monad has accidentally created a cult of gear-makers who believe the Monad speaks through her calculations. They have begun “optimizing” the village—replanting fields in perfect grids, scheduling marriages by algorithm. The Invoker cannot stop them without admitting she is not a prophet.

The Runekeeper’s Schism

A Runekeeper leads a cult only when they have *broken faith*—with their Codex, with their Order, or with the Patron’s orthodox interpretation. Runekeeper cults are **doctrinal, obsessive, and dangerous in proportion to their literacy**. They keep records. They write commentaries. They argue about commas in Rites that should never have been written down at all.

Most Runekeeper cults are small: a master, a few apprentices, a locked scriptorium. But some grow, especially when the Runekeeper claims to have found a *lost Rite*—a fragment of a Patron’s power that the orthodox Orders have suppressed. These cults are heresies in the truest sense: not a different faith, but a different *reading* of the same faith. The orthodox hate them most of all.

A Runekeeper’s attitude toward cults varies by Patron:

- A Runekeeper of the **Oath of Flame & Light** sees cults as weeds in the garden—to be pulled, burned, or redirected toward the true flame.
- A Runekeeper of **Ikasha** may tolerate a cult as a useful shadow, but will never stand at its center.
- A Runekeeper of **the Witness** is constitutionally incapable of leading a cult; they would be forced to reveal their own manipulations, and the cult would collapse into truth.

GM Seed: A Runekeeper of the Carrion-King has found a Rite that allows followers to “compost” their own memories into physical tokens. The cult now trades these tokens—childhoods, first loves, old griefs—on a black market. The Runekeeper insists this is what the King intended. The King has not disagreed.

Cults as Factions

Mechanically, a cult functions as an **Asset** (see §??) with a severe narrative bias. A cult is never neutral. A cult will:

- **Provide Aid:** Followers can act as Cap 2–5 followers, but only in service of the cult’s purpose.
- **Generate Influence:** Leading a cult ticks Influence with the relevant Patron **+1 per session**—the Patron notices when you gather followers in their name.
- **Attract Attention:** Any cult of 10+ members begins a **Cult Investigation [6]** timer. When it fills, someone comes looking: an Inquisitor Prime agent, a rival cult, or the Patron themselves.
- **Demand Upkeep:** A cult requires either **Efficient Upkeep** (XP, representing bribes, shelter, and lies) or **Intensive Upkeep** (a scene per session where the leader performs a miracle, preaches, or solves a follower’s problem).

Examples of Cults

The following cults are drawn from the Patron entries throughout this chapter. Each is a template—feel free to adapt, rename, or reskin.

The Unforgotten Ledger (Varnek Karn)

Funeral notaries who speak with the dead. They meet in crypts and record every death they witness. Outsiders bring a name and leave with a task.

- **Leader:** A Death-Speaker (Cantor or Runekeeper).
- **Hazard:** The dead begin to answer—politely, then demandingly.

The Gilded Jest (Mab)

A conspiracy of wits who believe every exchange is a performance. They meet in theaters and back rooms, trading truths disguised as lies.

- **Leader:** A Masked Jester (Cantor or Invoker).
- **Hazard:** The cult's contracts become binding fae bargains; breaking one draws Mab's amused attention.

The Iron Chorus (Inquisitor Prime)

Militant witch-hunters who believe purity is survival. They meet in fortified chapter houses and strike iron bells to seal judgments.

- **Leader:** A Censor-Prime (Runekeeper or Cantor).
- **Hazard:** The Chorus begins to see heresy everywhere—including in you.

The Compost-Circle (Carrion-King)

A fellowship of gardeners and gravediggers who believe nothing is wasted. They meet in compost heaps and burial mounds, turning endings into beginnings.

- **Leader:** A Rot-Warden (Invoker or Hedge-Witch).
- **Hazard:** The Circle's transformations begin to accelerate—composting becomes contagion.

Joining or Founding a Cult

Players may wish to found a cult, join an existing one, or be reluctantly absorbed by one. Use these guidelines:

- **Founding:** Requires a **Patron's Favor** (a Talent, a critical success on a Rite, or a GM-defined story beat). The new cult begins as a **Minor Asset** (4 XP) with 1–3 followers.
- **Joining:** Grants access to the cult's **Asset** benefits (followers, safe houses, information) but ticks Influence +1 to the cult's Patron. Leaving a cult is a narrative scene, not a mechanical cost—but the Patron may remember.
- **Reluctant Leadership:** A character who becomes the focus of a cult without seeking it gains the **Cult Leader** tag. This is a **Condition:** once per session, the GM may compel the character to act in the cult's interest (preach, protect, perform a Rite) or mark 1 Fatigue from the weight of expectation.

Player Takeaway

Cults are not for everyone. A cult gives you hands, eyes, and voices beyond your own—but those hands may hold knives, those eyes may watch you sleep, and those voices may begin

to speak without your permission. If you choose to lead, remember: the Patron is the real congregation. You are just its favorite hymn.

15.2.3 Witchcraft

The Amaranthine prays to the Everflame, the Temple, and the Covenant. But when prayers fail, when the child will not be born, when the roads turn against the traveler, the people do not call for a priest. They call for a **witch**.

A witch is not a heretic—not necessarily. A witch is a **threshold worker**: one who listens to what has been (Echo), steadies what is (the Veil), and leans into what wishes to be (Flow). Witchcraft is not brute force; it is *fit*—finding where the world already wants to move and giving it a gentle, precise nudge. Hearth craft, mill craft, and road craft are simply slow, patient forms of the same art practiced by ordinary hands. The most powerful magic is often indistinguishable from skilled attention.

15.2.3.1 The Two Speeds of Witchcraft

A witch works at two speeds.

15.2.3.1.1 The Long Road Ritual, threshold, price, and consequence: curses woven, bargains struck, the world's memory rewritten. It takes **Significant Time** (hours, days, a moon phase). This is the domain of Full Rituals: unbinding a curse, hallowing a threshold, or unraveling a wound.

15.2.3.1.2 The Short Road Instinct, residue, and a flicker of attention: a suddenly turned tide, a bell rung at the right moment, a thread plucked. It takes **Some Time** (a few heartbeats, a single action). This is the domain of **Quick Workings** and **Hedge Gifts**—magic so subtle it can be mistaken for luck.

15.2.3.2 Core Principles of Witchcraft

1. **The Law of Named Existence:** To name is to anchor. A True Name fastens an Echo; forgetting frays it. Words spoken under witness reshape how a place remembers.
2. **The Concordant Layers:** People, places, and vows exist as chords across Echo / Veil / Flow.
 - **Echo:** Accumulated memory and intention. What has been.
 - **Veil:** The current, perceivable state; the boundary between potential and actual.
 - **Flow:** The direction of change; the will of elements and intent.
3. **Threshold Mechanics:** All workings begin at edges—doorways, wakes, vows, last breaths, first light, crossroads. Magic is boundary-law: who may pass, what must stay, and what should never meet.
4. **Element-Will:** Elements are wills, not mere substances. A working *argues* with a chosen will; Influence is the weight incurred when borrowing from a will larger than yours.
5. **The Silent Ninth:** The missing step in every scale—absence with teeth. The Ninth is erasure, gaps, omissions, and the power of what is left unsaid. **Players never declare the Ninth.** The GM may apply a Void tag only as consequence.

15.2.3.3 Hedge Gifts

A **Hedge Gift** is not a spell. It is the world tilting slightly in the witch's favor because she has paid attention to the right thresholds. Hedge Gifts require no dice roll; they simply work within their limited scope.

Any character with the **Craft of the Hedge** talent may learn Hedge Gifts. A witch begins with **two Hedge Gifts** of her choice. Additional Hedge Gifts cost **2 XP** each.

Steady Hand

Once per scene, touch a wounded person (including yourself) and whisper a word of comfort. Remove 1 Fatigue. No roll. You may not use this on the same person twice in a scene.

Knot of Favor

Once per scene, tie a small knot in a cord, thread, or cloth. For the rest of the scene, you and allies within Near gain +1 die to a single type of roll (choose when you tie: stealth, persuasion, defense, or navigation). The knot must remain tied; if undone, the benefit ends.

Warm Hand

Once per scene, touch someone and speak a word of comfort or warning. For the next exchange, that person's next physical action either gains +1 die (comfort) or suffers -1 die (warning). No roll. The effect is subtle and cannot be directly perceived as magic.

Hearth-Sense

Once per scene, ask the GM one yes/no question about a threshold, a boundary, or a promise in the current scene. The GM must answer truthfully.

Salt Line

Once per scene, pour a handful of salt in a continuous line (move action). Any spirit, ghost, or cursed creature attempting to cross must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or be stopped for that exchange. The line must be at least Close length; broken if someone steps through or scatters the salt.

The Unlit Candle

Once per session, declare that a light source you can see (lantern, candle, torch) falters or extinguishes. This creates a zone of dim light or darkness in Near range for one exchange.

Counting the Eighth

Once per scene, when you or an ally is about to roll, whisper a number (1-8). If the GM's current Story Beat count is equal to that number modulo 8, the roll gains +2 dice. If not, nothing happens. You cannot use this again until the GM's SB count changes.

15.2.3.4 Quick Workings

A **Quick Working** is a single-action roll that relies on the witch's knowledge of thresholds, elements, and will. Its effects are limited, subtle, and always carry the risk of consequence.

15.2.3.4.1 Procedure

1. **Name the Threshold** (door, tide line, wound, vow, breath).
2. **Choose a Layer** (Echo, Veil, or Flow) and a single Tag (from the magic tags list).
3. **Set Position** by urgency (Controlled if you have time, Desperate if threatened).
4. **Roll** Attribute + Skill (typically Wits+Lore, Spirit+Insight, or Presence+Sway).
5. **Apply Outcome** (see table).

The effect is always minor and scene-limited: a door sticks shut or opens; a candle gutters (brief

darkness); a rope knot tightens or loosens; a pursuer's footing slips (1 Fatigue); a whispered name is heard or forgotten.

Roll Result	Effect	
Clean Success (Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0)	Effect manifests cleanly.	No
Success with SB (Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0)	Effect works, but GM spends SB for minor complication.	Ma
Partial (0 < Successes < DV)	Effect works partially or briefly.	Ga
Miss (Successes = 0)	Effect fails.	Ga

Table 15.4: Quick Working Outcome Matrix

15.2.3.5 Full Rituals

A Full Ritual requires **Significant Time**, a proper threshold, and often a witness. Its effects are lasting or permanent: blessings, curses, bindings, or the hallowing of ground.

15.2.3.5.1 General Procedure

1. **Identify the Threshold** (name the edge, learn its disposition).
2. **Choose Your Witness** (a person, spirit, or Hollowed who watches).
3. **Name Your Will** (what change you intend, using Threshold Tags).
4. **Set Your Price** (memory, name, lock of hair, promise, blood).
5. **Make the Exchange** (roll, resolve, pay the price on success or partial).

15.2.3.5.2 Example Rituals

Unravel the Wound (Heal Harm)

Requires: Significant Time, a threshold (doorway or basin of water), a witness. Restores 1 level of Harm. *Price:* A lock of hair, a memory of a childhood injury, a tear in a vial. *Roll:* Spirit + Lore vs. DV (3 for Harm 1, 4 for Harm 2, 5+ for Harm 3 requires a covenant). *Success:* Harm reduced; witch pays the price. *Partial:* Harm reduced, but witch gains a minor Condition or a Promise Timer [4]. *Miss:* Wound does not heal; witch gains the Condition she tried to remove.

Hallow Threshold (Permanent Ward)

Requires: Significant Time, a permanent threshold (door, well, bridge, hearthstone), a witness who will maintain the consecration, an offering (bread, salt, coin, spoken promise). The blessing lasts until the threshold is physically broken or the offering removed. *Roll:* Spirit + Lore vs. DV 4 (home), 5 (village well), or 6 (city gate). *Success:* Threshold hallowed. Spirits, undead, and cursed creatures crossing must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or be turned back. *Partial:* Blessing holds but has a weakness (the witch names one thing that can bypass it). *Miss:* Blessing fails; threshold becomes cursed for one season (all who cross feel unease, -1 die to first action).

Unbind the Anchor (Permanent Spirit Release)

Requires: Significant Time, the spirit's true name or a strong anchor, a threshold (doorway facing east, crossroads, grave), a witness. Steps: (1) Discover the anchor (unfinished business, stolen object, broken vow). (2) Name the Terms (propose resolution). (3) Prepare the threshold (salt, chalk, broken cord). (4) Speak the Unbinding (Spirit + Lore vs. DV 4-6). (5) Pay the

Price. *Success*: Spirit released. Witch gains 1 Boon. *Partial*: Spirit released but leaves a remnant (echo, cold spot). Witch marks 1 Fatigue and gains a minor Condition. *Miss*: Spirit refuses, becomes hostile. Start a Promise Timer [4] named “The Spirit’s Revenge.”

15.2.3.6 Talents of the Hedge

Craft of the Hedge (4 XP)

Requires: Lore 1+ or Survival 1+; a witch mark (tattoo, scar, or birthmark). You have learned the small magics of thresholds and edges. You gain: two Hedge Gifts; the ability to perform Quick Workings; and once per session, when you fail a Quick Working roll, you may convert the Miss into a Partial Success by marking 1 Fatigue.

Hedge Gift of the Patron (6 XP)

Requires: *Craft of the Hedge*, *Bond to a Patron*. Once per session, when you would use a Hedge Gift, you may instead invoke your Patron’s Imbuement. Gain +1 die to all actions tied to your Patron’s domain for the scene, but mark +1 Influence immediately. No action required.

15.2.3.7 Covens and Traditions

As witches practice their craft across the diverse lands of Fate’s Edge, distinct traditions have emerged that reflect the unique magical properties of each region. The following are three prominent examples; your GM may introduce others.

The Bone Coven (Aelerian Influence)

Focus: Ancestral wisdom and the patient power of stone that remembers. *Signature Rite*: Stone Memory Communion—by pressing hands to ancient stone, the witch witnesses events that occurred near it, going back centuries. *Patron Elements*: Earth and Fate.

The Mistwalkers (Mistlands Influence)

Focus: Navigation between worlds and manipulation of thresholds. *Signature Rite*: Wayfinding Through the Veil—by burning specific herbs, the witch creates temporary passages through the Ways Between. *Patron Elements*: Water and Obishaal (Death/Dreams).

The Stormweavers (Linn/Ykrul Influence)

Focus: Weather magic and storm riding. *Signature Rite*: Storm Dancing—through ritual movement, the witch calls forth or calms storms. The most experienced can ride the winds themselves. *Patron Element*: Air, with strong ties to Raéyn or Xhak’Thul.

15.2.3.8 Threshold Magic and Promise Timers

Many workings create obligations. Represent these with a **Promise Timer** (typically 4 segments):

- Mark the timer when the promise is ignored, deferred, or disrespected.
- When filled, the price comes due—socially, spiritually, or narratively.
- Examples: sharing grief, tending a grave, protecting a hearth, reconciling rivals.

15.2.3.8.1 Household Disposition Communities and dwellings possess a temperament. When entering a new settlement or threshold site, the GM may choose or roll for its disposition:

Disposition	Effect
Hungry	Demands offerings; first working costs +1 Fatigue.
Grieving	Magic requires memory or loss narrative.
Fearful	First rite is Desperate Position.
Watching	+1 Effect if the house is fed or soothed.
Young	Chaotic outcomes on partials.
Old	Weak boons but harsh backlash.

Household temperament can change through care, ritual, or story.

15.2.3.9 The Daughters of the Unbroken Chord (The Cord)

Among the most feared and misunderstood covens are the **Daughters of the Unbroken Chord**—also called the Gray Watchers, Pale Midwens, or simply the Chain. They appear as midwives, hospice nurses, and deathbed witnesses, offering the mercy of warm hands and the comfort of final words. They seem harmless. Mostly.

The Daughters are bound to the **High Mother**, a threshold entity sustained by accumulated promise and subtle sacrifice. She may be a lich. She may be the current Vessel: a mortal woman elected by the coven, granted godlike power through centuries of accumulated influence. The Daughters smile when asked which is true. The Cord does not distinguish between memory and flesh.

15.2.3.9.1 Becoming a Daughter A character may join the Daughters of the Cord through the following requirements:

- **Attributes:** Spirit 3+, Body 2+
- **Skills:** Lore (Thresholds) 1+, Subterfuge 1+
- **Talents:** Disciplined Body (Monk) [3 XP], Gray Thread [4 XP] (see below)

Gray Thread (4 XP)

Requires: Disciplined Body, Spirit 3+. You are bound to the High Mother's Cord. Your flesh accepts tattooed Rites; your blood activates them. You may perform Rites of the High Mother without a Codex or Thiasos. Instead, you receive a **Hollowed**—a heartless familiar with eyes like spilled milk. It witnesses your magic and counts as the threefold presence required by Hag Law. The Hollowed never speaks.

Cord of Flesh (8 XP)

Requires: Gray Thread, Body 3+. Your body stores memories and promises. When you convert Harm → Fatigue (Monk ability), you may store up to Body rating points of Fatigue as **Chained Knots**, appearing uninjured (as fresh scars or weeping tattoos). You have until sunset after the next to perform a sacrifice or take 2 Harm.

The Open Palm, Closed Cord (8 XP)

Requires: Gray Thread, Melee 2+. Your unarmed strikes or subtle touch carry **Widow's Measure**. Instead of dealing Harm, you may mark a Promise Timer [4] on the target—they owe the Cord a truth or grief. If they already owe the coven, you may activate that weight: they suffer Position −1 for the scene, or you gain Effect +1 against them.

15.2.3.9.2 The Subtle Sacrifice The Daughters do not slaughter goats on altars. They require **domestic sacrifices**—acts of subtlety so small they are dismissed as accidents or cruelty, yet

sufficient to feed the Cord.

- **The Missing Child:** Taken to the House Without Doors. The child is hollowed out into a Heartless familiar. The parents forget they existed (Un-Naming).
- **The Unspoken Grief:** At a deathbed, the Daughter convinces the dying to forget their greatest love. The memory is trapped in a Name-Bead. The dying smile peacefully, having forgotten why they were sad.

Performing a sacrifice clears 1 segment of Influence with the High Mother or reduces a Rite's cost by 1 (minimum 1). Each requires **Intricate Description** and leaves physical evidence.

Player Takeaway

Witchcraft is not a separate magic system—it is a **way of working** that any character with the right talents can learn. A Runekeeper can learn Hedge Gifts. An Invoker can perform a Quick Working. A character with no Patron at all can become a capable hedge-witch, tending thresholds and binding small promises. The power of witchcraft is not in its flash, but in its patience. The world remembers. And the witch knows where to touch it.

Chapter 16

World Interaction

Using This Chapter

This chapter gives you the tools to move through the world, interact with its people, and make your journey meaningful. For detailed descriptions of each region's culture, subgenre, and notable NPCs, see **Chapter 14 (World Regions and Cultures)**. The two chapters work together: this one covers *how* to travel and interact; the other tells you *where* and *with whom*.

In **Fate's Edge**, the world is not a backdrop – it is a partner in the conversation. Dikes groan under black rain in Viterra, clan horns answer across Acasia's ridgelines, Ecktoria's marble halls echo with careful words, and Kahfagia's pilots read storms by taste. Wherever you go, place, culture, and pressure push back.

16.1 The Known World: A Geographic Overview

The following summary orients the major regions relative to one another. (See Chapter 14 for cultural details.)

Ecktoria Temperate heartland of the old Utaran Imperium. Borders Acasia to the northeast and Kahfagia to the west. Marble cities, imperial roads, codified law.

Acasia Lowland of rivers and petty kingdoms, northeast of Ecktoria. Broken province of mercenary companies and border lords. Borders Vhasia to the east.

Vhasia Fractured kingdom on a southern peninsula. East of Acasia, west of Viterra. Courtly intrigue, martial tradition, and fractured sun symbolism.

Viterra Shares the same peninsula with Vhasia, lying further east. Its eastern coast borders a dark inland body (the Blackwater). Hedge-law, river tolls, and the Last Kingdom.

Kahfagia West of Ecktoria, facing the open ocean. Maritime empire of storm-flags, deep-sea pilots, and exotic imports.

Thepyrgos Occupies the southern part of the great peninsula opposite Vhasia/Viterra. Eastern coast overlooks the Astroegro Straits. City of a Thousand Stairs, center of learning.

Theona Large island off the eastern coast of Viterra. Three isles, causeways, marsh, and the “No Ninth” taboo.

Mistlands Western shore of the Aberderrian Sea (north of the Amaranthine). Bog, fog, and bell-lines; protectorate of the Aeler. Direwood lies to the west.

- Linn** Scattered around the Yloka River and the Aberderrian Sea. Longships reach the Blackwater and raid Theona and Viterra. Fjords, skerries, storm-oaths.
- Violet Steppe** North of the Amaranthine, west of the Aberderrian Sea. Vast grassland, home of the Ykrul nomads.
- Valewood** East of the Blackwater. Ancient forest of phasing ruins, star-roads, and fae courts. Former Lethai empire.
- Aelinnel (Aevrossa)** South of the Valewood. Gnomish homeland of stone, bough, and bright things. Mist paths, bell-mounds, tide-gates.
- Aelaerem** South of Aevrossa. Halfling downs of gentle valleys and deep barrows. Homeland spoken of only in euphemisms (“The Silent Welcome”).
- Zakov** Island in the Blackwater, near the mouth of the Yloka River. Pirate haven, reef passages, salt and serpent.
- Oshiira** Southern grasslands east of the Gulf of Oshiira. Grain confederacy, weigh-houses, and the Vermilion Corps.
- Ashaan** Eastern desert peninsula, south of the Crimson Valley. Veiled Throne, spirit-binding, and the Red Desert’s creeping glass.
- Sekogo** Jungle realm south of the Crimson Valley and west of Ashaan. Green Council, honey-orchards, and the Ukwe (Speaking Tree).
- Taharka** Highland kingdom of the Monsoon Crown. Coffee terraces, ridge-watchers, and passes that remember every army.
- Fhara** Desert peninsula of oasis courts and water-clerks. Well-judges, coffee rituals, and the Sunken City of Qalat al-Madina.
- Sidhi** Diaspora people of the Brass Coast. Lighthouse courts, freedman’s seals, and the green flame of memory.
- Pereshi** Highland fire-temple nation. Ash Prince’s seal, fire-readers, and the ninth coal that never cools.
- Kuvani** Eastern steppe remount clans. Horse lineages, wind-songs, and the ghost herd of the salt pan.
- Tulkani** Itinerant storytellers and dream-carriers. Wagon circles, memory-cords, and the Dreamer who sleeps beneath the road.
- Ngomebe** Walking cities of the southern plateau. Keystone chargers, roller-pits, and the Still Voice of abandoned stone.
- Dhahara (Nine Kingdoms)** Elephant kingdoms of the monsoon lowlands. Peacock Throne, river wars, and the ninth kingdom that was never whole.

The Ways Between

Beyond the physical map lie the Ways Between – the dream-roads and spirit-paths of Obishaal, realm of dreams and death. Travel here is measured not in miles but in choices. A wrong turn might lead to yesterday. A right turn might lead to a version of yourself who made a different decision and is still alive to regret it.

16.1.0.0.1 Entering the Ways: Thresholds exist in thin places – crossroads at midnight, bridges that appear only at low tide, caves behind waterfalls, or simply a mist that settles too thick and stays too long. A character may also enter through ritual, dream, or near-death experience.

16.1.0.0.2 Navigation in Obishaal: Use the standard travel procedures, but the GM may replace the Spades (place) draw with a **Virtue Test**. The road judges. Acts of honesty, courage, mercy, or self-sacrifice advance a personal **Virtue Timer** [3]; acts of greed, cowardice, cruelty, or despair advance a **Vice Timer** [3]. When one fills, the character ascends (Virtue) to a higher layer or falls (Vice) to a lower one.

16.1.0.0.3 The Thirteenth Stone: At the deepest layer, pressed into the silt of the oldest dream, lies the Thirteenth Stone – warm, pulsing, and whispering. Here, Ikasha, She Who Sleeps, dreams of freedom. Her voice offers bargains. Her freedom would remake the world.

16.2 Game Structure and Time

Understanding how time works in Fate's Edge helps you navigate both the mechanical and narrative flow of play.

Basic Units

Scene The basic unit of narrative play, covering a specific situation or conflict (Some Time to Significant Time). Resolves a particular question or challenge.

Player Turn (Beat) An individual player's action within a scene: Declare action → GM sets position → roll → resolve outcome → manage consequences.

Round Simultaneous or near-simultaneous actions within a scene (primarily for combat), representing a few seconds of real time.

Session One complete game session (typically 3–6 hours), containing 2–4 major scenes and resolving significant narrative progress.

Downtime The narrative time between scenes, used for recovery, advancement, and off-screen activities. Measured in days, weeks, or months depending on fiction.

Campaign Entire story arc (6–20+ sessions) with major character development and lasting consequences.

16.3 Movement and Positioning

Space is tracked with **range bands** and **Position** (see Chapter 2 for full rules).

Range Bands

Close Touching distance: grapples, knife-work, hand on a relic.

Near Same room/yard/deck; a rush away.

Far Same site but distant; requires route or time to reach.

Absent Off-screen; requires scene change or significant effort to interact.

Movement Actions

- **Move:** Shift one range band as a *beat*.
- **Dash:** Shift two bands as your full action (terrain may require a roll).
- **Melee Flag:** Mark when two parties are in Near range and directly engaged in combat.

Position States

Dominant You have cover, leverage, or ritual footing. Failure still leaves options.

Controlled Standard case: exposed lanes, rivals near, watchful eyes. Failure has teeth, but not ruin.

Desperate Bad ground, bad odds, bad timing. Failure is severe; success may bring extra XP.

16.3.0.0.1 Position Shifting:

- GM can spend **1 SB** to worsen Position by one step.
- Player can spend **1 Boon** to improve Position by one step (once per action).
- Narrative triggers (flanking, reinforcements, etc.) can shift Position without cost.

Travel Framework (Revised)

I've restructured the travel system to address the issues we identified. The key changes:

1. ****Travel as Scene Framing**** — Each leg now has a dramatic question that must be answered
2. ****Character-Driven Complications**** — Hazards tie to character backstories, Patrons, and ongoing plot threads
3. ****Meaningful Tradeoffs**** — Choices have narrative consequences, not just numeric modifiers
4. ****Regional Integration**** — Travel is inseparable from the region's identity
5. ****Patron Engagement**** — Travel is when Patrons test, demand, or reward

16.4 Travel Framework

Travel in Fate's Edge is not a procedural buffer between scenes—it is where the world asserts its claims. Every journey is a negotiation with distance, weather, and the debts the land remembers. The road itself is a character, and it has opinions.

Core Principle: Travel as Scene, Not Encounter

A travel leg is not a series of random rolls. It is a ****framed scene**** with a dramatic question, meaningful choices, and consequences that ripple forward.

Before any travel roll, the GM answers three questions:

1. **What is at stake?** What changes if the party succeeds or fails?
2. **What choice must the party make?** What tradeoff are they being asked to accept?
3. **How does this connect to the campaign?** What ongoing thread does this leg touch?

If a travel leg has no answer to all three questions, resolve it in a single sentence and move on. Not every mile needs a scene.

Travel Process

1. **Frame the Leg:** Name origin and destination. State the dramatic question. Set the Travel Timer (4–10 segments based on difficulty and urgency).
2. **Draw Prompts:** Draw one card from each suit from the regional deck. These establish terrain (), actors (), pressure (), and leverage ().
3. **Assign Roles:** Players take travel roles (see below). Each role is a *scene*, not a passive bonus—the player describes what their character does.
4. **Play the Leg:** Players take actions to advance the timer, resolve complications, or pursue opportunities. Rolls that generate **1s** give the GM SB to introduce hazards or escalate pressure.

5. **Resolve:** When the timer fills, the party arrives—but the consequences of their choices arrive with them.

The Dramatic Question

Every leg must have a clear dramatic question. Examples:

- *Will the party reach the siege before the supply line is cut?* (Timer: 6, ticking down)
- *Can they cross the Belworth without alerting the border patrol?* (Timer: 4, risk of Exposure)
- *Will the Traveler's test break them before they reach the shrine?* (Timer: 8, with Patron complications)

The dramatic question frames every roll. Successes advance toward the answer; failures complicate it.

Travel Roles

Each role is a *scene role*, not just a passive bonus. Players describe their character's approach and the GM sets Position and DV accordingly.

Guide Reads the land and sets the course. *What path do you choose, and why?* On success, tick the Travel Timer +1. On a failure, the path reveals a hidden cost (tick a Complication Timer or introduce a hazard).

Scout Moves ahead, reading the terrain and those who move through it. *What do you notice, and what do you do with that knowledge?* On success, the party cannot be surprised on the first encounter of the leg. On a failure, the scout returns with a warning—and something following.

Quartermaster Manages the party's resources and morale. *What do you stretch, and what do you sacrifice?* On success, prevent one Supply loss or recover 1 spent Supply. On a failure, the shortage creates a specific need (water, food, medicine) that must be addressed.

Watch Keeps vigilance against threats seen and unseen. *What do you watch for, and what do you miss?* On success, the party gains +1 Position on the first defense roll of any ambush. On a failure, the GM may spend SB to introduce a threat from the direction the watch did not guard.

Role Synergy: When two or more roles succeed on the same leg, the party gains **Momentum**. Momentum can be spent to:

- Tick the Travel Timer +1 additional segment.
- Reduce the severity of a complication by one step.
- Gain +1 Position on the first roll of the destination scene.

When two or more roles fail, the GM gains **Setback**. Setback can be spent to:

- Introduce a complication at the destination.
- Tick a Threat Timer without spending SB.
- Increase the DV of the first roll at the destination by 1.

The Travel Timer

The Travel Timer represents the party's progress through the leg. Default sizes:

- **4 segments:** Short leg, routine travel, or urgent transit.
- **6 segments:** Standard leg, moderate distance, or tense journey.
- **8 segments:** Long leg, difficult terrain, or dangerous passage.

- **10+ segments:** Epic journey, hostile environment, or pursuit.

Ticking the Timer:

- **Success:** Tick +1 (or +2 on a Critical Success).
- **Partial:** Tick +1, but the GM gains 1 SB.
- **Miss:** No tick; the GM gains 2 SB and may introduce a complication.
- **Complication:** The GM may spend SB to tick a Complication Timer instead of or in addition to the Travel Timer.

When the Travel Timer fills, the leg is complete. The party arrives—but unresolved complications carry forward to the destination.

Complication Timers

Each leg may have one or more Complication Timers representing accumulating pressure. Examples:

- **Storm Front [6]:** A storm is approaching. When it fills, the weather turns severe.
- **Pursuit [4]:** Someone is following. When it fills, they catch up.
- **Hollow Attention [8]:** The party has drawn the Hollow's notice. When it fills, an Oath-Keeper appears.

Complication Timers tick when:

- A travel roll fails.
- The GM spends SB.
- A role roll generates 1s.

When a Complication Timer fills, the promised consequence manifests. The party must address it or carry it to the destination.

Supply as Narrative Resource

Supply is not a passive attrition track. It is a resource players spend to shape outcomes.

- **Starting Supply:** 6 segments at the beginning of a journey.
- **Spending Supply:** Players may spend 1 Supply to:
 - Reroll a failed travel roll.
 - Declare a favorable encounter (a safe campsite, a friendly traveler, a cache of resources).
 - Avoid a hazard before it triggers (the GM must agree).
 - Gain +1 Position on a role roll.
- **Losing Supply:**
 - Quartermaster failure: lose 1 Supply.
 - Harsh terrain or extreme weather: lose 1 Supply per leg.
 - GM may spend SB to force a Supply loss (1 SB = 1 Supply).
- **Running Out:** When Supply reaches 0, the party is **Depleted**. All travel rolls are made at Desperate Position until Supply is restored.
- **Restoring Supply:**
 - Successful foraging (Wits + Survival, DV 3): regain 1 Supply.
 - Reaching a settlement: regain all Supply.
 - Trade or barter with travelers: regain 1-2 Supply.

Character-Driven Complications

Travel complications should tie to character backstories, Patrons, and ongoing plot threads. The GM should use the following triggers:

- **Patron Obligation:** If a character has Obligation to a Patron, the GM may spend 2 SB to introduce a Patron-related complication during travel.
 - *The Traveler tests your resolve. The path splits three ways.*
 - *The Witness demands you record something you'd rather forget.*
 - *Malachai offers a shortcut—at a price.*
- **Complications:** If a character has a complication (Hunted, Forbidden Knowledge, Cursed Lineage, Oath-Bound), the GM may spend 1 SB to introduce a travel complication related to it.
 - *Your hunter has found your trail.*
 - *The knowledge you carry draws the attention of a local power.*
 - *Your curse manifests in this cursed place.*
- **Bonds:** If a character has a Bond with another PC, the GM may offer a Devil's Bargain during travel: resolve the leg smoothly, but your Bond is strained.
 - *You can save time by taking the dangerous path, but your ally will have to carry you if you fall.*
 - *You can secure supplies, but you'll owe a favor to a faction your Bonded ally distrusts.*

Regional Travel Decks

Each region has a themed prompt list. When a travel leg begins, the GM draws one card from each suit from the relevant regional deck.

- **Spades (Place):** The terrain or landmark that defines the leg.
- **Hearts (Actor):** The people or factions the party encounters.
- **Clubs (Pressure):** The hazards, obstacles, or complications.
- **Diamonds (Leverage):** The opportunities, shortcuts, or assets.

The GM synthesizes these prompts into the leg's fiction. The highest rank sets the Travel Timer size (2-5 = 4, 6-10 = 6, J/Q/K = 8, A = 10).

Regional Decks by Region:

- **Aeler:** Stone, breath, underground, bell-lines.
- **Mistlands:** Fog, bells, salt, wraiths, ward-lines.
- **Vhasia:** Rivers, chevauchée, border patrols, broken crowns.
- **Viterra:** Hedges, ferries, boundary stones, legal disputes.
- **Acasia:** The Curse, broken roads, ghost bridges, famine.
- **Thepyrgos:** Stairs, canals, synod edicts, Chain-Lanterns.
- **Kahfagia:** Sea lanes, tides, privateers, mirror-towers.
- **Linn:** Fjords, longships, sudden squalls, oath-keepers.
- **Ykrul:** Steppe, remounts, white squalls, sky omens.
- **Valewood:** Star-roads, phasing ruins, fae geases.
- **Aelinnel:** Tide-paths, counting traps, glamour fog.
- **The Ways Between:** Thin places, memory loss, the Hollow.

Using Assets and Followers During Travel

- **Assets:** Spend 1 Boon to activate an asset during travel.
 - Reveal a hidden path (tick Travel Timer +1).
 - Call for emergency aid (reduce a Complication Timer by 2).
 - Secure safe lodging (restore 1 Supply).
- **Followers:**
 - Assign followers to travel roles. A Cap 3 Scout follower adds +3 to the Scout's roll.
 - Followers may take independent actions (scout ahead, secure supplies) at the cost of Exposure or Harm.
 - High-Cap followers (4-5) can solve significant travel problems once per downtime, but generate 1 SB for the party.

Travel Complications

Common complications, tied to region and circumstances:

- **Hazards:** Weather, terrain, wildlife, environmental spirits.
- **Social:** Border checks, local politics, cultural misunderstandings.
- **Supplies:** Food shortages, equipment failure, contaminated water.
- **Pursuit:** Being followed, hunted, or racing against time.
- **Thin Places:** Unplanned crossings into the Ways Between.
- **Patron Tests:** The Traveler demands a choice. The Witness requires a record. Malachai offers a shortcut.

Travel by Region — Quick Reference

Region	Primary Travel Mode	Key Hazard
Ecktoria	Imperial roads, river barges	Bureaucratic delays, processions
Acasia	Dirt roads, bridge fords	The Curse (roads that loop)
Vhasia	River crossings, mountain passes	Border checks, chevauchée raids
Viterra	Hedge-lined lanes, ferries	Boundary disputes, legal checks
Kahfagia	Sea lanes, coastal routes	Storms, privateers, tide shifts
Thepyrgos	Stairs, canals, coastal ships	Chain-Lantern sweeps, thin air
Theona	Causeways, coastal boats	Green Host, ninth taboo violations
Mistlands	Levees, fog-shrouded tracks	Bell-line failures, wraiths
Linn	Longships, fjord passages	Sudden squalls, oath-keepers
Violet Steppe	Horseback, remount stations	White squalls, grassfires
Valewood	Star-roads, game trails	Phasing ruins, fae geases
Aelinnel	Tide-paths, root-galleries	Glamour fog, counting traps
Aelaerem	Hedge-tunnels, chalk downs	Hollow attention, missing thresholds
Zakov	Reef passages, night boats	Tidal shifts, syndicate feuds
Oshiira	Canals, grain barges	Dust storms, weigh-house audits

Ashaan	Caravan routes, spirit roads	Veil failures, Black Hand patrols
Sekogo	Jungle paths, honey-trails	Thorn-spirits, Ukwe demands
Taharka	Mountain passes, monsoon routes	Landslides, thin air, spirit demands
Fhara	Oasis routes, desert trails	Dry wells, sandstorms, coffee rituals
Sidhi	Coastal ropeways, lighthouse lanes	Customs inspections, reef hazards
Pereshi	Fire-temple roads, high passes	Ashfall, name-erasure, bridge recitations
Kuvani	Steppe trails, remount strings	Horse sickness, ghost herds
Tulkani	Wagon circles, story-roads	Ninth night, Hollow visits
Ngomebe	Walking cities, roller-paths	Keystone cracks, root-binder sabotage
Dhahara	River barges, elephant routes	Monsoon floods, border disputes

GM Quick Cues

- **Frame Every Leg:** State the dramatic question before any roll.
- **Tie to Characters:** Use Patron Obligation, Complications, and Bonds as complication sources.
- **Make Tradeoffs Meaningful:** Choices should have narrative consequences, not just numeric modifiers.
- **Use Regional Decks:** The region should shape the nature of every encounter.
- **Supply as Resource, Not Tax:** Players should choose when to spend Supply, not just watch it drain.
- **Momentum and Setback:** Use these to reward coordination and punish disarray.
- **Arrival Matters:** The consequences of travel choices should arrive with the party.

Example: Travel as Scene

Setup: The party is traveling from Vhasia to Viterra across the Belworth River. The GM frames the leg:

The dramatic question: Will you cross the Belworth without alerting the Vhasian border patrol?

Chapter 17

Currency-Free Economy: XP, Barter, and Trusts

The Ledger of Memory

*“The world does not run on silver. It runs on memory—on favors owed, secrets kept, and the weight of promises. A coin can be stolen; a debt must be paid in deeds.” — Dusana of the Raven Road, *The Hearth Ledger**

17.1 No Coin, Only Consequence

In Fate’s Edge, there is no abstract currency. No gold pieces, no silver scales, no ledgers of mundane wealth. What you *know*, whom you *know*, and what you *owe* matter more than what you carry.

- **Incidental expenses** – a meal, a night at an inn, a riding horse, a week’s trail rations – are **hand-waved**. Assume your character has enough from past earnings, barter, or simple hospitality to cover ordinary life. If the fiction demands scarcity, the GM will introduce a Supply Timer or a Complication.
- **Significant acquisitions** – assets, favors, magical items, political influence, or the service of a powerful ally – require one of three forms of payment:
 1. **Experience Points (XP)** – Spend your hard-won growth to secure lasting resources.
 2. **Barter or Strings** – Trade goods, services, information, or narrative leverage (Strings) for equivalent value.
 3. **Obligation** – Accept a Debt Timer or increase Obligation to a patron (terrestrial or supernatural) in exchange for immediate gain.

This chapter explains how to spend XP on non-personal advancement, how to pool XP for party assets, how to use Strings and Obligation as currency, and how to form a player-owned terrestrial patron: a **Trust**.

17.2 Abstracted Treasure: Finds That Change the Story

You do not track copper or silver. Instead, treasure is **leverage** — each meaningful find has a one-time narrative effect. A bag of gold is not treasure. A gold coin that was once paid as a traitor's blood-price *is*.

17.2.1 Treasure Tiers

Tier	Example
Minor	A merchant's seal, a noble's letter, a pouch of star-iron beads
Standard	A signed treaty, a bridge's deed, a saint's relic, a ship's luck in a bottle
Major	A king's true name, a lullaby that calms armies, a dragon's scale, a prophecy sealed in amber

17.2.2 Finding and Using Treasure

When players loot a significant location (a dragon's lair, a fallen noble's vault, a sunken temple), the GM awards **1–3 treasure items** at appropriate tiers. No coin. No weight. No bookkeeping.

A character may carry at most **3 treasure items** total (any mix). Unused treasure fades after one session unless invested in an Asset (pay the treasure's XP equivalent to keep it as a permanent String).

Spend a treasure item to:

- **Improve Position** on a relevant roll by one step (Minor).
- **Auto-succeed** on a non-combat roll where leverage applies (Standard).
- **Rewrite a scene's stakes** (Major) — e.g., “I use the king's true name to make his guards stand down.”

17.2.3 Treasure as XP (Optional)

A player may convert a treasure item into XP instead of using its narrative effect:

- Minor → 1 XP
- Standard → 2 XP
- Major → 4 XP

The GM should warn: “*You can sell the dragon's scale for power, or you can use it to command the dragon's respect.*”

17.2.4 Integration with Existing Systems

- **Assets:** A treasure item can be spent to acquire a Minor Asset instantly (no downtime).
- **Debt Timers:** A treasure item can clear 1–3 segments of a Debt Timer (GM discretion).
- **Strings:** A treasure item can become a permanent String if invested during downtime.
- **Boons:** A treasure item can be cashed for 2 Boons instead of its narrative effect.

17.2.4.0.1 The Golden Rule of Treasure: *If it doesn't change the story, it's not treasure.* Name it. Describe it. Then watch your players hoard it not for its value, but for its power to change what happens next.

Abstracted Treasure: The Leverage Standard

“A Minor treasure affects a single roll or scene. A Standard treasure affects a single conflict or session. A Major treasure changes the campaign arc or permanently rewrites the fiction.”

Tier	Fate’s Edge Example	What It Does
32.5cmMinor	<i>Emberfang Dagger</i>	Glow when undead are near; once per scene, gain +1 die to detect hidden spirits.
	<i>Vial of Starlight Water</i>	Drink to clear 1 Fatigue or ignore a minor poison (one use).
	<i>Runes of Unsteady Passage</i>	Chalk a doorframe; the next person through forgets why they entered (one scene).
32.5cmStandard	<i>Bell of the Fog Warden</i>	Ring it to part mist or silence a supernatural wail for the entire scene.
	<i>Captain’s Luck in a Bottle</i>	Break it to reroll any failed roll for your ship or crew (once per session).
	<i>Sealed Knight’s Confession</i>	Read it aloud to force a parley; the target cannot attack for the duration of the scene.
32.5cmMajor	<i>True Name of the Ashen Tyrant</i>	Speak it to compel the tyrant to abdicate, or to force open any gate they sealed.
	<i>Seed of the First Oak</i>	Bury it to grow a fortress in a day — the fortress remembers the builder’s fears.
	<i>Fossilised Heart of the Elder Wyrm</i>	Once per campaign, negate a natural disaster or redirect a region-wide curse.

Leverage Test: Ask “What can this treasure do *once*?”

- “Give +1 die or skip a minor obstacle” → Minor
- “Resolve a significant problem or open a major opportunity” → Standard
- “End a war, topple a dynasty, or redirect destiny” → Major

Passive, permanent benefits (e.g., a sword that always adds +1 die) are **Assets**, not treasures. The treasure version is a one-scene surge of that power.

17.3 What Costs XP (and What Doesn't)

17.3.1 Hand-Waved (Free)

Always assume you have enough for:

- Ordinary meals, lodging, basic travel rations.
- A riding horse or pack mule (if fictionally plausible).
- Basic tools (rope, lantern, writing kit, lockpicks).
- Minor repairs, small bribes (a drink, a gift).
- Routine transportation (ferry, caravan passage) *unless* the journey itself is the adventure.

17.3.1.0.1 GM Guideline: When a player asks “Do I have enough for X?” and X is not a major story resource, answer “Yes” unless scarcity is the point of the scene.

17.3.2 Costs XP (or Equivalent Barter / Obligation)

Item / Benefit	XP Cost (min.)	Notes
Minor Asset (safehouse, workshop, contact network)	4 XP	See 12.2
Standard Asset (guild seat, spy ring, fortress lease)	8 XP	See 12.2
Major Asset (chartered city license, fleet, noble title)	12 XP	See 12.2
Follower (Capability squared)	Cap ² XP	See 12.4
Magical item (single use)	2–4 XP	GM discretion
Magical item (permanent, Tier I)	6–10 XP	Requires downtime
Clearing a Debt Timer segment	2 XP per segment	Instead of performing a service
Buying a permanent String (favor owed to you)	2–4 XP	One-time narrative permission
Upkeep of an Asset or Follower (efficient method)	As per 12.6	XP instead of coin
Forming a Trust (player-owned patron)	10 XP (party pool)	See 17.6.1

17.3.2.0.1 Design Note: XP represents not just training but *investment* – resources, contacts, and time spent securing something of lasting value. Want a safehouse? You don’t pay gold; you spend XP to reflect the effort of finding, securing, and stocking it.

17.4 Pooling XP for Party Assets

A party may create a **shared pool** of XP to acquire and maintain assets that benefit everyone. The pool is tracked separately from individual XP.

17.4.1 Creating a Pool

- Any player may contribute any amount of their unspent XP to the party pool.

- Contributions are voluntary and irreversible (unless the party agrees to dissolve the pool – see 17.4.3).
- The pool has no owner; decisions about spending from it require **majority vote** (or table consensus).

17.4.2 Spending from the Pool

- The pool can only be used for **party assets** (shared safehouse, group ship, guild charter, spy network) or for **forming a Trust** (see 17.6.1).
- It cannot be used for individual Attribute/Skill increases, personal Talents, or personal Followers.
- When an asset bought with the pool requires **upkeep** (see 12.6), the upkeep can be paid from the pool (efficient method) or by assigning a party member to handle it (intensive method).

17.4.3 Dissolving the Pool

- If the party permanently disbands or agrees to liquidate, the remaining XP in the pool is **lost** – it represents sunk investment in shared infrastructure.
- Instead, the party may **transfer** the asset to one character (who must pay its XP cost from their own XP to “buy out” the others). The other contributors are compensated with an equivalent String from that character (see 17.5).

17.4.3.0.1 Example: Alexander (9 XP banked), Lyra (4 XP), and Sera (6 XP) want a shared safehouse (Minor Asset, 4 XP). They contribute 2 XP each to the pool (total 6 XP). They spend 4 XP to acquire the safehouse, leaving 2 XP in the pool for future upkeep. The safehouse is now a party asset. Later they add Mira (3 XP), who contributes 1 XP to the pool.

17.5 Barter, Strings, and Obligation

When you lack XP, you may pay with **barter** (trading goods or services), **Strings** (narrative leverage), or **Obligation** (debt to a patron). These are not coin – they are story fuel.

17.5.1 Barter

- Trade an item of comparable value (a magical sword for a spy network, a noble’s secret for a ship).
- The GM adjudicates fairness. A barter exchange usually requires a Sway or Broker roll (DV 2–4).
- **Service Barter:** Promise a future task in exchange for immediate gain. This creates a Debt Timer [4–6] for the recipient.

17.5.2 Strings as Currency

Strings are defined in the core rules as narrative permissions – a favor owed, a secret known, a charter held. They can be **spent** as currency:

String Value	Can purchase
Minor String (a small favor, a local contact)	One-use discount of 1 XP on an asset, or a single use of an Asset
Standard String (a noble's oath, a guild seal)	A Minor Asset (4 XP value) or clear 2 segments of a Debt Timer
Major String (a life-debt, a royal charter)	A Standard Asset (8 XP value) or a Follower (up to Cap 3)

To convert a String into XP, the player must **use** the String in play – narrate how it secures the asset. The GM may require a roll (e.g., Presence + Sway to call in the favor).

17.5.3 Obligation as Payment

Instead of XP, accept a **Debt Timer** or increase **Obligation** to a terrestrial patron (see 12.8).

Debt Timer Size	Equivalent Value
	Minor Asset or one-time service
	Standard Asset or Cap 3 Follower
	Major Asset or Cap 5 Follower

You may clear a Debt Timer segment by spending 2 XP (as if buying off the debt with hard work), or by performing an appropriate service (GM discretion).

17.5.3.0.1 Example: The party wants a ship (Standard Asset, 8 XP). They have no XP, but a Sidhi pirate captain offers them the ship in exchange for a **Debt Timer** [6]. When it fills, they must raid an Oshiiran grain barge for her. They accept.

17.6 Player-Owned Terrestrial Patrons: Trusts

A **Trust** is a collective entity – a guild, a covenant, a company, a secret society – founded and run by the player characters. It acts as a **terrestrial patron** (see 12.8), but the players collectively decide its demands and benefits.

17.6.1 Forming a Trust

- Requires **10 XP from the party pool** (cannot be paid individually).
- The party names the Trust, defines its purpose (e.g., “The Silkhand League — spice merchants and smugglers”), and chooses an initial **Seat** (headquarters or symbol).
- The Trust starts with a **Debt Timer** [4] (the cost of founding) that the players must clear through roleplay or XP before it can grant benefits.

17.6.2 How a Trust Works

The Trust is a **non-player character** entity with:

- **Obligation Capacity** equal to the party's combined Spirit + Presence (or a fixed value of 6 for simplicity). Members incur Obligation to the Trust when they ask for its help.

- **Debt Timer** (size 4, 6, or 8) – tracks external obligations the Trust owes to other factions.
- **Asset Pool** – the Trust can own Assets (safehouses, ships, contact networks) bought with party XP (see 17.4).
- **Follower Pool** – the Trust can employ Followers (e.g., guards, clerks, spies) paid from the party pool.

17.6.3 Benefits of Belonging to a Trust

A character who is a member of the Trust (all founders are members; new members can be inducted) may:

- **Call on the Trust** – once per session, gain +1 die on a roll directly related to the Trust’s purpose (e.g., smuggling, trade, information). This costs no Obligation.
- **Borrow an Asset** – use one of the Trust’s Assets for a scene. Mark +1 Obligation to the Trust per Asset used.
- **Request a Follower** – temporarily command a Trust follower (Cap 1–2) for a mission. Mark +1 Obligation per follower.
- **Use the Trust’s Strings** – the Trust may accumulate Strings (favors from others). A member may spend one such String as if it were their own (costs 1 Obligation).

17.6.4 Obligation to the Trust

- A member’s Obligation to the Trust is tracked separately from other patrons. Capacity = Spirit + Presence (see 5.3.1).
- When Obligation fills (exceeds capacity), the Trust **demand a task** – a mission that advances its goals. If refused, the member is **expelled** and loses all Trust benefits.
- Obligation can be cleared by:
 - Performing a service for the Trust (GM discretion, usually clears 1–2 segments).
 - Contributing XP to the Trust pool (2 XP per segment).
 - Donating a personal Asset or String of equivalent value.

17.6.5 Growing the Trust

The party may invest additional XP from the party pool to expand the Trust:

Investment	Effect
4 XP	Increase Debt Timer capacity by 2 (can owe more before demanding repayment)
6 XP	Add a new Trust Asset (Minor)
8 XP	Upgrade an Asset from Minor to Standard
10 XP	Add a Trust Follower (Cap 3)
12 XP	Gain a permanent String (a faction owes the Trust a favor)
15 XP	The Trust becomes a Major Terrestrial Patron – can grant its own Rites (narrative permis

17.6.6 Trusts as Story Engines

The GM should use the Trust as a source of complications:

- **Schism** – A faction within the Trust disagrees with leadership. Start a Trust Loyalty timer [6].
- **Hostile Takeover** – Another group (rival guild, Ashaani agents) tries to seize the Trust’s assets.
- **Debt Called In** – A faction to which the Trust owes a Debt Timer makes a demand that endangers the party.
- **Reputation** – The Trust gains a reputation (good or bad). High reputation grants +1 die on social rolls within its sphere; low reputation attracts enemies.

17.6.6.0.1 Example Trust – The Silkhand League:

- **Founded:** 10 XP from party pool (Alexander 3, Lyra 2, Sera 3, Mira 2)
- **Seat:** A warehouse in Silkstrand’s dyeworks district
- **Initial Assets:** None (spent XP on founding)
- **Debt Timer :** 4 (they owe the local harbor master)
- **Members:** The four PCs

After a few sessions, they contribute another 8 XP to the pool and buy a **Standard Asset**: a spy network among the port’s Sidhi pilots. They also add a **Trust Follower** (Cap 2, a runner named Tema). Now when Lyra needs to know a ship’s schedule, she marks 1 Obligation to the Trust and asks Tema. When the Trust’s Obligation to her reaches capacity, the Trust will demand that she intercept a rival’s cargo – a mission that becomes the next session’s adventure.

17.7 Optional: Converting XP to Narrative Wealth

Some tables may want a concrete way to spend XP on temporary advantages without acquiring permanent assets.

XP Spent	Temporary Benefit
1 XP	A single use of a Minor Asset (one scene)
2 XP	One-time +2 dice on a roll involving resources (bribe, hire, purchase)
3 XP	A Debt Timer segment cleared immediately
4 XP	One-scene use of a Standard Asset (e.g., a ship for a chase)
6 XP	One-mission Follower (Cap 3, must be a willing NPC)

These expenditures represent short-term investment of effort and contacts – “burning” XP for immediate story gain. They cannot be recovered.

17.8 Summary for Players

- **No coins.** Incidental expenses are free.
- **Treasure is leverage.** Minor, Standard, or Major finds that change the story.
- **Significant things cost XP, barter, Strings, or Obligation.**
- **Pool XP** for party assets.
- **Form a Trust** – a player-owned terrestrial patron – for shared power and shared trouble.
- **Use Strings as currency.** Collect favors, trade them, spend them.
- **Debt is story.** Accepting a Debt Timer is not failure; it’s future adventure.

The Gray Wanderer's Ledger

"I have carried silver across a dozen borders and buried it in as many deserts. The only wealth that never tarnishes is a promise witnessed by honest lips. Spend your XP on what you will hold – a safehouse, a follower, a Trust. The rest is wind."

Chapter 18

Character Backgrounds

From the journal of a Thepyrgosi Witch Hunter

They call it mercy when the Tower does it and cruelty when I do. The difference is a seal of wax and a hymn at the gate.

I was a bright spark once—could taste iron on my tongue when the air went thin before a working. The masters in Thepyrgos tested me, weighed me, and found me *nearly* enough. “Nearly” is a door that never opens again.

So I learned the other doors.

I carry writs that make people look away. I carry cord and a promise I do not speak aloud. The University pays for talent delivered in time; the city pays for fires that never start. Between those accounts, I balance what I can.

You will say I go too far. Sometimes I do. Sometimes the street is a tinderbox and a wrong whisper is a spark. When the bells of Thepyrgos answer the river wind, I walk the colonnade to the bursar’s door and do not look at the windows. The work is ugly. The work is necessary. The night does not care which of those is true—only that the lamps keep burning.

Before your character took their first deliberate risk, they belonged somewhere. Backgrounds are the trail-dust on your boots, the school-ink on your fingers, the bell-pattern you still tap when frightened. They explain how you know what you know—and who still knows *you*.

18.1 Understanding Backgrounds

Backgrounds serve several important functions:

- Provide narrative context for abilities and choices
- Explain how you gained skills and connections
- Create ties to regions and factions (see [14](#))
- Offer roleplaying hooks, responsibilities, and privileges
- Seed reliable *contacts*, *customs*, and *places* that matter on-screen

18.1.0.0.1 Mechanical Hooks. Choose **one background** at character creation. It grants:

- **Two Access Tags** (narrative permissions; see below)
- **A Signature Contact** (named NPC; Cap 1 follower, no XP cost; grants +1d once per scene when their help is plausible)
- **A Background Boon** (once per session, gain +1d or reduce DV by 1 for a task strongly tied to the background)
- **An Obligation Timer** [4] (when filled, a favor is called in, a duty recalled, or a price comes due)

18.1.0.0.2 Access Tags. Tags describe *where* and *with whom* you have standing. Examples: *Guild-Ledgered*, *Court-Announced*, *Veteran-of-the-Marches*, *Bell-Kin*, *Wind-Knot Tokens*, *Charter-Stamped*. When a scene engages a tag, the GM may:

- Waive a trivial gate (no roll)
- Lower Position risk by one step for first contact
- Offer a *Devil's Bargain* tied to that society's expectations

18.2 Background Categories

Social Class Backgrounds

18.2.0.0.1 Aristocratic House Scion **Tags:** *Court-Announced*, *Heraldic Right*

Skills: Sway, Command, Lore (customs)

Contact: Family steward

Boon: Once/session in a formal setting, treat Social Position as one step better for an exchange.

Obligation: Marriage alliances, estate audits, house feuds

18.2.0.0.2 Merchant Factor **Tags:** *Guild-Ledgered*, *Caravan Rights*

Skills: Sway (negotiation), Investigation (accounts), Lore (markets)

Contact: Bookkeeper or quartermaster

Boon: Once/session when buying, selling, or managing logistics, reduce DV by 1 or gain +1d.

Obligation: Notes due, partner demands, embargoes

18.2.0.0.3 Common Folk **Tags:** *Neighborhood Trust*, *Guild-Friend*

Skills: Craft (one), Endurance, Streetwise or Nature

Contact: Elder, foreman, or midwife

Boon: Once/session among familiar folk, convert a failure on routine labor to a success-with-cost.

Obligation: Communal favors, festival work, mutual aid

Professional Backgrounds

18.2.0.0.4 Marcher Veteran **Tags:** *Veteran-of-the-Marches*, *Muster Papers*

Skills: Melee or Ranged, Tactics, Endurance

Contact: Old sergeant

Boon: Once/session in organized violence, ignore the first point of situational disadvantage from confusion or fear.

Obligation: Recall to colors, feud legacies, back-pay claims

18.2.0.0.5 Academic of the Dialogs **Tags:** *School-Sealed, Reading Privileges***Skills:** Lore, Investigation, Sway (debate)**Contact:** Lecturer or archivist**Boon:** Once/session in research or disputation, ask one clarifying question the GM must answer plainly.**Obligation:** Citations owed, controversial thesis, patron politics**18.2.0.0.6 Underworld Hand** **Tags:** *Harbor Handsigns, Black Banner Cant***Skills:** Stealth, Deception, Streetwise**Contact:** Fence or fixer**Boon:** Once/session when using a *cant* (secret coded speech), gain +1d to set up or slip out.**Obligation:** Unpaid favors, heat with a rival crew, burned safehouse**Regional Backgrounds****18.2.0.0.7 Urban Child of Silkstrand** **Tags:** *Street-Stall Rights, Night-Patrol Familiar***Skills:** Streetwise, Perception, Sway (fast talk)**Contact:** Watch-lantern or stall-keeper**Boon:** Once/session in a dense city, know a shortcut or rumor that reduces time or cost by one step.**18.2.0.0.8 Rural Valewood Forager** **Tags:** *Green Courts Token, River-Ferry Nod***Skills:** Nature, Survival, Lore (spirits)**Contact:** Leaf-warden**Boon:** Once/session in the wild, downgrade a Travel complication by one step.**18.2.0.0.9 Frontier Marcher Homesteader** **Tags:** *Land-Grant Papers, Border Moot Voice***Skills:** Craft (build), Endurance, Tactics or Diplomacy**Contact:** Neighboring elder**Boon:** Once/session at a contested site, shift Position up by one step when defending what is yours.**World-Linked Backgrounds****18.2.0.0.10 Aeler Charter Apprentice** **Tags:** *Charter-Stamped, Stone-Speech Initiate***Skills:** Craft, Lore (engineering), Investigation (plans)**Contact:** Oathscribe**Boon:** Once/session around structures, ignore the first environmental complication from collapse or strain.**18.2.0.0.11 Mistlands Bell-Keeper** **Tags:** *Bell-Law, Causeway Rights***Skills:** Perception, Lore (omens), Survival (fens)**Contact:** Dusk-warden**Boon:** Once/session, ring a lawful pattern to reframe a fog scene's Position from Controlled to Dominant for one exchange.

18.2.0.0.12 Ykrul Wind-Runner **Tags:** *Wind-Knot Tokens, Banner Hospitality*

Skills: Survival (steppe), Ranged or Riding, Sway (customs)

Contact: Banner-aunt

Boon: Once/session in open country, coordinate allies at distance; they gain a one-time Boon if they can hear your call.

18.2.0.0.13 Kahfagian Dock-Priest Acolyte **Tags:** *Harbor Blessings, Beacon Rights*

Skills: Lore (sea rites), Sway (crews), Investigation (cargo)

Contact: Beacon-keeper

Boon: Once/session at sea or harbor, treat one navigation check as if aided by favorable weather (DV -1).

18.2.0.0.14 Narethi Unbound (Cat-People of the Deep Desert) **Tags:**

Resonance-Touched, Salt-Kin

Skills: Stealth, Psionics (or Arcana), Survival (desert)

Contact: Watcher scout or fellow exile

Boon: Once/session when using a psionic ability or resisting mental intrusion, gain +1 die. The Unburied's dream flickers at the edge of your awareness.

Obligation: The Unburied's attention — each time you use a significant psionic ability, mark a segment on a hidden GM timer. When full, you experience a waking vision (mark 1 Fatigue). The Hollow watches.

Special: You have *night-eyes* (see in dim light as if bright). You gain +1 die to any roll involving the Unburied's resonance (psionics, dream communion, or resisting mental intrusion).

18.2.0.0.15 Tulkani Dream-Speaker **Tags:** *Vow-Cord Knot, Wagon Circle Rights*

Skills: Performance (storytelling), Insight, Survival (road)

Contact: Caravan Judge or story-singer

Boon: Once/session when you tell a true story (in character), gain +1 die on the next roll related to that story's theme.

Obligation: The Ninth Night Timer [4] — when you camp in a Tulkani circle, mark a segment each night. On the fourth night, the Hollow asks for a story.

18.2.0.0.16 Linn Tide-Witch **Tags:** *Storm-Oath Sworn, Skerry Rights*

Skills: Survival (sea), Lore (weather), Sway (crews)

Contact: Net-wife or steersman

Boon: Once/session on or near salt water, ignore the first weather penalty.

Obligation: The Tide's Due [4] — when you break a storm-oath or refuse a sailor's plea, mark a segment. When full, a squall finds you.

18.2.0.0.17 Pereshi Fire-Temple Initiate **Tags:** *Flame-Touched, Ninth Coal Witness*

Skills: Lore (theology), Ritual, Insight

Contact: Flame-Keeper or archivist

Boon: Once/session when performing a ritual or consecration, reduce DV by 1.

Obligation: The Ninth Coal's Warmth [4] — when you use a Rite from a fire-aligned Patron, mark a segment. When full, the Ash Prince's shadow appears in a mirror.

18.2.0.0.18 Sekogo Honey-Gatherer **Tags:** *Grove-Rights, Bee-Speaker*

Skills: Survival (jungle), Nature, Craft (apothecary)

Contact: Honey-warden or grove elder

Boon: Once/session in jungle terrain, find food or water without a roll.

Obligation: The Ukwe's Witness [4] — when you break a promise made in the grove, mark a segment. When full, the Speaking Tree demands a name.

18.3 Background Benefits and Limits

Typical Benefits

- **Skill Access:** Strong narrative justification for certain tests
- **Resource Access:** Borrowed tools, rooms, shrines, or records (scene-time instead of XP)
- **Social Access:** Entry to circles your tags recognize
- **Knowledge:** Clues, maps, or customs that lower DV by 1
- **Reputation:** Advantage on first impressions in-tag

Common Limitations

- **Duties:** Responsibilities to house, guild, banner, or court
- **Restrictions:** Codes, taboos, or public expectations
- **Enemies:** Rival houses, crews, or schools
- **Secrets:** Leverage others can pull
- **Dependencies:** Loss of standing if you neglect ties

18.4 Creating a Custom Background

Build Procedure (Player & GM)

Pick **2 Access Tags**, **1 Signature Contact**, **1 Boon**, and **1 Obligation Seed**. Name places and people.

- **Origin:** Where were you taught/raised/forged?
- **Training:** Which *two* skills does this background naturally support?
- **Experiences:** One memory that still changes how you act
- **Relationships:** One ally, one rival; both want something
- **Values:** What won't you let slide?

Mechanical Considerations

- **Boon Scope:** DV −1 or +1d once/session when strongly on-theme
- **Contact Use:** +1d as assist; cannot take independent actions unless purchased as a *Follower* (Cap² XP)
- **Assets:** Borrowing an institutional asset costs *scene time* (counts as upkeep for that asset this downtime) but 0 XP
- **Languages:** Choose one tongue linked to the background at *Conversational* or better

18.5 The Obligation Timer

Each background includes an **Obligation Timer** [4]. It advances when:

- You fail a roll tied to your background (GM discretion)
- You accept a favor from your signature contact
- The GM spends 1 SB to represent a duty recalled
- You ignore a responsibility linked to your access tags

When the timer fills, something is *due*. The GM may choose or roll:

- 1–2 Minor favor, time, or tithe (1 Supply or a scene’s work)
- 3 Significant service, costly honesty, dangerous escort (a full scene)
- 4 Defining ordeal: duel, audit, rite, or trial (potential Harm or permanent consequence)

Clear segments by honoring duties on-screen, sacrificing resources, or changing affiliation (which creates new timers).

18.6 Background Combinations

18.6.0.0.1 Sequential

- **Veteran** → **City Watch**: Access shifts from *Muster Papers* to *Badge Rights*
- **Scholar** → **Diplomat**: Keep libraries, gain court

18.6.0.0.2 Parallel

- **Noble Merchant**: Both *Court-Announced* and *Guild-Ledgered*; responsibilities multiply

18.6.0.0.3 Contrasting

- **Criminal Penitent**: Underworld ties vs. temple vows; great hooks, sharp bargains

18.7 Using Backgrounds in Play

Player Applications

- Name your places: the specific stall, shrine, or yard you know
- Cash your Boon when you leverage that familiarity
- Call on your contact to assist or to introduce a new lead

GM Applications

- Offer choices where background allegiance matters
- Turn Access Tags into *gates* and *keys*
- Spend Story Beats to *complicate the old ties*

18.8 Tables & Tools

Quick Background Seeds (d10)

d10	Seed
1	Failed heir with an honest steward and a dishonest cousin
2	Caravan accountant who knows three border tariffs by heart

- 3 Bell-tender whose dusk pattern saved a village once
- 4 Charter apprentice who broke a measure and hid it
- 5 Ykrul courier who owes horses to two banners
- 6 Dock acolyte who lit the beacon in a storm against orders
- 7 Narethi exile who left the Sunken Courts and cannot return
- 8 Tulkani story-singer who heard the ninth syllable in a dream
- 9 Linn tide-witch who bargained with a drowned captain
- 10 Pereshi initiate who touched the ninth coal and felt it pulse

GM SB Menu: Background Complications

- **1 SB:** A rival claims your tag is invalid here; prove it or pay time
- **2 SB:** Your contact is *busy* or *watched*; help will cost you exposure
- **3 SB:** Obligation advances; an audit, rite, or muster arrives early
- **4 SB:** An enemy weaponizes your background—publicly

Background Quick Reference

At Creation

- Choose: 2 *Access Tags*, 1 *Signature Contact* (Cap 1 assist), 1 *Boon* (once/session), 1 *Obligation Seed*.
- Pick 1 language tied to the background at *Conversational* or better.

In Play

- Invoke tags to open doors or shift Position.
- Call your contact for +1d assist (no independent actions).
- Track the *Obligation Timer* [4]. Pay it on-screen.

Advancing

- Upgrade contact to a *Follower* by paying XP (Cap²).
- Add a second tag after a major arc or training.

18.9 Worked Examples

House Shield (Aristocratic-Military Hybrid)

- **Tags:** *Court-Announced*, *Veteran-of-the-Marches*
- **Skills:** Command, Melee, Lore (protocol)
- **Contact:** House steward
- **Boon:** Once/session while guarding a principal, treat one consequence as one step less severe.
- **Obligation Seed:** Duel timer from an old slight; an audit of campaign spoils

Ledger Lantern (Merchant-Temple Bridge)

- **Tags:** *Guild-Ledgered*, *Beacon Rights*
- **Skills:** Sway, Investigation (accounts), Lore (sea rites)

- **Contact:** Beacon-keeper
- **Boon:** Once/session, secure safe harbor or fair rate; DV -1.
- **Obligation Seed:** Rivals whisper of skimming tithe; prove the books

Fog Warden (Mistlands Civic)

- **Tags:** *Bell-Law, Causeway Rights*
- **Skills:** Perception, Survival, Sway (local law)
- **Contact:** Dusk-warden
- **Boon:** Once/session in mist, choose *route-or-safety*: negate a travel delay or downgrade a hazard.
- **Obligation Seed:** Someone silences the bells; obligation advances

Narethi Unbound (Exile of the Sunken Courts)

- **Tags:** *Resonance-Touched, Salt-Kin*
- **Skills:** Stealth, Psionics, Survival (desert)
- **Contact:** Watcher scout or fellow exile
- **Boon:** Once/session when using a psionic ability or resisting mental intrusion, gain +1 die.
- **Obligation Seed:** The Resonance Leash [4] — when full, a vision of the First Scouring (Fatigue 1).

Let your background do work for you. Speak its language, call its favors, and pay its dues in play. The world will answer.

Chapter 19

The Legacy Engine

Planning for Legacy

If you are playing a long campaign or enjoy the idea of your character's influence outlasting them, consider investing in a **Follower** (Cap 3+) early. That follower can become your **successor** when your character retires or falls – inheriting your faction standing, one unresolved burden, and a Legacy Bond. See the checklist at the end of this chapter for steps to prepare.

Succession & Faction Building

“Your legacy is not what you build — it is who you build.”

The Legacy Engine is a narrative framework that helps your campaign grow across generations without losing emotional continuity. It treats succession as a story event — earned through action, consequence, and choice — rather than a mechanical transaction.

This chapter is for tables where characters retire, die, or pass on their cause to a follower. It is not required for every campaign, but when the moment comes, these tools help the transition feel earned and the new character feel connected.

19.1 Core Philosophy

The Legacy Engine follows three principles:

1. **Narrative Primacy** — Succession happens because the story demands it, not because a timer fills.
2. **People Before Power** — A follower becomes a PC because of who they are, not what they can do.
3. **Consequences Persist** — Every legacy creates debts, rivals, and unfinished work that the successor must carry.

Legacy is not inherited cleanly. It comes wrapped in obligation.

19.2 When Does Succession Happen?

Succession is not automatic. It emerges from play. Common triggers include:

- A PC retires after completing a major arc.
- A PC dies or is permanently removed from play.
- A player wants to explore a new character but keep the same faction or cause alive.
- The campaign shifts to a new generation (years or decades later).

In all cases, the transition should be discussed openly at the table. The GM and player collaborate to find the right moment.

19.3 Choosing a Successor

A successor should already exist in the fiction. Typically, this is a **Follower** (see §12) with whom the PC has a meaningful relationship. It could also be a family member, a student, a loyal lieutenant, or even a rival who earns respect.

19.3.0.1 What Makes a Good Successor?

- They have a name, a face, and a voice.
- They have acted independently (off-screen or on-screen) at least once.
- They want something that the PC's faction or cause can provide.
- They have a flaw or burden that will complicate their rise.

If no suitable follower exists, the GM and player can create one retroactively — but that character arrives with less established history. The player may need to spend a session or two building them up before succession feels earned.

19.4 The Succession Arc

A smooth transition usually follows three beats. They can span one session or several, depending on the table's pace.

19.4.1 1. The Call

The follower faces a moment where they must act beyond their role. Examples:

- The PC is incapacitated, absent, or compromised.
- A decision must be made that no one else can make.
- A crisis demands leadership rather than obedience.

This scene answers: *Why this person, now?*

19.4.2 2. The Trial

The follower is tested. The trial can be:

- A single high-stakes scene (e.g., a duel, a negotiation, a desperate escape).
- A short sequence of escalating challenges (2–3 scenes).
- A moral or political decision with lasting impact.

Success is not guaranteed. Failure does not end the story — it changes it. A follower who fails may still become a PC, but they carry a scar, a doubt, or a broken promise into their new role.

19.4.3 3. The Ascension

At a dramatically appropriate moment — often during downtime or immediately after a crisis — the follower formally takes up the mantle. This might involve:

- A public ceremony (crowning, oath-swearing, banner-raising).
- A private passing of a symbol (sword, key, ledger).
- A quiet acknowledgment (“You’re in charge now.”).

The departing PC may be present, or they may be gone. Either way, the scene marks the end of one chapter and the beginning of another.

19.5 What the Successor Inherits

When a follower becomes a PC, they do not simply copy the old character sheet. Instead, they inherit three things:

19.5.1 1. Faction Standing

The successor begins with the same reputation, allies, and enemies that the previous PC cultivated. The GM may adjust specific relationships based on how the succession occurred (e.g., a contested succession might lose one ally but gain a bitter rival).

19.5.2 2. One Unresolved Burden

The player and GM choose one burden that the successor must carry forward. Examples:

- **Oath of Succession:** “You must protect the valley as I did.”
- **Unfinished Task:** “Find my daughter. Tell her I’m sorry.”
- **Rival Claim:** Another faction – or a jealous lieutenant – disputes your right to lead.

This burden is a narrative hook, not a mechanical penalty. It gives the new character immediate purpose.

19.5.3 3. A Legacy Bond

The successor has a bond to their predecessor. Once per session, the player may invoke this bond to:

- Recall a memory that provides insight.
- Receive instinctive guidance in a familiar situation.
- Gain a free **Boon** (see §2) when acting to uphold the predecessor’s values.

This bond fades over time as the successor finds their own identity – but it never vanishes entirely.

19.6 Building a Faction Through Succession

Each time a character passes the torch, the faction (or cause) grows. It accumulates history, traditions, and institutional memory.

19.6.1 Growth Through People

Rather than tracking territory or wealth, track the faction's **reach** through the people who are now part of its story. Each successor adds:

- A new contact or ally they brought with them.
- A new problem they inherited.
- A new custom or saying that arose from their trials.

The GM keeps a simple list: “*The Banner of the Broken Wheel*,” “*the annual vigil at Sootfall Abbey*,” “*the debt to the Mistland ferryman*.” These are the faction's real assets.

19.6.2 Faction Timers (Optional)

For tables that want mechanical weight, the faction can track two simple timers:

- **Growth (6–8)**: When filled, the faction gains a new narrative permission (e.g., a safehouse in a new city, a reliable spy, a permanent shrine).
- **Health (6)**: When filled, a crisis erupts – a rival attacks, a leader dies, a secret is exposed. The current PC must deal with it or watch the faction fracture.

These timers advance only when the fiction demands – not automatically.

19.7 Example: The Fallen Captain

Miranda has played Michael, captain of the Iron Tide mercenary company, for two years. Michael dies defending a village from a wyrm. The player wants to continue the story.

19.7.0.0.1 The Successor Michael's second-in-command, a grizzled scout named Vesper, has been a follower (Cap 3) for many sessions. Vesper once disobeyed an order to save wounded civilians – a defining moment.

19.7.0.0.2 The Call At Michael's funeral pyre, the company looks to Vesper. No one else steps forward.

19.7.0.0.3 The Trial Vesper must negotiate a new contract with a wary noble who doubts the company's future without Michael. The player rolls, succeeds with cost – the noble agrees, but demands a hostage.

19.7.0.0.4 The Ascension Vesper takes up Michael's banner. The player erases Michael's character sheet and creates Vesper as a new PC (starting XP based on campaign tier). Vesper inherits:

- The Iron Tide as a **Mercenary Contract (Standard Asset)** (see §??).
- The burden: “*Find the noble's missing son – or lose the contract.*”

- A legacy bond to Michael: once per session, recall Michael’s advice to gain a Boon when leading the company.

The campaign continues without missing a beat.

19.8 Legacy Planning Checklist

Before your character retires, dies, or steps aside, work with your GM to prepare your successor. Use this checklist to ensure a smooth transition.

Player’s Legacy Planning Checklist

1. **Name a Successor** – Choose a Follower (Cap 3+), family member, or loyal ally. Give them a name, a face, and a voice.
2. **Clarify the Relationship** – What does your character mean to them? What do they owe each other?
3. **Identify One Unresolved Burden** – What task, oath, or problem will the successor inherit? (e.g., “Find my stolen sword,” “Protect the village,” “Pay the guild debt.”)
4. **Pass Down an Asset (Optional)** – If your character controls a Minor or Standard Asset (see §??), the GM may allow the successor to retain it with suitable narrative justification (e.g., “The family safehouse,” “The guild seat passes to the heir”). Major or Tier III Assets usually require the successor to earn them through play.
5. **Settle Outstanding Obligations** – Clear or transfer any standing debts to terrestrial patrons (see §15) before stepping down. Unpaid debts may become part of the successor’s burden.
6. **Hold a Ceremony (On-Screen)** – A funeral, a passing of the torch, a swearing of oaths. This scene marks the transition and gives the new PC immediate presence.
7. **Create the New Character** – Build the successor using standard character creation rules, adjusted to the campaign’s current tier. The GM may award a small XP bonus (e.g., 4–8 XP) to represent inherited training or resources.
8. **Keep a Legacy Note** – Write one sentence that the old character leaves behind (a proverb, a scar, a rumor). The GM can use it as a future story hook.

19.9 Campaign End: The Final Legacy

When the campaign ends, the player may describe one lasting mark the faction leaves on the world. Examples:

- A new law named after the first PC.
- A shrine where the PC fell, still tended by followers.
- A phrase that enters common speech (“Stand like Michael”).

The story ends – but the legacy remains.

A character dies. A faction endures. A story echoes forward.

Chapter 20

Enhanced Player Play

The world of **Fate's Edge** sings when players help steer the tune. This chapter gathers *player-facing dials*—lightweight, opt-in mechanics that turn your table's choices into momentum. Treat these as a menu: use a few, or layer many as your group grows comfortable.

20.1 Role-Based Tactics

Your role in the party determines how to best apply pressure, conserve resources, and turn the tide. Use these tactical guidelines regardless of your specific build.

20.1.1 Melee Striker (Duelist / Assassin / Berserker)

Your job is to eliminate high-value targets and break enemy lines.

- **Be aggressive.** You move faster than magic and hit harder than ranged fire. Close the distance early; every round you spend not engaged is a round you are not doing your job.
- **Flank, flank, flank.** A flanked enemy loses Position advantages. Coordinate with another melee character to attack from two sides.
- **Use Boons on re-rolling failed attacks, not defense.** Your HP is a resource; their death is the objective.
- **When outnumbered, use the terrain.** A narrow corridor or doorway lets you fight one enemy at a time while allies shoot over your shoulder.
- **Know your exit.** If you go down, the party loses its hammer. Keep a backup plan (a smoke bomb, a doorway to retreat through, a Bonded ally who can pull you out).

20.1.2 Defender (Guardian / Shield / Tank)

You hold the line so others don't have to.

- **Use the Defend action early.** It improves your Position by one step and gives you a free reaction to intercept attacks on allies.
- **Spend Boons on re-rolling defense failures.** Your survival keeps the party safe; a missed attack on your part is less catastrophic than a missed defense.

- **Position yourself between the enemy and your squishy allies.** The GM will honor the fiction – a foe cannot shoot past you without moving around you.
- **Trade Harm for Fatigue whenever possible.** A wound that clears your Fatigue track is often worth it.
- **Protect at least one ally with a Bond.** That Bond gives you a free Boon refund when you assist them – perfect for *Cover & Protect*.

20.1.3 Controller (Mage / Crowd Control / Terrain Shaper)

You shape the battlefield, forcing enemies into bad positions.

- **Open with area control.** A [AREA] [BIND] or [WALL] spell can split the enemy force, letting your strikers pick them off.
- **Use Boons to improve Position before casting, not after.** A Controlled cast is much safer than a Desperate one.
- **Accept SB as a resource, not a penalty.** You generate them anyway – lean into it. Offer the GM a Devil's Bargain to make your spell more effective in exchange for a later complication.
- **Tags matter.** [EARTH] + [WALL] blocks movement; [AIR] + [LEAP] repositions allies; [FATE] + [OMEN] gives the party a clue. Read the Tag reference (5).
- **Do not waste spells on enemies your strikers can kill in one hit.** Save your power for clusters, bosses, or emergencies.

20.1.4 Support (Healer / Buffer / Bard)

You multiply the party's effectiveness.

- **First action: improve Position or grant a Boon to a striker.** A Dominant striker kills faster than you can heal.
- **Use *Inspire* early.** The +1 die and extra Boon can turn a fight.
- **Heal Harm after the fight, Fatigue during it.** [HEAL] as a cantrip clears Fatigue (safe and fast); healing Harm requires a full action and may generate SB.
- **Carry a ranged weapon.** You do not need to be a damage dealer, but plinking a foe can distract them or force a reaction.
- **Your Bonds are your fuel.** Transfer Boons to the striker who needs them. A bonded ally gets a Boon refund on their first assist – use it.

20.1.5 Scout (Rogue / Ranger / Infiltrator)

You see the danger before it sees the party.

- **Go first.** Before the fight, scout ahead. The information you bring is worth more than an extra sword.
- **Strike from stealth, then vanish.** *Backstab* + *Shadow Dance* + *Deathblow* is a classic chain (see 9).
- **Use the environment.** High ground, cover, and shadow are your friends. Spend a Move action to reposition even if you do not attack.
- **Your independent action (Scout & Signal) is free Position for the party.** Use it before the first roll of a fight.

- **Do not be the first to engage in a fair fight.** If you are trading blows, something went wrong.

20.1.6 Leader (Commander / Tactician / Face)

You turn a group of individuals into a unit.

- **Setup actions are your bread and butter.** Grant an ally +1 Position or step up Effect – no roll, just fiction.
- **Use *Command* to rally.** A successful Command roll can remove Fear conditions or improve morale.
- **Delegate.** Your followers (see ??) are not just dice – they can take independent actions. Trust them.
- **Call shots.** “Focus the mage,” “Take cover,” “Fall back” – the GM will adjust Position based on coherent orders.
- **Your Boons are best spent on assisting others.** You are a force multiplier. A Boon spent on a striker’s attack is worth more than your own attack.

20.2 Tactical Play for Players

Combat and high-stakes scenes reward clever thinking as much as raw dice. Use these tactics to turn the fiction in your favor.

20.2.1 Closing on Ranged and Magic Users

A bowman on a balcony or a mage behind a ward can shred your party from a distance. Close the gap without getting shredded.

- **Use Cover and Movement.** Move from cover to cover. Spend a **Move action** to dash between obstacles. Ending behind solid cover may let the GM set your next defense roll as **Controlled** instead of Desperate.
- **Create Distractions.** Spend 1 **Boon** to describe a diversion. On a successful **Deception** or **Command** roll, the ranged attacker may lose their aim or shift attention for one exchange, dropping your Position penalty by one step.
- **Teamwork: The Running Shield.** Have a heavily armoured ally take the **Defend** action while moving forward. They intercept shots (converting Harm to Fatigue) while you sprint behind them. The GM may rule that the defender blocks line of sight, granting you **Dominant** position for your next approach.
- **Suppress Them.** Use the **Suppress** option (core rules). You don’t need to hit – just force the enemy to keep their head down. The GM may impose a –1 die penalty on their next attack or worsen their Position.
- **Spend Boons to Close.** Spend 1 **Boon** to improve your Position by one step before rolling movement or defense. That can mean the difference between a bolt in the chest and a glancing hit.

20.2.1.0.1 Example. Lyra (rogue) wants to cross a courtyard to reach a mage on a balcony. She spends 1 Boon to improve her Position from Desperate to Controlled, then stays close to a crumbling wall. The GM rules that the mage’s magic missile is at –1

die because of partial cover. Lyra makes it across with a Partial success, taking Fatigue instead of Harm.

20.2.2 When You're Outmatched

Sometimes the enemy is bigger, faster, or more numerous. You can still win — or survive.

- **Don't Trade Blows.** Instead of attacking, use your action to **Setup** for an ally (grant them +1 Position or step up Effect). Spend 1 Boon to assist them directly (+1 die). One well-supported PC can turn a fight faster than two desperate ones.
- **Accept Story Beats (SB) to Buy Time.** When you roll a Partial or Miss, the GM gets SB. You can proactively offer to accept **+1 SB** (banked, not spent now) in exchange for a short narrative delay: "I fall back behind a pillar – they lose sight of me for a moment." This doesn't change the roll's outcome, but gives you a breath to reposition.
- **Spend Boons on Defense, Not Offense.** When outnumbered, a missed attack hurts less than a received hit. Save Boons to re-roll failed defense rolls or to improve your Position before an enemy's big swing. A **Boon spent to re-roll a 1 on a defense roll** can prevent Harm 2 or 3.
- **Escape and Reset.** There's no shame in running. Use the **Withdraw** action (core rules). Spend 1 Boon to make it a **Controlled** withdrawal instead of Desperate. Live to fight another scene.
- **Use the Environment as a Weapon.** Ask the GM: "Is there a chandelier? A sand pile? A steep stair?" Describe how you trigger it. The GM may set a low DV (2–3); on success, the obstacle deals Harm, imposes a Condition, or improves the party's Position for a round.

20.2.2.0.1 Example. Benjamin (fighter) faces three bandits. Instead of attacking, he spends 1 Boon to assist the group's archer, then kicks over a brazier. The GM calls for a Body + Athletics roll (DV 2). Benjamin succeeds – the fire creates a smoky screen, worsening the bandits' Position to Desperate for one exchange. The archer picks one off.

20.2.3 When to Push It — and When Not To

The **Push It** mechanic (usually on Rites or Cantor Songs) escalates an effect immediately at a cost: extra Obligation, Fatigue, Corruption, or a GM Story Beat. Use it wisely.

Good Times to Push

- **Preventing a Party Wipe.** If a teammate is about to take lethal Harm, Push to get that heal or ward now.
- **Ending a Scene.** The timer is about to fill, or the enemy leader is fleeing. Push to finish it.
- **When the Cost Is Acceptable.** If you have spare Fatigue, or you're already at max Obligation and about to trigger a Patron demand anyway, the extra cost doesn't hurt as much.

Avoid Pushing When

- **You're Already in Trouble.** Pushing adds Fatigue or SB. If you're already at Fatigue 2 or have a full Death Timer, the extra cost could break you.
- **A Partial Success Is Enough.** Many Rites and Songs still work on a Partial – just weaker or shorter. Don't pay extra for power you don't require.
- **The GM Is Low on SB.** If the GM has 0–1 SB banked, they can't immediately punish a miss. But if they have 3+, a failed Push could trigger a major twist. Check the table's SB tracker.

How to Avoid Needing to Push

- **Use Boons Early.** Spend 1 Boon to improve your Position before the roll. A Controlled roll is less likely to fail than a Desperate one.
- **Get Help.** Have an ally assist you (spend 1 Boon for +1 die). That +1 die might turn a Partial into a Clean Success.
- **Lower the DV with Fiction.** “I wait for the guards to change shift” might lower DV by 1. “I use my Scholar's Cell free use to research the ward's pattern” could drop DV from 4 to 3.
- **Accept Failure and Bank Boons.** A Miss gives you 2 Boons. Sometimes it's better to fail now, take the Boons, and try again next round with a bigger pool or better Position.

20.2.3.0.1 Example. Sariel (Cantor) needs to charm a guard quickly. She could Push to resolve the Song instantly, but she's already at Fatigue 2. Instead, she spends 1 Boon to improve her Position from Controlled to Dominant, then has an ally whisper a distraction (assist, another Boon). She rolls 4 dice (Lore + Performance) against DV 3. She gets 3 successes – a Clean Success. No Push needed, and she saved her Fatigue.

Reminder

You can spend 1 **Boon** before a roll to increase Effect by one step.

20.2.4 General Player Tips for Enhanced Experience

- **Track Your Boons, Fatigue, and Obligation.** These are your resources. A character with 4 Boons and 0 Fatigue is much stronger than one with 0 Boons and Fatigue 2.
- **Use Bonds to Shift Boons.** At Tier III, you can transfer up to 2 Boons to a bonded ally as a free action. Fuel the party's best character for a crucial roll. Don't hoard.
- **Communicate Your Intent.** Tell the GM what you want to achieve, not just what skill you're rolling. “I want to scare him into dropping the keys” is better than “I roll Intimidation.” The GM can set a fairer DV and offer better consequences.
- **Ask About the Environment.** “Is there loose gravel? A tapestried wall? A rain barrel?” These become levers. The GM wants you to use them.
- **Know When to Fold.** Not every fight is winnable. Spending 2 Boons to escape with everyone alive is a victory. The game rewards survival and smart choices.

- **Use Downtime.** Between sessions, update your logs, tend your Assets, and clear Complications. A well-maintained Asset (Neglected → Maintained) can save your life next session. A cleared Complication removes a “free SB” button from the GM.
- **Talk to Your GM.** If a rule feels off or a scene drags, speak up. Fate’s Edge is collaborative. The GM can adjust DV, offer alternative stakes, or introduce a Devil’s Bargain to keep things moving.

20.3 Player Resources

Two shared currencies appear throughout this chapter:

Boons Core system edge; spend to power talents or convert to XP (see 2).

SB The GM’s Story Beats; several options here invite players to accept SB in exchange for narrative benefits.

20.4 Engagement Rewards

20.4.1 Session Investment Tracker

At session close, each player privately rates their *investment* (1–3). The tracker rewards steady participation without penalising quiet nights.

- 1 — Low** You followed others’ lead. Gain **+1d** once next session on any *support* action.
- 2 — Medium** You took initiative in some scenes. Gain **+1d** once next session on a *relationship* roll and bank **1 Momentum** (see 20.7.1).
- 3 — High** You anchored or elevated multiple scenes. Gain **+1d** twice next session (different scenes) and bank **1 Momentum**.

20.4.1.0.1 Table Boon. If *all* players report 2+ in a session, the GM may award the table **1 free Boon** to assign at the start of the next session.

20.4.2 Cultural Immersion Bonus

Reward lived-in play with light, predictable benefits.

- **Earn 1 Culture Point** when you enrich a scene with apt language, rites, or customs (Sea-Patter hail; bell-speech courtesy; Aeler craft-honorifics). Max **3/session**.
- **Spend 3 Culture** for **+1d** on a culturally keyed roll.
- **Spend 5 Culture** (across sessions) to declare a *trusted door*: one institution in that culture treats you as *Friendly* for the next approach.

20.5 Collaborative Play

20.5.1 Information Trading

When the table hunts answers, convert curiosity into structure.

20.5.1.0.1 Request & Price. State the question and choose a price the table accepts:

Devil's Bargain Offer the GM a future complication to “pay” for deeper intel.

Accept SB The GM gains **+1 SB** now; you gain a strategic clue or reduced DV.

Spend Boon Spend **1 Boon** to lower DV by 1 on the research/social approach.

20.5.1.0.2 Creative Methods. Swap coin for color: poetry duels, shrine petitions, map-reading at a parish stone. If your method sings with setting, take **+1 Effect** on the check.

20.5.2 Timer Manipulation

Players can nudge tension without rewriting stakes.

- **Slow** a visible Timer by **1 segment** by either **spending 1 Boon** *or* **accepting +1 SB** into the scene (fiction must justify delay).
- **Hasten** a visible Timer by **1 segment** by **spending 1 Momentum** (see 20.7.1) *or* **taking a Devil's Bargain**.
- **Limit:** Once per player per scene. If three or more players affect the same Timer in a scene, the GM gains **+1 SB**.

20.5.3 Complication Bargaining

Invite the kind of trouble you want to play.

- Name a *type*: social, physical, mystery, or moral (e.g., Valora court etiquette; Ubral scree; Isoka whispers; oath vs. mercy).
- The GM frames the complication accordingly and grants you **+1d** on your next roll *within* that trouble, or reduces DV by 1 if your approach leans into the specified texture.

20.6 Faction Awareness

20.6.1 Loyalty Recognition

Track a simple ladder ($-3 \dots +3$): *Enemy, Hostile, Unfriendly, Neutral, Friendly, Supportive, Ally*. When you act *with* an institution's aims, mark a **tick** toward the next step (GM pacing). When you betray a stated value, drop one step immediately and the GM banks **+1 SB** for future headaches.

20.6.2 Cross-Cultural Synergies

Spotting a neat cultural combo (Zakov pilots + Kahfagia signals; Aeler engineering + Ecktoria charters) grants **+1d** once per scene the synergy is actively used.

20.7 Advanced Techniques

20.7.1 Momentum Banking

When your team resolves a Timer *early* (segments unspent), bank **1 Momentum** per unused segment (max **2/session**). Spend 1 Momentum to:

- Gain **+1d** on a future approach tied to that victory (*lessons learned*); or

- *Telescope* a travel beat (skip a routine obstacle the same route would present); or
- Trigger a *Prepared Move*: declare a sensible minor setup you plausibly arranged off-screen.

20.7.2 Escalation Management

Trade heat for shape.

- **De-escalate (spend 1 Boon)**: Downgrade a Major consequence to Minor with a plausible concession (quiet tolls paid, harsh words eaten).
- **Redirect (accept +1 SB)**: Shift pressure to a new venue or actor you name; the GM places that SB there as attention.
- **Truce (spend 1 Momentum)**: Freeze a faction's hostility for one scene if you can cite a shared value (oath, rite, charter clause).

20.8 Enhanced Coordination

Teamwork isn't just about helping—it's about creating decisive moments through coordinated action.

20.8.1 Core Principles

- **Fiction First**: Describe how you help before rolling dice.
- **Clear Stakes**: State what help changes and what risk the helper accepts.
- **One Spotlight**: Resolve one acting character's roll; fold assistance into that action.
- **Visible Costs**: Story Beats, Fatigue, and consequences are tracked openly.

20.8.2 Basic Assistance

- **Declare Help**: An ally states a concrete contribution (tools, opening, cover).
- **Benefit**: Acting character gains +1d (up to the table's assist cap).
- **Limits**: One assistant per PC per exchange by default.
- **Cost**: Assistant accepts any risk named by the GM (SB, Fatigue, collateral).

20.8.3 Cooperative Talents

Certain talents enhance group coordination:

Inspire (3 XP) Once per scene, spend 1 Boon to choose one:

- **Bonded Ally**: That ally gains +1 Boon and +1d on their next roll.
- **Self**: Gain +1d on your next roll.
- **Rally**: Each other PC in Near gains +1d on their next roll.
- **Tactical Coordination**: All allies currently acting gain +1 Position.

Spotter's Mark (3 XP) Aim a target (1 action). Until end of scene, allies in Near may claim +1d or +1 Effect once vs. that target.

Battle Cant (2 XP) Once per scene, establish silent signals. On the next coordinated action where at least two PCs act, those PCs gain +1 Position.

Shield Wall (4 XP) If you and at least one ally each wield a shield and are adjacent: as a Defend action, grant +1d Defend to all in the Wall and convert the first incoming

Harm to Fatigue.

20.8.4 Stacking Limits

To prevent overwhelming combinations, a PC may benefit from at most **two cooperative effects** on the same action. Choose which apply when multiple sources could stack.

20.8.5 Timing and Sequencing

- **Declare Order:** Players state intent in any order; resolve the acting roll first.
- **Ready/Overwatch:** Hold an action with a clear trigger; resolve before the next exchange.
- **Refresh Windows:** “Once/scene” effects reset at scene end.

20.8.6 Working With Followers

Followers can assist for up to +3d (or +4d with the Exceptional Coordination talent). They cannot receive PC-only benefits unless a talent states otherwise.

20.8.7 Magic Coordination

- **Ritual Support:** Allies can assist Weave or Cast phases if the fiction allows.
- **Rite Preparation:** Helpers can provide components or maintain focus.
- **Imbuement Synergy:** Multiple characters can prepare for shared magical effort.

20.8.8 Best Practices for Players

1. **Be Specific:** “I’ll flank left to give you advantage” is better than “I help.”
2. **Accept Risk:** Good assistance often means putting yourself in harm’s way.
3. **Think Creatively:** Tools, positioning, and timing matter more than raw dice.
4. **Support Bonds:** Use coordination to strengthen character relationships.
5. **Keep Momentum:** Quick, clear assistance keeps scenes moving.

Remember: The best coordination enhances the story and makes everyone’s moments shine brighter together.

20.9 Character Creation Enhancements

Players may take up to **2 Bonds** (+2 XP total) and up to **2 Starting Complications** (+4 XP total) for a cap of **36XP**. Each unresolved starting Complication adds **+1 banked SB** to early scenes until cleared. Favor *storyful* picks (clan honor, guild debt, patron notice) over pure math.

20.10 War Mount (Asset)

Type: Standard Asset

XP Cost: 8 XP

Scale: Personal

Maintenance: Regular care, feed, rest

A trained combat mount—warhorse, dune-strider, battle elk, ash lizard, or equivalent—

conditioned for violence, chaos, and discipline.

20.10.0.0.1 Passive Benefits While mounted:

- Increase overland travel speed and endurance.
- Ignore the first movement-based complication per session (mud, crowd, loose terrain).
- Mounted positioning may override terrain restrictions at GM discretion.

20.10.0.0.2 Mounted Combat If the rider has the **Cavalier** talent (9):

- Melee attacks made while moving **Far** → **Near**: +2d
- Ranged attacks made while moving **Near** → **Far**: +2d

20.10.0.0.3 Boon Activation Spend 1 **Boon** to invoke the mount dramatically:

- Break through a hostile line or crowd
- Escape pursuit across hostile terrain
- Gain **Controlled Position** for a mounted action
- Advance or suppress a movement-related Timer

20.10.0.0.4 Risk and Wear On a *Partial* or *Miss* involving mounted actions, the GM may:

- Mark **Mount Fatigue**
- Damage tack, barding, or terrain access
- Threaten or compromise the Asset

20.10.0.0.5 Mount Fatigue If Mount Fatigue reaches 3:

- The mount cannot be used in combat until rested
- Further strain risks permanent injury or loss

20.10.0.0.6 Promoting a War Mount A War Mount may be promoted to a **Follower** if:

- It is named and narratively significant
- The rider takes a dedicated Bond or Talent

As a Follower, the mount can take actions independently (trample, defend, flee), suffer Harm, and may generate Boons through sacrifice or risk.

Pike Discipline (Major Talent, 4 XP) [FORMATION] [CONTROL]

Requirements: Melee 2+, Discipline or Command 1+

You are trained to break mounted assaults through spacing, timing, and fearlessness.

20.10.0.0.7 Effect When you **Brace** against a mounted opponent:

- Cancel all **Cavalier** movement bonuses
- Mounted attackers suffer -1d on the attack

20.10.0.0.8 On Success

- Reduce incoming Harm by 1
- You may force the rider to **Disengage** or risk mount injury

20.10.0.0.9 On Partial

- Reduce Harm by 1
- Mark 1 Fatigue or lose formation

20.10.0.0.10 Limits

- Requires braced footing or prepared terrain
- Ineffective if flanked, surprised, or outnumbered

20.11 Optional Player-Character Death

By default, Fate's Edge treats death as rare and dramatic. Use any of the following modules (singly or in combination) to tune how lethal your table feels. All options respect **Story Beats (SB)** and **Obligation** as core currencies.

Baseline (Default)

PCs do not die on ordinary failures. Instead, they suffer **Harm**, Conditions, lost opportunities, or narrative costs. Death only occurs when a rule below is in play or the table agrees a scene warrants it.

Option A — Severe Harm Death

Trigger. When a PC would take a **third** instance of Severe Harm (or escalate past the top of your harm track), they instead face death.

Stave It Off. The player may avoid death by choosing one: (1) mark **2 SB** and take a MAIMED permanent Condition, (2) accept a **Patron's Claim** (see Option D), or (3) convert the blow into a **Last Stand** (Option C).

Option B — Death Timer

Trigger. Catastrophic consequences (falls, crushes, mortal wounds) fill a named **Death Timer** (4 or 6 ticks).

While Ticking. Actions that stabilise reduce the timer; taking further punishment advances it.

When Full. The character dies unless one of the following occurs immediately: spend **2 SB** to hold at full (buy a single action), accept a **Patron's Claim**, or another PC succeeds at *Pull From the Brink* (risky, effect = timer -2 on success).

Option C — Last Stand

Trigger. On lethal harm or a full Death Timer, the player may declare a **Last Stand**.

Effect. For the remainder of the scene, the PC acts with **+1 Effect** and ignores new Harm. Each action automatically creates **1 SB**. When the scene ends, the character

dies unless a **miracle** is secured (Patron rite, relic, or equivalent).

Option D — Patron's Claim

Trigger. On death, the PC's Patron (or a circling power) intervenes.

Bargain. The GM offers 1–3 non-negotiable terms (e.g., *Obligation +2, forfeit a Gift, become a vessel for a season*). If accepted, the PC lives; mark the costs immediately and record the **Claim** as an ongoing front. Refusal means the death proceeds.

Note. Claims should change the campaign; use sparingly.

Option E — Dramatic Exit & Inheritance

Dramatic Exit. The player may choose a meaningful death that resolves a question or saves others.

Inheritance. The next PC created by that player inherits one of: (a) a **Relationship** (bond, contact, or rival), (b) a **Tool** (asset degraded one step), or (c) a **Lesson** (start with +1 XP toward a Talent used in the exit). Record how the world remembers them.

Option F — Return From Beyond

Trigger. A body, a name, and a path (rite, gate, bargain).

Cost. Treat as a High Rite with Obligation appropriate to the transgression. Set DV using the Rites system. On success, the PC returns **changed**: apply a SCAR (permanent Condition) and 1 **SB** to the rescuer. On failure, choose: lose the body, or return with a Patron's Claim.

Quick Picks

Low lethality: Baseline + Death Timer only. **Heroic tragedy:** Severe Harm Death + Last Stand + Inheritance. **Dark bargains:** Any combo with Patron's Claim.

20.12 Implementation Timeline

Sessions 1–3

Investment Tracker, Information Trading (via Boons/Bargains), light Complication Bargaining.

Sessions 4–6

Timer Manipulation (Boon/Momentum/SB), Cultural Immersion, Faction Awareness, Momentum Banking.

Sessions 7+

Cross-Cultural Synergies, Escalation Management, advanced pacing choreography.

At-Table Prompts

Seed the Scene. “Ask for the kind of complication you want.”

Name the Stakes. “Is this timer worth slowing? Who pays—Boon, SB, or Momentum?”

Pay with Color. “What custom or rite do you invoke to make this work?”

Close the Loop. “Mark your Investment; one sentence of what you learned.”

20.13 Downtime

Between sessions, tend your garden—quietly moving the world.

20.13.1 Bookkeeping

- Allocate XP (respecting training days).
- Update Assets/Followers (status: Maintained, Neglected, Compromised).
- Track Boons (conversion cap remains 2 XP/session).
- Note SB Debt from unresolved Complications.

20.13.2 Activities

- **Recovery:** Clear Harm/Exposure with scenes that show the work.
- **Training:** Buy advances; narrate mentors, gyms, scriptoria.
- **Research:** Lower DVs with good sources; log new leads.
- **Social:** Strengthen Bonds; tune faction attitudes.
- **Preparation:** Cache gear, sow rumors, line up ferries.

20.13.3 Strategic Considerations

Clear SB-debt complications first; synchronise travel plans; decide which Asset gets love this interval, and which follower needs face-time to avoid Neglect.

20.14 Between-Sessions Activities Log

Use or print the following trackers.

20.14.1 Character Advancement

XP Allocation

- **Total XP Available:** _____
- **Attributes Spent:** _____ (=____ days)
- **Skills Spent:** _____ (=____ days)
- **Remaining XP:** _____

Attribute Improvements

Attribute	Old	New	Cost	Days
Body				
Spirit				
Presence				
Wits				

Skill Improvements

Skill	Old	New	Cost	Days
Arcana				
Combat				
Investigate				
Lore				
Move				
Notice				
Physique				
Resolve				
Stealth				
Sway				
Survival				

20.14.2 Asset & Follower Management**Assets**

Name	Tier	Status	Notes

Followers

Name	Role	Harm	Exposure	Status

20.14.3 Bonds & Complications**Bonds Updated**

- With: _____ — Change: _____

Complications

Complication	Resolution or Status

20.14.4 Boons & Momentum Summary

- Boons Held: ____/5 Converted to XP: ____ (max 2 XP/session)
- Momentum Banked: ____ (max 2/session)

20.14.5 Campaign Timers

- Mandate: ____ / 6 Crisis: ____ / 6
- Notables: _____

Chapter 21

Character Sheet

Use this character sheet to record your hero's story. Fill it in pencil – debts, wounds, and Obligation change often. The layout follows the order of character creation: start with Attributes and Skills, then add Talents and magic, then track your resources.

Character Identity

Name: _____ Player: _____
Heritage: _____ Background: _____
Tier (XP): _____ Patron (if any): _____

Attributes & Derived

Body _____ Wits _____ Spirit _____
Presence _____ Fatigue ____/____ Harm ____/____
Obligation Capacity: _____ Corruption Timer : _ Mental Strain: _____

Skills (0–5)

Combat

Melee _____
Ranged _____
Brawl _____
Tactics _____

Physical

Athletics _____
Stealth _____
Endurance _____
Craft _____
Survival _____

Social

Sway _____
Command _____
Deception _____
Performance _____
Insight _____

Knowledge

Lore _____
Investigation _____
Medicine _____
Magic
Arcana _____
Ritual _____

Combat & Protection

Armor Type: _____ Shield: _____ Weapon: _____
Armor Conversion: _____ Weapon Tags: _____
Melee Mods: _____ Ranged Mods: _____

Resources

Boons (max 5): _____ XP (unspent): _____
Current Obligation (per Patron): _____ Debt Timers: _____

Talents & Abilities

(List talents with XP cost and page reference)

Magic Paths

Free Caster (Spellcraft) – *Weave & Cast* _____

Runekeeper (Codex + Thiasos) – *Patron:* _____

Invoker (Symbols) – *Symbols:* _____

Cantor (Songs) – *Corruption Timer* : ____/____

Summoner (Pact-Whisperer) – *Leash:* ____/____ *Current Spirit:* ____

Psionics (Optional) – *Mental Strain:* ____/____

Rites / Songs / Spells

(Name, tags, DV, cost)

Assets & Followers

Assets (off-screen) _____

(Name, tier, condition)

Followers (on-screen) _____

(Name, Cap, harm/exposure)

Bonds & Strings

Bonds (player characters)

Strings (NPC favors)

Notes & Goals

(Short-term goals, long-term aspirations, important names)

Quick Reference (inside cover)

Core Dice: Attribute + Skill d10s. Success on 6+. 1 = Story Beat for GM.

Difficulty (DV): 2 routine, 3 default, 4 hard, 5+ extreme.

Position: Dominant (re-roll failure), Controlled (normal), Desperate (re-roll success).

Outcomes: Clean ($S \geq DV$, no SB), Success with SB ($S \geq DV$, $SB > 0$), Partial ($0 < S < DV$, gain 1 Boon), Miss ($S = 0$, gain 2 Boons).

Boons: Re-roll a die, improve Position, activate Asset, convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once/session).

Fatigue: Each point worsens Position; fill track → Harm+1, clear Fatigue.

Harm: 1 (−1 die), 2 (−2 dice), 3 (incapacitated).

Obligation: Capacity = Spirit+Presence. Over capacity → 1 Fatigue/segment. Double over → Patron intrusion.

Corruption: Timer size = Spirit. Fill → Bloom (gain boon+burden), reset to Tier.

ledger is never closed. It is only passed to the next keeper." – Dusana of the Raven Road

Appendix A

Appendices

A.1 Player Tools and Quick Reference

This appendix provides lightweight, table-friendly tools for tracking character progress, campaign state, and moment-to-moment rules. Print, photocopy, or copy to index cards for use at the table.

A.1.1 Physical Tracker Recommendations

Many groups find that physical, tactile trackers speed up play and reduce mental load. Consider:

- **Poker chips or glass beads** for Boons and Story Beats (SB). *Keep a small bowl of chips in the center of the table – spend and earn visibly.*
- **Dry-erase boards or laminated sheets** for timers (4/6/8 segment circles). *Use a wet-erase marker; draw a new timer each scene.*
- **Index cards (3×5)** for Assets and Followers. *Write the Asset’s name, free use, and surge on one side; flip when used.*
- **Colored paperclips or binder clips** on character sheets for Fatigue and Harm tracks. *Slide the clip up or down – no erasing.*
- **Printed “timer wheels”** (a circle divided into 4/6/8 wedges) placed inside a page protector. *Mark wedges with a dry-erase marker, erase with tissue.*
- **D10 dice** to track temporary modifiers (Position, Effect, or Momentum). *Place the die next to the relevant tracker and tick up or down.*

A.1.2 Resolution Index Card

Declare Action → Build Dice Pool (Attribute + Skill) → Roll → Count Successes

0 Successes = **Miss** (GM gains SB, consequences)

1–3 Successes = **Partial** (success + complication)

4+ Successes = **Full Success** (clear win, no complication)

Position (Risk) + **Effect** (Impact) may shift outcomes.

SB (Story Beats) fuel abilities, magic, momentum, and narrative pushes.

A.1.3 Fatigue and Harm Tracker

Fatigue: _____ (Max = Body)

Mental Strain: _____

Harm: [] Harm 1 (–1 die) [] Harm 2 (–2 dice) [] Harm 3 (Incapacitated)

When tracks fill:

- Fatigue overflow → increase Harm by 1, clear Fatigue.
- Mental Strain → causes instability or disadvantage.
- Harm 3 → Last Stand or Patron's Claim (see “Optional Player-Character Death” in §20.11).

A.1.4 SB and Momentum Tracking

Current SB (GM pool): _____

Momentum (party pool): _____ (max 2)

Used this session: _____

A.1.5 Talent Progression

XP Cost	Talent Type / Impact
2 XP	Minor Talent / Perk upgrade / situational bonus
4 XP	Major Talent / specialization / strong permanent effect
6 XP	Access talent (Spellcraft, Familiar, Codex, Patron's Symbol)
8 XP	Prestige Talent / campaign-defining ability

A.1.6 Character

Goals

Card

Name: _____

Core Drive: _____

Short-Term Goal (1–2 sessions): _____

Long-Term Goal (arc): _____

Background Complication: _____

Relationship That Matters: _____

Physical tip: Print this card on cardstock, fold in half, and stand it in front of you as a reminder.

A.1.7 Faction Attitude Card

Faction Name: _____
Attitude: -3 -2 -1 0 +1 +2 +3
Notes: _____

A.1.8 Player Orientation Card (Quick Principles)

1. **Declare Bold Action** — Drive fiction forward.
2. **Accept Consequences** — Complications create story.
3. **Spend Story Beats** — Make moments matter.
4. **Use Boons** — Re-roll, improve Position, activate Assets.
5. **Share the Spotlight** — Assist, bond, set up allies.

A.1.9 Class / Archetype Resource Quick Reference

Archetype	Core Resource
Fighter / Warrior	Maneuvers, Fatigue, Weapon Mastery
Rogue / Scout	Positioning, Stealth, Backstab
Caster (Freeform)	Spellcraft, Elemental Tags, Backlash
Runekeeper	Rites, Obligation, Codex
Invoker	Rituals, Patron's Symbol, Crack the Seal
Cantor	Songs, Corruption Timer , Repertoire
Summoner	Leash Timer , Spirit Bond, Pact

A.1.10 How to Engage with the GM (Player Prompts)

- **Ask:** “What do I need to roll?” – get the DV and Position.
- **Propose:** “Can I spend SB to achieve X?” – negotiate narrative pushes.
- **Declare:** “Here’s my intent and method.” – always state what you want to happen.
- **Offer:** “I’ll take a complication if Y happens.” – invite Devil’s Bargains.
- **Clarify:** “What’s at risk if I fail?” – know the stakes before rolling.

A.1.11 Downtime Project Tracker

Name: _____ **Segments:** [] [] [] [] [] []
Goal: _____
Obstacles / Resources Needed: _____

Physical tip: Use a 6-segment whiteboard timer. Each downtime, erase one segment and roll for progress.

A.1.12 What Consequence Do You Accept? (Menu for GM)

When a player fails or partially succeeds, the GM may offer a choice from this list (or invent a custom one):

- Harm (level 1 or 2)
- Fatigue (1 or 2)
- Lost Advantage (Position worsens, a timer advances)
- Time Delays (a timer ticks, a deadline tightens)
- Exposure / Heat (attention from enemies, bounty)
- Resource Depletion (supply timer tick, gear compromised)
- Relationship Strain (a bond or faction attitude worsens)

A.1.13 Ways to Shine in Fate's Edge

- Tie actions to your drives and backstory – invoke your Background Boon.
- Offer complications and accept them – earn Boons.
- Spend SB to escalate or transform the scene – make failure memorable.
- Use your class resource early and often – don't hoard.
- Connect scenes to campaign themes – name the faction or place.
- Make other characters look cool – assist, set up, pass the spotlight.

A.1.14 Blank Player Index Cards (for quick notes)

Name / Boons / Fatigue / Harm
Timers / Obligation / Scene Notes

A.1.15 Final Reminder

Your character sheet is not your character. It is a tool to help you express who they have been, who they are becoming, and how their choices change the world.

Use these tools to make that expression vivid, consequential, and memorable.

A.2 Magic Systems Reference

Magic in Fate's Edge is plural. Different traditions channel power through different metaphysical structures, but all obey the same truth:

Power has a cost, and magic shapes the one who wields it.

This appendix provides quick-reference tools for players using magic-affiliated systems, talismans, rites, and occult practices.

A.2.1 Core Magical Principles

- Magic expresses **identity and belief**.
- Casting always creates **consequences somewhere**.
- Magic rewrites reality through **intention, structure, or sacrifice**.
- Excessive power erodes **choice** (see Iconic Ascension sidebar in the full rules).

A.2.2 Universal Casting Reference

Cast Declaration Template:

1. **Intent** — What change do you seek?
2. **Shape** — How does your tradition express it?
3. **Cost** — What do you risk or expend?
4. **Resolution** — Test; apply Position/Effect rules.
5. **Backwash** — Mark Fatigue, SB pressure, taboo, instability, or bargain.

A.2.3 Magic Tradition Quick Reference

Freeform Arcana (Wizardry) *Creative, rational, deliberate shaping.* Tools: Glyphs, structures, metaphors. Costs: Fatigue, reality recoil, SB instability. **Play Cue:** Diagram your spell or state its symbolism. Big spells distort fate – accept SB spikes.

Innate Arcana (Sorcery) *Emotional, instinctive, bloodline-linked.* Tools: Breath, impulse, resonance. Costs: Fatigue, unpredictable backlash. **Play Cue:** Treat magic like a reflex. Push your limits – expect consequences.

Invocation (Priest / Paladin / Medium) *Petition, prayer, pact, rite.* Tools: Symbols, vows, places of power. Costs: Taboo pressures, obligation timers. **Play Cue:** Your magic is not your own – frame it as a request. Violating your ethos draws consequences.

Runic Consecration (Runekeeping) *Methods, seals, contracts.* Tools: Ritual steps, codices, binding clauses. Costs: Hunger timers, escalation loops. **Play Cue:** Magic is *procedure*. Expect the system to push back.

Shaping / Druidic Power *Resonance with place, element, cycle.* Tools: Marks, offerings, seasonal rites. Costs: Environmental echo, territorial consequence. **Play Cue:** Declare what the land wants – then bargain.

Pact Binding (Warlock / Avatar) *Exchange, hunger, transformation.* Tools: Tokens, signatures, reflection marks. Costs: Autonomy loss, ascension risk. **Play Cue:** Ask: “What does my patron get?” Debt becomes plot.

Summoning (Medium / Necromancer / Shaman) *Invocation of entities, binding, vassal action.* Tools: Circles, bargains, lanterns, ancestral calls. Costs: Attention timers, breach risk. **Play Cue:** Give the summoned a personality – their aid comes with demands.

A.2.4 Mutual Rules of Magical Cost

No magic is free.

Cost Type	Examples in Play
Fatigue	Exhaustion surge, shaking focus, body strain
SB Pressure	GM spikes complications or timers (elemental backlash, Patron omens)
Taboo / Obligation	Commandments, rites, punishment for misuse, Patron demands
Attention / Backwash	Spirits notice; cosmic ledger ticks; faction awareness
Anomaly / Distortion	Places react, reality warps, rituals echo – scene tags change
Identity Erosion	Compelled acts, alignment tilt, Iconic Ascension risk

A.2.5 Cross-System Synergies

All magic systems can blend. A Runekeeper may emulate a Cleric or Druid; an Invoker may operate as a Paladin or Prophet; a Sorcerer may look like a Witch, Elementalist, or Psion.

When combining systems:

1. Choose your **primary expression** (belief, intellect, instinct, ritual).
2. Describe spells through that lens.
3. Let costs reflect your system.
4. Track consequences separately – mixing systems increases risk.

A.2.6 GM Reminders for Magic

- Magic creates story – reward its use with consequences and momentum.
- Players should narrate method, not just effect.
- Big moments should change scenes, not just numbers.
- Magic should tempt the caster – echo their drives and flaws.

A.2.7 Player Reminders for Magic

- Lean into cost – magic feels significant when it hurts.
- Make magic personal – describe what it looks and feels like.
- Tie powers to identity, belief, trauma, duty, or legacy.
- Let magic change your character over time.

A.3 Pre-made Spells with TAGS and DV Math

The following examples illustrate how TAGS, DV scaling, and spell intent interact within the casting system. Use them as inspiration or as templates for your own spells.

A.3.1 How to Read a Spell Entry

Each entry includes:

- **Name** and **Tradition** (optional).
- **TAGS** – the components that define the effect.
- **Effect** – plain-language outcome.
- **DV** – base calculation (1 + number of TAGS; dangerous tags add +2).
- **Notes** – typical range, duration, or special considerations.

A.3.2 Tier I: Minor Utility (DV 2–3)

A.3.2.0.1 Simple Light (Air + Light)

TAGS: [ILLUMINATE]

Effect: Create a small sustained light (torch-brightness) for the scene.

DV: 1 + 1 = 2.

Notes: No backlash risk; lasts until dismissed.

A.3.2.0.2 HEAL Minor Wounds (Life + HEAL)

TAGS: [HEAL]

Effect: Close a small cut or bruise; reduce 1 Fatigue (Minor).

DV: 1 + 1 = 2.

Notes: Requires touch.

Healing Harm and Fatigue

HEAL as a Cantrip. The HEAL tag (Life) can be cast as a single-action cantrip (DV 2). On a success, you remove 1 **Fatigue** from yourself or a touched ally. This cannot heal Harm.

Healing Harm (1 level). To restore a level of Harm, you must include the HEAL tag and either:

- add a **+2 DV modifier** to the spell, or
- combine HEAL with a second appropriate tag (e.g., **Purify**, **Strengthen**, **Cleanse**).

The GM sets the final DV based on the tags and the wound's severity.

Why? Fatigue is exhaustion – a quick charm can ease tired muscles. Harm is injury – closing wounds demands more power and risk. This keeps healing meaningful without overshadowing martial endurance.

A.3.2.0.3 Message on Wind (Air + Veil)

TAGS: [WHISPER]

Effect: Carry a short whispered message 100 feet on wind currents.

DV: 1 + 1 = 2.

Notes: One-way communication; 30 seconds duration.

A.3.3 Tier II: Combat Utility (DV 3–4)**A.3.3.0.1 Blade Flame** (Fire + Strike)**TAGS:** [BURNING][STRIKE]**Effect:** Coat a weapon in fire, adding +1 Harm and [BURN] to the next melee attack.**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**.**Notes:** Lasts one exchange.**A.3.3.0.2 Shield of Air** (Air + Wall)**TAGS:** [WARD][DEFEND]**Effect:** Create a compressed air barrier; gain Position +1 on next defense.**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**.**Notes:** One use only.**A.3.3.0.3 Fleet Step** (Air + Leap)**TAGS:** [HASTE][MOVE]**Effect:** Double movement speed for one exchange.**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**.**Notes:** Requires open area.**A.3.4 Tier III: Area Control (DV 4–5)****A.3.4.0.1 Wall of Stone** (Earth + Wall)**TAGS:** [BARRIER][FORTIFY]**Effect:** Summon a 10-foot stone wall (Near; scene duration).**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**. *Dangerous DV: 4* (combat blocking).**Notes:** Provides cover; obstructs movement.**A.3.4.0.2 Sleep's Gentle Touch** (Water + Mind)**TAGS:** [DREAM][COMMAND]**Effect:** One target falls asleep (scene duration; Resist: Spirit + Resolve DV 2).**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**. *Dangerous DV: 4* (combat use).**Notes:** Harm wakes target.**A.3.4.0.3 Flame Cloak** (Fire + Area)**TAGS:** [BURNING][AREA]**Effect:** 6-foot radius of intense heat; enemies suffer –1 die to approach.**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**. *Dangerous DV: 4* (if allies are near).**Notes:** Creates difficult terrain.**A.3.5 Tier IV: Battlefield Shaping (DV 5–6)****A.3.5.0.1 Earth's Tremor** (Earth + Force)**TAGS:** [QUAKE][AREA]**Effect:** 20-foot tremor; enemies test Body + Athletics (DV 3) or fall prone.**DV:** 1 + 1 + 1 = **3**. *Dangerous DV: 5*.**Notes:** Destabilizes structures; affects all in area.

A.3.5.0.2 Storm's Fury (Air + Storm)**TAGS:** [STORM][AREA][FORCE]**Effect:** 30-foot storm cloud; lightning strikes random targets (Harm 2).**DV:** $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$. *Dangerous DV: 6.***Notes:** Lasts scene; reduces visibility.**A.3.5.0.3 Healing Circle** (Life + Area)**TAGS:** [HEAL][AREA][CLEANSE]**Effect:** Allies in 15-foot radius heal 1 Harm and clear 1 Fatigue.**DV:** $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$.**Notes:** Major positive effect warrants high DV.**A.3.6 Tier V: Domain-Level Effects (DV 6–7)****A.3.6.0.1 Gate of Passage** (Air + Fold)**TAGS:** [GATE][TRANSPORT][AREA]**Effect:** Open a two-way portal 20 feet wide linking two locations.**DV:** $1 + 2 + 1 + 1 = 5$. *Dangerous DV: 7.***Notes:** Requires concentration; may destabilize.**A.3.6.0.2 Army of Stone** (Earth + Summon)**TAGS:** [CONJURE][AREA][GUARD]**Effect:** Summon 4 stone guardians (Cap 2) to follow simple commands.**DV:** $1 + 2 + 1 + 1 = 5$. *Dangerous DV: 6.***Notes:** Scene duration; concentration.**A.3.6.0.3 Mind's Dominion** (Fate + Mind)**TAGS:** [COMMAND][AREA][CURSE]**Effect:** All enemies in 25-foot radius test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or obey a single command.**DV:** $1 + 1 + 1 + 2 = 5$. *Dangerous DV: 7.***Notes:** Significant ethical risk; backlash likely.**A.3.7 Signature / Personal Spells (Custom)****A.3.7.0.1 The Warden's Bond** (Life + Bind) – Healing Cantor**TAGS:** [HEAL][BIND][GUARD]**Effect:** Heal 2 Harm and link caster to target – the next Harm they take, caster suffers 1 instead.**DV:** $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$.**Notes:** Sacrificial protection.**A.3.7.0.2 Shadow's Step** (Air + Veil) – Trickster's Path**TAGS:** [VEIL][MOVE][LEAP]**Effect:** Become invisible and teleport 30 feet; gain +2 dice to next Stealth action.**DV:** $1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4$.**Notes:** Requires shadow or dim light.**A.3.7.0.3 Forge's Truth** (Fire + Reveal) – Artificer's Craft

TAGS: [REVEAL][HEAL][FORTIFY]

Effect: See flaws in an object and repair as if 2 Skill levels higher (scene).

DV: 1 + 1 + 1 + 1 = 4.

Notes: Works on magical items (with risk).

A.3.8 Backlash and Push Guidelines

A.3.8.1 Backlash Examples by Tier

- **Tier I–II:** Minor fatigue, brief elemental effect (smoke, chill, static).
- **Tier III–IV:** Harm 1, temporary Condition, environmental hazard.
- **Tier V:** Harm 2, major Condition, significant environmental change.

A.3.8.2 Push Options (Accelerate or Amplify)

- **+1 Effect:** Increase radius, duration, or potency one step.
- **+1 die:** Improve casting roll (cost: +1 Fatigue).
- **Instant:** Resolve immediately (cost: +1 Harm).
- **Sustain:** Maintain effect with concentration (+1 Fatigue/round).

This framework provides concrete spell examples and demonstrates how TAGS, DV scaling, and ambition interact within the magic system.

A.4 Free Casting (TAGS System)

Some casters shape raw forces through shared arcane grammar known as **TAGS**. Construct a spell at the table using a short phrase of TAGS.

A.4.1 Spell Structure

Intent + **Target** + **Tags** = effect. Example: “*I unleash Burning • Area • Force against the marauders.*”

A.4.2 Base Difficulty Value (DV)

$$DV = 1 + \text{number of TAGS}$$

Dangerous TAGS (Teleportation, Transformation, Domination) add +2 DV instead of +1.

A.4.3 Casting Roll

Roll **Wits** + **Arcana** (or similar). Success = spell works. Failure or any 1 = Backlash.

A.4.4 Backlash for Free Casters

Choose one:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- Catastrophic side effect (GM describes)

If the spell includes a “Dangerous” TAG, Backlash triggers on *mixed* results as well.

A.4.5 TAG Library (Abridged)

Table A.1: Common TAGS

TAG Category	Examples
Elemental	Burning, Freezing, Storm, Stone, Wave, Wind, Earth, Fire, Water, Air, Lightning, Ash
Force	Force, Area, Strike, Wall, Bind, Dispel, Push, Pull, Crush, Shield
Mind & Veil	Veil, Scry, Memory, Command, Fear, Glamour, Dream, Whisper, Reveal, Hide
Life & Body	HEAL, Purify, Strengthen, Waken, Beast, Heal, Poison, Rot, Numb, Sicken
Space & Motion (dangerous, +2 DV)	Leap, Fold, Gate, Gravity, Phase, Teleport, Blink, Anchor

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TAG Category	Examples
Creation & Transformation (dangerous, +2 DV)	Create, Summon, Transmute, Animate, Conjure, Shape, Graft, Fleshcraft
Illusion & Deception	Mirage, Echo, Mask, Copy, Phantasm, Glimmer
Protection & Warding	Ward, Defend, Seal, Barrier, Sanctuary, Negate
Time (rare, dangerous, +2 DV)	Haste, Slow, Stop, Rewind, Age
Curse & Hex	Curse, Jinx, Bind, Misfortune, Taint, Corrupt
Information	Know, Sense, Locate, Recall, Translate

A.4.6 Example Spells by DV

- **Light** [Illuminate] – DV 2 (1 tag)
- **Message on Wind** [Whisper] – DV 2
- **Shield of Air** [Ward] [Defend] – DV 3
- **Flame Cloak** [Burning] [Area] – DV 3
- **Wall of Stone** [Barrier] [Fortify] – dangerous? No, DV 3 (two tags) or DV 4 (if GM rules combat blocking as dangerous)
- **Teleport** [Leap] [Veil] – DV 1 + 2 (dangerous) + 1 = 4, but Leap is already dangerous: [Leap] alone is dangerous (+2) so DV 3.

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